THE CONVERSATIONAL NEW TESTAMENT

MATTHEW

The Genealogy of Jesus (cp. Lk 3:23-38)

1:[1]The genealogy of Jesus the Messiah, son of David, son of Abraham

[2]Abraham, father of Isaac, father of Jacob, father of
Judah and his brothers;
[3]Judah was father of Peres and Zerah by Tamar;
Peres was father of Hezron, father of
Ram, [4]father of Amminadab, father of Nahshon, father of
Salmon, [5]father of Boaz by Rahab;
Boaz was father of Obed by Ruth;
Obed was father of
Jesse, [6]father of David the king.

David was father of
Solomon by his wife, who
had been Uriah's wife. [7]Solomon was father of Rehoboam, father of
Abijah, father of Asaph, [8]father of Jehoshaphat, father of
Joram, father of Uzziah, [9]father of Jotham, father of
Ahaz, father of Hezekiah, [10]father of Manasseh, father of
Amos, father of Josiah, [11]father of Jechoniah and his brothers
at the exile to Babylon.

[12]After the exile,
Jechoniah was father of Shealtiel, father of Zerubbabel, [13]father of
Abiud, father of Eliakim, father of Azor, [14]father of
Zadok, father of Achim, father of Eliud, [15]father of
Eleazar, father of Matthan, father of Jacob, [16]father of Joseph
husband of Mary,
who gave birth to Jesus,
called Messiah.

[17]There are 14 generations from Abraham to David,
14 from David to the exile in Babylon, and

14 from the exile to Messiah. **Mt 1:1-17**

Jesus' Birth Announced to Joseph

18This is how the birth of Jesus the Messiah took place. His mother Mary was engaged to Joseph. Before they got married, it was discovered that she was pregnant (by the Holy Spirit). **19**Joseph, her husband, was a just man and not willing to disgrace her publicly, so he intended to break off the engagement privately. **20**As he was struggling with the matter, an angel of the LORD appeared in a dream, *"Joseph son of David, don't have qualms about marrying her. She's pregnant by the Holy Spirit.* **21***She'll have a son you're to name* Jesus*, because he'll 'save' his people from their sins."* **22**That fulfilled what the LORD had said by the prophet Isaiah,

> **23*"A virgin will have a son***
> ***they'll call* Immanuel *('God with us')"*** **[Is 7:14]**.

24Joseph got up and did what the angel said, **25**but didn't have relations with her till she had a son; he named him Jesus. **Mt 1:18-25**

The Visit of the Magi

2:1 When Jesus was born in Bethlehem, Judaea, during the reign of King Herod the Great, Magi from the East arrived in Jerusalem, **2***"Where's the newborn king of the Jews? In the East we saw his star and have come to pay him homage."* **3**That disturbed *Herod* and the whole city as well. **4**He called in the chief priests and scribes of the people and asked them where the Messiah was to be born.

5They said, *"In Bethlehem, Judaea. The prophet wrote,*

> **6*'You, Bethlehem,*** *Judah,*
> ***are*** *by no means* ***least among the leading*** **cities** ***of Judah,***
> ***because a leader will come out of you***
> ***to shepherd my people Israel'"*** **[Mic 5:2]**.

7Herod privately called the Magi to find out when the star had appeared, **8**and sent them to Bethlehem, *"Look for the child carefully. When you find him, let me know so I can come and pay him homage too."*

9So they started out, and the star they'd seen back East started going ahead of them till it stood above where the child was. **10**When they saw the star, they were elated. **11**They went into the house and saw the child with Mary his mother and bowed down in homage to him. They opened their treasure chests and brought him gold, frankincense, and myrrh. **12**God warned them in a dream not to go back to Herod, so they took a different route home. **Mt 2:1-12**

The Flight to Egypt
the Slaughter of the Infants

[13]When they'd gone, an angel of the LORD appeared to Joseph in a dream, *"Get up and hurry to Egypt with the child and his mother. Stay there till I tell you. Herod intends to look for the child to destroy him."* [14]Joseph got up during the night and took them to Egypt. [15]He stayed there till Herod died—in keeping with what the LORD said by the prophet,

"I've called my son out of Egypt" **[Hos 11:1]**.

[16]When Herod saw the Magi had tricked him, he was enraged and had all the male children killed in and around Bethlehem—the ones two years old and under as figured from the time the Magi told him. [17]That paralleled what the prophet Jeremiah said,

[18]***"A sound*** **was** ***heard in Ramah,***
weeping and bitter crying;
Rachel **was** ***weeping for her children.***
She wouldn't be consoled;
they were gone" **[Jer 31:15].** **Mt 2:13-18**

The Return from Egypt and Settlement in Nazareth

[19]After Herod died, the angel appeared[p] to Joseph in a dream in Egypt, [20]*"Get up and take the child and his mother to Israel. The ones that were trying to kill him have died."* [21]He got up and took them to Israel; [22]but when he heard that Archelaus was ruling Judaea in place of his father Herod, he was afraid to go there. God warned him in a dream, and he withdrew into Galilee [23]and settled down in a town called Nazareth. That name sounds like what the prophets said he'd be: a Nazarene [*nezer*, *shoot*; **Is 11:1; 53:2**][lit]. **Mt 2:19-23**

The Beginning of John's Ministry

3:[1]In time, John the Baptist came[p] preaching in the desert in Judaea, [2]*"Repent, the kingdom of heaven's coming."* [3]He's the one Isaiah spoke about:

"One shouting in the desert,
'Get the road ready for the LORD!
Make it straight!'" **[Is 40:3]**

[4]John wore *clothes woven from* camel's hair with a leather belt around his waist and lived on locusts and wild honey. [5]People from Jerusalem, all over Judaea, and around the Jordan River were going out [6]to have him baptize them in the Jordan as they confessed their sins. **Mt 3:1-6**

An Example of John's Preaching

[7]When John saw lots of Pharisees and Sadducees coming to his baptism, he said,

*"*You *bunch of poisonous snakes! Who warned you to flee from God's wrath to come?* [8]*Bear fruit appropriate for repentance.* [9]*Don't think, 'Abraham's our father.' God can raise up descendants of Abraham from these rocks.* [10]*An axe is already lying at the base of the trees. Every tree that doesn't bear good fruit*

will be chopped down and burned. [11]*I'm immersing you in water to repentance. The One who's coming after me is greater than me; I'm not worthy to take his sandals off. He'll 'immerse' you in the Holy Spirit and fire.* [12]*His winnowing fork is in his hand, and he'll thoroughly clean up his threshing floor. He'll put the grain in his granary but burn up the chaff with a fire you can't put out."* **Mt 3:7-12**

The Baptism of Jesus

[13]Then Jesus came[p] from Galilee to the Jordan to have John baptize him. [14]But John tried to stop him, *"I need you to baptize me, and you're coming to me?"*

[15]Jesus answered, *"Let's do this; it's appropriate to do everything that's right.*" So John went ahead[p] *and baptized* him.

[16]When he'd baptized him, *Jesus* came up from the water and the sky opened up, and *John* saw God's Spirit come down on *Jesus* like a dove. [17]A voice came out of the sky*, "This is my dearly loved Son that I delight in."* **Mt 3:13-17**

The Temptation of Jesus

4:[1]Then the Spirit led Jesus into the desert to be tempted by the devil. [2]After fasting 40 days, he was hungry, [3]and the tempter came, *"If you're God's Son, tell these stones to become loaves of bread."*

[4]But he answered,

"People aren't to live by bread only,
but by everything God says" **[Deut 8:3]**.

[5]The devil took[p] him to the Holy City and stood him on the pinnacle of the Temple, [6]*"If you're God's Son, throw yourself down. Scripture says,*

'He'll tell his angels to catch you
so you'll never trip over a rock'" **[Ps 91:11-12]**.

[7]Jesus said, *"Again scripture says,*

'Don't tempt the LORD your God'" **[Deut 6:16]**.

[8]The devil took[p] him to a tall mountain and showed[p] him the kingdoms of the world and their splendor, [9]*"If you kneel down and worship me, I'll give you all this."*

[10]Jesus said[p], *"Go away, Satan. Scripture says,*

'Worship the LORD your God,
and** only **serve him'" **[Deut 6:13]**.

[11]The devil left[p], and angels came to give him support. **Mt 4:1-11**

Introductory Statements About the Galilean Ministry

[12]When Jesus heard that John had been arrested, he withdrew into Galilee, [13]and moved from Nazareth to Capernaum by the lake in the region of Zebulun and Naphtali. [14]That fulfills what Isaiah the prophet said,

[15] ***"Land of Zebulun, land of Naphtali,***
by the road along the lake,
by the Jordan,
Galilee of the Gentiles—
[16] ***people that lived in darkness***
have seen a bright light.
It has dawned on those who lived
in a region of deep darkness" **[Is 9:1-2]**.
[17] From then on, Jesus preached, *"Repent; the kingdom of heaven's coming."* **Mt 4:12-17**

Calling Four Fishermen

[18] As he was walking along Lake Galilee, he saw two brothers, Simon called Peter, and Andrew. They were casting nets into the lake; they were fishermen. [19] He told[p] them, *"Come with me, and I'll have you 'fishing' for people."* [20] Right away, they left their nets and went with him.

[21] He went on from there and saw two more brothers, James and John, sons of Zebedee, in a boat with their father, mending nets; and he called them. [22] At once, they left the boat and their father and went with him. **Mt 4:18-22**

The First General Tour of Galilee

[23] He started going all over Galilee, teaching in their synagogues, delivering the good news about the kingdom, and healing all kinds of disease and illness among the people. [24] The news about him spread all over Syria, and they brought him people that were ill, people distressed with various sicknesses and pains, demoniacs, epileptics, paralytics; and he healed them. [25] Big crowds followed him from Galilee, Decapolis, Jerusalem, Judaea, and beyond the Jordan. **Mt 4:23-25**

The Sermon on the Mount**

5:[1] When he saw the crowd, he went up on a hillside and sat down. His disciples joined him, [2] and he started teaching:

[3] *"Poor people are fortunate spiritually;*
they have the kingdom of heaven.
[4] *"People in mourning are fortunate;*
comfort will come.
[5] *"Humble people are fortunate;*
they'll inherit the earth.
[6] *"People that are hungry and thirsty for righteousness are fortunate;*
they'll be satisfied.
[7] *"Merciful people are fortunate;*

they'll receive mercy.

8 *"People that are pure in heart are fortunate;*

they'll see God.

9 *"Peacemakers are fortunate;*

they'll be called God's children.

10 *"People persecuted for living right are fortunate;*

they have the kingdom of heaven. **Mt 5:1-10**

11 *"When people insult you, mistreat you, say all* kinds of *bad things about you falsely because of me, you are fortunate.* **12** *Be glad, because you have a great reward in heaven. They treated the prophets the same way.*

13 *"You are the salt of the earth; but if salt loses its saltiness, what can make it salty? It's not good for anything but to throw out for people to walk on.* **14** *You are the light of the world. A city on a hill can't hide.* **15** *Nobody lights a lamp and sticks it under a basket; they put it on a stand, and it gives light to everybody in the house.* **16** *Let your light shine so people can see the good things you're doing and praise your Father in heaven.*

17 *"Don't get the impression that I'm here to destroy the Law or the Prophets. I'm not here to destroy them, but to fulfill them.* **18** *Earth and sky will pass away, but not one iota or one serif* will pass away from the Law till it's fully accomplished its purpose.* **19** *Whoever breaks one of its least commandments and teaches people to do that, is least in the kingdom of heaven; but whoever does and teaches them is great in that kingdom.* **20** *Unless the way you live is better than the way the scribes and Pharisees live, you won't even get into the kingdom of heaven.* **Mt 5:11-20**

21 *"You've heard that God said long ago,* ***'Do not commit murder'*** **[Ex 20:13; Deut 5:17]***; 'whoever commits murder faces condemnation.'* **22** *I'm telling you, anybody that's mad at someone faces judgment. Whoever says, 'You good for nothing . . .' has the court to face. Whoever says, 'You idiot,' faces a burning hell.* **23** *So if you're taking your gift to the altar and remember your brother has something against you,* **24** *leave it at the altar and go reconcile with him. Then come and offer your gift.* **25** *Come to terms with your opponent quickly while you're on the way to court with him so he doesn't deliver you to the judge, and the judge turn you over to the court assistant, and he put you in jail.* **26** *You won't get out till you pay the last penny.*

27 *"You've heard,* ***'Do not commit adultery'*** **[Ex 20:14; Deut 5:18].** **28** *I'm telling you, anybody that looks at a woman to lust for her has already committed adultery with her in his heart.* **29** *If your right eye is causing you problems, gouge*

it out and throw it away. It's better to lose one part of your body than for your whole body to get thrown into hell. **30** *If your right hand is causing you problems, cut it off and throw it away. It's better to lose one part of your body than for your whole body to go to hell.* **Mt 5:21-30**

31 *"It's been said,* ***'Whoever divorces his wife has to give her divorce papers"*** **[Deut 24:1].** **32** *I'm telling you, whoever divorces his wife—except for adultery—is treating her like an adulteress, and whoever marries a divorced woman commits adultery.*

33 *"Again, you've*[pl] *heard that God said long ago,* ***'Do***[sg] ***not swear falsely'****;* ***'perform your***[sg] ***oaths to the LORD'*** **[Lev 19:12; Num 30:3; Deut 23:21].** **34** *I'm telling you*[pl] *not to swear at all—not by heaven, it's God's throne;* **35** *not by the earth, it's his footstool; not by Jerusalem, it's the city of the Great King;* **36** *not by your head, you can't make one hair white or black.* **37** *Just say 'yes,* I will*' or 'no,* I won't*'; anything more than that comes from the evil one.* **Mt 5:31-37**

38 *"You've heard,* ***'An eye for an eye,' 'a tooth for a tooth'*** **[Ex 21:24; Lev 24:20; Deut 19:21].** **39** *I'm telling you not to try to get even with evil. Whoever slaps you on the right cheek, offer the other one too.* **40** *If somebody sues you for your shirt, give them your coat too.* **41** *If somebody makes* you go one mile, go with them two.* **42** Give *to whoever asks you, and don't turn away from anybody that wants to borrow from you.*

43 *"You've heard,* ***'Love your***[sg] ***neighbor*** **[Lev 19:18]***, and hate your enemy.'* **44** *I'm telling you*[pl] *to love your enemies and pray for people that mistreat you* **45** *so you can be like your Father in heaven. He raises his sun on the good and the bad, and sends rain on the just and the unjust.* **46** *If you love the people that love you, what's special about that? Don't tax collectors do that?* **47** *If you just say 'Hi' to your buddies, what's special about that? Don't even pagans do that?* **48** *You be perfect like* your Father. **Mt 5:38-47**

6:1 *"Be careful about practicing your*[pl] *goodness in public so people will see you. Otherwise, you won't have any reward from your Father in heaven.*

2 *"When you*[sg] *donate to benevolence, don't blow a trumpet like the hypocrites do in the synagogues and on the streets so people will admire them. They have all the reward they're going to get.* **3** *When you donate to benevolence, don't let your left hand know what your right hand's doing.* **4** *That will keep your benevolence will be private, and your Father who sees private things will reward you.*

5 *"When you*[pl] *pray, don't do like the hypocrites. They like to pray standing in the synagogues and on the street corners so people will see them. I tell you*[pl]*,*

they have all the reward they're going to get. **6** *When you*[sg] *pray, go to your private room, shut the door, and pray in private. Your Father, who sees private things, will reward you.* **Mt 6:1-6**

7 *"When you*[pl] *pray, don't say things over and over like pagans do. That doesn't mean anything. They think they'll be listened to because they say lots of words.* **8** *Don't do that. Your Father knows what you need before you ask.* **9** *You pray this way,*

'Our Father in heaven,
you are holy.
10 *May your kingdom come,*
and your will be done
on earth like it is in heaven.
11 *Give us our day's food today.*
12 *Forgive us of our debts*
like we've forgiven our debtors.
13 *Keep us from facing temptation;*
deliver us from the evil one,
[because the kingdom, power, and glory
belong to you forever. Amen.][ms]

14 *If you*[pl] *forgive people, your heavenly Father will forgive you.* **15** *If you don't, he won't forgive you.* **Mt 6:7-15**

16 *"When you*[pl] *fast, don't do like the hypocrites. They neglect their appearance to show people they're fasting. That's all the reward they're going to get.* **17** *When you*[sg] *fast, anoint your head and wash your face* **18** *so you won't be showing people you're fasting. Your Father who sees secret things will reward you.*

19 *"Don't save up wealth on earth, where moths and rust ruin things, and thieves break in and steal them.* **20** *Save up wealth in heaven, where moths and rust don't ruin it, and thieves don't break in and steal it.* **21** *Your heart will be where your wealth is.*

22 *"The eyes are the body's lamp. If you have good eyes, your whole body will have light.* **23** *If your eyes are bad, your whole body will be in the dark. If the light that's in you is darkness, that's serious darkness!* **Mt 6:16-23**

24 *"Nobody can serve two masters. You'll disregard one and be loyal to the other. You can't serve God and money.* **25** *So don't worry about what you'll eat or drink or what you'll wear. Isn't life more than food and the body* more *than clothes?*

26 *"Look at the birds in the sky. They don't plant or harvest or gather into barns, but your heavenly Father feeds them. Aren't you worth more than birds?* **27** *Which one of you, by worrying, can make yourself a foot and a half taller?* **28** *Why worry about clothes? Look how wild flowers grow. They don't spin or toil,* **29** *but Solomon in all his splendor didn't dress like one of them.* **30** *If God dresses the plants in the field that way—here today and thrown in an oven tomorrow—won't he much more dress you, you with little faith?*

31 *"So don't worry about what you're going to eat or what you're going to wear.* **32** *Gentiles strain after things like that. Your heavenly Father knows you need them.* **33** *Strive after his kingdom and his goodness, and they'll come along with it.* **34** *Don't worry about tomorrow; it will worry about itself.* **Mt 6:24-34**

7:1 *"Don't criticize and you*[pl] *won't get criticized.* **2** *The criticism you*[pl] *criticize with, you'll*[pl] *be criticized by; the measure you*[pl] *measure with, you'll*[pl] *be measured by.* **3** *Why look*[sg] *at a speck of sawdust in somebody else's eye, and not see the log in your*[sg] *own?* **4** *How can you*[sg] *say, 'Let me get the piece of sawdust out of your*[sg] *eye,' when there's a log in yours!?* **5** *You foolish people, get*[sg] *the log out of your own eye so you*[sg] *can see to get the speck of sawdust out of theirs.*

6 *"Don't give sacred things to dogs or throw your pearls in front of pigs. They'll trample them under their feet and turn on you and tear you apart.*

7 *"Ask and you'll get, seek and you'll find, knock and it'll open for you.* **8** *People that ask get, people that seek find, and people that knock it opens for.* **9** *If your boy asked for a loaf of bread, you wouldn't give him a rock, would you?* **10** *If he asked for a fish, would you give him a snake?* **11** *If <u>you</u>, who are sinful, know how to give good gifts to your kids, how much more will your Father in heaven give good things to people that ask him?* **12** *Treat other people the way you want them to treat <u>you</u>. That covers the Law and the Prophets.* **Mt 7:1-12**

13 *"Go through the narrow gate. It's a broad road and a wide gate that leads to destruction, and many go through it.* **14** *How narrow the path is and tight the gate that leads to life! Not many find it.*

15 *"Watch out for false prophets that come to you in wool, but inside they're wolves.* **16** *You can recognize them by what they produce. People don't gather grapes from thorns or figs from thistles, do they?* **17-18** *Good trees bear good fruit; bad trees bear bad fruit.* **19** *Every tree that doesn't bear good fruit gets chopped down and thrown into the fire.* **20** *So, you can recognize them by what they produce.*

[21] *"Not everybody that <u>says</u> to me 'Lord' is going to get into the kingdom of heaven. It's the ones that <u>do</u> the will of my Father in heaven.* [22]*A lot of people will try to say to me in that day, 'Lord, didn't we prophesy in your name, cast out demons in your name, and do lots of miracles in your name?'* [23]*I'll tell them, 'I never knew you. Go away, sinners.'* **Mt 7:13-23**

[24] *"Everybody that hears what I'm saying and does it, is like a wise man that built his house on bedrock.* [25]*Rain fell, floods came, winds blew and beat on it; but it didn't collapse. He'd built it on bedrock.*

[26] *"Everybody that hears what I'm saying and doesn't do it, is like a foolish man that built his house on sand.* [27]*Rain fell, floods came, winds blew and beat on it, and it collapsed—a total loss."*

[28]When Jesus finished, the crowd was amazed at his teaching. [29]He taught them like somebody that had authority, not like their scribes. **Mt 7:24:29**

Cleansing a Leper

8:[1]When Jesus came down from the hillside, big crowds followed him. [2]A leper came and knelt down to him, *"Sir, if you're willing, you can cleanse me."*

[3]Jesus reached out and touched him, *"I'm willing; be cleansed."* Instantly his leprosy disappeared. [4]Jesus told[p] him, *"Don't tell anybody.* Instead, for *a public statement, show yourself to a priest and offer the gift Moses commanded."* **Mt 8:1-4**

Healing the Centurion's Servant

[5]He went to Capernaum, and a centurion came and appealed to him, [6] *"Sir, my servant is laid up at home paralyzed and tormented terribly."*

[7]Jesus said[p], *"I'll come and heal him."*

[8]But the centurion answered, *"I don't deserve to have you under my roof. Just say the word, and my servant will be healed.* [9]*I'm under authority myself, with soldiers under <u>me</u>. I say, 'Go.' and they go; to another, 'Do this,' and he does it."*

[10]Jesus was impressed and told the people that were following him, *"I haven't found faith like that in Israel.* [11]*Lots of people will come from the east and west, and recline at table with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob in the kingdom of heaven;* [12]*but citizens of the kingdom will be thrown out into the dark. There'll be crying and chattering of teeth."*

[13]He told the centurion, *"Go on, it'll happen according to your faith."* His servant was cured the same hour. **Mt 8:5-13**

Teaching and Miracles in Capernaum

[14]Jesus went to Peter's house and saw his mother-in-law in bed with a fever. [15]He touched her hand and the fever left. She got up and started waiting on him.

[16]That evening, people brought him a number of demon-possessed people, and he cast the spirits out with a word. [17]As Isaiah the prophet said,

"He took our weaknesses
and bore our illnesses" **[Is 53:4].** **Mt 8:14-17**

A Conversation About Following Jesus

[18]When Jesus saw a crowd around him, he gave instructions to leave for the other side of the lake.

[19]A scribe came, *"Rabbi, I'll go with you wherever you go."*

[20]Jesus said[p], *"Foxes have dens and birds have nests, but the Son of Man doesn't have a place to lay his head."*

[21]Another of his disciples said, *"Let me go bury my father first."*

[22]*"Come on with me; let the dead bury their dead."* **Mt 8:18-22**

Stilling the Storm

[23]He got in the boat, and his disciples left with him. [24]A dangerous storm came up, and the waves were beginning to splash into the boat. He was sleeping. [25]*The disciples went and* woke him up, *"Lord, help* us*! We're going to die!"*

[26]*"Why are you so scared? Where's your faith?"* He got up and rebuked the wind, and a general calm settled in.

[27]They were astounded, *"What kind of man is this who can even make the wind and waves obey?"* **Mt 8:23-27**

Healing the Gadarene Demoniac

[28]When he got to the region of the Gadarenes on the other side, two demon-possessed men from the tombs met him. They were so vicious nobody dared to go around there. [29]They started crying out, *"What is this, you Son of God? Did you come to torment us ahead of time?"*

[30]A little way off a tremendous herd of pigs was feeding. [31]The demons begged, *"If you're going to cast us out, send us into the pigs."*

[32]*"Go ahead."*

They went into the pigs, and the whole herd stampeded down the steep place into the lake and drowned. [33]The herdsmen ran away to town and reported everything, including what had happened to the demoniacs. [34]The whole town came out to meet Jesus. When they saw him, they begged him to leave. **Mt 8:28-34**

Healing a Paralyzed Man

9:[1]They got in the boat and crossed back over to his town. [2]Some men were trying to bring him a paralyzed man on a stretcher. When he saw their faith, he said to the man, *"Take heart, son; I've forgiven your sins."*

[3]Some of the scribes said to themselves, *"He's blaspheming!"*

[4]Jesus knew what they were thinking, *"Why are you thinking critical things?* [5]*Which is easier, to say, 'I've forgiven your sins' or 'Get up and walk'?* [6]*So you can know that the Son of Man has the right on earth to forgive sins"*—he said[p] to the man, *"Get up, pick up your stretcher, and go home."* [7]He got up and went home. [8]When the crowd saw it, they were afraid and praised God for giving such authority to mortals. **Mt 9:1-8**

Calling Matthew;
Controversy About Table Fellowship

[9]Jesus went along from there and saw a man called Matthew sitting at the tax booth, and said[p], *"Come with me."* He got up and went with him. [10]While he was reclining at table in Matthew's house, many tax collectors and sinners came and reclined at table with Jesus and his disciples. [11]When the Pharisees saw it, they started saying, *"Why is your Rabbi eating with tax collectors and sinners?"*

[12]He overheard it, *"Healthy people don't need a doctor; sick ones do.* [13]*Go figure out what this means,* ***'I want mercy more than sacrifice'*** **[Hos 6:6]**. *I didn't come so much to call good people, as* to call *sinners."* **Mt 9:9-13**

Questions About Fasting

[14]Then John's disciples came, *"Why do we and the Pharisees fast often, but your disciples don't fast?"*

[15]Jesus said,

> *"The groomsmen can't feel sad while the groom is around, can they? The time's coming when the groom will be taken away. They'll fast then.* [16]*Nobody puts a patch of unshrunk cloth on an old garment. The new material would pull away from the old garment and make the tear worse.* [17]*People don't put new wine in old wineskins. The wineskins would burst and be ruined, and the wine would drain out. They put new wine in new wineskins, and both are preserved."*
>
> **Mt 9:14-17**

Healing a Woman from Hemorrhaging;
Raising of Jairus' Daughter

[18]While he was saying that, a ruler came and knelt to him, *"My daughter has just died. If you come and put your hand on her, she'll come back to life."* [19]Jesus and his disciples followed him.

[20]A woman with chronic bleeding for 12 years came up behind him and touched the fringe of his cloak. [21]She said to herself, *"If I can just touch his cloak, I'll be cured."*

22Jesus turned and saw her, *"It's okay, daughter, your faith has cured you*." She was cured from then on.

23Jesus went into the ruler's house and saw flute players and a crowd making an uproar, **24***"You can go; the girl's not dead; she's 'asleep.'"* They started to ridicule him. **25**When he'd put them out, he went in and took the girl's hand and raised her up. **26**That news *about the miracle* got out into the whole area. **Mt 9:18-26**

Healing Two Blind Men and a Mute Man with a Demon

27As Jesus was leaving, two blind men followed him, shouting, *"Son of David, have mercy on us!"* **28**When he went into the house, they came to him. Jesus said, *"Do you believe I can do this?"*

"Yes."

29Jesus touched their eyelids, *"Let it happen according to your faith"*; **30**and they could see. Jesus strictly warned them to keep this to themselves. **31**But they went out and spread the news about him all over that area.

32As they were leaving, people brought him a demon-possessed man that couldn't talk. **33**When Jesus had cast out the demon, the man could speak. The crowd was amazed, *"Nothing like this has ever happened in Israel."* **34**The Pharisees were claiming he was casting out demons by the ruler of demons. **Mt 9:27-34**

The Mission of the Twelve; Jesus' Third Tour of Galilee

35Jesus was traveling around the towns and villages, teaching in their synagogues, delivering the good news about the kingdom, and healing all *kinds of* disease and illness. **36**When he saw the crowds, he felt sorry for them. They were stressed and scattered like sheep without a shepherd. **37**He told[p] his disciples, *"There's a big crop to harvest, but there aren't many workers.* **38***Ask the harvest foreman to put more workers in his harvest."* **Mt 9:35-38**

10:1 He called his twelve disciples together and gave them authority to cast out unclean spirits and heal all *kinds of* disease and illness. **2**These are the twelve apostles: Simon called Peter; his brother Andrew; James son of Zebedee, his brother John, **3**Philip, Bartholomew, Thomas, Matthew the tax collector, James son of Alphaeus, Thaddaeus, **4**Simon the Cananaean, and Judas Iscariot, who also betrayed him *in the end*.

5Jesus sent out these twelve,

> *"Don't go out among Gentiles or to any Samaritan town.* **6***Go to the lost sheep in Israel.* **7***As you go, say, 'The kingdom of heaven is coming.'* **8***Heal the*

sick, raise the dead, cleanse lepers, cast out demons. You've received at no charge; give at no charge.

9 *"Don't get any gold, silver, or copper coins for your money belts.* **10** Don't get *a traveler's bag, a staff, shoes, or two shirts for the trip. Workers deserve their wages.* **Mt 10:1-10**

11 *"Whatever town or village you go into, find out who's worthy in it, and stay at that place till you leave.* **12** *When you go into a house, greet it.* **13** *If the house is worthy, let your peace rest on it. If not, take it back.*

14 *"Whoever doesn't welcome you or listen to what you have to say, go outside that house or town and shake the dust off your feet.* **15** *On judgment day it'll be more bearable for Sodom and Gomorrah than for that town.*

16 *"I'm sending you*[pl] *out like sheep among wolves, so be as subtle as snakes and harmless as doves.* **17** *Watch out for people, because they'll deliver you up to the courts and flog you in their synagogues.* **18** *They'll take you in front of governors and kings because of me as a testimony to them and the Gentiles.* **19** *When they deliver you up to the courts, don't worry about how or what to say. It'll come to you at the time.* **20** *You won't be the ones talking; your Father's Holy Spirit will be speaking in you*[pl].

21 *"Brothers will betray brothers to death; fathers will betray sons.* **22** *Everybody will hate you because of me. Whoever stays with it to the end will be saved.* **23** *When they persecute you in one town, flee to the next. You won't get around to all the towns in Israel before the Son of Man comes.* **Mt 10:11-23**

24 *"Students have it no better than their teachers, and servants have it no better than their masters.* **25** *It's enough for a student to become like the teacher and a servant to be like the master. If they've called the head of the house Beelzebub, how much worse the members of his household.*

26 *"Don't be afraid of them. Everything that's covered up will become public; everything that's hidden will come out in the open.* **27** *What I tell you in the dark, say in the light; what's whispered in your ear, announce from the housetops.* **28** *Don't be afraid of people that kill the body but can't kill the soul. Be more afraid of the One that can kill both soul and body in hell.* **29** *Aren't two sparrows sold for a dollar, and not one of them falls to the ground without your Father* knowing it? **30** *The very hairs on your head are all numbered,* **31** *so don't be afraid; you're worth more than lots of sparrows.*

32 *"Everybody that acknowledges me to* other *people,*

I'll acknowledge to my Father in heaven.

33 *Whoever denies who I am to* other *people,*

I'll deny to my Father in heaven as belonging to me. **Mt 10:24-33**

34 *"Don't think I've come to bring peace to the earth.*
I didn't come to bring peace, but a sword, **35** *to turn*
son ***'against father,'***
'daughter against mother,'
'daughter-in-law against mother-in-law.'
36 ***'People's enemies will be in their own houses'*** **[Mic 7:6]**.

37 *"If you love father or mother more than me, you don't deserve me.*
If you love son or daughter more than me you don't deserve me.
38 *If you don't pick up your cross and follow me, you don't deserve me.*
39 *If you find your life, you'll lose it;*
if you lose your life over me, you'll find it.
40 *"Anyone that receives you receives me;*
Anyone that receives me receives the One that sent me.
41 *If you receive a prophet as a prophet,*
you'll receive a prophet's reward.
If you receive good people as good people,
you'll receive a good person's reward.
42 *If you give one of these little ones*
even a cup of cool water as a disciple,
you'll certainly receive reward."

11:1 When Jesus had finished giving his disciples directions, he went off to teach and preach in their towns. **Mt 10:34-11:1**

John's Question and
Jesus' Comments on John

2 In prison John heard what the Messiah was doing and sent disciples **3** to ask him, *"Are <u>you</u> the One to come or should we wait for somebody else?"*

4 Jesus answered them, *"Tell John what you're seeing:* **5** *the blind see, the lame walk, lepers are cleansed, the deaf hear, the dead resurrect, and the poor are hearing the good news.* **6** *He is blessed that's not disappointed in me."*

7 While they were leaving, Jesus started talking to the crowd about John,

"What did you go out to the desert to see? A reed waving in the wind? **8** *What did you go out to see? Somebody dressed in fine clothes? People that wear fine clothes live in palaces.* **9** *What <u>did</u> you go out to see? A prophet? Oh yes, and more than a prophet.* **10** *He's the one scripture refers to,*

'I'll send my messenger ahead of you
to get the road ready for you' **[Ex 23:20; Mal 3:1]**.

[11]*I'm telling you, nobody that's ever been born is greater than John the Baptist, but the least in the kingdom of heaven is greater than him.* [12]*From his time till now, violent people have been trying to bring in the kingdom of heaven by force.* [13]*All the Prophets and the Law prophesied till John.* [14]*If you're ready to accept it, he is the Elijah that was to come.* [15]*Whoever has ears, listen!* **Mt 11:2-15**

[16]*"What are people like today? They're like kids sitting in a marketplace, calling out to one another,*

[17]*'We played a flute for you, but you didn't dance.*
We wept, but you didn't mourn.'

[18]*John came, not eating or drinking, and people said, 'He's got a demon.'* [19]*The Son of Man came eating and drinking, and they say, 'A glutton and a drunk, a pal of tax collectors and sinners.' Wisdom is vindicated by what it produces."*

Mt 11:16-19

Cities Denounced for Unbelief:
The Great Invitation

[20]He began to denounce the towns where many of his miracles had happened, because they didn't repent.

[21]*"Woe to you, Chorazin! Woe to you, Bethsaida! If the miracles that happened in you had happened in Tyre and Sidon, they would've repented long ago in burlap and ashes.* [22]*On judgment day, it'll be more bearable for them than for you.*

[23]*"And you, Capernaum, you won't rise up to heaven, will you? You'll go down to hell. If the miracles that took place in you had happened in Sodom, they'd still be here.* [24]*On judgment day, it'll be more bearable for the area around Sodom than for you."*

[25]Then Jesus said,

"I praise you, Father, Lord of heaven and earth, for hiding these things from the wise and intelligent, and revealing them to the innocent. [26]*Yes, you delighted in doing it that way."*

[27]*"The Father has handed everything over to me, and nobody knows the Son but the Father, and nobody knows the Father but the Son and whoever the Son wants to reveal him to.*

[28]*"All of you that labor and carry heavy loads, come to me; you'll get some rest.* [29]*Put my yoke on and learn about me. I'm gentle and humble, and you'll get relief.* [30]*My yoke fits right, and my load is light."* **Mt 11:20-30**

Another Controversy About Breaking Sabbath

12:[1]At that time, Jesus was walking along through grain fields on the Sabbath. His disciples were hungry and started picking off heads of wheat and eating the seeds.

[2]When some Pharisees saw it, they said, *"Your disciples are breaking the Law."*

[3]He said, *"You've read, haven't you, what David and his men did when they needed food?* [4]*He went into God's house, and* he and his men *ate the consecrated loaves that were against the Law for him and his men to eat,* loaves *that were only for priests.* [5]*Or, you've read in the Law, haven't you, how the priests in the Temple desecrate Sabbath and remain innocent?* [6]*Something more important than the Temple is here.* [7]*If you'd known what this means,* ***'I want mercy more than sacrifice'*** **[Hos 6:6]**, *you wouldn't have criticized innocent people.* [8]*A person is more important than the Sabbath."*[lit] **Mt 12:1-8**

Healing a Man with a Paralyzed Hand

[9]He left and went into their synagogue. [10]A man with a paralyzed hand was there, and they asked Jesus if it was lawful to heal on a Sabbath (so they could accuse him).

[11]He said, *"Wouldn't any of you pull your sheep out that fell in a ravine on a Sabbath?* [12]*A person's worth more than a sheep. So, it's lawful to do good on a Sabbath."*

[13]Then he told the man, *"Hold out your hand."* It was restored like the other one. [14]The Pharisees went out and plotted to destroy him. **Mt 12:9-14**

Jesus and the Multitudes:
Teaching and Healing

[15]Jesus knew it and left. Many [crowds][ms] followed him, and he healed them all [16]and charged them not to expose him—[17]in fulfillment of what Isaiah the prophet said,

> [18]***"My servant that I've chosen,***
> ***my dearly loved one I delight in—***
> ***I'll put my Spirit on him,***
> ***and he'll render justice for the nations.***
> [19]***He won't quarrel or shout;***
> ***nobody will hear him in the streets.***
> [20]***He won't break a bent reed***
> ***or put out smoking flax,***
> ***till he brings justice to victory.***
> [21]***The nations will put their hope in him"*** **[Is 42:1-4]**. **Mt 12:15-21**

Pharisees' Charge That Jesus Was
in League with the Devil

[22]They brought Jesus a demon-possessed blind mute, and he healed him; he could speak and see. [23]The crowds were astounded, *"This isn't the Son of David, is it?"*

[24]When the Pharisees heard *about it*, they said, *"He casts out demons by Beelzebub, the ruler of demons."*

[25]He knew what they were thinking and told them,

"Every kingdom at cross purposes with itself becomes desolate; no city or family at cross purposes with itself will stand. [26]*If Satan casts out Satan, he's at cross purposes with himself; how would his kingdom stand?* [27]*If I cast out demons by Beelzebub, who do your students cast them out by? Judge for yourselves.*

[28]*"If I cast out demons by God's Spirit, then God's kingdom has reached you.* [29]*How can somebody go into a strong man's house and seize his property unless he ties him up first? Then he can ransack his house.*

[30]*"Whoever's not with me is against me, and whoever doesn't gather with me scatters around.* [31]*So, every sin and blasphemy can be forgiven except blasphemy against the Spirit.* [32]*Whoever insults me can be forgiven, but whoever blasphemes the Holy Spirit won't be forgiven in this age or the next.*

[33]*"Consider a tree and its fruit good or bad together, because by its fruit a tree is known to be good or bad.* [34]You *bunch of poisonous snakes! How can you bad people say good things? The mouth says what the heart holds.* [35]*A good person brings good things out of his good treasure; a bad person brings out bad things.*

[36]*"At the judgment, people will account for every off-handed comment they make.* [37]*What you say will justify you or condemn you."* **Mt 12:22-37**

Scribes and Pharisees Demand a Sign

[38]Some scribes and Pharisees answered, *"Rabbi, we want to see you do a sign."*

[39]He answered them,

"A sinful, adulterous generation is straining to see a sign, but it won't get one—except the sign of the prophet Jonah. [40]*As* ***'Jonah was in the stomach of the sea monster for three days and nights'*** **[Jon 1:17]**, *the Son of Man will be in the ground for three days and nights.* [41]*The people of Nineveh will stand up in the judgment with people from today and condemn them. They repented at Jonah's preaching; something greater than Jonah is here.* [42]*The queen of the South will rise up in the judgment with people from today and condemn them; she came from the ends of the earth to hear Solomon's wisdom; something greater than Solomon is here.*

43"*When an unclean spirit leaves someone, it wanders through desert places looking for rest and doesn't find any.* 44*It says, 'I'm going back to the house I left.' It goes and finds it empty, swept out, and decorated.* 45*Then it takes seven spirits worse than itself, goes in and takes up permanent residence. The person's last condition is worse than the first. That's how it'll be with today's bad people."* **Mt 12:38-45**

Jesus' Mother and Brothers
Interrupt His Ministry

46While Jesus was talking to the crowd, his mother and brothers were standing outside of the crowd, trying to get to him to talk to him. 47Someone told him, *"Your mother and your brothers have been standing outside, trying to get to talk to you."*

48He answered the person, *"Who's my mother? Who are my brothers?"* 49He held out his hand toward his disciples, *"My mother and my brothers!* 50*My brother, my sister, my mother is whoever does the will of my Father in heaven."* **Mt 12:46-50**

The Sermon in Stories

13:1Jesus left the house that day and sat down by the lake. 2So many people were gathering that he got in a boat and sat down while the crowd stood on the shore. 3He told them lots of things with stories.

"A sower went out to sow his seed. 4*As he sowed, some seed fell along the path, and birds came along and ate it.*

5*"Some fell on rocky ground. It sprouted up right away because there wasn't much soil.* 6*But when the sun climbed high, the seed dried up because it didn't have roots.*

7*"Some fell among thorns, and the thorns grew up and choked it out.*

8*"But others fell on good ground and yielded 30, 60, or 100 times as much as he planted.*

9*"Whoever has ears, listen!"* **Mt 13:1-9**

10The disciples came and asked, *"Why are you telling them stories?"*

11*"Because <u>you</u>'re allowed to know unrevealed things about the kingdom of heaven, but <u>they</u>'re not.* 12*Whoever has, will receive; whoever doesn't have, will lose even what he has.* 13*That's why I'm telling them stories: though they see, they don't see; though they hear, they don't hear or understand.* 14*They illustrate the way Isaiah describes them:*

'You can certainly see, but don't understand;
you can certainly hear, but don't perceive,

[15]***because you've become insensitive;***
you're hard of hearing and
you've closed your eyes
so you don't see or hear,
understand or change
so I can heal you' **[Is 6:9-10].** **Mt 13:10-15**

[16] *"But your eyes are fortunate because they see; and your ears are fortunate, because they hear.* [17]*Many prophets and good people have wanted to see what you're seeing and didn't see it, and to hear what you're hearing and didn't hear it.*

[18] *"You listen, then, to the story about the sower.*

[19] *"People that hear the message about the kingdom and don't understand it are the ones the devil comes to and snatches what was planted in their heart: they're the seed sown along the path.*

[20] *"Seed sown on rocky soil represents people that hear the message and are glad to accept it right away,* [21]*but they don't have root in themselves and don't last. When difficulties or persecution come because of the message, they give up their faith right away.*

[22] *"Seed sown among thorns represents people that hear the message, and the cares of the world and the deception of wealth choke it out, and it doesn't produce anything.*

[23] *"Seed sown on good ground represents people that hear the word and understand it, who produce 30, 60, 100 times as much as sown."* **Mt 13:16-23**

[24]He presented another story.

"The kingdom of heaven is like a man that sowed clean seed in his field. [25]*While people were sleeping, his enemy came and sowed darnels in the wheat.* [26]*When the plants grew and began to mature, the darnels appeared too.* [27]*The servants came to the owner, 'Master, didn't you plant clean seed in your field? Where'd darnels come from?'*

[28] *"The owner said, 'An enemy has done this.'*

"'Do you want us to go pull them up?'

[29] *"'No, that would uproot the wheat too.* [30]*Let them both grow till harvest. I'll tell the reapers, "Gather up the darnels first and bundle them to burn, but gather the wheat into my granary."'*

[31] *"The kingdom of heaven is like a mustard seed a fellow planted in his garden.* [32]*What's the smallest of seeds, when grown, is bigger than the garden plants and becomes a tree, so birds come and build nests in its branches.*

[33] *"The kingdom of heaven is like yeast a woman put in a bushel of meal till the whole bushel had risen."*

[34]Jesus only taught the crowd these things with stories [35]like the prophet said,

"I'll speak to them with stories
and tell them things not revealed since the founding of the world"
[Ps 78:2]. **Mt 13:24-35**

Further Private Instruction in Stories

[36]When he left the crowd and went into the house, his disciples came, *"Explain the story about the darnels in the field."*

[37]Jesus answered,

"The One who sowed the clean seed is the Son of Man, [38]the field is the world, the clean seed is the people of the kingdom, the darnels are the ones that belong to the evil one, [39]the enemy that sowed them is the devil, [40]the harvest is the end of the age, the reapers are angels. [41]The darnels are gathered and burned just like it'll be at the end of the age: the Son of Man will send his angels to rid his realm of evil people and everything that makes people stumble, [42]and throw them in the furnace. There'll be crying and gritting teeth there. [43]Good people will shine like the sun in their Father's kingdom. Whoever has ears, listen!

[44] *"The kingdom of heaven is like a treasure a man found hidden in a field. He hid it* again *and in his excitement went[p] and sold[p] everything he had and bought[p] that field.*

[45] *"The kingdom is like a businessman that was looking for valuable pearls. [46]When he found a really valuable one, he sold everything he had and bought it.*

[47] *"The kingdom's like a net cast into the sea that gathers all kinds of fish. [48]When it's full, the fishermen pull it up on shore and sit down. They put the good ones in containers and throw the bad ones away. [49]That's how it'll be at the end of the world. The angels will come and separate the bad from the good, [50]and throw them in the furnace. There will be crying and gritting of teeth there.*

[51] *"Do you understand?"*

"Yes."

[52] *"So, every scribe that's become a disciple in the kingdom is like a homeowner that brings out of his holdings things new and old."*

[53]When Jesus had finished those stories, he left. **Mt 13:36-53**

Last Visit to Nazareth

54When he came to his hometown; he began to teach them in their synagogue. They were astonished, *"Where'd he get that wisdom and those miracles?* **55***Isn't Mary his mother? Aren't James, Joseph, Simon, and Judas his brothers?* **56***Aren't his sisters all with us? Where'd he get all that?"* **57**They were put off by him.

He told them, *"A prophet is respected everywhere but at home."* **58**He didn't do many miracles there because of their lack of faith. **Mt 13:54-58**

Herod's Conscience Stricken;
Confusion of John the Baptist and Jesus

14:1 Herod the tetraarch heard about Jesus **2**and told his servants, *"That's John the Baptist, risen from the dead. That's why he has miraculous powers."* **3**Herod had arrested John, bound him, and put him in prison over Herodias, his brother Philip's *former* wife. **4**John kept telling him, *"It's against the Law for you to be living with her."* **5**Although Herod wanted to put him to death, he was afraid of the people. They considered John a prophet.

6But when Herod's birthday came, Herodias' daughter danced at the banquet, and it pleased Herod. **7**So he solemnly swore to give her whatever she asked for. **8**Prompted by her mother, she said, *"Give me here the head of John the Baptist on a platter."* **9**Although the king was grieved, because of the oaths and those reclining at table with him, he commanded it to be given. **10**He had John beheaded in the prison. **11**They brought his head and gave it to the girl, and she took it to her mother. **12***John's* disciples came and took the corpse and buried it, and went to tell Jesus. **Mt 14:1-12**

Feeding the 5,000

13When he heard the news, he withdrew by boat into open country privately. The crowds heard *where he was going* and followed him on foot from the towns. **14**When he got out, he saw a large crowd and felt sorry for them and healed their sick.

15In the evening his disciples came, *"Nobody lives around here, and it's getting late. Dismiss the crowd so they can go to the villages and buy food."*

16Jesus said, *"They don't need to leave. Feed them."*

17 *"We only have five loaves and two fish."*

18 *"Bring them here."*

19He told the crowd to sit down on the grass. He took the five loaves and two fish, looked up to heaven and blessed them, broke them up for the disciples to give to the crowd. **20**Everybody ate their fill, and *the disciples* picked up twelve medium-sized baskets of leftovers. **21**About 5,000 men had eaten—plus women and children. **Mt 14:13-21**

Jesus Walking on the Water

22He urged the disciples to get in the boat right way and go on to the other side *of the lake* while he dismissed the crowd. **23**When he'd dismissed them, he went up on the hill by himself to pray. When evening came, he was there alone. **24**The boat was already a long way from land, and waves were bashing it because the wind was against them. **25**About 4 in the morning, he went to them, walking on the lake. **26**When they saw him, they were terrified. *"It's a ghost!"* they cried out in fear.

27At once Jesus spoke, *"It's me. Don't be afraid."*

28Peter responded, *"If it's you, tell me to come to you on the water."*

29 *"Come on."*

Peter got down out of the boat and started walking to Jesus on the water. **30**But when he saw the strong wind, he got scared and started to sink. He cried out, *"Save me!"*

31At once Jesus reached out and grabbed him, *"One with little faith, why did you doubt?"*

32When they climbed up into the boat, the wind died down. **33**The ones in the boat bowed to him, *"You really must be God's Son!"* **Mt 14:22-33**

Miracles at Gennesaret

34When they got across, they landed at Gennesaret. **35**The people recognized him and sent out into that whole area for everybody that was sick. **36**They pleaded with him just to let them touch the fringe of his cloak. As many as touched him were cured. **Mt 14:34-36**

Attack by the Jerusalem Pharisees
About Traditions

15:1 Then Pharisees and scribes came[p] from Jerusalem, **2** *"Why don't your disciples keep the tradition of the elders? They don't wash their hands before they eat."*

3He answered them,

> *"Why do you transgress God's commandment with your tradition?* **4***A case in point: God said,* ***'Honor your parents'*** **[Ex 20:12; Deut 5:16],** *and* ***'Execute whoever cusses at his father or mother'*** **[Ex 21:17].** **5***But you say, 'Whoever says to his father or mother, "I've given God what you could have used,"* **6***certainly wouldn't be honoring his father. You've negated God's word with your tradition.*
> **7***You foolish people, Isaiah described you well,*
>
> **8** ***'These people honor me with their lips,***
> ***but their heart is far from me.***
> **9** ***They worship me without meaning it,***
> ***and teach their rules as doctrines'"*** **[Is 29:12 LXX].**

10He called the crowd, *"Listen and get this.* **11***It's not what goes in your mouth that defiles you, but what comes out of it."*

[12]Then the disciples came to him, *"Do you realize you offended the Pharisees with what you said?"*

[13] *"Every plant my heavenly Father hasn't planted will be pulled up.* [14]*Let them alone; they're blind guides of the blind. If the blind guides the blind, they both fall into the ditch."*

[15]Peter said, *"What does your illustration mean?"*

> [16] *"You*[pl] *still don't understand either?* [17]*You do know, don't you, that everything that goes into your mouth goes into your stomach and is eliminated in the toilet.* [18]*But what comes out of your mouth comes from your heart. That's what defiles you.* [19]*Evil thoughts, murder, adultery, sexual immorality, stealing, lying, insults come from your heart.* [20]*They are what defile you. Not washing your hands when you eat doesn't defile you."* **Mt 15:1-20**

Healing the Syrophoenician Woman's Daughter

[21]Jesus left for the territory around Tyre and Sidon. [22]A Canaanite woman there began to shout, *"Have mercy on me, Lord, Son of David! My daughter's cruelly demon-possessed!"* [23]But Jesus didn't answer her.

His disciples came and asked him, *"Send her away; she keeps shouting behind us."*

[24]He answered *her*, *"I was just sent to the lost sheep in Israel."*

[25]But she came and bowed down, *"Help me, Lord."*

[26] *"It's not right to take the kids' food and toss it to the house dogs."*

[27] *"Yes, but even house dogs eat the crumbs that fall from their owners' table."*

[28] *"Dear woman, you have strong faith. Have what you asked for."* Her daughter was healed from then on. **Mt 15:21-28**

Ministry in Decapolis;
Feeding the 4,000

[29]Jesus crossed Lake Galilee and went up on a hill and sat down. [30]Big crowds came with lame, blind, disabled, mute, and other conditions, and put them by him to heal them. [31]They were amazed at seeing the mute speak, the crippled cured, the lame walk, the blind see; and they praised Israel's God.

[32]Jesus called his disciples to him, *"I feel for the crowd. They've stayed with me three days without anything to eat. I don't want to send them away hungry for fear they'll give out on the way."*

[33]His disciples said[p], *"Where can we get enough bread out in the country to satisfy such a crowd?"*

[34] *"How many loaves do you have?"*

"Seven—and a few small fish."

[35]He had the crowd sit down on the ground. [36]He took the seven loaves and the fish, blessed them, and broke them up for the disciples to pass out to the crowd. [37]They all ate their fill, and the *disciples* picked up seven large baskets of leftover pieces. [38]4,000 men ate—besides women and children. [39]After he dismissed them, he got in a boat and went to the area around Magadan. **Mt 15:29-39**

Visit to Magadan;
Demand for a Sign from the Sky

16:[1]The Pharisees and Sadducees came, testing him, asking for a sign from the sky.

[2]He answered, *"When evening comes, you say, 'It'll be fair weather; the sky's red.' [3]In the morning, 'It'll be bad weather today; the sky's red and dark.' You can read the sky, but you can't read the signs of the times. [4]A sinful, adulterous generation keeps looking for a sign, but it's not going to get one—except for the sign of Jonah."* He left. **Mt 16:1-4**

Fourth Withdrawal East of the Lake;
Warning to the Disciples

[5]The disciples went to the other side *of the lake* and had forgotten to take bread. [6]Jesus told them, *"Watch out for the 'yeast' from the Pharisees and Sadducees."*

[7]They started talking among themselves, *"He said that because we didn't bring any bread."*

[8]Jesus knew it, *"Men with little faith, why are you talking about not having any bread? [9]Don't you understand or remember the 5 loaves for the 5,000 and how many medium-sized baskets full you picked up, [10]or the 7 loaves for the 4,000 and how many large baskets full you picked up? [11]How do you not know I wasn't talking about bread!? Watch out for the 'yeast' from the Pharisees and Sadducees."* [12]Then they got it; he hadn't warned them about the yeast in bread, but about the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees. **Mt 16:5-12**

Peter's Great Confession

[13]When Jesus came into the area around Caesarea Philippi, he asked his disciples, *"Who are people saying the Son of Man is?"*

[14] *"John the Baptist, Elijah, Jeremiah, one of the prophets."*

[15] *"Who do <u>you</u> say I am?"*

[16]Simon Peter said, *"You're the Messiah, the Son of the living God."*

[17] *"Bless you, Simon Barjonah. You didn't get that from other people, but from my heavenly Father. [18]As sure as you're 'Peter,' I'll build my church on that 'rock.' Even the gates of the grave won't be strong enough to stop it. [19]I'll give you*[sg] *the keys to the kingdom of heaven. Whatever you lock up on earth will be locked up in heaven, and whatever you unlock on earth will be unlocked in heaven."* [20]Then he charged them not to tell anybody he was the Messiah.

Mt 16:13-20

The First Prediction of His Death

21From then on Jesus started showing his disciples that he had to go to Jerusalem; suffer many things from the elders, chief priests, and scribes; be put to death, and resurrect the third day.

22But Peter pulled him aside and got after him, *"That's not going to happen to you!"*

23But Jesus turned away from him, *"Get behind me, Satan. You're being a stumbling block to me. You don't have God's interests in mind, but people's interests."*

24Then he told his disciples,

> *"If anybody wants to follow me, he has to set his own interests aside, pick up his cross, and follow me.* **25***Whoever wants to save his life will lose it, and whoever loses it over me will find it.* **26***What good does it do to get the whole world and lose your life? What will you give in exchange for your life?* **27***The Son of Man will come in the glory of his Father with his angels.* **28***Some people standing here won't die before they see the Son of Man coming in his kingdom.*

Mt 16:21-28

The Transfiguration

17:1 Six days later, Jesus took[p] Peter, James, and his brother John up on a tall mountain by themselves **2**and was transfigured in front of them. His face glowed like the sun, and his clothes turned as white as light. **3**Moses and Elijah appeared to them and were talking to him.

4Peter responded, *"Lord, it's good to be here. If you want, I'll put up three tents—one each for you and Moses and Elijah."*

5While he was still talking, a bright cloud engulfed them, and a voice said, *"This is my dearly loved Son that I delight in. Listen to him."*

6When the disciples heard it, they fell on their faces terrified. **7**Jesus came and touched them, *"Get up; don't be afraid."* **8**They looked up and didn't see anybody but Jesus. **Mt 17:1-8**

Discussing the Vision

9As they were coming down the mountain, Jesus impressed on them, *"Don't tell anybody what you saw till I've resurrected from the dead."*

10The disciples asked, *"Why do the scribes say Elijah has to come first?"*

11 *"Elijah does come first to restore everything.* **12***He's already come, and they didn't recognize him. They treated him however they wanted to. That's the way it'll be, too, when I suffer at their hand."* **13**Then they caught on that he was talking about John the Baptist. **Mt 17:9-13**

Healing a Demoniac Boy

14When they got to the crowd, a man came up to Jesus and fell on his knees, **15** *"Sir, have mercy on my boy. He suffers badly with epilepsy. He falls into the fire and the water.* **16***I brought him to your disciples, but they couldn't heal him."*

17 *"Unbelieving, perverse bunch, how long am I going to be with you? Bring*[pl] *him to me."* **18**Jesus rebuked the demon, and it came out of him. The child was healed from then on.

19The disciples came to Jesus privately, *"Why couldn't we cast it out?"*

20 *"Because your faith was weak. If you have faith the size of a mustard seed, you can tell this mountain to move from here to there, and it'll move. You can do anything. [[***21** *"This kind doesn't come out except by prayer and fasting."]]*[ms] **Mt 17:14-21**

Third Prediction of His Death

22While they were together in Galilee, Jesus said, *"I'm going to be betrayed.* **23***They'll put me to death, but I'll resurrect on the third day."* That really distressed them. **Mt 17:22-23**

Jesus and the Temple Tax

24As he was going into Capernaum, those who collect the didrachma came to Peter, *"Your Rabbi pays the didrachma, doesn't he?"*

25 *"Yes."*

When he came in the house, Jesus spoke first, *"What do you think, Simon? Who do kings exact tribute from—citizens or foreigners?"*

26When Peter said, *"Foreigners,"*

Jesus said, *"So citizens are exempt.* **27***But we don't want to make them stumble. Go to the lake and throw in a fishhook. Take the first fish you catch and open its mouth. You'll find a stater. Give it to them for you and me."* **Mt 17:24-27**

Discussion About Rank;

18:1 At that time the disciples came to Jesus, *"Who's greatest in the kingdom of heaven?"*

2He called a little child and stood him in front of them,

3 *"Unless you change and become like little children, you won't* even *get into the kingdom.* **4***Whoever humbles himself like this little child is greatest in the kingdom of heaven,* **5***and whoever receives a little child like this in my name, receives me.* **Mt 18:1-5**

The Question of Stumbling Blocks

6 *"Whoever makes a little one stumble that believes in me, would be better off to have a large millstone hung around their neck and drown in the sea.* **7***Woe to the world because of temptations. They'll come, but woe to the ones that bring them.* **8***If your*[sg] *hand or foot causes you problems, cut it off and throw it away.*

It's better to go about life deformed or lame than to have two hands and two feet to be thrown into the eternal fire. **9***If your*[sg] *eye is causing you problems, gouge it out and throw it away. It's better to go about life with one eye than to have two eyes to be thrown into the burning hell.*

10 *"Make sure you*[pl] *don't look down on one of these little ones. I tell you*[pl]*, their angels in heaven can always see my heavenly Father. [***11***]*[ms] **12***What do you*[pl] *think? If a man has 100 sheep and one wanders off, doesn't he leave the 99 on the hillside and go looking for the stray?* **13***If he finds it, he's happier over it than over the 99 that didn't stray.* **14***In the same way, your heavenly Father doesn't want a one of these little ones to perish.* **Mt 18:6-14**

Mistreatment and Forgiveness

15 *"If your*[sg] *brother sins against you, go show him his fault privately. If he listens, you've gained him back.* **16***If he doesn't, take one or two with you so* ***'two or three witnesses will confirm everything'*** **[Deut 19:15].** **17***If he won't listen, tell the church. If he won't even listen to the church, regard him like a Gentile or a tax collector.*

18 *"Whatever you*[pl] *bind on earth will be bound in heaven, and whatever you loose on earth will be loosed in heaven.* **19***Again, if two of you agree on earth about anything you ask for, it'll happen for you from my Father in heaven.* **20***Where two or three gather in my name, I'm with them."* **Mt 18:15-20**

21Then Peter came and asked, *"How many times should I forgive someone that sins against me? Up to 7 times?"*

22Jesus said[p], *"I wouldn't say up to 7;* I'd say *up to 77."*

23 *"The kingdom of heaven is like a king that wanted to settle accounts with his servants.* **24***As he was making the settlements, one debtor was brought to him that owed 10,000 talents.* **25***Since he couldn't repay it, the lord commanded his wife, children, and everything he owned to be sold to make the repayment.* **26***The servant prostrated himself and pleaded, 'Be patient with me, and I'll repay it all.'* **27***The lord felt sorry for him, let him go, and forgave his debt.* **Mt 18:21-27**

28 *"That servant went out and found a fellow servant that owed him 100 denarii. He grabbed him and began to choke him, 'Pay me what you owe me.'* **29***His fellow servant fell down and began to beg him, 'Be patient with me, and I'll pay you back.'* **30***But he wasn't willing. He put him in prison till he'd paid what he owed.*

31 *"His fellow servants were deeply grieved and reported to their lord what happened.* **32***His lord called him in, 'Evil servant, I forgave you all that debt when*

you begged me. **33***Shouldn't you have been merciful with your fellow servant like I was with you?'* **34***His lord was angry and turned him over to the torturers till he'd pay everything he owed.*

35 *"My heavenly Father will do the same thing to you[pl] unless you forgive your fellow believer from your heart."* **Mt 18:28-35**

Jesus in Perea;
Teaching About Divorce

19:1 When Jesus finished, he left Galilee and went into the regions of Judaea on the other side of the Jordan. **2**Big crowds followed him, and he healed them there.

3Pharisees came to him, testing him, *"Is it lawful to divorce a wife for any reason whatever?"*

4He answered, *"You've read, haven't you, that ever since the beginning the Creator* ***'has made them male plus female'?*** **[Gen 1:27; 5:2]** **5***So* ***'a man is to leave his parents and unite with his wife, and they are to become one physical unit'*** **[Gen 2:24].** **6***So, they're no longer two but one. What God has united, people are not to separate."*

7They said, *"So why did Moses command* ***'a husband to divorce his wife in writing****?"* **[Deut 24:1]**

8 *"Because of your hardheartedness, Moses let you divorce your wives, but ever since the beginning it's not been that way.* **9***Whoever divorces his wife—except for sexual immorality—and marries someone else, is committing adultery."*

10His disciples said[p], *"If that's the way it is, it's better not to get married."*

11Jesus said, *"Not everybody can live that way—just the ones who have that gift.* **12***Some are eunuchs from birth, some are made eunuchs by men, and others have conducted themselves like 'eunuchs' for the kingdom of heaven's sake. Let him accept it that can accept it."* **Mt 19:1-12**

Jesus and the Little Children

13At the time, people were bringing their kids so Jesus could lay hands on them and pray. But the disciples fussed at them.

14Jesus said, *"Let the kids alone. Don't get in their way. The kingdom of heaven is made up of people like them."*

15He laid hands on them and left. **Mt 19:13-15**

The Rich Young Ruler

16A man came and said, *"Rabbi, what good can I do to have eternal life?"*

17He said, *"Why are you asking me about what's good? There's only One that's good. But if you want to enter eternal life, keep the commandments."*

18 *"Which ones?"*

Jesus said, ***"'Do not commit murder, commit adultery, steal,*** *or* ***lie'***; [19] ***'honor father and mother,' 'Love your neighbor as yourself'"*** **[Ex 20:12-16; Deut 5:16-20].**

[20]The young man said[p], *"I've kept all of those. What do I still need to do?"*

[21] *"If you want to be perfect, go sell what you own and give it to the poor, and you'll have wealth in heaven. Come with me."*

[22]When he heard that, he went away discouraged because he owned lots of things. **Mt 19:16-22**

The Peril of Wealth

[23]Jesus told his disciples, *"Wealthy people have a hard time getting into the kingdom of heaven.* [24]*It's easier for a camel to get through a needle's eye than for someone rich to get into God's kingdom."*

[25]That really surprised them, *"Then who can be saved?"*

[26]Jesus looked at them and said, *"With people it's not possible, but with God everything's possible."*

[27]Peter responded, *"We've left everything to follow you. What will we have?"*

[28]Jesus told them, *"In the next age when the Son of Man sits on his glorious throne, you that have followed me will sit on twelve thrones and judge the twelve tribes of Israel.* [29]*Anybody that has left houses, brothers, sisters, father, mother, children, or fields for my sake will receive 100 times as much and inherit eternal life.* [30]*Many first will be last; and last, first.* **Mt 19:23-30**

Parable About Workers in a Vineyard

20:[1] *"The kingdom of heaven is like a landowner that went out early to hire workers.* [2]*He agreed to pay them a denarius for the day and sent them to his vineyard.* [3]*About 9 o'clock he went out and saw some other men standing idle in the marketplace,* [4] *'You go to my vineyard too, and I'll pay you what's right.'* [5]*At noon and one o'clock, he did the same thing.* [6]*About five o'clock he found some more standing around, 'Why are you standing here idle all day?'*

[7] *"'Nobody's hired us.'*

"'You go to my vineyard too.'

[8] *"That evening, he told his foreman, 'Call the workers and pay them from last to first.'* [9]*When the five o'clock men came, they got a denarius apiece.* [10]*When the first came, they thought they'd get more; but they got a denarius too.* [11]*They complained,* [12] *'These last hires worked an hour, and you made them equal to us who bore the burden and scorching heat of the day.'*

[13] *"The landowner answered one of them, 'Friend, I've been fair with you. Didn't you agree to a denarius?* [14]*Take what's yours and go. I want to pay this last hire what I paid you.* [15]*Can't I do what I want with what's mine? Are you*

jealous because I'm generous?' [16]That's how the last will be first and the first, last." **Mt 20:1-16**

Another Prediction of His Death

[17]As Jesus was going up to Jerusalem, he took the twelve disciples aside on the way, [18]*"We're going to Jerusalem, and I'll be betrayed to the chief priests and scribes, and they'll condemn me to death.* [19]*They'll turn me over to the Gentiles to make fun of, flog, and crucify; but on the third day I'll resurrect."* **Mt 20:17-19**

James and John's Request for Rank

[20]Then Zebedee's wife came with her sons, bowed down, to ask for something,

[21]*"What is it you want?"*

"Say that my two sons will sit on your right and left hand in your kingdom."

[22]Jesus answered, *"You[pl] don't know what you're asking. Can you[pl] drink the cup <u>I'm</u> about to drink?"*

"Yes."

[23]*"You'll drink it, but I don't decide who sits on my right and left hand. They're the ones my Father prepared it for."*

[24]When the ten heard it, they were indignant at the two brothers.

[25]Jesus called them over to him,

"You know the rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them; their *important ones act like tyrants.* [26]*It won't be that way with you. Whoever wants to be great among you will minister to you,* [27]*whoever wants to be first among you will serve you—*[28]*just like I didn't come to be served but to serve, and to give my life as a ransom for many."* **Mt 20:20-28**

Healing Two Blind Men at Jericho

[29]As they were leaving Jericho, a big crowd was following him. [30]Two blind men were sitting by the road. When they heard that Jesus was going by, they yelled out, *"Have mercy on us, Lord, son of David."*

[31]The crowd sternly told them to be quiet, but they yelled louder, *"Have mercy on us, Lord, son of David."*

[32]Jesus stopped, *"What do you want me to do?"*

[33]*"Make us able to see."*

[34]Jesus felt sorry for them and touched their eyelids. Immediately they could see again, and went along with him. **Mt 20:29-34**

The Triumphal Entry

21:1When they got close to Jerusalem, to Bethany on the Mount of Olives, Jesus sent two disciples, 2*"Go in the village across from you. Close by you'll find a donkey tied and a colt with her. Untie them and bring them to me.* 3*If anybody says anything, say the Lord needs them; they'll send them right away."* 4That fulfilled what the prophet said,

> 5***"Tell the people of Zion*** **[Is 62:11],**
> ***'Your king's coming to you,***
> ***humble and riding on a donkey—***
> ***the colt of a donkey'"*** **[Zech 9:9].**

6The disciples did like Jesus said, 7brought the donkey and colt, and put their cloaks on them, and he sat on them. 8The big crowd spread cloaks on the road; others started cutting tree branches and spreading them on the road. 9The crowd ahead and behind started shouting,

> ***"Hosanna*** *to the son of David!*
> ***Blessed be the One that's coming in the name of the LORD*** **[Ps 118:25-26]!**
> ***Hosanna*** *in the highest!"*

10When he went into Jerusalem, it stirred up the whole city, *"Who is this?"*

11The crowd said, *"The prophet Jesus from Nazareth in Galilee."* **Mt 21:1-11**

Second Cleansing of the Temple;
Cursing the Fig Tree

12Jesus went into the Temple and drove out the ones that were buying and selling, and turned over the tables of the moneychangers and the chairs of men selling doves.

13He said[p], *"Scripture says,*

> ***'Call my house a house for prayer'*** **[Is 56:7].**
> *You've made it* ***'a den of thieves'****!"* **[Jer 7:11]**

14Blind and lame people came to him in the Temple, and he healed them. 15But when the chief priests and the scribes saw the amazing things he was doing and the kids shouting in the Temple, *"Hosanna to the son of David!"* they were indignant, 16*"Do you hear what they're saying?"*

"Yes. You've read, haven't you, ***'Out of the mouth of infants and nursing babies you've prepared yourself perfect praise'****?"* **[Ps 8:3 LXX]** 17He left the city for Bethany to spend the night.

18In the morning as he was coming into the city, he was hungry. 19He noticed one fig tree beside the road. He went over to it and didn't find anything on it but leaves. He said[p], *"You'll never grow fruit again."* Right away the tree started shriveling up. **Mt 21:12-19**

Discussing the Shriveled Fig Tree

20When the disciples saw it, they were surprised, *"How did it shrivel up so fast?"*

[21]Jesus answered, *"If you have faith—and don't doubt—not only will you do what happened to this fig tree; even if you tell this mountain to be picked up and thrown in the sea, it'll happen.* [22]*Whatever you ask for in prayer you'll receive if you believe."* **Mt 21:20-22**

Jesus' Authority Challenged

[23]When he went into the Temple, the chief priests and the elders of the people came while he was teaching, *"What right do you have to do this? Who gave you that right?"*

[24]*"I'll ask you a question too. If you tell me, I'll tell you what right I have to do this.* [25]*Was John's baptism from heaven or humans?"*

They talked it over, *"If we say, 'From heaven,' he'll say, 'Why didn't you believe him?'* [26]*If we say, 'From humans,' we're afraid of the people"* (everybody considered John a prophet). [27]So they answered, *"We don't know."*

He also said, *"I won't tell you either what right I have to do this."* **Mt 21:23-27**

Parable About Two Sons

[28]*"What do you think? A man had two sons. He went to the first, 'Go work in the vineyard today.'*

[29]*"'I don't want to,' but later he regretted it and went.*

[30]*"He went to the other son and said the same thing.*

"'Okay,' but didn't go.

[31]*"Which one did the father's will?"*

They said, *"The first."*

Jesus said[p],

"Tax collectors and prostitutes are going into God's kingdom before you are. [32]*John came telling you to live right, and you didn't believe him; but tax collectors and prostitutes did. But <u>you</u>, when you saw that, didn't even regret it later and believe him.* **Mt 21:28-32**

Parable About a Vineyard

[33]*"Listen to another story. A landowner planted a vineyard, put a wall around it, dug a wine press in it, built a tower, rented it out to tenants, and went on a trip.* [34]*When it came time for the fruit, he sent his servants to the tenants to get his fruit.* [35]*The tenants took them and beat one, murdered another, and stoned another.* [36]*He sent some others—more than the first, and they did the same thing.* [37]*Finally, he sent his son, 'They'll respect my son.'* [38]*But when they saw him, they said, 'That's the heir. Come on, let's kill him and take his inheritance.'* [39]*They dragged him out of the vineyard and killed him.* [40]*When the owner comes, what will he do to those tenants?"*

[41]They said, *"He'll miserably destroy those sinful men and rent out the vineyard to other tenants that will pay him the fruit in its season."*

[42]Jesus said[p], *"You've read in the scriptures, haven't you,*

'The stone the builders rejected
has become the cornerstone.
That has come from the LORD;
it's amazing to us'? **[Ps 118:22-23]**

[43]*So God will take the kingdom away from you and give it to a nation that will produce its fruit. [[*[44]*Whoever falls on that stone will get bruised, and whoever it falls on will get crushed.]]*[ms]*"*

[45]The chief priests and the Pharisees knew he'd told his stories about them. [46]They were trying to find a way to arrest him, but they were afraid to; the people considered him a prophet.

Mt 21:33-46

Parable About a Wedding Garment

22[:1]Jesus told them another story.

[2]*"The kingdom of heaven is like a king that prepared a wedding banquet for his son.* [3]*He sent servants to call the people that he'd invited, but they didn't want to come.* [4]*He sent some other servants, 'Tell the ones I've invited, "I've prepared my banquet. I've butchered my oxen and grain-fed calves; everything's ready. Come on to the banquet."'* [5]*But they didn't pay any attention and went on with their own affairs, one to his field, another to his business.* [6]*The rest grabbed his servants, treated them disgracefully, and killed them.* **Mt 22:1-6**

[7]*"The king was angry and sent troops to destroy those murderers and burn their town.* [8]*Then he told his servants, 'The wedding banquet is ready, but the people I invited didn't deserve it.* [9]*So go out to the main roads and invite everybody you find.'* [10]*They went out in the roads and gathered everybody they could find, good and bad, and filled the wedding banquet with guests.*

[11]*"The king went in to inspect the guests and saw a man that wasn't dressed for a wedding.* [12]*He said, 'How'd you get in here without being dressed for a wedding?' He was speechless.* [13]*The king told the attendants, 'Tie him up hand and foot, and throw him out in the dark. There'll be crying and chattering of teeth out there.* [14]*Many are called, but few are chosen.'"* **Mt 22:7-14**

Question About Tribute to Caesar

[15]The Pharisees plotted how to trap Jesus in what he said. [16]They sent[p] their disciples with the Herodians, saying, *"Rabbi, we know you tell the truth and teach the way of God correctly; you don't defer to anybody or respect persons.* [17]*So tell us what you think: Is it lawful to pay tribute to Caesar?"*

[18]Jesus perceived their wickedness, *"Why are you trying to put me on the spot, you hypocrites?* [19]*Show me the coin for paying the tribute."*

They brought him a denarius.

[20] *"Whose image and inscription are these?"*

[21] *"Caesar's."*

"Then pay Caesar what you owe Caesar and pay God what you owe God."

[22]They were dumbfounded and left. **Mt 22:15-22**

The Question About Resurrection

[23]That day, some Sadducees, saying there's no resurrection, approached him,

[24] *"Rabbi, Moses said,*

'If a man dies childless, his brother is to marry his wife' **[Deut 25:5]** ***and 'raise up heirs for his brother'*** **[Gen 38:8].**

[25]*There were seven brothers with us, and the first died. Since he had no children, he left his wife to his brother.* [26]*The same thing happened with the second and third through the seventh.* [27]*Last of all, the woman died.* [28]*So, whose wife will she be in the resurrection? They'd all married her."*

[29]Jesus answered them, *"You're mistaken because you don't know the scriptures or God's power.* [30]*In the resurrection there's no such thing as marriage. They're like the angels in heaven.*

[31] *"Now as to the resurrection of the dead, you've read, haven't you, what God said to you,* [32]***'I'm Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob's God'****?* **[Ex 3:6, 15, 16]** *He's not a God of the dead, but of the living."*

[33]The crowd was astounded at his teaching. **Mt 22:23-33**

Question About the Greatest Commandment

[34]When the Pharisees heard he'd silenced the Sadducees, they gathered around him. [35]One of them, [a lawyer][ms], tested him, [36] *"Rabbi, which is the most important commandment in the Law?"*

[37] *"****'Love the LORD your God with all your heart, soul, and mind'*** **[Deut 6:5]**. [38]*That's the most important commandment.* [39]*The second is like it,* ***'Love your neighbor as yourself'*** **[Lev 19:18].** [40]*The whole Law and the Prophets depend on those two commandments."* **Mt 22:34-40**

Question About the Son of David

[41]While the Pharisees were *there* together, Jesus asked them, [42] *"What do you think about the Messiah? Whose son is he?"*

"David's."

[43] *"How then does David by inspiration call him 'Lord':*

[44] ***'The LORD told my Lord,***

"Sit at my right hand

till I make your enemies your footstool'? **[Ps 110:1]**

[45]*If David calls him 'Lord,' how can he be his son?"* [46]Nobody could answer him, and nobody dared ask him any more questions. **Mt 22:41-46**

Denunciation of the Pharisees

23[:1]Jesus told the crowd and his disciples,

[2] *"The scribes and Pharisees sit on Moses' seat.* [3]*So do whatever they tell you, but don't be like them; they say and don't do.* [4]*They strap heavy, awkward burdens on people's shoulders, but <u>they</u> aren't willing to move them with one of their fingers.* [5]*They do everything for show—like making wide phylacteries and long tassels.* [6]*They like places of honor at banquets, prominent seats in synagogues,* [7]*greetings in marketplaces, and people calling them Rabbi.* [8]*Don't <u>you</u> be called Rabbi. You have one Rabbi; <u>you're</u> all brothers.* [9]*Don't call anybody on earth your father. You have one Father, the One in heaven.* [10]*Don't be called leaders. You have one Leader, the Messiah.* [11]*The greatest among you will be your minister.* [12]*Whoever exalts himself will be humbled, and whoever humbles himself will be exalted.* **Mt 23:1-12**

[13] *"Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! You lock up the kingdom of heaven in front of people. You don't go in yourselves or let them go in that are trying to. [*[14]*]*[ms]

[15] *"Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! You travel all over land and sea to make one proselyte. Then you make him more destined for hell than you are.*

[16] *"Woe to you, blind guides that say, 'Whoever swears by the sanctuary hasn't taken a binding oath, but whoever swears by the gold of the sanctuary <u>has</u> taken a binding oath.'* [17]*Blind fools! Which is more imporant, the gold or the sanctuary that makes it holy?*

[18] "You *also* say, *'Whoever swears by the altar hasn't taken a binding oath, but whoever swears by the gift on the altar <u>has</u> taken a binding oath.'* [19]*You blind people! Which is more important, the gift or the altar that makes it holy?* [20]*So whoever swears by the altar swears by it and everything on it.* [21]*Whoever swears by the sanctuary swears by it and the One that lives there.* [22]*Whoever swears by heaven swears by God's throne and the One that sits on it.* **Mt 23:13-22**

[23] *"Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! You give a tenth of mint, dill, and cumin; and neglect the more important things in the Law: justice, mercy, faith. You should've done these and not neglected those.* [24] *Blind guides that strain out the gnat and swallow the camel!*

[25] *"Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! You clean the outside of the cup and plate, but inside they're full of greed and self-indulgence.* [26] *Blind Pharisee! Clean the inside of the cup first so the outside of it becomes clean too.*

[27] *"Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! You're like whitewashed tombs that look beautiful on the outside, but inside they're filled with filth and dead men's bones.* [28] *You look good on the outside, but inside you're filled with hypocrisy and lawlessness.* **Mt 23:23-28**

[29] *"Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! You build the tombs of the prophets and decorate the graves of the righteous* [30] *and say, 'If we'd lived when our ancestors did, we wouldn't have joined them in shedding the prophets' blood.'* [31] *You speak against yourselves because you're just like the ones that murdered the prophets.* [32] *Go ahead and be as bad as your ancestors.* [33] *You snakes! You nest of vipers! How will you escape condemnation in hell?* [34] *For this reason I'll send you prophets, wise men, and scribes. You'll kill and crucify some of them; some you'll flog in your synagogues and persecute from city to city.* [35] *So on you will come all the righteous blood shed from Abel to Zechariah son of Berechiah, the one you murdered between the altar and the sanctuary.* [36] *I'm telling you, it'll all come down on this generation!*

[37] *"Jerusalem! Jerusalem! that murders prophets and stones my messengers! How many times I've wanted to gather your people the way a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, but you didn't want to!* [38] *I leave your house to you deserted.* [39] *You won't see me again till you say,* ***'Blessed is the One that's coming in the name of the LORD'*** *"* **[Ps 118:26].** **Mt 23:29-39**

The Olivet Discourse

24[:1] Jesus was leaving the Temple when his disciples came to show him the buildings of the Temple complex.

[2] He responded, *"See all this? There won't be one stone left on another."*

[3] When he was sitting on the Mount of Olives, the disciples came privately, *"Tell us, when will that happen, what will be the sign that you're coming and the end of the age?"*

[4] Jesus answered,

"Make sure nobody deceives you. [5] *Many will come, saying, 'I'm the Messiah,' and deceive lots of people.* [6] *You'll hear about wars and reports of*

wars. Don't let it alarm you. They have to happen, but that's not the end. [7]*Nation will attack nation and kingdom attack kingdom. There'll be famines and earthquakes in various places.* [8]*That's the beginning of labor pains.*

[9]*"Then they'll bring distress on you and kill you, and Gentiles will hate you because of me.* [10]*Many will fall away, betray each other, hate one another.* [11]*False prophets will rise up and deceive people.* [12]*Since lawlessness will increase, many people's love will grow cold;* [13]*but the one that endures to the end will be saved.* [14]*The good news about the kingdom will be delivered in the whole empire for a testimony to the nations. Then the end will come.* **Mt 24:1-14**

[15]*"When you see 'the abomination of desolation,' that Daniel the prophet spoke about, standing in the holy place (reader, understand.),* [16]*people in Judaea need to flee to the hill country.* [17]*Nobody on a housetop should go down to pick up things out of the house.* [18]*Nobody in the field should go back to get a coat.* [19]*Woe to the ones who are pregnant and nursing babies then!* [20]*Pray that your flight won't happen in the winter or on a Sabbath. Great distress will come on the country and wrath on this people.* [21]*That time will be the worst ever—from the beginning till now or ever again.* [22]*If the* LORD *hadn't shortened those days, nobody would survive. But because of the Chosen, he'll cut those days short.*

Mt 24:15-22

[23]*"Then if anybody says, 'Here's the Messiah,' or, 'There*'s the Messiah*,' don't believe it.* [24]*False Messiahs and false prophets will arise and give great signs and wonders that could deceive, if possible, even the Chosen.* [[25]] [26]*If anybody says, 'He's in the desert,' don't go out* there. *'He's in private quarters,' don't believe it.* [27]*The Son of Man will come like lightning flashes from east to west.* [28]*Vultures will gather where the carcass is,*

[29]*"Immediately after* <u>*that*</u> *ordeal,*

the sun will grow dark,
the moon won't shine,
stars will fall,
and the powers in the sky will be shaken. **Mt 24:23-29**

[30]*"Then the Son of Man will appear in the sky, and every tribe on earth will mourn.* ***They'll see him coming in the clouds*** **[Dan 7:13]** *with power and great glory.* [31]*He'll send out his angels with a loud trumpet blast to gather his Chosen from every direction, from one end of the sky to the other.*

[32]*"Learn a lesson from a fig tree. When its branches get tender and sprout leaves, you know summer's coming.* [33]*So too, when you see these things, you'll*[p]

know he's at the door. [34]<u>This</u> generation won't pass away before it happens. [35]Earth and sky will pass away, but what I say won't pass away.

[36]"But nobody knows about <u>that</u> day and hour, not the angels, not the Son, just the Father. [37]When the Son of Man comes, it will be like it was in Noah's time. [38]Before the flood came, people were eating and getting married till Noah went into the ark. [39]They didn't realize what was going to happen till the flood came and swept them all away.

"That's how the coming of the Son of Man will be. [40]Two men will be in the field; one taken, the other left. [41]Two women will be grinding at the mill; one taken, the other left. [42]So keep watching because you don't know what day your Lord will come. **Mt 24:30-42**

[43]"Do know this: if the homeowner had known in which watch the thief would come, he would've been on alert and not let the thief ransack his house. [44]So <u>you</u> be ready too; the Son of Man will come when you least expect it.

[45]"Who then is a smart, reliable servant that his master has put in charge of feeding his family on time? [46]He's fortunate whose master finds him doing that when he comes. [47]He'll put him in charge of everything he owns. [48]But if a sinful servant says to himself, 'My master won't be coming for a long time'; [49]and he starts abusing fellow servants, and eating and getting drunk with drunks, [50]his master will come on a day he doesn't expect at an hour he doesn't know. [51]He'll punish him severely and assign him a place with the hypocrites. There'll be crying and chattering of teeth there. **Mt 24:43-51**

A Story About Ten Virgins

25[:1]*"At that time the kingdom of heaven will be like ten virgins that took their lamps to meet the groom. [2]Five were foolish, five were wise. [3]The foolish didn't take any oil along. [4]The wise took some along in flasks with their lamps. [5]The groom was delayed, and they all got drowsy and fell sleep. [6]At midnight the shout came, 'The groom! Come out to meet him!' [7]The virgins got up and trimmed their lamps.*

[8]"The foolish said to the wise, 'Give us some of your oil; our lamps are going out.'

[9]"The wise said, 'No, there won't be enough for all of us. Go to the dealers and get your own.' [10]While they were gone, the groom came. The ones that were ready went in with him to the wedding feast, and the door was locked.

[11]*Later, the rest of the virgins came, 'Sir, let us in.'* [12]*But he answered, 'I don't know you.'* [13]*So be alert; you don't know the day or the hour."* **Mt 25:1-13**

A Story About Talents

[14] *"The kingdom of heaven is like a man going on a trip. He called his servants and entrusted them with things he owned.* [15]*He gave five talents to one, two to another, and one to another—according to their abilities—and left. Right away* [16]*the one with five talents went and traded with them and earned five more.* [17]*The one with two talents did the same thing and earned two more.* [18]*But the servant with one talent dug a hole and hid it.*

[19] *"After a long time, the master came back and settled accounts with them.* [20]*The one he gave five talents came and said, 'Master, you entrusted me with five talents; I've earned five more.'*

[21] *"'Well done, good, dependable servant. You were dependable in handling a few things; I'll put you in charge of many. Enjoy my approval.'*

[22] *"The one he gave two talents came up, 'You entrusted me with two talents; I've earned two more.'* **Mt 25: 14-22**

[23] *"'Well done, good, reliable servant. You were reliable in handling a few things; I'll put you in charge of many. Enjoy my approval.'*

[24] *"But the servant he gave one talent came up, 'Master, I knew you were a hard man, reaping where you didn't sow, gathering where you didn't scatter.* [25]*I was afraid and hid your talent in the ground. You have what's yours.'*

[26] *"'You wicked, lazy servant. You knew, did you, that I reap where I don't sow and gather where I don't scatter?* [27]*You should've taken my money to the bankers. When I came back, I would've received it back plus interest.* [28]*Take the talent away from him and give it to the one with ten.* [29]*Everybody that has will receive more; but the one that doesn't have will lose what he does have.* [30]*Throw the worthless servant out into the dark. There'll be crying and chattering of teeth out there.* **Mt 25:23-30**

Discussion of the Final Judgment

[31] *"When the Son of Man comes in his glory with the angels, he'll sit on his glorious throne.* [32]*The nations will stand in front of him, and he'll separate them like a shepherd separates sheep from goats.* [33]*He'll put the sheep on his right and the goats on his left.* [34]*The king will tell the sheep, 'Come, my Father's blessed ones, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the founding of the world.* [35]*I was hungry, and you fed me. I was thirsty, and you gave me a drink. I was a*

stranger, and you gave me a place to stay. [36]I needed clothes, and you gave me some. I was sick, and you took care of me. I was in prison, and you visited me.'

Mt 25:31-36

[37] *"Those good people will say, 'When did we see you hungry and feed you, or thirsty and give you a drink? [38]When did we see you a stranger and give you a place to stay, or needing clothes and give you some? [39]When did we see you sick or in prison and take care of you.'*

[40] *"The king will answer, 'When you did it for the of least of these friends of mine, you did it to me.'*

[41] *"Then he'll say to the people on the left, 'Go away, you accursed, into the eternal fire prepared for the devil and his angels. [42]I was hungry, and you didn't give me anything to eat. I was thirsty, and you didn't give me anything to drink. [43]I was a stranger, and you didn't give me a place to stay. I needed clothes, and you didn't give me any. I was sick and in prison and you didn't take care of me.'*

[44] *"They'll say, 'When did we see you hungry, thirsty, a stranger, needing clothes, sick, or in prison, and not help you?'*

[45] *"He'll answer, 'Since you didn't do it for the least of these friends of mine, you didn't do it for me either.' [46]Those will go away into eternal punishment, but the good people will go into eternal life."* **Mt 25:37-46**

Fifth Prediction of His Death

26:[1]When Jesus finished, he told his disciples, [2] *"As you know, the Passover is two days from now. I'll be handed over to be crucified."*

[3]Meantime the chief priests and the elders of the people met in the courtyard of Caiaphas, the high priest, [4]and conspired to arrest Jesus by treachery and put him to death. [5]But they said, *"Not during the festival; the people will riot."* **Mt 26:1-5**

The Anointing by Mary

[6]While Jesus was in Bethany in the house of Simon the leper, [7]a woman approached him with an alabaster cruise of very expensive ointment and poured it on his head while he was reclining at table. [8]The disciples were indignant, *"What's the point of such waste? [9]She could've sold it for a lot and given the money to the poor."*

[10]Jesus was aware of it, *"Why are you fussing at her? She's done me a good turn. [11]You always have poor people around, but you won't always have[fp] me. [12]She put this ointment on my body to prepare me for burial. [13]I tell you, wherever you deliver the good news in the world, tell what she did in memory of her.* **Mt 26:6-13**

Judas' Plot to Betray Jesus

[14]Then Judas Iscariot, one of the Twelve, went to the high priests, [15]*"What would you give me to deliver Jesus over to you?"* They counted out 30 silver shekels for him. [16]From then on, he was looking for a chance to deliver him over *to them*. **Mt 26:14-16**

Preparation for the Passover Meal

[17]On the first day of Unleavened Bread, the disciples came to Jesus, *"Where do you want us to get things ready for the Passover?"*

[18]He said, *"Go into the city to such and such a man and say, 'The Rabbi says, "My time's getting close. I'll observe*[p] *the Passover at your place with my disciples."'"*

[19]The disciples did that and got things ready for *observing* the Passover *meal*. **Mt 26:17-19**

The Passover Meal;
Judas Identified as Traitor

[20]That evening, Jesus was reclining at table with the Twelve.

[21]While they were eating, he said, *"I tell you, one of you is going to betray me."*

[22]They were really distressed and started saying, *"It's not me, is it?"*

[23]He answered, *"It's the one that has dipped his hand with me in the bowl.* [24]*The Son of Man will go the way scripture says, but woe to the one that betrays him. It would've been better if he hadn't been born."*

[25]Judas, the one that did betray him, said, *"It's not me, is it?"*

"Yes." **Mt 26:20-25**

The Lord's Supper Instituted

[26]During the meal, Jesus took a loaf, gave thanks, broke it, and gave it to his disciples, *"Take* and *eat* it*; it's my body."* [27]He took a cup, gave thanks, and gave it to them, *"All of you, drink out of it;* [28]*it's my blood of the covenant that's shed for many for the forgiveness of sins.* [29]*This is the last time I'll be drinking this fruit of the vine till I drink it with you in my Father's kingdom."*

[30]They sang a hymn and went out to The Mount of Olives. **Mt 26:26-30**

The Disciples Warned

[31]Jesus told[p] them, *"All of you will desert me tonight. Scripture says,*

'I'll strike down the shepherd,
and his sheep will scatter' **[Zech 13:7].**

[32]*After I'm resurrected, I'll go ahead of you to Galilee."*

[33]Peter responded, "Even *if everyone else deserts you, I'll never desert you."*

34Jesus said, *"I tell you, tonight before a rooster crows, you'll deny three times that you know me."*

35Peter said[p], *"Even if I have to die with you, I won't deny you."*

That's what all the disciples said. **Mt 26:31-35**

The Agony in the Garden

36Jesus went[p] with them to a place called Gethsemane. *"Sit here while I go over there and pray."*

37He took Peter and the two sons of Zebedee and became overwhelmed with dread. **38**He said[p], *"I'm distressed to death. Stay here and keep watch with me."*

39He went on a little way and fell on his face, *"My Father, if it's possible, take this cup away from me; but not what I want, but what you want."*

40He came back[p] and found[p] them sleeping. He said[p] to Peter, *"Couldn't you[pl] keep watch one hour?* **41***Keep watch and pray so you won't be tempted. The spirit's willing, but the flesh is weak."*

42A second time he went and prayed, *"My Father, if this can't pass without me drinking it, your will be done."* **43**He came back and found them sleeping again; they couldn't keep their eyes open. **44**He left them again and prayed the same thing a third time. **45**He came[p] back to his disciples, *"You're still sleeping and resting? It's time; I'm about to be betrayed[p] to sinners.* **46***Get up; let's go. The one that's betraying me is coming."* **Mt 26:36-46**

The Arrest of Jesus

47While he was still talking, Judas came with a large contingent armed with swords and clubs from the chief priests and elders of the people. **48**The traitor had given them a signal, *"The one I kiss is him; arrest him."*

49At once he came to Jesus, *"Hello, Rabbi,"* and kissed him.

50Jesus said, *"Companion, do what you came to do."*

They came and grabbed him and arrested him. **51**One of the men with Jesus drew his sword and struck the high priest's servant and cut his ear off.

52Jesus told[p] him, *"Put your sword away. Everybody that picks up a sword dies by a sword.* **53***Do you suppose I can't ask my Father right now for over 70,000 angels?* **54***How then would I fulfill the scriptures that this is the way things need to be?"*

55Jesus said to the crowd, *"You've come out* here *with swords and clubs to arrest me like an insurrectionist? I sat teaching in the Temple every day, and you didn't arrest me.* **56***But this is all happening to fulfill what the prophets wrote."*

The disciples ran away. **Mt 26:47-56**

The Trial Before Caiaphas; Peter's Denials;

The Final Condemnation by the Sanhedrin

57The ones that arrested Jesus took him to Caiaphas the high priest, where the scribes and elders had assembled. **58**A long way behind, Peter followed him to the high priest's courtyard, went inside, and sat down with the officers to see the end.

59The chief priests and the full Sanhedrin were looking for false testimony against Jesus so they could execute him. **60**But they didn't find it even though a number of false witnesses came forward. Finally, two came forward, **61***"He said, 'I can tear down God's sanctuary and rebuild it in three days.'"*

62The high priest got up and said, *"You aren't going to answer the claims these men are making against you?"*

63Jesus didn't say anything.

The high priest said, *"I'm putting you under oath: by the living God, tell us if you're the Messiah, the Son of God."*

64*"Yes. Nevertheless, I'm telling you,*

'Later you'll see ***the Son of Man***
sitting on the right hand of Power and
coming on the clouds'" **[Ps 110:1; Dan 7:13]**.

65The high priest tore his clothes, *"He blasphemed. What do we need witnesses for?" You heard the blasphemy.* **66***What's your verdict?"*

"He deserves the death penalty." **Mt 26:57-67**

67They spit in his face, punched him, and slapped him, **68***"Tell us, 'Messiah,' who slapped you."*

69Peter was sitting outside in the courtyard, and a servant girl came up, *"You were with Jesus the Galilean too."*

70He denied it in front of them all, *"I don't know what you're talking about."*

71When he went out to the gateway, another *servant* girl saw him and said to the ones there, *"This fellow was with Jesus the Nazarene."*

72He denied it again—with an oath: *"I don't know him."*

73A little while later the ones standing around came up to Peter, *"You <u>are too</u> one of them. Your accent gives you away."*

74He started pronouncing curses and swearing: *"I don't know him."* Immediately a rooster crowed. **75**Peter remembered, *"Before a rooster crows, you'll deny me three times."* He went out and broke down sobbing.

27:1 In the morning, the chief priests and the elders of the people developed a strategy for getting Jesus executed.

2They bound him and delivered him to Pilate, the governor. **Mt 26:67-27:2**

The Death of Judas

3When Judas the traitor saw *Jesus* was condemned, he regretted it and took the 30 silver shekels back to the chief priests and elders, **4** *"I've sinned. I betrayed innocent blood."*

They said, *"What's that to us? That's your problem."*

5He threw the shekels into the sanctuary and went and hanged himself.

6The chief priests took the shekels and said, *"It's against the Law to put them in the Temple Treasury since they're blood money."* **7**They talked it over and decided to use them to buy a potter's field as a cemetery for foreigners. **8**That's why it's still called the Field of Blood.* **9**That fulfilled what Jeremiah the prophet said,

"I took the 30 silver shekels,
the price of the One as evaluated by the people of Israel,
10*and they*[ms] *bought a potter's field,*
like the LORD instructed me" **[Zech 11:12-13; cp Jer 32:6-9].** **Mt 27:3-10**

The First and Second Trials
in Front of Pilate

11Jesus stood in front of the governor, who asked him, *"Are you king of the Jews?"*

"Yes."

12While the chief priests and elders were accusing him, he didn't respond.

13Pilate said, *"You hear all the things they're accusing you of, don't you?"*

14He didn't answer him on a single charge. The governor was really surprised. **Mt 27:11-14**

15At each *Passover* Festival the governor had a custom of releasing one prisoner the crowd wanted. **16**At the time they were holding a notorious prisoner called [Jesus][ms] Barabbas. **17**So while they were assembled, Pilate said, *"Who do you want me to release to you, [Jesus][ms] Barabbas or Jesus, called Messiah?"* (**18**He knew they'd delivered him up out of envy.)

19While he was sitting on the judgment seat, his wife sent him a message, *"Don't do anything with that innocent man. I suffered a terrible nightmare last night because of him."*

20The chief priests and elders persuaded the crowd to ask for Barabbas and execute Jesus.

21Pilate asked them, *"Who do you want me to release?"*

"Barabbas."

22 *"What do you want me to do with Jesus, called Messiah?"*

"Crucify him!"

23 *"Why? What's he done?"*

They started shouting louder, *"Crucify him!"*

24When Pilate saw he wasn't getting anywhere, but a riot was brewing, he took water and washed his hands in front of the crowd, *"I'm innocent of this man's blood. This is your problem."*

25The people answered, *"His blood's on us and our descendants."*

[26]Then he released Barabbas, had Jesus scourged, and turned him over to be crucified.
Mt 27:15-26

Torture by the Roman Soldiers

[27]The governor's soldiers took him into the Praetorium and gathered the whole cohort around him. [28]They stripped him and put a scarlet military robe on him. [29]They twisted together a crown made out of thorns and put it on his head. They put a reed in his right hand, knelt to him, and made fun of him, *"Hail, King of the Jews!"* [30]They spit on him and took the reed and kept beating him over the head with it. **Mt 27:27-30**

The Way to Golgotha

[31]When they got done making fun of him, they took the robe off, put his clothes back on him, and led him off to crucify him.

[32]As they were coming out, they found a Cyrenian named Simon and made him carry the cross. [33]When they got to a place called Golgotha ("Place of the Skull"), [34]they offered him wine mixed with gall; but, after tasting it, he wouldn't drink it. [35]After they crucified him, they divided up his clothes by casting lots [36]and sat down to keep watch. [37]They put his accusation above his head: *"Jesus, King of the Jews."*

[38]They crucified two insurgents with him, on his right and left. **Mt 27:31-38**

The Death of Jesus

[39]The ones passing by were ridiculing him, shaking their heads, [40]*"You that tear down the sanctuary and rebuild it in three days, save yourself! If you're God's Son, and come down from the cross!"*

[41]The chief priests as well as the scribes and elders were making fun of him too: [42]*"He saved other people; he can't save himself! He's king of Israel! Let him come down from the cross, and we'll believe it.* [43]*He has trusted in God; let* God *rescue him now if he wants him"*—because he said, *"I'm God's Son."* [44]The insurgents that were crucified with him were denouncing him.

[45]From noon till 3, it got dark over the whole country. [46]About 3 p.m., Jesus shouted, **"*Eli, Eli, lema sabachthani* (*My God, my God, why have you deserted me*)*?*"** **[Ps 22:1]**

[47]Some of the ones standing there heard him, *"He's calling for Elijah."*

[48]One of them ran to fill a sponge with sour wine, put it on a reed, and gave him a drink. [49]The rest were saying, *"Let's see if Elijah will come*[p] *to save him."*

[50]Jesus let out another loud cry and quit breathing. **Mt 27:39-50**

Miracles Accompanying His Death

[51]The sanctuary curtain tore in two, top to bottom; the ground tremored, and the bedrocks ruptured. ([52]Tombs came open, and the bodies of many saints resurrected. [53]They left their graves after

his resurrection and went into the Holy City and appeared to many people.) **54**The centurion and the ones on watch with him were scared to death when they saw the earthquake and the other things that were happening.

55Several women were watching from a distance. They'd traveled with Jesus from Galilee to wait on him. **56**Among them were Mary the Magdalene, Mary the mother of James and Joseph, and the mother of the sons of Zebedee. **Mt 27:51-56**

The Burial of Jesus

57That evening a wealthy man named Joseph from Arimathea came; he was a disciple of Jesus. **58**He went to Pilate and asked for the body, and Pilate ordered it to be given to him. **59**He took it and wrapped it in a clean linen cloth. **60**He put it in his own new, rock-hewn tomb, rolled a large stone against the entrance, and left. **61**Mary the Magdalene and the other Mary were there sitting across from the grave. **Mt 27:57-61**

The Watch at the Tomb

62The next day, the day after Preparation, the chief priests and Pharisees got together with Pilate, **63***"Sir, we've remembered that while he was alive, the deceiver said he'd resurrect after three days.'* **64***Have the grave sealed till the third day so his disciples can't steal the body and tell the people he arose from the dead. The last deception would be worse than the first."*

65Pilate told them, *"You have a guard. Secure it as well as you know how."* **66**They secured the tomb with a guard and put a seal on the stone. **Mt 27:62-66**

The Resurrection of Jesus

28:1 After the Sabbath, as the first day of the week began to dawn, Mary the Magdalene and the other Mary came to see the tomb. **2**There was a violent earthquake. An angel of the LORD came down from heaven, rolled the stone away, and sat on it. **3**His appearance was like lightning; his clothes were white as snow. **4**The guards were so shaken they were paralyzed with fear like dead men.

5The angel said to the women, *"You don't need to be afraid. I know you're looking for Jesus, who was crucified.* **6***He's not here; he resurrected like he said* he would. *Come see where he was lying.* **7***Hurry and tell his disciples, 'He arose from the dead and is going ahead of you into Galilee; you'll see him there.' I've told you."* **Mt 28:1-7**

The Appearance to the Other Women

8They left the tomb quickly with fear and great excitement and ran to tell his disciples. **9**Jesus met them and said, *"Hello."* They went and took hold of his feet and worshiped him. **10**Then Jesus said[p], *"You[pl] don't need to be afraid. Go tell my brothers to go to Galilee. They'll see me there."* **Mt 28:8-10**

The Report of the Guard

11While they were on their way, some of the guards went into the city and reported to the chief priests what all happened. **12**When they got together with the elders and took counsel, they gave a large number of silver coins to the soldiers, **13***"Say that his disciples came during the night while you were asleep and stole him.* **14***If the governor hears about this, we'll persuade him and keep you out of trouble."* **15**They took the silver coins and did what they were told. That story has spread among the Jews to this day. **Mt 28:11-15**

The Great Commission

16The eleven disciples went to Galilee to the mountain Jesus had indicated. **17**When they saw him, they worshiped, but some of them doubted! **18**He came and told them,

> *"All authority has been given to me in heaven and on earth.* **19***Go make disciples in every country. Baptize them into the name of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit;* **20***and teach them to observe everything I've commanded you. I'll always be with you till the end of the age."* **Mt 28:16-20**

MARK

1:1 THE GOSPEL ABOUT JESUS THE MESSIAH, GOD'S SON

The Beginning of John's Ministry

2 Isaiah the prophet wrote,

"I'll send my messenger ahead of you
to get the road ready *for you* **[Ex 23:20; Mal 3:1],**
3 ***one shouting in the desert,***
'Get the road ready for the LORD!
Make it straight'1" **[Is 40:3]**

4 John came baptizing in the desert and preaching a baptism of repentance to forgive sins. 5 The people from Jerusalem and Judaea were going out to have him baptize them in the Jordan *River*, as they confessed their sins. 6 John wore camel's hair with a leather belt around his waist and lived on locusts and wild honey. **Mk 1:1-6**

An Example of John's Preaching

7 He preached, *"After me someone more important is coming. I'm not even worthy to squat down and unfasten his sandals.* 8 *I'm immersing you with water; he'll 'immerse' you in the Holy Spirit."* **Mk 1:7-8**

The Baptism of Jesus

9 At that time Jesus of Nazareth in Galilee came, and John baptized him in the Jordan. 10 When he came up out of the water, *John* saw the sky open up and the Spirit come down on him like a dove. 11 A voice came out of the sky, *"You're my dearly loved Son that I delight in."* **Mk 1:9-11**

The Temptation of Jesus

12 The Spirit took[p] him directly into the desert, 13 and the devil tempted him there for 40 days. He was with the wild animals, and angels were helping him. **Mk 1:12-13**

Introductory Statements
About the Galilean Ministry

14 After John was arrested, Jesus went to Galilee, delivering God's good news: 15 *"It's time; God's kingdom is on its way. Repent and believe the good news."* **Mk 1:14-15**

Calling 4 Fishermen

16 As he passed along Lake Galilee, he saw Simon and his brother Andrew casting nets in the lake; they were fishermen. 17 Jesus said, *"Come with me; I'll have you 'fishing' for people."* 18 They left their nets and went with him. 19 A little farther along, he saw Zebedee's sons, James and John, in a boat, mending nets. 20 He called them, and they left their father in the boat with the hired help and went with him. **Mk 1:16-20**

Teaching and Miracles in Capernaum

21They went[p] to Capernaum and entered the synagogue on the Sabbath, and he started teaching. **22**The people were amazed at how he taught; he was teaching them like someone that had authority, not like the scribes.

23A man in their synagogue had an unclean spirit that shouted, **24***"What is this, Jesus, you Nazarene? Did you come to destroy us? I know who you are: God's Holy One!"*

25Jesus rebuked it, *"Be quiet and come out of him!"* **26**The unclean spirit threw him into convulsions, made a loud noise, and came out.

27They were surprised and started wondering to each other, "*What* is *this? A new* kind of *teaching with authority? He even gives orders to unclean spirits, and they obey."* **28**The news about him spread all over that part of Galilee.

29They left the synagogue and went to Simon and Andrew's house with James and John. **30**Peter's mother-in-law was in bed sick with a fever, and they told him about her. **31**He went and took her hand and raised her up. The fever went away, and she started waiting on them.

32That evening at sunset, people were bringing him the sick and demon-possessed. **33**The whole town gathered at the door. **34**He healed them from many kinds of diseases and cast out lots of demons. He wouldn't let the demons speak because they knew who he was. **Mk 1:21-34**

The First General Tour of Galilee

35In the morning, a good while before daylight, Jesus got up and went out by himself to pray. **36**Simon and the others hunted for him **37**till they found him; *"Everybody's looking for you."*

38He said[p], *"Let's go to the villages nearby so I can preach there too. That's the* main *reason I came out here."* **39**He went around preaching in their synagogues and casting out demons all over Galilee. **Mk 1:35-39**

Cleansing a Leper

40A leper came[p] and pleaded with him on his knees, *"If you're willing, you can cleanse me."* **41**He felt sorry for him and reached out and touched him, *"I'm willing; be cleansed."* **42**Instantly his leprosy disappeared. **43**Jesus spoke earnestly to him and sent him off at once, **44***"Keep this to yourself, show yourself to a priest, and offer for your purification what Moses commanded for a public testimony."* **45**But he went out and started spreading it around, so Jesus had a hard time going into a town openly anymore. He stayed out in rural areas, and people were coming to him from everywhere. **Mk 1:40-45**

Healing a Paralyzed Man

2:1 Several days later, Jesus went back to Capernaum, and people heard he was home. **2**So many people gathered, there wasn't room at the door, and he was speaking the message to them. **3**Four men came[p], carrying a paralyzed man. **4**With the crowd in the way, they couldn't get to Jesus; so they took the roof apart above him and lowered the stretcher with the man on it.

5When Jesus saw their faith, he told[p] the man, *"Son, I'm forgiving your sins."*

6Some scribes sitting there wondered to themselves, **7***"Why's he talking like that? He's blaspheming. Who can forgive sins but God?"*

[8]Jesus knew what they were thinking,

"Why are you wondering about that? [9]*Which is easier: to say to a paralyzed man, 'I'm forgiving your sins'; or to say, 'Get up, pick up your stretcher, and walk'?* [10]*Just so you know that the Son of Man has the right on earth to forgive sins"*—he said to the man, [11] *"Get up, pick up your stretcher, and go on home."*

[12]He got up at once, picked *it* up, and went out in front of everybody. They were astounded and praised God, *"We've never seen such a thing."* [13]Jesus went out again beside the lake. The whole crowd went along, and he started teaching *again*. **Mk 2:1-13**

Calling Matthew;
Controversy About Eating with Sinners

[14]As he was going along, he saw Levi son of Alphaeus sitting at the tax booth. He said[p], *"Come with me."* He got up and went with him.

[15]He was reclining[p] at table in *Levi's* house. Many tax collectors and sinners were reclining at table with him and his disciples because many of them were following him. [16]When the scribes of the Pharisees saw him eating with sinners and tax collectors, they started saying to his disciples, *"Why's he eating with tax collectors and sinners?"*

[17]Jesus overheard it, *"Healthy people don't need a doctor; sick ones do. I didn't come so much to call good people as* to call *sinners."*

Question About Fasting

[18]The disciples of John and the Pharisees were accustomed to fasting. They came[p] and asked[p] Jesus, *"Why do John's and the Pharisees' disciples fast, but yours don't?"*

[19]He said, *"Groomsmen can't feel like fasting while the groom's around, can they?* [20]*The time's coming when the groom will be taken away from them. They'll fast then."*

[21] *"Nobody sews a patch of unshrunk cloth on an old garment. The new patch would pull away from the old material and make the tear worse.* [22]*Nobody puts new wine in old wineskins. It would burst the wineskins, and the wine and wineskins would be lost. People put new wine in new wineskins."* **Mk 2:14-22**

Controversy About Breaking Sabbath

[23]On a Sabbath he was going along the grain fields, and his disciples started picking off heads as they went along.

[24]The Pharisees said, *"Why are they doing what's against the Law on Sabbath?"*

[25]He said, *"You have read, haven't you, what David did when he and his men needed something to eat?* [26]*He went into God's house at the time of Abiathar the high priest and ate the consecrated bread that's against the Law for anybody but priests to eat. He gave some to the ones with him.* [27]*Sabbath was made for people, not people for Sabbath.* [28]*Person takes precedence over Sabbath"*[lit]. **[or lit., "The Son of Man is Lord of the Sabbath."]** **Mk 2:23-28**

Healing a Man with a Paralyzed Hand

3[:1]Again he went into a synagogue. A man with a paralyzed hand was there. [2]*Pharisees* were watching to see if he'd heal him on Sabbath so they could accuse him. [3]He told[p] the man,

"Stand up." [4]He asked[p] them, *"Is it lawful to do good on Sabbath or to do bad, to save life or take life?"*

They didn't say anything.

[5]He looked around at them angry, dismayed at their lack of compassion. He told[p] the fellow, *"Hold out your hand."* He did, and it was restored. [6]The Pharisees left right away to plot with the Herodians to destroy him. **Mk 3:1-6**

Jesus and the Multitudes

[7]Jesus went with his disciples to the side of the lake. A huge crowd followed him from Galilee, Judaea, [8]Jerusalem, Idumea, from beyond the Jordan, and from around Tyre and Sidon. They came because they heard about the things he was doing.

[9]He told his disciples to bring a boat up close so the crowd wouldn't throng him. [10]He'd healed so many people that everybody with an ailment was crowding up to touch him. [11]When unclean spirits would see him, they'd kneel down to him and cry out, *"You're God's Son."* [12]He'd strictly order them not to tell who he was. **Mk 3:7-12**

Calling the Twelve Apostles

[13]He went up[p] on a mountain and called the ones he wanted. [14]He appointed twelve and named them apostles. *He appointed them* to be with him so he could "send" them out to preach [15]and have authority to cast out demons. [16]*The Twelve were* Simon, that he named Peter; [17]James and John, sons of Zebedee, that he nicknamed Boanerges (Sons of Thunder); [18]Andrew, Philip, Bartholomew, Matthew, Thomas; James son of Alphaeus, Thaddaeus, Simon the Zealot, [19]and Judas Iscariot, who *later* betrayed him. **Mk 3:13-19**

The Pharisees' Charge That
Jesus Was in League with the Devil

[20]He came[p] home, and again such a crowd gathered[p] that *he and his disciples* couldn't even eat. [21]When his neighbors heard about it, they went out to rescue him, because they said he was out of his mind. [22]Scribes, down from Jerusalem, started claiming he had Beelzebub—that he was casting out demons by the ruler of demons. [23]He called them over and gave them an illustration:

> *"What sense does it make to say Satan casts out Satan?* [24]*A kingdom at cross purposes with itself can't stand.* [25]*A family at cross purposes with itself can't stand.* [26]*If Satan opposes himself and is at cross purposes, he can't stand.* [27]*Nobody can go into a strong man's house and seize his property unless he ties him up first. Then he can ransack* his *house.*
>
> [28]*I tell you, any sin can be forgiven, including blasphemy;* [29]*but anybody that blasphemes the Holy Spirit will never be forgiven; they're guilty of permanent sin"* ([30]He gave that warning because they were saying he had an unclean spirit.) **Mk 3:20-30**

Jesus' Mother and Brothers
Interrupt His Ministry

31His mother and brothers came[p] and stood outside and sent a message, calling him. **32**The crowd sitting around him said[p], *"Your mother and brothers [and sisters] are outside, they want to talk to you."*

33He answered[p], *"Who are my mother and my brothers?"* **34**He looked all around at the crowd, *"My mother and my brothers!* **35***Whoever does God's will, is my brother, my sister, my mother."* **Mk 3:31-35**

The Sermon in Parables

4:1 Later he was trying to teach by the lake, but the crowd was[p] so big he got in a boat on the water and sat down. The crowd was on the shore.

2He started teaching them with stories.

3"*Listen. A sower went out to sow.* **4***As he sowed, some seed fell along the path, and birds came and gobbled it up.* **5***Some fell on rocky ground, where there wasn't much soil. It sprouted up right away because the soil was thin.* **6***But when the sun climbed high, it scorched and shriveled up because it didn't have roots.* **7***Some seed fell among thorns, and the thorns grew up and choked it out, and it didn't produce anything.* **8***But other seed fell on good ground, came up, grew, and produced 30, 60, 100 times over.* **9***Whoever has ears, listen!"*

10When he was by himself, the ones around him with the Twelve asked him about the stories. **11**He told them, *"You're allowed to know the unrevealed things about God's kingdom, but to people outside I'm doing things in parables* **12***so*

'They'll certainly see, but not perceive;
they'll certainly hear, but not understand,
be converted, and
I forgive them' **[Is 6:9-10].** **Mk 4:1-12**

13*"You don't understand this story? How will you understand any story?* **14***A sower sows the message. Some* seeds *fall beside the path where the message is sown.* **15***When they hear it, Satan comes at once and takes away what was sown in them.* **16***Some fall on rocky soil. When they hear the message, they're glad and accept it right away.* **17***But they don't have root in themselves and just last a while. When trouble or persecution comes on account of the message, they stumble.* **18***Some* seeds *fall among thorns. They hear the message;* **19***but the cares of this age, the deception of wealth, the desire for other things enter in and choke them out, and they don't produce anything.* **20***Others fall on good ground; they hear the message, accept it, and produce 30, 60, 100 times as much as was sown."*

21*"People don't take a lamp and put it under a basket or bed, do they? Don't they put it on a stand?* **22***Nothing is hidden that won't be revealed; nothing is secret that won't come to light.* **23***Whoever has ears, listen!"*

[24] *"Be careful what you listen to. The measure you measure with, you'll be measured by—and more so.* [25]*Those who have, will receive more; those who don't have, will lose what they do have."* **Mk 4:13-25**

[26] *"God's kingdom is like a man that puts seed in the ground.* [27]*He sleeps and gets up day after day, but he doesn't know how the seed sprouts and grows.* [28]*The ground produces crops on its own—the stalk, the head, then the seed in the head.* [29]*When the crop is ready to harvest, he gets out his scythe to harvest it."*

[30] *"What can we compare God's kingdom to? What's it like?* [31]*It's like a mustard seed, which is smaller than any other seed people plant.* [32]*Yet it grows up bigger than the other garden plants and puts out branches, so birds build nests in its shade.*

[33]Only with stories like those was he delivering the message to them as they could understand. [34]Privately he'd explain them to his disciples. **Mk 4:26-34**

Stilling the Storm

[35]That evening he said[p], *"Let's go to the other side."* [36]They left the crowd and took him along in the boat like he was; *some* other boats went along. [37]A dangerous storm came up[p] and was sloshing waves into the boat, and it was filling up. [38]He was in the back of the boat, sleeping with his head on a pillow. They woke[p] him up, *"Rabbi, don't you care that we're about to die?"* [39]He got up and rebuked the wind and waves, and a general calm settled in. [40] *"Why are you so scared? Don't you trust me yet?"* [41]They were even more scared now, *"Who is this that even the wind and waves obey?"* **Mk 4:35-41**

Healing the Gadarene Demoniacs

5:[1]They came to the other side of the lake, to the area of the Gerasenes. [2]As soon as he got out of the boat, a man with an unclean spirit met him from the tombs. [3]He'd been living in the tombs, and nobody could tie him up anymore. [4]People had often bound him with shackles and chains. He'd pulled the chains apart and break the shackles in pieces. Nobody was strong enough to subdue him. [5]Constantly day and night in the tombs and in the hills, he'd scream and cut himself with stones. [6]When he saw Jesus a long way off, he ran and bowed to him [7]and screamed[p], *"What is this, Jesus, Son of God Most High! I beg you by God not to torment me!"* ([8]He said that because Jesus had told the unclean spirit to come out of him.)

[9]He asked him, *"What's your name?"*

"'Legion'; there are lots of us." [10]He begged Jesus not to send them out of the area. [11]A tremendous herd of pigs was feeding on the hillside. [12] *"Send us into the pigs."* [13]Jesus let them. They went into the herd of about 2,000, which stampeded down the steep hill into the lake and drowned.

[14]The herdsmen ran away and reported it in town and in the countryside, and people came to see what had happened. [15]They came[p] over to Jesus and saw the demon-possessed man sitting there dressed and in his right mind, and they were afraid. [16]The people that had seen it described to them how it happened with the demoniac and the pigs. [17]The people started begging Jesus to leave their territory.

18As he was getting in the boat, the demoniac begged to go along; **19**but Jesus told[p] him, *"Go home to your family and tell them how much the Lord has done for you and how he was merciful to you."* **20**He went and told in the Decapolis what all Jesus had done for him, and everybody was amazed. **Mk 5:1-20**

Raising Jairus' Daughter;
Healing a Woman with Chronic Hemorrhaging

21When Jesus crossed back over to the other side in the boat, a big crowd had gathered beside the lake. **22**A ruler of the synagogue, named Jairus, saw him, came[p] and fell down[p] to him, **23**and pleaded[p], *"My little girl is at the point of death. Please come and lay hands on her so she'll live."* **24**Jesus went with him.

A big crowd was following him and pressing in on him. **25**A woman there had been hemorrhaging for twelve years. **26**She'd been put through a lot by doctors and spent everything she had without any benefit—but got worse. **27**When she heard about Jesus, she came up behind him in the crowd and touched his clothes. She'd said, **28***"If I can just touch his clothes, I'll be cured."* **29**Instantly her bleeding stopped. She could feel that she was healed from the scourge she'd been dealing with for so long.

30At once Jesus sensed that power had gone out of him. He turned around in the crowd, *"Who touched my clothes?"*

31His disciples said, *"You see the crowd pressing in on you and you say, 'Who touched me?'"*

32He kept looking around to see who did it. **33**The woman, afraid and nervous, knew what had happened to her. She came and fell down to him and admitted the whole thing.

34*"Daughter, your faith has cured you. Have a good day and stay healed from your ailment."*

35While he was speaking, they came[p] from the synagogue ruler's *house*, *"Your daughter has died; why concern the Rabbi further?"*

36Jesus overheard it and told[p] him, *"Don't give up; just trust me."*

37He only let Peter, James, and his brother John follow him. **38**When he came[p] to the man's house and saw confusion and the people crying and loudly wailing, **39**he went in and said[p], *"Why are you making such a scene? The girl's not dead; she's 'asleep.'"* **40**They started ridiculing him. He put them all out and took her parents and the three with him into where the girl was. **41**He took her hand and said, "*Talitha, qum (Girl, get up)."* **42**She stood up right away and started walking around. (She was twelve.) They were completely astounded. **43**He gave them strict orders that nobody should know about this and told them to give her something to eat.
Mk 5:21-43

Last Visit to Nazareth

6:1 He left for his hometown with his disciples. **2**When Sabbath came, he taught in the synagogue, and many were astonished when they heard[p] *him*: *"Where'd he get that wisdom and those miracles he does with his hands?* **3***Isn't this the builder, Mary's son and the brother of James, Joseph, Judas, and Simon? Aren't his sisters here?"* They were put off by him.

[4]Jesus told them, *"A prophet is respected everywhere except in his hometown, among his relatives, in his own family."* [5]He couldn't do any miracle there—except he did lay hands on a few sick people and healed them. [6]He was amazed at their disbelief.

He continued to move around the villages and teach. **Mk 6:1-6**

Mission of the Twelve

[7]He called[p] the Twelve aside and got them ready to go out in pairs with authority over unclean spirits. [8]He instructed them not to take anything except a staff—no bread, traveler's bag, or money in their belt, [9]but to wear sandals. *"Don't take two shirts to wear.* [10]*Stay at whatever house you enter till you leave the area.* [11]*If a place doesn't welcome you or listen to you, leave and shake the dust off your feet as a statement to them."* [12]They went out and preached that people should repent. [13]They were casting out demons and anointing many sick people with olive oil and healing them.

Mk 6:7-13

Herod's Stricken Conscience

[14]King Herod[Antipas] heard about *him* because Jesus had become well known. People were saying John the Baptist had arisen from the dead and that was why miraculous powers were working in him. [15]Others were saying he was Elijah or like one of the prophets. [16]When Herod heard about it, he said, *"John that I beheaded has resurrected."* [17]Herod himself had sent and arrested John and bound him in prison on account of Herodias, his brother Philip's wife, because he'd married her. [18]John kept telling Herod, *"It's against the Law for you to be living with your brother's wife."* [19]Herodias had a grudge against him and wanted to have him killed; but she couldn't [20]because Herod was afraid of him. He knew he was upright and holy, and he protected him. He listened to him many times and was confused, but he liked to listen to him.

[21]A chance came on his birthday when Herod held a banquet for his officials, military commanders, and prominent men of Galilee. [22]When Salome, his step-daughter—daughter of Herodias—came in and danced, it pleased Herod and the ones reclining at table with him. The king said to the girl *"Ask me for whatever you want, and I'll give it to you."* [23]He strongly swore to her, *"I'll give you whatever you ask for up to half my kingdom."*

[24]She went out and asked her mother what to ask for.

"The head of John the Baptist!"

[25]She hurried back and asked, *"I want you to give me right now the head of John the Baptist on a platter."*

[26]Herod became deeply grieved; but because of his oaths and the guests, he wasn't willing to refuse her. [27]He sent an executioner to bring John's head. He went and beheaded him in the prison, [28]brought his head on a platter and gave it to the girl, and she gave it to her mother. [29]When his disciples heard about it, they came and got his corpse and put it in a tomb. **Mk 6:14-29**

Feeding the 5,000

[30]The apostles *he'd sent* came back[p] to Jesus and reported what all they'd done and taught. [31]He said[p], *"Come off by yourselves away from the crowds and rest awhile."* So many people were coming and going they didn't even have time to eat. [32]They left in a boat to a place off by themselves.

33People saw them leaving and many figured out where they were going. They ran from the towns and got there ahead of them. **34**When he got out *of the boat*, he saw a big crowd and felt sorry for them: they were like sheep without a shepherd. He began to teach them a lot of things.

35When it was getting quite late, his disciples came to him, *"Nobody lives around here, and it's getting late.* **36***Dismiss them so they can go into the countryside and villages to buy food."*

37But he answered, *"You feed them."*

"Should we go spend 200 denarii on bread to feed them!?"

38 *"Go see how many loaves you have."*

They found five, and two fish.

39He told *his disciples* to have everybody sit down on the green grass **40**in groups of 50 and 100. **41**He took the five loaves and two fish, and looked up at the sky, blessed and broke the loaves, and started giving *them* to his disciples to pass out to the crowd, and distributed up the two fish for everybody. **42**They all ate till they were full. **43***The disciples* picked up twelve baskets of fish and pieces of pieces. **44**5,000 men had eaten the loaves. **Mk 6:30-44**

Jesus Walking on the Water

45Jesus urged his disciples to get in the boat right away and go on to Bethsaida, on the other side, while he dismissed the crowd. **46**When he'd said goodbye to them, he went up on the hill to pray. **47**In the evening the boat was out on the lake, and he was by himself on land. **48**He saw them straining at the oars because the wind was against them. About 4 in the morning, he went to them walking on the water as if he intended to go on by. **49**When they saw him walking on the water, they thought he was a ghost and cried out terrified. **50**At once he spoke[p], *"It's me. Don't let me scare you."* **51**He climbed up into the boat with them and the wind died down. They were astounded. **52**They hadn't got the point about the loaves. They weren't catching on.**Mk 6:45-52**

Miracles at Gennesaret

53When they'd crossed over to land, they tied up at Gennesaret. **54**As soon as they got out of the boat, people recognized him. **55**They hurried around the vicinity and started bringing sick people on stretchers to wherever they would hear he was. **56**Whatever villages, towns, or countryside he'd go to, they'd put sick people in the marketplaces and appeal to him just to touch his clothes. As many as touched him were cured. **Mk 6:53-56**

Attack by the Jerusalem
Pharisees About Traditions

7:1 Pharisees and some scribes from Jerusalem **2**had seen some of his disciples eat[p] with defiled—unwashed—hands. (**3**The Pharisees and all the Jews always wash their hands vigorously before they eat—keeping the tradition of the elders. **4**When they come in from the marketplace, they don't eat unless they take a bath. They keep many other customs—ritual washing of cups, pitchers, bronze kettles [and bedrolls][ms].) **5**They gathered around Jesus and asked, *"Why don't your disciples follow the tradition of the elders instead of eating with defiled hands?"*

6He told them,

"Isaiah described you hypocrites well when he wrote:

'This people honors me with their lips,
but their heart is far from me.
7 ***They worship me without meaning anything, and***
teach human rules as* God's *doctrines' **[Is 29:13 LXX].**

8-9 *You neatly set aside divine commandment to establish human tradition.* **10** *A case in point: Moses said,* ***'Honor your father and your mother'*** **[Ex 20:12; Deut 5:16]**, *and,* ***'Put to death whoever cusses at*** *his* ***father or mother'*** **[Ex 21:17].** **11** *But you say, 'If a person tells his father or mother, "Whatever would have helped you is 'Corban ('Given').'"* **12** *You let him do nothing for his parents.* **13** *You negate God's word with* your *tradition. You do a lot of things like that."*

14 He called the crowd again, *"Listen, all of you, and get this.* **15** *Nothing that goes in you can defile you. It's what comes out of you that defiles you."* [**16**][ms]

17 When he went into the house away from the crowd, his disciples asked him about the illustration.

18 *"Don't you get it either? Don't you know that nothing that goes into you can defile you.* **19** *It doesn't go into your heart, but into your stomach, and is eliminated in the toilet* (a comment that *cleanses all food ceremonially*)? **20** *What comes out of you is what defiles you.* **21** *From the inside—from your heart—come sinful thoughts, sexual immorality, theft, murder,* **22** *adultery, coveting, evil intentions, deception, indecency, jealousy, pride, senselessness.* **23** *Sinful things from inside you are what defile you."* **Mk 7:1-23**

Healing the Syrophoenician Woman's Daughter

24 From there he traveled to the locale around Tyre and went into a house because he didn't want anybody to know *it*, but he couldn't hide. **25** Right away, a woman whose daughter had an unclean spirit heard about him and came and fell down to him. **26** She was a Greek, a Syrophoenician. She kept asking him to cast out the demon.

27 He told her, *"Let the kids eat first. It's not right to take their food and toss it to the dogs in the house."*

28 But she answered, *"Lord, even house dogs under the table eat the kids' scraps."*

29 *"Because of that comment,* you can *go; the demon has come out of your daughter."*

30 When she went in her house, she found the little girl lying on her bed and the demon gone. **Mk 7:24-30**

Ministry in Decapolis;
Feeding the 4,000

31 He left the area around Tyre and traveled through Sidon to Lake Galilee in the territory of Decapolis. **32** They brought[p] him a deaf man with a speech impediment and asked[p] him to put his hand on him. **33** He took him away from the crowd by himself and put his fingers in his ears, spit, and touched his tongue. **34** He looked up at the sky, and made a groaning sound and said[p], "*Ephphatha (Open up)*." **35** His ears opened and his tongue freed up, and he started speaking clearly. **36** Jesus told the people not to tell anybody, but the more he told them to keep something

quiet, the more they spread it around. **37**They were completely astonished, *"He's done everything well. He even makes deaf people hear and mutes speak."* **Mk 7:31-37**

8:1 At that time again, the large crowd didn't have anything to eat. Jesus called[p] the disciples over, **2** *"I feel for the crowd. They've stayed with me three days already and don't have any food.* **3***If I send them home hungry, they'll collapse on the way. Some of them have come a long way."*

4His disciples answered, *"Where can anyone satisfy them with bread out here in country?"*

5 *"How many loaves do you have?"*

"Seven."

6He told[p] the crowd to sit down. He took the seven loaves, blessed them, and gave them to his disciples to distribute to the crowd. **7**They had a few small fish. He blessed them and said to pass them out too. **8**The people ate till they were full, and the *disciples* picked up seven large baskets of leftover pieces. **9**About 4,000 people were there, and he dismissed them. **10**Directly he got in the boat with his disciples and went to the vicinity of Dalmanutha. **Mk 8:1-10**

Visit to Magadan;
Demand for a Sign from the Sky

11The Pharisees came and started arguing with him and demanding a sign from the sky—testing him. **12**He groaned under his breath, *"Why do people today keep looking for a sign? They're not going to get one."* **13**He got in the boat again and went back to the other side.

Mk 8:11-13

Fourth Withdrawal East of the Lake;
Warning to the Disciples

14The disciples had forgotten to take bread along and only had one loaf left in the boat. **15**He gave them strict orders, *"Watch out for the 'yeast' from the Pharisees and Herod."* **16**They started reasoning with one another *that his comment was* because they did not have any bread. **17**He knew it and said[p],

> *"Why are you talking about not having any bread? Don't you get it yet? Are you dense?* **18***Do you have eyes that can't see, and ears that can't hear? Don't you remember* **19***how many medium-sized baskets of leftover pieces you picked up when I broke the five loaves for the 5,000?"*
>
> *"Twelve."*

20*"How many large baskets of leftovers did you pick up when I broke the seven loaves for the 4,000?"*

"Seven."

21 *"You still don't get it?"*

22They went[p] to Bethsaida, and people brought[p] Jesus a blind man and asked[p] him to touch him. **23**He led him by the hand out of the village. He spit in his eyes and put his hands on him, *"Do you see anything?"*

24He looked up and said, *"I can see people—like trees—walking."*

25Jesus put his hands over the man's eyes again; the man looked intently, and his sight came back clear.

26Jesus sent him home, *"Don't go back into the village."* **Mk 8:14-26**

Peter's Great Confession

27Jesus and his disciples went out to the villages around Caesarea Philippi. On the way he asked them, *"Who are people saying I am?"*

28 *"John the Baptist; others, Elijah; others, that you're one of the prophets."*

29 *"Who do you say I am?"*

Peter answered, *"You're the Messiah."*

30Jesus told them not to tell anybody. **Mk 8:27-30**

The First Prediction of Messiah's Death

31He started explaining to them that the Son of Man had a lot to suffer; be rejected by the elders, chief priests, and scribes; be put to death, and resurrect after three days. **32**He was talking about the matter openly, and Peter pulled him aside and began to scold him. **33**He turned around and saw his disciples and scolded Peter, *"Get behind me, Satan. Your mind's not on God's interests, but human interests."*

34He called the crowd with his disciples,

> *"If people want to follow me, they have to set aside their own interests, pick up their cross, and follow me.* **35***Whoever wants to save their life will lose it; whoever loses their life on account of and the good news will save it.* **36***What good does it do anyone to gain the whole world and forfeit their life?* **37***What would they give in exchange for their life?* **38***Whoever's ashamed of me and my message in this adulterous, sinful time, the Son of Man will be ashamed of when he comes in his Father's glory with his holy angels.* **9:1***Some* of you *standing here will certainly live to see God's kingdom come with power."* **Mk 8:31-9:1**

The Transfiguration

2Six days later Jesus took[p] Peter, James, and John up on a mountain by themselves, and was transfigured in front of them. **3**His clothes turned brilliant white like no laundryman can bleach them. **4**Elijah appeared with Moses, talking to Jesus. **5**Peter responded[p], *"Rabbi, it's good to be here. Ler's we set up three tents—one each for you, Moses, and Elijah."* **6**He didn't know what to say, because they were afraid. **7**A cloud engulfed them, and a voice came out of it, *"This is my dearly loved Son; listen to him."* **8**Suddenly they looked around and didn't see anybody but Jesus. **Mk 9:2-8**

Discussing the Vision

9As they were coming backdown the mountain, he impressed on them not to pass on to anybody what they'd seen till the Son of Man arose from the dead. **10**They kept the matter to themselves and wondered what *"arising from the dead"* meant.

11They asked him, *"Why do the scribes say Elijah has to come first?"*

[12] *"Elijah does come first to restore everything, and how does the scripture say that the Son of Man has to suffer many things and be rejected?* [13]*But Elijah has in fact come, and they treated him however they wanted to, like scripture says."* **Mk 9:9-13**

Healing the Demoniac Boy

[14]When they got back to the rest of the disciples, they saw a big crowd around them and scribes arguing with them. [15]When they saw him, the whole crowd was really surprised and ran to greet him. [16]Jesus asked, *"Why are you arguing with them?"*

[17]A man in the crowd answered him, *"Rabbi, I brought you my boy. He has a spirit that makes him unable to talk.* [18]*Wherever it seizes him, it throws him on the ground. He foams at the mouth and grinds his teeth and becomes stiff. I spoke to your disciples about casting it out, but they couldn't do it."*

[19] *"Unbelieving bunch, how long am I going to be with you? How long am I going to deal with you? Bring him to me."*

[20]They brought him; and when the spirit saw Jesus, it threw the boy into convulsions. He fell on the ground and started rolling around and foaming at the mouth.

[21]Jesus asked his dad, *"How long has this been going on?"*

"Ever since he was little. [22]*Lots of times it even throws him into the fire or the water to destroy him. But if you can, help us; have sympathy for us."*

[23]Jesus said, *"If you can? Everything's possible for someone that believes."*

[24]His dad cried out, *"I believe! Help my unbelief!"*

[25]When Jesus saw a crowd quickly coming together, he commanded the unclean spirit, *"Mute and deaf spirit, I charge you to come out of him and don't go into him again."*

[26]It cried out and threw him into severe convulsions and came out. The boy looked like he was dead, so much so that many of them said he'd died. [27]But Jesus took hold of his hand to raise him up, and he stood.

[28]When Jesus went into a house, his disciples asked him privately, *"Why couldn't <u>we</u> cast it out?"*

[29] *"This kind doesn't come out except by prayer."* **Mk 9:14-29**

Third Prediction of His Death

[30]They left and began traveling around Galilee. He didn't want anybody to know it, [31]because he was trying to teach his disciples, *"I'm going to be betrayed to authorities that will put me to death. Three days later I'll resurrect."* [32]They didn't understand, but they were reluctant to ask him about it. **Mk 9:30-32**

Discussion About Rank

[33]When they came home to Capernaum, he asked them, *"What were you*[pl] *arguing about on the road?"* [34]They kept still because they'd been arguing about who had highest rank. [35]He sat down and called the Twelve over, *"If anybody wants to be first, he'll put himself last as servant of all."* [36]He took a little child and stood him among them and put his arms around him, [37] *"Whoever receives one of these children in my name receives me, and whoever receives me receives the One that sent me."*

The Unknown Exorcist

38John said, *"Rabbi, we saw a fellow casting out demons in your name and tried to stop him because he wasn't following us."*

39"*Don't stop*[pl] *him. Nobody that performs a miracle in my name will turn right around and say something bad about me.* **40***Whoever is not against us is for us.* **41***Whoever gives you a cup of water in my name because you're following the Messiah, will certainly not miss out on his reward.* **Mk 9:33-41**

The Question of Stumbling Blocks

42 *"Whoever makes one of these little ones stumble that believes in me, would be better off to have a large millstone put around their neck and be thrown into the sea.* **43***If your hand causes you problems, amputate it. It's better to go about life deformed than to have two hands and go to hell—into the unquenchable fire. [***44***]*[ms] **45***If your foot causes you problems, amputate it. It's better to go about life deformed than to have two feet and be thrown into hell. [***46***]*[ms] **47***If your eye causes you problems, gouge it out. It's better to get in God's kingdom with one eye than to have two eyes and be thrown into hell,* **48***where the worms don't die, and the fire doesn't burn out.*

49 *"Everybody will be tested with fire.* **50***Salt's good, but if it loses its saltiness, how will you make it salty? Have salt in yourselves and get along with each other."* **Mk 9:42-50**

Jesus in Perea;
Teaching About Divorce

10:1 From there he went[p] to places in Judaea and beyond the Jordan. Again, crowds went[p] with him; and he was teaching them like usual.

2Pharisees came and asked if a man could legally divorce his wife—testing him.

3He answered, *"What did Moses command you?"*

4 *"Moses allowed a husband* ***to divorce his wife in writing"*** **[Deut 24:1, 3].**

5Jesus said, *"He wrote that because of your hardheartedness.* **6***From the beginning of creation,* ***'he made them male plus female*** **[Gen 5:2].** **7*****So a man is to leave his parents and unite with his wife,*** **8*****and they are to become one physical unit'*** **[Gen 2:24]***; they're no longer two but one.* **9***What God has joined, people are not to separate."*

10In the house the disciples asked him about it again.

11 *"Whoever divorces his wife and marries another woman commits adultery against her.* **12***If a woman divorces her husband and marries another man, she commits adultery."* **Mk 10:1-12**

Jesus and the Little Children

[13]People were bringing their kids so he could touch them, but the disciples fussed at them. [14]When Jesus saw it, he was indignant, *"Let them come to me. Don't get in their way. God's kingdom is made up of people like them.* [15]*Whoever doesn't welcome God's kingdom like a little child, will certainly not get into it."* [16]He took the children in his arms and laid hands on them. **Mk 10:13-16**

The Rich Young Ruler

[17]As he was going out to the road, a man ran and knelt to him, *"Good Rabbi, what do I need to do to inherit eternal life?"*

[18]Jesus said, *"Why are you calling me good? Only God is good.* [19]*You know the commandments,* ***'do not murder, commit adultery, steal, lie, or swindle; respect your parents"*** **[Ex 20:12-16; Deut 5:16-20; 24:14].**

[20]*"I've kept those since I was a boy."*

[21]Jesus looked at him and liked him, *"There is one thing you lack. Sell what you own, give it to the poor, and you'll have wealth in heaven; come with me."*

[22]He was shocked and went away discouraged because he owned a lot. **Mk 10:17-22**

The Peril of Wealth

[23]Jesus looked around and said[p] to his disciples, *"It's so hard for wealthy people to get into God's kingdom."*

[24]That surprised the disciples, but he said[p] it again; *"Children, it's so hard to get into God's kingdom.* [25]*It's easier for a camel to go through a needle's eye than for rich people to get into God's kingdom."*

[26]They were surprised even more, *"So who can be saved?"*

[27]Jesus looked at them and said[p], *"It's not possible with people, but with God everything's possible."*

[28]Peter spoke up, *"We've left everything to follow you."*

[29]Jesus said, *"Everybody that's left a house, brothers, sisters, mother, father, children, or fields for my sake* [30]*will receive houses, brothers, sisters, mothers, children, and fields 100 times over in this age with persecution and eternal life in the age to come.* [31]*Many first will be last and last, first."* **Mk 10:23-31**

Another Prediction of His Death

[32]On the way up to Jerusalem, Jesus was ahead of them. They were wondering what was going to happen, and the people behind were afraid. He called the Twelve again and explained to them what was about to happen: [33]*"We're going to Jerusalem, and I'll be betrayed to the chief priests and the scribes. They'll condemn me to death and turn me over to the Gentiles.* [34]*They'll make fun of me, spit on me, flog me, and put me to death. Three days later I'll resurrect."*

Mk 10:32-34

James and John's Request for Rank

[35]James and John, Zebedee's sons, came[p], saying, *"Rabbi, we want you to do something."*

[36]*"What is it?"*

[37]*"Let us sit on your right and left hand in your glory."*

38Jesus told them, *"You don't know what you're asking. Can you drink the cup I drink and be baptized with the baptism I'm baptized with?"*

39 *"Yes."*

Jesus said, *"You'll drink the cup I drink* all right *and be baptized with the baptism I'm baptized with.* **40***But I'm not the One that decides who sits on my right and left hand. They're the ones* it's *prepared for."*

41When the ten heard it, they were indignant over what James and John had done.

42Jesus said[p],

> *"You know that rulers among the Gentiles lord it over them, and their great ones are tyrants toward them.* **43***It's not that way with you. Whoever wants to be great among you will be your servant,* **44***and whoever wants to be first among you will be the servant of all.* **45***Even I didn't come to be served, but to serve, and to give my life as a ransom for many."* **Mk 10:35-45**

Healing a Blind Man at Jericho

46They came[p] to Jericho. As he, his disciples, and a sizeable crowd were leaving the city, Bartimaeus (*"Son of Timaeus"*), a beggar, was sitting by the road. **47**When he heard it was Jesus the Nazarene, he started yelling, *"Jesus, son of David, have mercy on me!"*

48People told him to quiet down, but he yelled louder, *"Son of David, have mercy on me."*

49Jesus stopped, *"Call him* over here*."*

They called him, *"Okay; get up; he's calling for you."*

50He threw his cloak aside, jumped up, and went to Jesus.

51Jesus answered him, *"What do you want me to do for you?"*

"Rabbi, I want to see again."

52 *"Go on, your faith has made you able to see."* Instantly he could see again, and he went with Jesus on the road. **Mk 10:46-52**

The Triumphal Entry

11:1 When they got[p] close to Jerusalem—to Bethphage and Bethany, on the Mount of Olives, he sent[p] two disciples, **2** *"Go in the village over there. Just inside, you'll find a donkey colt tied that nobody has ridden. Untie it and bring it here.* **3***If anybody says, 'Why are you doing this?' say, 'The Lord needs it,' and he'll send[p] it here right away."*

4They went and found the colt tied at the gate outside by the road and untied[p] it. **5**Some of the ones standing there said, *"What're you doing, untying the colt?"*

6The disciples said what Jesus told them to say, and they let them take it. **7**They brought[p] it to Jesus and put[p] their cloaks on it, and he sat on it. **8**People spread their cloaks on the road and brought leafy branches they'd cut out of the fields. **9**The ones in front and behind started shouting,

> ***"Hosanna!***
>
> ***Blessed be the one that's coming in the name of the LORD*** **[Ps 118:25-26]!**
>
> **10***Blessed is the coming kingdom of our ancestor David.*
>
> ***Hosanna*** *in the highest!"*

11He entered the Temple in Jerusalem and looked around at everything. It was already evening, and he went out to Bethany with the Twelve. **Mk 11:1-11**

Cursing the Fig Tree;
Second Cleansing of the Temple

12The next day, when they left Bethany, he was hungry. **13**From a distance he saw a fig tree leafed out and went to see if he'd find anything on it. He didn't find anything but leaves—it wasn't the season for figs yet. **14**He said to it, *"May nobody ever eat fruit from you again."* His disciples heard it.

15They went[p] into Jerusalem. In the Temple, he started putting out the buyers and sellers. He turned over the tables of the moneychangers and the chairs of men selling doves. **16**He wouldn't let anybody carry a container through the Temple. **17**He began to teach, *"Doesn't scripture say,*

> ***'Call my house a house of prayer for all the nations'****?* **[Is 56:7]**
> *You've made it* ***'a den of thieves'****!"* **[Jer 7:11]**

18The chief priests and scribes heard about it and kept looking for a way to destroy him. They were afraid of him, and the crowd was astonished at his teaching. **19**In the evening, he *and his disciples* left the city. **Mk 11:12-19**

Discussing the Shriveled Fig Tree

20As they went by early the next morning, they saw the fig tree completely shriveled up. **21**Peter remembered, *"Rabbi, the fig tree you cursed has shriveled up!"*

22Jesus said[p], *"Trust God.* **23***Whoever says to this mountain, 'Be picked up and thrown into the sea,' and doesn't doubt, it'll happen.* **24***As many things as you ask for in prayer, believe you've as good as received it[aorist], and you will.* **25***When you stand praying, if you have anything against anybody, forgive them so your Father in heaven will forgive you."* [**26**][ms] **Mk 11:20-26**

Jesus' Authority Challenged

27They went[p] into Jerusalem again. While he was walking in the Temple, the Pharisees, scribes, and elders came[p], **28***"What right do you have to do this? Who gave you that right?"*

29Jesus said, *"I'll ask you something. Answer me and I'll tell you what right I have to do this.* **30***Was John's baptism from heaven or humans? Answer that."*

31They consulted with one another, *"If we say, 'From heaven,' he'll say, 'Why didn't you believe him?'* **32***But if we say, 'From humans'"*—they were afraid of the crowd because they all certainly considered John a prophet. **33**They answered[p], *"We don't know."*

Jesus said[p], *"I won't tell you either what right I have to do this."* **Mk 11:27-33**

Parable About a Vineyard

12:1 He started telling stories.

> *"A man planted a vineyard, put a wall around it, dug a wine pit with a trough under it, rented it out to tenants, and left on a trip.* **2***At harvest time he sent a servant to the tenants to receive the fruit from the vineyard.* **3***They took him and*

beat him up and sent him away empty-handed. [4]*He sent another servant, and they beat him over the head and abused him.* [5]*He sent another, and they killed him. He sent many others. They beat up some and killed others.*

[6]*"He still had one, dear son. He sent him to them last, 'They'll respect my son.'* [7]*But those tenants said to one another, 'This is the heir. Come on, let's kill him, and the inheritance will belong to us.'* [8]*They took him, threw him out of the vineyard, and killed him.* [9]*What will the owner do? He'll come and destroy those tenants and give the vineyard to other people.* [10]*Didn't you ever read this scripture:*

'The stone the builders rejected
has become the cornerstone.
[11]***That has come from the LORD;***
it's amazing to us.'" **[Ps 118:22-23]**

[12]The *Pharisees* were looking for a way to arrest him, but they were afraid of the crowds. They knew he'd aimed the story at them, and they left. **Mk 12:1-12**

Question About Tribute to Caesar

[13]They sent some Pharisees and Herodians to trap him in what he said. [14]They said, *"Rabbi, we know you tell the truth, you don't defer to anybody, you don't respect persons, you teach the way of God correctly. Is it lawful to pay tribute to Caesar?"*

[15]He saw through their hypocrisy, *"Why are you trying to put me on the spot? Bring me a denarius."*

[16]They brought him one, and he said, *"Whose image and inscription are these?"*

"Caesar's."

[17]*"So pay Caesar what you owe Caesar and pay God what you owe God."*

They were stunned. **Mk 12:13-17**

Question About Resurrection

[18]The Sadducees came—who say there's no resurrection,

[19]*"Rabbi, Moses wrote to us that* ***if someone's brother dies*** *and* ***leaves*** *a wife and* ***no child, his brother is to take the wife and raise up heirs for his brother*** **[Gen 38:8; Deut.25:5]**. [20]*There were seven brothers. The first married a wife and left no offspring when he died.* [21]*The second married her and died, with no offspring. The third did the same thing.* [22]*All seven died, not leaving any offspring. Last of all, the woman died too.* [23]*Whose wife will she be in the resurrection? The seven had her as a wife."*

[24]Jesus said,

"Don't you err because you don't know the scriptures or God's power? [25]*When people resurrect, they don't get married. They're like angels in heaven.*

[26]*"As to the resurrection of the dead, haven't you read in the book of Moses in the bush passage how God spoke to him:* ***'I'm Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob's God'****?* **[Ex 3:6, 15-16]** [27]*He's not a God of the dead but of the living. You're greatly mistaken."* **Mk 12:18-27**

Question About the Most Important Commandment

[28]When one of the scribes heard them arguing and saw that Jesus had answered them well, he came and asked, *"What is the most important commandment?"*

[29]Jesus answered, *"The most important is,* ***'Listen, Israel, the LORD your God is LORD alone.*** [30]***Love the LORD your God with all your heart, all your soul,*** *all your mind****, all your strength'*** **[Deut 6:4-5]**. [31]*The second is,* ***"Love your neighbor as yourself"*** **[Lev 19:18]**. *There's no commandment more important than those."*

[32]The scribe said, *"Well put, Rabbi; you're right that* ***he is the only one*** **[Deut 6:4]*****; there is no other God besides him*** **[Deut 4:35; Is 45:21]**. [33]***Loving him with all your heart, mind*** **[Deut 6:5; Josh 22:5]***, and strength, and* ***loving your neighbor as yourself*** **[Lev 19:18]** *is more* important *than all burnt offerings and sacrifices."*

[34]Jesus saw he'd made a sensible comment, *"You're not far from God's kingdom."*

Nobody dared ask him any more questions. **Mk 12:28-34**

Question About the Son of David

[35]After he answered those questions, as he was teaching in the Temple, he said, *"How can the scribes say that the Messiah is David's son?* [36]*David said by the Holy Spirit,*

'The LORD said to my Lord,
"Sit at my right hand
till I put your enemies under your feet"' **[Ps 110:1]**.

[37]*David himself called him 'Lord'; how can he be his son?"* The huge crowd loved it.

Denunciation of the Pharisees

[38]In his teaching, he was saying, *"Watch out for the Pharisees. They like to walk around in long robes, receive greetings in marketplaces,* [39]*occupy prominent seats in synagogues and places of honor at banquets.* [40]*They confiscate widows' houses and offer long prayers for show. They'll receive more severe condemnation."* **Mk 12:35-40**

The Widow's Mite

[41]He sat down across from the Treasury and was watching *people from* the crowd put copper coins in the Treasury. Wealthy people were putting in big amounts. [42]A poor widow came and put in two leptons, which equal a quadrans. [43]He called his disciples over, *"That poor widow put in more than all the others.* [44]*They donated out of their abundance, but she donated out of her poverty—everything she had to live on."* **Mk 12:41-44**

The Olivet Discourse

13:[1]As he was leaving the Temple, one disciple said[p], *"Rabbi, look at what wonderful stones and magnificent buildings!"*

[2]Jesus said, *"You see these large buildings? Not one stone will be left on top of another here."*

[3]When he was sitting on the Mount of Olives across from the Temple, Peter, James, John, and Andrew asked him privately, [4]*"Tell us when that will happen and what will indicate that it's about to happen."*

[5]Jesus told them,

"Make sure nobody deceives you. [6]Many will come, claiming to be Messiah, and deceive lots of people. [7]When you hear about wars and reports about wars, don't panic. They need to happen, but that's not the end yet. [8]Nation will attack nation; kingdom will attack kingdom. There'll be earthquakes and famines in many places. They're the beginning of labor pains. **Mk 13:1-8**

[9]*"Watch out. They'll take you to court and flog you in the synagogues. You'll stand in front of governors and kings to speak* for me. [10]*The good news needs to reach all the countries first.* [11]*When they arrest you and put you on trial, don't worry about what you're going to say. Say what comes to you at that time; you won't be the ones speaking; it'll be the Holy Spirit.* [12]*Brother will betray brother to death, and father will betray child. Children will rise up against parents and have them put to death.* [13]*People will hate you because of me. The one that endures to the end will be saved.*

[14]*"When you see 'the abomination of desolation' positioned where it shouldn't be* (reader, understand), *people in Judaea need to flee to the hill country.* [15]*The one on the housetop must not go down to get what's in the house.* [16]*The one in the field must not go home to get his cloak.* [17]*Woe to those who are pregnant or nursing then.* [18]*Pray that it won't happen in the wintertime.* [19]*Those days will be the worst ever—from the beginning of God's creation till now or ever will be.* [20]*If the* LORD *hadn't shortened them, nobody would survive. But, because of the Chosen, he has shortened them.* **Mk 13:9-20**

[21]*"If anybody says, 'Here's the Messiah,' or 'There's* the Messiah*,' don't believe it.* [22]*False Messiahs and false prophets will arise and give signs and wonders to deceive, if possible, even the Chosen.* [23]*But you be careful. I've told you all this ahead of time.*

[24]*"After that distress,*
the sun will go out, and
the moon won't shine.
[25]*Stars will fall from the sky, and*
the powers in the sky will be shaken.
[26]*Then people will see* ***the Son of Man coming on the clouds*** **[Dan 7:13-14]** *with great power and glory.* [27]*He'll send out his angels to gather the Chosen from every direction, from the end of earth to the end of sky.*

[28]*"Take a lesson from a fig tree. When its branches get tender and sprout leaves, you know summer's coming.* [29]*The same way, when you see these things happening, you know he's at the door.* [30]*They'll take place in* <u>*this*</u> *generation.* [31]*Earth and sky will pass away, but what I say won't pass away.* **Mk 13:21-31**

[32]*"Nobody knows about* <u>*that*</u> *day or hour—not the angels in heaven, not the Son of Man, only the Father.* [33]*Be careful, stay alert; you don't know when it will happen*[p]*.* [34]*A man leaving on a trip gives each servant the authority to do his job and tells the doorkeeper to stay alert.* [35]*Watch; you don't know when the master of the household will come back—in the evening, at midnight, at rooster*

crowing, or in the morning—[36]*so if he comes unexpectedly, he won't catch you sleeping.* [37]*What I'm saying I'm saying to all of you. Watch!"* **Mk 13:32-37**

Fifth Prediction of His Death

14[:1]The Passover and Festival of Unleavened Bread was two days away. The chief priests and scribes were trying to find a way to arrest Jesus by stealth and put him to death. [2]They said, *"Not during the festival; the people will riot."* **Mk 14:1-2**

The Anointing of Jesus by Mary

[3]When he was in Bethany in the house of Simon the leper, reclining at table, a woman came with an alabaster cruise of expensive pure nard ointment. She broke open the alabaster cruise and poured it on his head. [4]Some were expressing their indignation to one another, *"Why has she wasted this ointment?* [5]*She could've sold it for over 300 denarii and given it to the poor."* They started fussing at her.

[6]Jesus said, *"Leave her alone. Why are you bothering her? She's done me a good turn.* [7]*You always have poor people around; you can do something good for them any time. You won't always have*[p] *me.* [8]*She did what she could: she anointed my body ahead of time for burial.* [9]*Wherever you deliver the good news in the world, tell what she's done in memory of her."* **Mk 14:3-9**

Judas' Plot to Betray Jesus

[10]Judas Iscariot, one of the Twelve, went to the high priests to deliver Jesus to them. [11]When they heard his offer, they were elated and promised to give him silver; so he started looking for a chance to turn him over. **Mk 14:10-11**

Preparation for the Passover Meal

[12]On the first day of Unleavened Bread, when the Passover lamb was being sacrificed, his disciples said, *"Where do you want us to get things ready for eating the Passover?"* [13]He sent[p] two disciples, *"On the way into the city, you'll meet a man carrying a clay pot of water. Follow him,* [14]*and where he goes in, say to the owner, 'The Rabbi says, "Where's the guest room so I can eat the Passover with my disciples?"'* [15]*He'll show you a big room upstairs, furnished and set up. Get things ready there."*

[16]The disciples went into the city and found it like Jesus had said and got things ready. **Mk 14:12-16**

The Passover Meal;
Judas Identified as Traitor

[17]He arrived[p] that evening with the Twelve. [18]As they were reclining at table eating, he said[p], *"One of you that's eating with me is going to betray me."*

[19]They became sad and said one by one, *"It's not me, is it?"*

[20]He said, *"It's one of the Twelve that's dipping with me in the bowl.* [21]*The Son of Man will go like scripture says, but woe to the one that betrays him! It would've been better for him if he hadn't been born."* **Mk 14:17-21**

The Lord's Supper Instituted

22During the meal Jesus took a loaf, blessed it, broke it, and handed it to them: *"Take it; this is my body."* **23**He took a cup, blessed it, handed it to them, and they all drank out of it. **24**He said, *"This is my blood of the covenant that's shed for many.* **25***This is the last time I'll drink the fruit of the vine till I do it in God's kingdom."*

26They sang a hymn and went out to the Mount of Olives. **Mk 14:22-26**

The Disciples Warned

27Jesus told[p] them, "*You're all going to desert me because scripture says,*

'I'll strike down the shepherd,
and* his *sheep will scatter' **[Zech 13:7]**.

28*But after I resurrect, I'll go ahead of you to Galilee."*

29Peter said, *"Even if everybody else deserts you, I won't."*

30Jesus said[p], *"I tell you, before a rooster double-crows in the morning, you're going to deny me three times."*

31He kept insisting, *"Even if I have to die with you, I won't deny you."*

That's what they all said. **Mk 14:27-31**

The Agony in the Garden

32They came[p] to a place named Gethsemane, and he told[p] his disciples, *"Sit here while I pray."* **33**He took[p] Peter, James, and John, and began to feel stress and dread. **34***"I'm really stressed. Stay here and keep watch."* **35**He went on a little way and fell on the ground, and prayed that, if possible, the time would pass him by. **36***"Abba (Father), you can do anything. Take this cup away from me. But not what I want, but what you want."* **37**He came[p] and found[p] them sleeping and said[p] to Simon, *"You're[sg] sleeping? Couldn't you[sg] watch for one hour?* **38***Watch[pl] and pray so you[pl] won't be tempted. The spirit's willing but the flesh is weak."* **39**He went again and prayed the same thing. **40**When he came back, he found them sleeping; they couldn't keep their eyes open. They didn't know what to say. **41**He came[p] the third time, *"You're still sleeping and resting? The time has come. The Son of Man is being betrayed to sinners.* **42***Get up; let's go! The one that's betraying me is coming."* **Mk 14:32-42**

The Arrest of Jesus

43While he was still talking, Judas came[p] with a crowd from the chief priests, scribes, and elders, carrying[pl] swords and clubs. **44**The traitor had given them a signal, *"The one I kiss is him. Arrest him and take him away safely."* **45**He came right up to Jesus and said[p], *"Rabbi,"* and kissed him. **46**They grabbed Jesus and arrested him. **47**One of those standing by drew his sword and struck the high priest's servant and cut off his ear. **48**Jesus responded to them, *"You've come out* here *with swords and clubs to arrest me like an insurgent?* **49***I was with you every day in the Temple teaching, and you didn't arrest me. But* this is happening *to fulfill the scriptures."* **50***The disciples* ran away. **51**A young man was following him with a linen sheet around his naked body. They grabbed at him, **52**but he left the sheet behind and fled naked.

53They took Jesus to the high priest. The chief priests, elders, and scribes convened[p]. **54**Peter followed him at a distance to the high priest's courtyard and sat down with the officers to warm himself at the fire. **Mk 14:43-54**

The Trial Before Caiaphas

55The chief priest and the full Sanhedrin were looking for testimony against Jesus so they could put him to death, but they couldn't find any. **56**A number of people gave false testimony against him, but their testimonies didn't agree with each other. **57**Some got up and gave false testimony, **58***"We heard him say he'd tear down this sanctuary made with hands and build another one in three days without hands."* **59**Their testimonies didn't agree even on that point.

60The high priest stood up and asked Jesus, *"Aren't you going to answer anything these men are testifying against you?"*

61He didn't answer.

The high priest asked him again, "*Are you the Messiah, the Son of the Blessed?"*

62*"I am;*

'You'll see the Son of Man
sitting on the right hand of Power *and*
coming with the clouds'" **[Ps 110:1; Dan 7:14].**

63The high priest tore his clothes, *"Why do we still need witnesses?* **64***You've heard the blasphemy. What's your verdict?"*

They ruled for the death penalty.

65Some started spitting on him, blindfolding and slapping him, *"Say* who did that*!"* The officers took him, slapping him. **Mk 14:55-65**

Peter's Denials

66Peter was down below in the courtyard. A servant girl of the high priest came. **67**When she saw Peter warming himself, she looked at him closely, *"You were with the Nazarene, Jesus."*

68But he denied it, *"I don't know what you're talking about,"* and he went out to the entryway.

69The servant girl saw him again and started telling the ones standing around, *"This <u>is</u> one of them."*

70He denied it again.

A little later the ones standing around said, *"You really <u>are</u> one of them; you're a Galilean."*

71He started taking oaths and swearing, *"I don't know the man you're talking about."* **72**Immediately a rooster double-crowed, and Peter remembered: *"Before a rooster double-crows, you'll deny me three times."* He broke down sobbing. **Mk 14:66-72**

The Two Trials Before Pilate

15:1 At daylight, the chief priests held session with the elders, scribes, and full Sanhedrin. They bound Jesus and led him away to Pilate. **2**Pilate asked him, *"Are you the 'King of the Jews'?"*

"Yes."

[3]The chief priests accused him of all kinds of things.

[4]Pilate asked him again, *"You're not saying anything? Look at all the things they're accusing you of."* [5]Jesus still didn't answer. Pilate was surprised.

[6]At each festival, Pilate would release a prisoner that they asked for. [7]A prisoner called Barabbas was incarcerated with insurgents that[pl] had committed murder in the uprising. [8]The crowd came forward and started asking Pilate to do as he customarily did for them.

[9]Pilate answered, *"Do you want me to release 'the King of the Jews'?"* ([10]He knew the high priests had delivered him over because they envied him.)

[11]But the high priests stirred up the crowd to ask for Barabbas instead.

[12]Pilate answered again, *"What do you want me to do then with the one you call 'the King of the Jews'?"*

[13] *"Crucify him!"*

[14] *"What's he done?"*

They shouted louder, *"Crucify him!"*

[15]Pilate wanted to quiet the crowd, so he released Barabbas and delivered Jesus to be flogged and crucified. **Mk 15:1-15**

Torture by the Roman Soldiers

[16]The soldiers took him into the court—The Praetorium—and got the whole cohort together. [17]They dressed him in purple and twisted together a crown made out of thorns and put it on him. [18]They began to acclaim him, "*Hail, King of the Jews!"* [19]and were beating him on the head with a reed, spitting on him, and kneeling and bowing to him. [20]When they were done making fun of him, they took off the purple robe and dressed him in his own clothes, and took[p] him away to crucify him. **Mk 15:16-20**

The Way to Golgotha

[21]They conscripted[p] Simon, a Cyrenian coming in from the countryside—father of Alexander and Rufus—to carry his cross. [22]They took[p] him to Golgotha ("The Skull"), [23]and offered him wine mixed with myrrh, but he didn't take it. [24]When they'd crucified him, they divided up his clothes by casting lots for what each soldier would take. **Mk 15:21-24**

The Death of Messiah

[25]It was 9 o'clock when they crucified him. [26]Pilate inscribed his accusation above him, *"The King of the Jews."* [27]They also crucified[p] two insurgents with him, one on each side. [[28]][ms]

[29]The people going past threw insults at him and shook their heads, *"Ha! You that tear down the sanctuary and rebuild it in three days,* [30]*save yourself; come down from the cross!"*

[31]The chief priests along with scribes made fun of him too, *"He saved other people; he can't save himself!* [32]*Messiah, King of Israel, come down now from the cross so we can see and believe!"* Even the ones crucified with him were insulting him.

[33]At noon it got dark over the whole country till 3. [34]At 3 o'clock Jesus cried out very loud, **"*Eloi, Eloi, lama sabachthani* (My God, my God, why have you deserted me) [Ps 22:1]?"** [35]Some of the people standing nearby heard it, *"He's calling for Elijah."*

[36]One man ran and filled a sponge with sour wine, put it on a reed, and gave him a drink, *"Let's see if Elijah will come and take him down."*

[37]Jesus let out a loud cry and quit breathing. **Mk 15:25-37**

Miracles Accompanying Messiah's Death

[38]The curtain in the sanctuary tore in two, top to bottom. [39]When the centurion standing beside him saw the way he quit breathing, he said, *"This man really was God's Son."*

[40]Some women watching from a distance included Mary the Magdalene; Mary, mother of James the Less and Joses; and Salome. [41]When he was in Galilee, they traveled with him and helped him. There were some other women that came up with him to Jerusalem. **Mk 15:38-41**

The Burial of Jesus
and Watch at the Tomb

[42]When evening came, since it was Preparation, the day before Sabbath, [43]Joseph of Arimathea—a respected member of the Sanhedrin, who was waiting for God's kingdom—gathered the courage to go to Pilate and ask for Jesus' body. [44]Pilate was surprised that he'd already died. He called the centurion to ask him if Jesus was dead already. [45]When he understood from him that Jesus was dead, he let Joseph have the body. [46]Joseph had bought a linen sheet; he took Jesus down and wrapped him in it. He put him in a rock-hewn tomb and rolled a stone over the entrance. [47]Mary the Magdalene and Mary, mother of Joseph, watched where they laid him. **Mk 15:42-47**

The Resurrection of Messiah

16[:1]When Sabbath had passed, Mary the Magdalene; Mary, mother of James; and Salome bought aromatic oils to put on his body. [2]Very early on the first day of the week, they came[p] to the tomb as the sun was just starting to come up. [3]They were saying to one another, *"Who's going to roll the stone away for us from the entrance to the tomb?"* [4]When they looked up, they saw[p] the big stone had been rolled away. [5]They went into the tomb and saw a young man sitting on the right wearing a white robe, and they were startled. [6]He said[p], *"Don't be startled. You're looking for Jesus the Nazarene that was crucified. He's not here; he resurrected. See where they laid him.* [7]*Go tell his disciples and Peter, 'He's going on ahead of you to Galilee. You'll see him there like he said.'"* [8]They went out and ran from the tomb because trembling and excitement gripped them. They didn't talk to anybody because they were afraid. **Mk 16:1-8**

Appearance to Mary the Magdalene

[[[9]After he'd resurrected early on the first day of the week, he appeared first to Mary the Magdalene, that he'd cast seven demons out of. [10]She reported it to the ones that had been with him, who were mourning and crying. [11]When they heard she'd seen him alive, they didn't believe it. **[Mk 16:9-11]**

Appearance to Two Disciples
and to the Ten

[12]After that, he appeared to two of them in a different form as they were walking[p] into *the* countryside. [13]They went back *to Jerusalem* to report it to the rest, *but* they didn't believe them either.

14Later, he appeared to the eleven as they were reclining at table and chided them for their resistance to believing the ones that had seen him resurrected. [**Mk 16:12-14]**

Appearance in Jerusalem

15He told them,

"Go all over the world and tell everybody the good news. **16***Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved; whoever disbelieves will be condemned.* **17***These signs will follow the ones that believe:*

they'll cast out demons in my name;
they'll speak in new languages;
18*they'll pick up snakes, and*
if they drink anything deadly, it won't hurt them;
they'll lay hands on sick people, and they'll recover." **[Mk 16:15-18]**

The Ascension

19After the Lord Jesus had spoken to them, he was taken up into heaven and sat down on God's right hand. **20***The disciples* went out and delivered the good news everywhere, and the Lord worked with them by confirming the message with the signs that followed.]] [**Mk 16:19-20]**

LUKE

Prologue

1:1 Many have undertaken to put together an account of what's been fulfilled among us. **2** Eyewitnesses from the beginning and ministers of the message have handed down *accounts of* those events to us. **3** It seemed appropriate to me, as well, to trace these things from the start and write you an orderly account, most excellent Theophilus, **4** so you can know for certain that your oral instruction was accurate. **Lk 1:1-4**

The Birth of John Announced

5 At the time of Herod king of Judaea, there was a priest named Zachariah in the Abijah division; his wife Elizabeth descended from Aaron. **6** They both lived upright before God and conducted themselves blamelessly by his commandments. **7** Elizabeth couldn't have children, and both were getting old.

8 Zachariah was carrying out his priestly duties in front of God in the sequence of his division. **9** According to the custom of the priestly office, he'd been chosen by lot to go into the sanctuary of the LORD to offer incense. **10** A crowd was praying outside. **11** An angel of the LORD appeared to him and stood on the right side of the altar of incense. **12** When Zachariah saw him, he froze in fear. **13** The angel said,

"You don't need to be afraid, Zechariah; God has heard your prayer.
Your wife will have a son, and you're to name him 'John.' **14** *You'll*[sg] *be so happy,*
and lots of people will celebrate his birth. **15** *He'll be great before the LORD:*
He won't drink wine or strong beer;
he'll have the Holy Spirit from birth.
16 *He'll return many Israelites to the LORD their God.*
17 *and go ahead of the Lord in the spirit and power of Elijah.*
He'll return the hearts of fathers to their children
and the disobedient to the attitude good people have.
He'll thoroughly prepare people for the LORD."

18 Zechariah said, *"How am I going to know that? My wife and I are both old."*

19 *"I'm Gabriel; I stand beside the LORD. He sent me to bring you this good news.* **20** *You won't be able to talk till it happens, because you didn't believe me; but it will come about in due time."*

21 The people waiting for Zechariah couldn't believe how long he'd been in the sanctuary. **22** When he did come out, he couldn't talk. They surmised that he must have seen a vision in the sanctuary. He was making gestures to them.

[23]When his term of service was up, he went back home. [24]Later, Elizabeth became pregnant and stayed inside for five months, [25]*"That's how the LORD dealt with me when he looked favorably at me and took away my disgrace* at not being able to have children*."* **Lk 1:5-25**

The Birth of Jesus Announced

[26]In *Elizabeth's* sixth month, God sent Gabriel to Nazareth, a town in Galilee. [27]*He went* to a virgin named Mary, who was engaged to Joseph, a descendant of David. [28]He went inside and said, *"Hello, favored one; the LORD's with you."* [29]It startled her, and she wondered what he meant.

[30]The angel said,

"You don't need to be afraid, Mary. God's pleased with you. [31]*You'll become pregnant and have a son you're to name 'Jesus.'*

[32]*He'll be great*

and be called the Son of the Most High.

The LORD God will give him the throne of his ancestor David.

[33]*He'll rule Jacob's descendants forever;*

his kingdom will never end."

[34]Mary said, *"How can that be? I don't have a husband."*

[35]*"The Holy Spirit will come over you, and the power of the Most High will overshadow you. So the Holy One begotten will be called God's Son.* [36]*Elizabeth your relative is pregnant, too, with a son in her old age. This is the sixth month with her that's been childless.* [37]*God can do anything."*

[38]Mary said, *"I'm the LORD's servant; may it be to me like you've said."*

The angel left. **Lk 1:26-38**

Mary Visits Elizabeth

[39]Mary hurried to a town in the hill country of Judaea, [40]and went into Zechariah's house to greet Elizabeth. [41]When she heard Mary's greeting, her baby kicked, and Elizabeth was filled with the Holy Spirit: [42]she shouted, *"You're a blessed woman, and your baby's blessed too!* [43]*How is it that my Lord's mother comes to me?* [44]*When I heard you say, 'Hello,' I felt the baby kick for joy.* [45]*You're blessed for believing the LORD will keep his promise to you."*

[46]Mary said,

"My soul exalts the LORD;

[47]*I'm happy because God my Savior*

[48]*has regard for my modest circumstance.*

From now on, all generations will consider me blessed.

[49]*The Mighty One has done great things for me;*

he is holy.
[50]*His mercy is for generations upon generations*
toward people that respect him.
[51]*He has done mighty things*
and scattered the proud in their vanity.
[52]*He has brought down rulers from thrones*
and lifted up the poor.
[53]*He has filled the hungry with good things*
and sent the rich away empty.
[54]*He has helped Israel his child*
by remembering his mercy,
[55]*like he promised our ancestors,*
Abraham and his descendants forever."
[56]Mary stayed with her three months and went back home. **Lk 1:39-56**

The Birth and Naming of John

[57]When it came time for Elizabeth to deliver, she had a son. [58]Her neighbors and relatives heard that the *LORD* had shown her such mercy, and they celebrated with her. [59]The eighth day they came to circumcise the little boy and started calling him "Zechariah," after his father. [60]His mother answered, *"No, his name is 'John.'"*

[61]But they said, *"None of your relatives are named that."* [62]They motioned to his father *to see* what he wanted to name him.

[63]He asked for a tablet and wrote, *"His name is 'John.'"*
That surprised them. [64]Right then, *Zechariah* began to talk, praising God. [65]Their neighbors became respectful, and everybody in the hill country of Judaea was talking about it. [66]People that heard what happened took it to heart, *"What's this child going to be"* (because the *LORD* was with him)*?*

[67]Zechariah was filled with the Holy Spirit and prophesied:
[68]*"Blessed* be *Israel's God,*
who has visited us to deliver his people.
[69]*He has raised up a horn of salvation for us*
in the house of his servant David—
[70]*as he said through his holy prophets of old—*
[71]*salvation from our enemies,*
from everybody that hates us.
[72]*He showed mercy to our ancestors and*
remembered his holy covenant,

[73]*the oath he swore to our ancestor Abraham,*
[74]*to deliver us from our enemies*
so we can serve him without fear
[75]*in holiness and goodness all our lives.*
[76]*You, child, will be a prophet for the Most High.*
You'll go in front of the LORD
to prepare his way,
[77]*to tell his people how to be saved from their sins.*
[78]*Our God shows tender mercy;*
because of it the Sunrise from on high will visit us,
[79]*to shine on a people sitting in darkness and*
the shadow of death,
to direct us onto the path to peace."

[80]The child grew up and became strong in spirit. He lived in the open country till his public appearance to Israel. **Lk 1:57-80**

The Birth of Jesus

2:[1]At that time Caesar Augustus issued a decree to take a census of the Roman Empire. [2]That was the first census, when Quirinius was governing Syria. [3]Everyone went to his ancestral city to register. [4]Joseph went up from Nazareth in Galilee to Judaea, to Bethlehem, David's city because he'd descended from David. [5]He went up to register with Mary, who was engaged to him and pregnant. [6]While they were there, she came due [7]and had her firstborn son. She wrapped him in cloths and laid him in a manger because there wasn't any room for them in the inn.

Lk 2:1-7

The Angels and the Shepherds

[8]Nearby, shepherds were watching sheep outdoors at night. [9]An angel of the *LORD* stood beside them, and the brightness of the *LORD* shined around them. They were really afraid. [10]The angel said,

"You don't need to be afraid; I have good news for you that will make everybody happy. [11]*A Savior was born today in David's city: the Messiah the Lord.* [12]*You'll find a baby wrapped in cloths, lying in a manger."*

[13]All of a sudden, a vast host of angels in the sky joined the angel, praising God:

[14]*"Glory to God in the highest,*
and peace on earth among people he favors."

[15]When the angels went back to heaven, the shepherds said, *"Let's go to Bethlehem and see what the LORD's told us about."* [16]They hurried away and found Mary and Joseph and the baby that was lying in a manger. [17]When they'd seen him, they told everybody what the angel

had said about him. [18]What the shepherds were saying amazed them. [19]Mary treasured all that up in her heart. [20]The shepherds went back, glorifying and praising God for everything they'd seen and heard, which was just like the angel said. **Lk 2:8-20**

Jesus' Circumcision, Naming,
and Presentation in the Temple

[21]When eight days had passed for circumcising him, they named him Jesus, like the angel had directed before Mary became pregnant.

[22]When the time was up for their purification according to the Law of Moses, they went up to Jesus to present him to the *LORD* —[23]like the Law of the *LORD* says,

"Set aside to the LORD every male firstborn" **[Ex 13:2, 12, 15]—**

[24]and to offer the sacrifice the Law called for:

"a pair of turtledoves or two young pigeons" **[Lev 12:8]**.

[25]A man in Jerusalem named Simeon, a good, devout man, was looking forward to Israel's liberation. The Holy Spirit was on him and [26]told him that he'd see the *LORD*'s Messiah before he died. [27]The Spirit led him into the Temple; and when the parents brought in the child Jesus to do for him according to custom, [28]he took him in his arms and blessed God:

[29] *"Now, Master, I can leave satisfied*
like you said.
[30]*I've seen the salvation*
[31]*you've prepared for all nations,*
[32]*a light for revelation to Gentiles*
and for the honor of your people Israel."

[33]He amazed *Joseph and Mary* with what he was saying. [34]He blessed them and told Mary,
"This child is destined to cause the rise and fall of many in Israel and to be a controversial sign.
[35]*A sword will pierce your own heart too; lots of people will show what they're really like."*

[36]There was Hannah as well, a prophetess, daughter of Penuel from the tribe of Asher. She was quite elderly, married for seven years [37]and then a widow to age 84. She never left the Temple, worshiping with fasting and prayer day and night. [38]She came up and thanked God and talked about *the child* to everyone that was anticipating Jerusalem's liberation.

[39]When Mary and Joseph had finished what the Law required, they went back home. [40]The child grew and became strong and increased in wisdom. God's grace was on him.

Lk 2:21-40

The Youth of Jesus

[41]Every year his parents would go up to Jerusalem for the Passover Festival. [42]When he was twelve, they went up to the festival as usual. [43]After it was over, they headed back; but the boy Jesus stayed in Jerusalem without his parents knowing it; [44]they thought he was in the

caravan. They traveled for a day and started looking for him among relatives and acquaintances. [45]When they didn't find him, they went back to Jerusalem. [46]Three days later they found him in the Temple, sitting among the teachers, listening and asking them questions. [47]Everybody that heard him was surprised at his understanding and answers.

[48]When *his parents* saw him, they were astonished. His mother said, *"Son, why have you done this to us? Your father and I have been looking all over for you, worried sick."*

[49]He said, *"Why were you looking all over for me? Wouldn't you know I'd be in my Father's house?"*

[50]They didn't get what he meant.

[51]He went down with them to Nazareth and was subject to them. His mother treasured all that up in her heart. [52]Jesus kept growing in wisdom and stature, in favor with God and people.

Lk 2:41-52

The Beginning of John's Ministry

3:[1]In the fifteenth year of Tiberias Caesar, Pontius Pilate was governing Judaea, Herod was tetraarch of Galilee, his brother Philip was tetraarch of Iturea and Trachonitis, Lysanius was tetraarch of Abilene, [2]Annas and Caiaphas were high priests.

That's when a message came from God to John son of Zachariah in the desert. [3]He went to the area around the Jordan River and started presenting a baptism of repentance to forgive sins. [4]Scripture says in Isaiah the prophet,

"One shouting in the desert,
'Get the road ready for the LORD!
Make it straight!
[5]Fill every chuck hole.
level out every bump;
straighten out the curves;
smooth out the rough stretches.
[6]Everybody will see God's salvation" **[Is 40:3-5].** **Lk 3:1-6**

An Example of John's Preaching

[7]He was saying to the crowds that were coming out to have him baptize them,

*"*You *bunch of poisonous snakes! Who warned you to run from God's wrath that's coming? [8]Bear fruit appropriate for repentance and don't even begin to tell yourselves, 'Abraham's our ancestor.' God can raise up descendants of Abraham from these stones. [9]An axe is already lying at the root of the trees. Every tree that doesn't bear good fruit will be chopped down and burned."*

[10]The crowds asked him, *"What should we do?"*

[11] *"If you have two shirts, give one to a person that doesn't have any. If you have food, do the same thing."*

12Tax collectors came to be baptized, *"Rabbi, what should we do?"*
13 *"Don't collect more than required."*
14Soldiers asked, *"What should we do?"*
"Don't extort money by false charges. Be satisfied with your pay."
15While people were wondering if John might be the Messiah, **16**he said,

"I'm immersing you in water, but Someone more important is coming, whose sandals I'm not worthy to unstrap. He'll 'immerse' you in the Holy Spirit. **17***He'll use his winnowing fork to thoroughly clean up his threshing floor. He'll gather the seed into his granary and burn up the chaff with a fire you can't put out."*

18He encouraged them about lots of other things and delivered good news to the people.

Lk 3:7-18

The Arrest of John the Baptist

19When John reprimanded Herod *Antipas* the tetraarch about Herodias, his half-brother's wife, **20**and all the wicked things he'd done, *Herod* added this on top of them: he locked John up in prison. **Lk 3:19-20**

The Baptism of Jesus

21While John had been baptizing the people, Jesus was baptized too. As he was praying, the sky opened up, **22**and the Holy Spirit came down on him in bodily form like a dove. A voice came out of the sky, *"You're my dearly loved Son that I delight in."* **Lk 3:21-22**

The Genealogy of Jesus According to Luke
(cp. Mt 1:1-17)

23Jesus was about 30 when he began his ministry. He was—as supposed—the

son of Joseph, *son-in-law of* Eli, *son of* Matthat, **24***son of* Levi, *son of* Melchi,
son of Jannai, *son of* Joseph, **25***son of* Mattathias, *son of* Amos, *son of* Nahum,
son of Hesli, *son of* Naggai, **26***son of* Maath, *son of* Mattathias, *son of* Semein,
son of Josech, *son of* Joda, **27***son of* Joanan, *son of* Rhesa, *son of* Zerubbabel,
son of Shealtiel, *son of* Neri, **28***son of* Melchi, *son of* Addi, *son of* Cosam,
son of Elmadam, *son of* Er, **29***son of* Joshua, *son of* Eliezer, *son of* Jorim,
son of Matthat, *son of* Levi, **30**son of Simeon, *son of* Judah, *son of* Joseph,
son of Jonam, *son of* Eliakim, **31***son of* Melea, *son of* Menna, *son of* Mattathia,
son of Nathan, *son of* David, **32***son of* Jesse, *son of* Obed, *son of* Boaz,
son of Salmon, *son of* Nahshon, **33***son of* Amminadab, *son of* Admin, *son of* Ram,

son of Hezron, *son of* Perez, *son of* Judah, [34]*son of* Jacob, *son of* Isaac,
son of Abraham, *son of* Terah, *son of* Nahor, [35]*son of* Serug, *son of* Reu,
son of Peleg, *son of* Heber, *son of* Shelah, [36]*son of* Cainan, *son of* Arphaxad,
son of Shem, *son of* Noah, *son of* Lamech, [37]*son of* Methuselah, *son of* Enoch,
son of Jared, *son of* Mahalaleel, *son of* Cainan, [38]*son of* Enosh, *son of* Seth,
son of Adam, *son of* God. **Lk 3:23-38**

The Temptation of Jesus

4:[1] Jesus went away from the Jordan filled with the Holy Spirit. The Spirit was leading him to the desert [2]while the devil tempted him during 40 days. He didn't eat anything during that time. Afterwards, he was hungry,

[3]and the devil said, *"If you're God's Son, tell this stone to become a loaf of bread."*

[4]Jesus answered, *"Scripture says,*

'People aren't to live by bread alone'" **[Deut 8:3]**.

[5]*The devil* took him up to show him the kingdoms of the world in an instant, [6]*"I'll give you all this authority and their splendor. It's been given to me, and I can give it to whoever I want to.* [7]*If you bow down to me, it'll all be yours."*

[8]Jesus answered, *"Scripture says,*

'Worship the LORD your God,
and** only **serve him'" **[Deut 6:13]**.

[9]*The devil* took him to Jerusalem and stood him on the pinnacle of the Temple, *"If you're God's Son, throw yourself down.* [10]*Scripture says,*

'He'll tell his angels to guard you' **[Ps 91:11]**;

[11]*and*

'They'll catch you
so you'll never trip on a rock'" **[Ps 91:12]**.

[12]Jesus answered, *"It says,*

'Don't tempt the LORD your God'" **[Deut 6:16].**

[13]When the devil finished tempting him, he left till another chance would come. **Lk 4:1-13**

Introducing the Galilean Ministry

[14]Jesus returned to Galilee in the power of the Spirit, and the news about him spread all over the region. [15]He was teaching in their synagogues, and everybody was praising him.
Lk 4:14-15

The First Rejection at Nazareth

[16]He went to Nazareth, where he grew up. He went into the synagogue on the Sabbath as usual and stood up to read. [17]They handed him a scroll of the prophet Isaiah. He unrolled it to where it says,

[18]***"The Spirit of the LORD is on me.***
He's anointed me to deliver good news to the poor;
he sent me to announce release to captives,
and sight to the blind,
to free the afflicted,
[19]***to announce the LORD's acceptable time"*** **[Is 61:1-2; 58:6]**.

[20]He rolled up the scroll, handed it back to the attendant, and sat down. Everybody in the synagogue gave him their full attention. [21]He began, *"Today you can hear this scripture being fulfilled."*

[22]They started whispering about him, amazed at the gracious way he was speaking. *"Isn't this Joseph's son?"*

[23]He said,

"No doubt you'll use this saying against me, 'Doctor, heal yourself.' 'Do here what we heard you did in Capernaum.' [24]*I tell you, a prophet is not welcome in his hometown.* [25]*There were lots of widows in Israel at the time of Elijah, when it hadn't rain for 3½ years, and a severe famine dragged on.* [26]*But the LORD didn't send Elijah to any of them but to a widow in Zarephath, up around Sidon.* [27]*There were lots of lepers in Israel at the time of Elisha the prophet, but none of them were cleansed except Naaman the Syrian."*

[28]Everybody in the synagogue just lost it. [29]They jumped up and threw him out of town. They hustled him to the brow of the hill the town was built on, to throw him over the cliff. [30]But he passed through the mob and left. **Lk 4:16-30**

Teaching and Miracles in Capernaum

[31]He went down to Capernaum, a town in Galilee, and was teaching them every Sabbath. [32]They were impressed because he delivered his message with authority.

[33]A man in the synagogue with an unclean demon shouted, [34]*"Ah, what is this, Jesus, you Nazarene? Did you come to destroy us? I know who you are: God's Holy One!"*

[35]Jesus ordered him to be quiet and come out of him. The demon convulsed him right in front of them and came out without harming him.

[36]Everybody was astounded, *"What is this? With authority and power, he gives orders to unclean spirits, and they come out!"* [37]The news about him went out everywhere in the surrounding countryside.

38He left the synagogue and went to Simon *Peter's* house. Simon's mother-in-law was sick with a high fever, and they asked Jesus about her. **39**He stood over her and ordered the fever to leave. She got up right away and started waiting on them.

40As the sun was going down, they brought him people with several kinds of illness. He laid hands on each one and healed them. **41**Demons were coming out of many, crying out, *"You're God's Son*." He wouldn't let them keep talking because they knew he was the Messiah.

Lk 4:31-41

The First General Tour of Galilee

42At daybreak the next morning, Jesus went out away from people, and the crowd was looking for him. When they found him, they tried to keep him from leaving, **43**but he said, *"I need to present God's kingdom in other towns too; that's why I was sent."* **44**He continued to preach in the synagogues of Judea [Galilee[ms]]. **Lk 4:42-44**

The Calling of Four Fishermen

5:1 While a crowd was pressing on him and listening to God's message, he was standing by Lake Gennesaret **2**and saw two boats at the edge of the lake. The fishermen had gotten out of them and were washing their nets.

3He got in one of the boats—Simon's—and asked him to shove it out a little from the shore. Then he sat down and started teaching the crowd from the boat. **4**When he finished, he told Simon to put out into the deep water and let down his nets for a catch.

5He answered, *"We've worked all night and haven't caught a thing. But, at your bidding, I'll let down the nets."*

6When they did, they caught such a big school of fish that their nets started to tear. **7**They signaled to their partners in the other boat to come and help. They came and filled both boats, so they were in danger of sinking. **8**When Peter saw it, he fell at Jesus' knees, *"Go away from me; I'm a sinful man."* **9**Amazement over the catch gripped him and the others that were with him, **10**including James and John, Zebedee's sons, Simon's partners.

Jesus told Simon, *"You don't need to be afraid. From now on you'll be 'catching' people."*

11When they brought their boats to land, they left everything behind and went with him.

Lk 5:1-11

Cleansing a Leper

12In one town a man covered with leprosy saw Jesus and fell down to him, begging, *"Sir, if you're willing, you can cleanse me."*

13Jesus reached out and touched him, *"I'm willing; be cleansed."* Instantly the leprosy was gone. **14**Jesus told him not to keep it to himself, but to go show himself to a priest and offer for his purification what Moses commanded for a public statement. **15**Instead, he spread the news

about Jesus, and big crowds came together to listen and be healed. **16**Jesus would go to places away from people and pray. **Lk 5:12-16**

Healing a Paralyzed Man

17One day he was teaching, and Pharisees and teachers of the Law were sitting there. They'd come from Jerusalem and every village in Galilee and Judaea. The power of the LORD was with him to do healing. **18**Men carrying a paralyzed man on a stretcher were trying to get him in to Jesus. **19**Since they couldn't because of the crowd, they got up on the roof, and let him down through the tiles on the stretcher, right in front of Jesus.

20When he saw their faith, he said, *"Sir, I've forgiven your sins."*

21The scribes and Pharisees started thinking, *"Who can forgive sins but God?"*

22Jesus knew what they were thinking, *"Why are you reasoning in yourselves?* **23***Which is easier to say, 'I've forgiven your sins' or 'Get up and walk'?* **24***So you can know that the Son of Man has a right on earth to forgive sins"*—he said to the man—*"Get up, pick up your stretcher, and go on home."*

25At once he stood up, picked up what he was lying on, and went home, praising God. **26**Astonishment gripped them, and they were all praising God, filled with fear, *"We've seen some incredible things today."* **Lk 5:17-26**

Calling Matthew

27After that, he went out and saw Levi, a tax collector, sitting in the tax booth, *"Come with me."* **28**He left everything behind and went with him.

29Levi gave a big reception for Jesus in his house. A large group of tax collectors and others were reclining at table with them. **30**The Pharisees and scribes started complaining to his disciples, *"Why are you*[pl] *eating with tax collectors and sinners?"*

31Jesus answered them, *"Healthy people don't need a doctor; sick ones do.* **32***I didn't come so much to call good people to repentance, as* to call *sinners."* **Lk 5:27-32**

Questions About Fasting

33People said to him, *"John's disciples fast often and offer prayers like the Pharisees' disciples do, but yours don't fast."*

34Jesus said, *"You*[pl] *can't expect groomsmen to fast while the groom's around, can you?* **35***The time's coming when he'll be taken away from them. They'll fast then."*

36He added an illustration:

> *"Nobody tears a patch off of a new cloak and sews it on an old one. That would ruin something new, and the patch from the new wouldn't match the old.*
> **37***Nobody puts new wine in old wineskins. The wine would burst the wineskins and*

drain out, and the wineskins would be ruined. **38***New wine must be put in new wineskins.*

39*Nobody that drinks the old wants the new. 'The old is better,' they say."*

Lk 5:33-39

Controversy About Breaking Sabbath

6:1 Jesus was passing along between grain fields on a Sabbath, and his disciples were picking off heads, rubbing them in their hands, and eating the seeds.

2Some Pharisees said, *"Why are you doing what's against the Law on Sabbath?"*

3Jesus answered,

"You've read, haven't you, what David and the ones with him did when they were famished? **4***He went into God's house and took the consecrated loaves, ate them, and gave them to the ones that were with him. They're against the Law for anybody but priests to eat.* **5***Person takes precedence over Sabbath."* **Lk 6:1-5**

Healing a Man with a Paralyzed Hand

6On another Sabbath he went into a synagogue and taught, and a man with a paralyzed right hand was there. **7**The scribes and Pharisees were watching to see if he'd heal on a Sabbath so they could have something to accuse him of.

8He knew what they were thinking and said to the man, *"Stand up where people can see you."* He stood up.

9 *"I ask you*[pl]*, is it lawful to do good on a Sabbath or to do bad, to save life or destroy it?"* **10**He looked around at them and told him to hold out his hand. He held it out, and it was restored. **11**But they were angry and deliberated about what they could do to Jesus. **Lk 6:6-11**

Calling the Twelve Apostles

12At that time he went up on a mountain to spend the night praying. **13**At daylight, he called his disciples and chose twelve that he named apostles: **14**Simon, he named Peter; his brother Andrew; James, John, Philip, Bartholomew, **15**Matthew, Thomas, James son of Alphaeus, Simon called Zelotes, Judas son of James, **16**and Judas Iscariot, who became a traitor.

Lk 6:12-16

Sermon on a Level Place (cp Mt 5-7)

17Jesus came down with them and stood on a level place. There was a big crowd of disciples and a throng of people from Jerusalem, all over Judaea, and the coastal region of Tyre and Sidon. **18**They'd come to listen to him and be healed from illness and unclean spirits that were harassing them. **19***People in the* crowd would try to touch him because power would go out from him and heal them.

20He looked up at his disciples and said,

"You that are poor are fortunate;
you have God's kingdom.
21 *You that are hungry now are fortunate;*
you'll be filled.
You that mourn now are fortunate;
you will laugh.
22 *You're fortunate when people hate you, shun you, insult you, reject you as bad because of the Son of Man.* **23** *Be happy in times like that. Jump up and down for joy because you have a great reward in heaven. Their ancestors used to treat the prophets the same way.*
24 *But woe to you rich people;*
you have your comfort.
25 *Woe to you that eat well now;*
you'll be hungry.
Woe to you that laugh now;
you'll grieve and cry.
26 *Woe* to you *when everybody says good things about you. Your ancestors used to do the same things about false prophets.* **Lk 6:17-26**

27 *"I'm telling you, love your enemies. Treat them well that hate you.* **28** *Bless the ones that curse you. Pray for those who mistreat you.* **29** *To the one that slaps you on the cheek offer the other one. From the one that takes your coat, don't withhold your shirt.* **30** *Give to anybody that asks you; don't demand back what someone steals from you.* **31** *Treat people the way you want them to treat you.* **32** *If you love people that love you, what's special about that? Even sinners love people that love them.* **33** *If you do good to people that do good to you, what's special about that? Even sinners do that.* **34** *If you lend to the ones you expect to repay it, what's special about that? Even sinners lend to sinners they expect will repay it.* **35** *On the contrary, love your enemies. Do good to them and lend to them, and don't expect that they will repay it. You'll be greatly rewarded, and you'll be like the Most High, because he's gracious to ungracious people.* **36** *Have compassion like your Father does.*

37 *"Don't criticize, and you won't be criticized. Don't condemn, and you won't be condemned. Pardon and you'll be pardoned.* **38** *Give and people will give to you good measure, pressed down, shaken together, and running over. The measure you measure with, you'll be measured by."* **Lk 6:27-38**

39 He gave an illustration.

"Blind people don't lead blind people, do they? Wouldn't they all fall in the ditch? **40***Students are not better off than their teacher, but everybody that finished their education will be like their teacher.* **41***Why look at a speck of sawdust in somebody else's eye, and not notice the log in your own?* **42***How can you say to somebody, 'Let me get that speck of sawdust out of your eye,' when you don't see the log in yours? Foolish people, get the log out of your* <u>*own*</u> *eye first; then you can see how to get the speck out of the other's eye.*

43*"A good tree doesn't bear bad fruit, and a bad tree doesn't bear* <u>*good*</u> *fruit.* **44***That's what being a good or bad tree means—its fruit is good or bad. People don't gather figs from thorns or grapes from briars.* **45***Good people bring good things out of the good treasure in their hearts; bad people bring bad things out of their bad treasure. People's mouths say what overflows from their hearts.*

46*"Why call me 'Lord' and not do what I tell you?* **47***I'll tell you what people are like whot listen to what I say and do it.* **48***They're like a man that was building a house: he dug down and set the foundation on bedrock. When a flood came, the creek rushed against that house and couldn't budge it because he'd built it right.* **49***People that listen and don't do* it *are like a fellow that built his house on dirt with no foundation. The creek rushed against it, and it collapsed—a total loss."* **Lk 6:39-49**

Healing the Centurion's Servant

7:1 After he finished, he went to Capernaum. **2**A centurion's valued servant was sick, close to death. **3**The centurion heard about Jesus and sent elders of the Jews to ask him to come get the servant through it. **4**When they got to Jesus, they urged him earnestly, *"He deserves doing that for him.* **5***He loves our nation and built us a synagogue."* **6**Jesus went with them.

While they were still a good way from *his* house, the centurion sent friends,

"Sir, don't bother coming under my roof. *I don't deserve that.* **7***I didn't feel worthy of coming to you personally. Just say the word, and let my servant be healed.* **8***I'm directed by the authority of superior officers myself with soldiers under me. I tell one to go, and he goes; another to come, and he comes; a servant to do something, and he does it."*

9Jesus was impressed and turned around to the crowd, *"I haven't seen faith like that even in Israel."* **10**When the ones the centurion had sent got back, they found the servant healed. **Lk 7:1-10**

Resurrecting the Widow of Nain's Son

11Soon afterward he went to a village called Nain; his disciples and a large crowd were going with him. **12**When he got close to the village gate, people were carrying out a widow's only son, and a sizable crowd from the village was with her. **13**When the Lord saw her, he felt

sorry for her, and told her not to cry. [14]He went and touched the bier, and the pall bearers stopped. He said, *"Young man, get up."* [15]The dead boy sat up and started talking, and Jesus gave him to his mother. [16]Fear gripped them, and they praised God*: "A great prophet has arisen among us; God has visited his people."* [17]News about him spread all over Judaea and the surrounding countryside. **Lk 7:11-17**

John's Question and
Jesus' Comments on John

[18]John's disciples reported to him what was going on. He called two of them [19]to go ask the Lord, *"Are <u>you</u> the One that's* supposed to *come, or should we wait for somebody else?"* [20]The men went to Jesus and asked him that. [21]At the time, Jesus was healing a lot of people from sicknesses, afflictions, and evil spirits, and enabling a number of blind people to see. [22]He answered them, *"Go tell John what you've seen: blind people regaining their sight, lame* people *walking, lepers cleansed, deaf people hearing, the dead resurrected, poor people hearing the good news.* [23]*He's blessed that's not disappointed in me."*

[24]After John's messengers left, Jesus said to the crowd,

"What did you go out to the desert to see? A reed blowing in the wind? [25]*What did you go out to see? Someone dressed in fine clothes? People in palaces dress in fine clothes and live in luxury.* [26]*What <u>did</u> you go out to see? A prophet? Oh yes, and more than a prophet.* [27]*He's the one that scripture refers to,*

'I'll send my messenger ahead of you
to get *your* ***road ready for you'*** **[Mal 3:1].**

[28]*Nobody that's ever been born is greater than John, but the least in God's kingdom is greater than he is."*

[29]When the people and the tax collectors heard that, they acknowledged God's good expectations, because they'd had John baptize them. [30]But the Pharisees and the lawyers rejected God's intentions for them by not having him baptize them.

[31]*"What are people today like?* [32]*They're like kids sitting in a marketplace, calling out one to another:*

'We played a flute for you, and you didn't dance;
we sang a funeral song, and you didn't cry.'

[33]*John the Baptist came, not eating bread or drinking wine, and you say he's got a demon.* [34]*The Son of Man has come eating and drinking, and you say he's a glutton, a drunk, a pal of tax collectors and sinners.* [35]*Wisdom becomes obvious from what it produces."*[lit] **Lk 7:18-35**

In the House of Simon the Pharisee

36A Pharisee invited Jesus to eat with him. He went into the Pharisee's house and sat down. **37**A woman of ill repute in town learned Jesus was reclining at table in the Pharisee's house. She brought an alabaster cruise of ointment and **38**stood behind him at his feet, crying. She started to wet his feet with her tears, wipe them with her hair, kiss them, and anoint them with the ointment. **39**the Pharisee thought to himself, *"If he was a prophet, he'd know what kind of woman is touching him."*

40Jesus responded, *"Simon, a question."*

"What is it, Rabbi?"

41 *"A money lender had a couple clients that owned him money. One owed 500 denarii; the other owed 50.* **42***When they couldn't pay him back, he forgave them both. Which one loved him more?"*

43 *"I suppose the one he forgave more."*

Jesus said, *"That's right."*

44He turned to the woman and said to Simon,

"You see this woman? When I came in your house, you didn't give me any water for my feet; she has wet my feet with her tears and wiped them with her hair. **45***You didn't give me a kiss; she's been kissing my feet ever since she got here.* **46***You didn't anoint my head with olive oil; she anointed my feet with perfumed ointment.* **47***So I've forgiven her many sins because she loved a lot. The one that's forgiven little loves little."*

48He told her, *"I've forgiven your sins."*

49The ones reclining at table with him started saying to themselves, *"Who is this that forgives sins?"*

50He told the woman, *"Your faith has saved you. Have a good day."* **Lk 7:36-50**

Second Preaching Tour of Galilee

8:1 Soon afterward he started traveling from one town and village to another, announcing *the coming of* God's kingdom. The Twelve were with him **2**as well as some women he healed from illnesses and evil spirits: Mary, called the Magdalene, that seven demons had come out of; **3**Joanna wife of Chuza, Herod's business manager; Susanna, and quite a few that were contributing to them out of their own resources. **Lk 8:1-3**

Sermon in Parables

4When a large crowd was gathering and people from various towns were traveling to him, he told a story.

5 *"A sower went out to sow his seed. As he sowed, some seeds fell along the path; people walked on them, and birds gobbled them up.* **6***Some fell on rocky*

ground; they sprouted but shriveled up because they didn't have enough moisture.
[7]*Some fell among thorns; the thorns grew up with them and choked them out.*
[8]*Others fell on good ground, grew up, and produced 100 times as much sown.*
Whoever has ears, listen!"

[9]His disciples asked him what the story meant. [10]He said,

"You can come to know the unrevealed things about God's kingdom, but to the rest I'm delivering the message in stories so

'though they see, they don't perceive;
though they hear, they don't understand' **[Is 6:9-10]**.

[11] *"This is what the story means. The seed is God's message.* [12]*The seeds along the road represent people that hear the message. Then the devil comes and takes the message away from their hearts so they won't believe and be saved.*
[13]*The seeds on rocky ground represent people that are happy to accept the message, but they don't have root. They believe for a while, but in trying times they fall away.* [14]*The seeds falling among the thorns represent people that hear the message; but the cares, wealth, and pleasures of life choke them out, and they don't produce anything.* [15]*But the seeds in the good ground represent those who hear the word with a good and honest heart and produce by staying with it.*

[16] *"Nobody lights a lamp and hides it under a jar or puts it under a bed. They put it on a stand so people that come in can see it.* [17]*Everything hidden will become known; everything secret will come to light.*

[18] *"Be careful how you listen: whoever has will receive more, and whoever doesn't have will lose what they seem to have."* **Lk 8:4-18**

Jesus' Mother and Brothers
Interrupt His Ministry

[19]His mother and brothers came but couldn't get to him because of the crowd. [20]People relayed to him, *"Your mother and brothers are standing outside the crowd, wanting to see you."*

[21]He responded, *"My mother and brothers are people that hear God's message and do it."* **Lk 8:19-21**

Stilling the Storm

[22]One day he and his disciples got in a boat, and he said, *"Let's go to the other side of the lake,"* and they launched. [23]While they were sailing, he went to sleep. A windstorm swept down on the lake, and they were taking on water and in danger of sinking. [24]They went and woke him up, *"Master, we're going to die!"*

He got up and rebuked the wind and crashing waves. The wind stopped, and the lake grew calm. **25** *"Where's your faith?"* They were afraid and amazed, and said to one another, *"Who is this that even the wind and waves obey?"* **Lk 8:22-25**

Healing the Gadarene Demoniac

26They sailed to the region of the Gerasenes, across the lake from Galilee. **27**When Jesus got out of the boat, a fellow from the town met him. For a long time, the man had been demon-possessed, naked, and homeless, living among the tombs. **28**When he saw Jesus, he cried out and ran to him and screamed. *"What is this, Jesus, you Son of God Most High? Please don't torment me!"* **29**(Jesus had commanded the unclean spirit to come out. It had seized him many times. He'd be bound under guard with chains and shackles; but he'd break the bonds, and the demon would drive him into uninhabited places.)

30Jesus asked him, *"What's your name?"*

"Legion," because lots of demons had gone into him. **31**They started begging him not to send them away into the abyss.

32A tremendous herd of pigs was feeding on the hillside. The demons appealed to Jesus to let them go into them. He let them. **33**When the demons went into the pigs, the herd stampeded down the steep place into the lake and drowned. **34**The herdsmen saw it and ran away and reported it in town and in the countryside. **35**People came out to see what had happened and came to Jesus. They found the man dressed and in his right mind, sitting by Jesus. They were afraid. **36**Witnesses told them how Jesus had delivered the demoniac.

37The whole crowd from the area of the Gerasenes asked him to go away, because fear had overwhelmed them. When he got in the boat to go, **38**the fellow begged to go with him, but Jesus sent him back, **39** *"Go home and tell them what great things God has done for you."* He went away and told in every city what great things Jesus had done for him. **Lk 8:26-39**

Raising Jairus' Daughter;
Healing Woman with Hemorrhaging

40When Jesus returned, the crowd welcomed him; they'd been waiting for him. **41**Jairus, a ruler of the synagogue, came and fell down to Jesus, pleading with him to come to his house. **42**His only daughter—about twelve—was at the point of death.

As Jesus was making his way along, the crowd was pressing in on him. **43**A woman that had been hemorrhaging for twelve years and had spent her whole living on doctors **44**came up from behind and touched the fringe of his cloak. The hemorrhaging stopped at once.

45Jesus said, *"Who touched me?"*

While they were all denying it, Peter said, *"Master, the crowd's pressing on you and jostling you."*

46But Jesus said, *"Somebody touched me. I felt power go out from me."*

47When the woman saw she hadn't escaped notice, she came trembling, fell down to him, and admitted in front of them why she'd touched him.

48He said, *"Daughter, your faith has saved you. Have a good day."*

49While he was still talking *to her*, someone came[p] from the house of the synagogue ruler, *"Your daughter has died. You needn't bother the Rabbi further."*

50When Jesus heard it, he responded, *"Don't give up hope; just trust me. She'll be okay."*

51He went into the house and wouldn't let anybody go with him except Peter, James, and John, and her parents. **52**Everybody was crying and wailing over her.

He said, *"Don't keep crying. She's not dead; she's 'asleep.'"*

53They laughed at him because they knew she was dead.

54He took her hand and said, *"Girl, get up."* **55**She started breathing again, and stood up instantly. He told them to give her something to eat. **56**Her parents were stunned, but he told them not to tell anybody what had happened. **Lk 8:40-56**

The Mission of the Twelve

9:1 He called the Twelve together and gave them power and authority to cast out demons and heal sicknesses. **2**He sent them out to announce *the coming of* God's kingdom and to heal the sick. **3***"Don't take anything with you—no staff, sack for extra clothes, bread, money, or two shirts apiece.* **4***Stay in whatever house you enter till you leave the area.* **5***Whoever doesn't welcome you, go outside of town and shake the dust off your feet as a gesture to them."*

6They went out and started traveling around village by village, preaching and healing.

Lk 9:1-6

Herod's Conscience;
Confusing John the Baptist and Jesus

7Herod *[Antipas]* the tetraarch heard about what was happening and was puzzled because some were saying John had risen from the dead, **8**that Elijah had appeared, that one of the prophets of old had resurrected. **9**Herod said, *"I beheaded John. Who is this?"* And he kept trying to see him. **Lk 9:7-9**

Feeding the 5,000

10The apostles came back from their mission and reported to Jesus what all they'd done. He took them and withdrew privately near a town called Bethsaida. **11**The crowds found out and followed him. He welcomed them, talked to them about God's kingdom, and healed as many as needed it.

12As it was getting late, the Twelve came to him, *"Dismiss the crowd so they can go to villages around the countryside to find lodging and buy food. Nobody lives around here."*

13He said, *"<u>You</u> feed them."*

They said, *"We only have five loaves and two fish—unless we go buy food for all these people."* **14**There were about 5,000 men.

He said, *"Have them sit down in groups of about 50."*

[**15**] **16**He took the five loaves and two fish, and looked up to heaven, blessed them, broke them in pieces, and started giving them to his disciples to distribute to the crowd. **17**They all ate till they were full, and the leftovers filled twelve medium-sized baskets. **Lk 9:10-17**

Peter's Great Confession

18When he was praying alone with the disciples, he asked them, *"Who are the crowds saying I am?"*

19They answered, *"John the Baptist, Elijah, or a prophet of old that's resurrected."*

20 *"Who do <u>you</u> say I am?"*

Peter answered, *"God's Messiah."*

21He told them not to tell people who he was. **Lk 9:18-21**

The First Distinct Prediction of Messiah's Death

22 *"I need to suffer a lot of things; be rejected by the elders, chief priests, and scribes; be executed, and resurrected the third day."*

23He told the crowd,

> *"If you want to follow me, you have to set aside your own interests, pick up your cross every day, and follow me.* **24***If you want to save your life, you'll lose it; if you lose your life over me, you'll save it.* **25***What good does it do to get the whole world and lose your self?* **26***If you're ashamed of me and my message, I'll be ashamed of you when I come in the glory of the Father and the holy angels.* **27***Some of you standing here will live to see God's kingdom."* **Lk 9:22-27**

The Transfiguration

28About eight days later, Jesus took Peter, James, and John up on a mountain to pray. **29**While he was praying, his face changed appearance, and his clothes became brilliant white. **30**Two men were talking to him—Moses and Elijah. **31**They had a brilliant appearance and talked about his death soon in Jerusalem. **32**Peter and the ones with him were really sleepy, but they were fully awake and saw his brilliant appearance and the two men that were standing with him.

33As they were leaving him, Peter said, *"Master, it's good to be here. Let us make three tents—one each for you and Moses and Elijah"*—not thinking clearly about what he was saying. **34**A cloud came and engulfed them. It scared them as they went into it.

35A voice spoke out of it, *"This is my chosen Son; listen to him."*

36When it had spoken, Jesus was the only one there, and his disciples kept quiet. At the time they didn't tell anybody what they'd seen. **Lk 9:28-36**

Healing a Demoniac Boy

37The next day when they came down from the mountain, a big crowd met him. **38**A man from the crowd ran up, *"Rabbi, please look at my boy; he's the only son I have.* **39***A spirit keeps seizing him and suddenly makes him scream. It throws him into convulsions, makes him foam at the mouth, and bruises him. It hardly ever leaves him alone.* **40***I pleaded with your disciples to cast it out, but they couldn't."*

41Jesus answered, *"*You *unbelieving, perverse bunch, how long am I going to be here and deal with you? Bring me your boy."*

42While he was coming, the demon attacked him and threw him into convulsions. Jesus rebuked the unclean spirit and healed the boy and gave him back to his dad. **43a**They were all amazed at God's greatness. **Lk 9:37-43a**

Third Prediction of His Death

43b While everybody was astounded at the things Jesus was doing, he told his disciples, **44***"Keep this in mind: I'm going to be betrayed."* **45**They didn't know what to make of it and were afraid to ask him about it. **Lk 9:43b-45**

Discussion About Rank

46His disciples got into an argument about who would have highest rank. **47**Jesus knew about it, so he took a little child and stood him next to him, **48***"Whoever receives this little child in my name receives me, and whoever receives me receives the One that sent me. The least among you has the highest rank."* **Lk 9:46-48**

The Unknown Exorcist

49John answered, *"Master, we saw a fellow casting out demons in your name. We tried to stop him because he's not following with us."*

50Jesus said, *"Don't stop*[pl] *him. Whoever is not against us is for us."* **Lk 9:49-50**

Private Journey to Jerusalem Through Samaria

51When the time came to go up to Jerusalem, he headed there **52**and sent messengers on ahead. They went to a Samaritan village to make arrangements for him, **53**but they wouldn't welcome him because he was heading for Jerusalem. **54**When the disciples James and John saw it, they said, *"Do you want us to call down fire from the sky to consume them?"* **55**He turned and reprimanded them, **56**and they went on to another village. **Lk 9:51-56**

Conversation About Following Jesus

57As they were going along the road, a man said, *"I'll follow you wherever you go."*

58Jesus said, *"Foxes have dens and birds have nests, but I don't have anywhere to rest."*

59He said to another man, *"Come with me."*

"Sir, let me go bury my father first."

60He told him, *"Let the dead bury their dead. You go and announce* the coming of *God's kingdom."*

61Another fellow said, *"I'll go with you; let me go say goodbye to the ones in my house."*

62Jesus told him, *"Nobody that takes hold of a plow and looks back is fit for the kingdom."* **Lk 9:57-62**

The Mission of the Seventy

10:1 After that, the Lord appointed 72 other men to go ahead of him in pairs to every town and place where he intended to go.

2He told them,

"It's a huge harvest and there aren't many workmen, so ask the crew chief to put more help in his harvest. **3***I'm sending you out like lambs among wolves.* **4***Don't carry a money bag, knapsack, or shoes. Don't visit with anybody along the road.* **5***Whatever house you go in, first say, 'Peace to this house.'* **6***If peace-loving people live there, your blessing will rest on them. If not, it will come back to you.* **7***Stay in the same house and eat what they provide. A worker is worth his wages. Don't move around from house to house.* **8***Whatever town you go in and they welcome you, eat what they put in front of you.* **9***Heal the sick in it and say, 'God's kingdom has come close to you.'* **10***Whatever town doesn't welcome you, go out in the main streets and say,* **11** *'Even the dust of your town that sticks to our feet we wipe off against you. But know this: God's kingdom has come close* to you*.'* **12***At the judgment it'll be more bearable for Sodom than for that town.*

Lk 10:1-12

13 *"Woe to you, Chorazin! Woe to you, Bethsaida! If the miracles done in you had been done in Tyre and Sidon, they would've repented long ago in burlap and ashes.* **14***At the judgment it'll be more bearable for those cities than for you.* **15***And you, Capernaum! You won't be exalted to heaven, will you? You'll be taken down to hell.*

16"*Whoever listens to you is listening to me; whoever rejects you is rejecting me; and whoever rejects me is rejecting the One that sent me."*

17The 72 came back excited, *"Even the demons submit to us in your name!"*

18He said, *"I've been watching Satan fall from heaven like a blazing meteor*.* **19***I've made you able to step on snakes and scorpions, and have* authority *over the power the enemy*

has. Nothing will hurt you. [20]*But, don't get excited as much about the spirits submitting to you as about having your names recorded in heaven."*

[21]Right then he was especially glad, *"I praise you, Father, LORD of earth and sky, for keeping these things from wise, smart people and revealing them to children.* [22-23]*Yes, you delighted in doing that."*

He turned to his disciples, *"My Father has turned everything over to me, and nobody knows who the Son is but him, and who he is but the Son, and whoever the Son wants to reveal him to."*

"You're fortunate to see what you're seeing. [24]*Prophets and kings have wanted to see it and haven't seen it."* **Lk 10:13-24**

The Parable About the Good Samaritan

[25]A lawyer stood up to test him, *"Rabbi, what do I need to do to inherit eternal life?"*

[26]Jesus said, *"What's the Law say? How do you read it?"*

[27]He answered, ***"Love the LORD your God with all your heart, soul, strength*** **[Deut 6:5; 10:12; Josh 22:5]**, *and mind; and* ***love your neighbor as yourself"*** **[Lev 19:18]**.

[28]Jesus said, *"That's right. Do that and you'll inherit* eternal life*."*

[29]But he wanted to justify *asking* his question, so he said, *"Who's my 'neighbor'?"*

[30]Jesus answered,

> *"A man going down from Jerusalem to Jericho was attacked by robbers. They stripped him, beat him up, and left him half dead.* [31]*By chance a priest was going down that road and saw him and went around him.* [32]*A Levite came to the place and saw him and did the same thing.* [33]*But a Samaritan on business came by and saw him and felt sorry for him.* [34]*He went over and treated his wounds with oil and wine, bandaged them up, put him on his own pack animal, and took him to an inn to take care of him.*
>
> [35]*"The next day he took out two denarii and gave them to the innkeeper. 'Take care of him. Whatever more you spend I'll pay you when I get back.'* [36]*Which of the three do you think proved to be a neighbor to the man the robbers attacked?"*

[37]The lawyer said, *"The one that showed him mercy."*

Jesus said, *"Go do that."* **Lk 10:25-37**

Jesus with Mary and Martha

[38]As they were traveling, he went into a village, and a woman named Martha welcomed him. [39]She had a sister, Mary, who was sitting in front of Jesus, listening to him. [40]Martha was worried with serving, and came and said, *"Sir, don't you care that my sister has left me to do the serving by myself? Have her help me."*

[41]Jesus said, *"Martha, you're worried about a lot of things, [42]but one thing is essential: Mary has chosen the good part; I'm not going to take it away from her."* **Lk 10:38-42**

Discourse on Prayer

11[:1]He was praying in a place. When he finished, one of his disciples said, "*Teach us how to pray like John used to teach his disciples."*

[2]He said,

"When you pray, say,
'Father, you are holy.
We want your kingdom to come.
[3]*Give us our food each day.*
[4]*Forgive us of our sins*
because <u>we</u> forgive everybody that's in debt to us.
Don't let us get led into temptation.'

[5]*"Which of you would go to a friend in the middle of the night and say, 'Lend me three loaves of bread.* [6]*A friend of mine has come, and I don't have anything to feed him.'*

[7]*"From inside, the friend would answer, 'Don't bother me. The door's already shut; the kids are in bed with me. I can't get up to give you anything.'* [8]*Though he didn't want to, he got up and gave him what he needed because he was his friend and persisted.* [9]*Ask and you'll receive, seek and you'll find, knock and it'll open for you.* [10]*The one that asks receives, the one that seeks finds, the one that knocks it'll open for.*

[11]*"If your son asks for a fish, would you give him a snake instead?* [12]*If he asks for an egg, would you give him a scorpion?* [13]*If you, being sinful, know how to give good things to your kids, how much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to people that ask him."* **Lk 11:1-13**

The Pharisees' Charge That Jesus
Was in League with the Devil

[14]He was casting a demon out that made a man mute. When he'd cast it out, the man could speak, and the crowd was surprised. [15]Some of them said, *"He casts out demons by Beelzebub, the ruler of demons."* [16]Others, trying to test him, were looking for him to give them a sign out of the sky.

[17]He knew what they were thinking,

"Any kingdom falls that's at cross purposes with itself. [18]*If Satan is at cross purposes with himself, how will his kingdom stand—because you're saying I*

cast out demons by Beelzebub? **19** *If I'm casting out demons by Beelzebub, who do your students cast them out by? They'll be your judges.*

20 *"But if I'm casting out demons by the finger of God, then his kingdom has come to you.* **21** *When a strong man, fully armed, guards his courtyard, his possessions are undisturbed.* **22** *When somebody stronger than he is attacks and overpowers him, he seizes the armor the man depended on and scatters his plunder.* **23** *Whoever's not with me is against me, and whoever doesn't gather with me scatters around.*

24 *"When an unclean spirit leaves a person, it roams around in dry places, looking for rest. When it doesn't find any, it says, 'I'll go back to the house I left.'* **25** *When he goes, he finds it swept out and decorated.* **26** *Then he takes along seven spirits worse than him, goes in, and settles down there. The person's last condition is worse than the first."* **Lk 11:14-26**

27 While he was talking, a woman in the crowd shouted, *"Blessed is the womb that bore you and the breasts you nursed."*

28 But he said, "*More important, blessed are people that hear God's message and keep it."*

29 As the crowds were growing, he said,

"This is a wicked time. People are looking for a sign, but they're not going to get one other than the sign of Jonah. **30** *As he was a sign to the Ninevites, so the Son of Man will be to people of today.* **31** *The queen of the south will stand up in the judgment with people of today and condemn them. She came from the ends of the earth to hear Solomon's wisdom, and something greater than Solomon is here.* **32** *The people of Nineveh will stand up in the judgment with people today and condemn them. They repented when Jonah preached to them, and something greater than Jonah is here.*

33 *"Nobody lights a lamp and puts it in the cellar [or under a basket]*[ms]*. They put it on a stand so people that come in can see it.* **34** *Your eye is the lamp for your body. When your eyes are clear, your whole body has light; but when they're bad, your body is also in the dark.* **35** *Watch out so the light that's in you won't be darkness.* **36** *If your whole body has light, it's like a bright lamp that gives you light."* **Lk 11:27-36**

37 When he'd finished speaking, a Pharisee invited him to eat with him. He went in and directly reclined at table. **38** When the Pharisee saw it, he was surprised that Jesus hadn't ceremonially washed his hands before the meal.

39 The Lord said to him,

"You Pharisees clean the outside of the cup and dish, but inside you're filled with theft and wickedness. **40***You foolish people, didn't the One that made the outside make the inside too?* **41***Give the internal things over to charity, and everything will be clean to you.*

42 *"But woe to you Pharisees! You give a tenth of mint, rue, and vegetables, but pass over justice and love for God. You should have done those without neglecting these.*

43 *"Woe to you Pharisees! You love the most prominent seats in the synagogues and the greetings in the marketplaces.*

44 *"Woe to you! You're like unmarked graves that people walk on without knowing it."*

45A lawyer spoke up[p], *"Rabbi, when you say things like that, you insult us too."*

46Jesus said,

"Woe to you lawyers as well! You load people down with hard-to-carry burdens, but <u>*you*</u> *don't touch them with one of your fingers.*

47 *"Woe to you! You build the tombs of the prophets, and people like you killed them.* **48***So you're witnesses and approve of what people like you did; they killed them; you build their tombs.* **49***So God in his wisdom has said, 'I'll send them prophets and apostles. They'll persecute some and kill others.* **50***So the blood of all the prophets shed since the world began God will require of this generation—***51***from the blood of Abel to Zechariah that they murdered between the altar and the Temple. Yes, he'll require it of this generation.'*

52 *"Woe to you lawyers! You take away the key for understanding. You don't go in yourselves, and you stand in the way of the ones that are trying to."*

53Before he left, the scribes got terribly hostile and badgered him with questions about all kinds of things, **54**trying to goad him into saying something they could use against him. **Lk 11:37-54**

Disciples Warned Against Fearing Men

12:1 Meantime, the thousands in the crowd *that had been following him* were so packed together they were stepping on each other. Jesus started saying to his disciples first,

"Watch out for the yeast from the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy. **2***Everything covered up will be uncovered; everything hidden will be discovered.* **3***What you[pl] say in the dark will be heard in the light; what you[pl] whisper in the storerooms will be shouted from the housetops.*

4 *"Friends, don't be afraid of people that can kill the body and that's all they can do.* **5***I'll show you who to be afraid of: the One with the right to kill you and throw you into hell. Yes, be afraid of* <u>*him*</u>*.* **6***Don't 5 sparrows cost 2 assarions? And God doesn't forget about a one of them.* **7***The very hairs on your head are numbered. Don't be afraid; you're worth more than lots of sparrows.*

8 *"Everyone that acknowledges me to other people, I'll acknowledge to God's angels.* **9** *Whoever denies* who I am *in front of other people I'll deny in front of God's angels.* **10** *Everyone that slanders* <u>*me*</u> *can be forgiven, but whoever blasphemes the Holy Spirit won't be forgiven.*

11 *"When they take you in front of synagogues, rulers, and authorities, don't worry about what to say to defend yourselves.* **12** *The Holy Spirit will teach you at the time what to say."* **Lk 12:1-12**

The Parable About the Rich Fool

13 A fellow in the crowd said, *"Rabbi, tell my brother to split the inheritance with me."*

14 Jesus said, *"Sir, who appointed me to act as a judge or arbitor in your*[pl] *affairs?"*

15 *"Guard against every kind of greed; even in abundance a person's life doesn't consist of what he owns."*

16 He told the crowd a story,

"A rich man's ground produced a bumper crop. **17** *He deliberated what to do because he didn't have enough room to put up his crop.* **18** *He said, 'This is what I'll do: I'll tear down my barns and build bigger ones so I can store all my grain and good things.* **19** *I'll tell myself, "You have a lot of good things for years to come. Rest, eat, drink, celebrate."'* **20** *God said, 'You foolish man! Tonight they'll demand your life; who will these things belong to then?'* **21** *That's how it is with people that store up for themselves and aren't rich toward God."* **Lk 12:13-21**

Encouragement to Trust God

22 He said to his disciples, *"So don't worry about your life what you're going to eat or for your body what you're going to wear.* **23** *Life is more than food, and the body is more than clothes.* **24** *Think about black birds; they don't sow or reap; they don't have a storeroom or barn. God feeds them. You're worth a lot more than birds!* **25** *Which of you by worrying can add 18 inches to your height?* **26** *If you can't do such a small thing, why worry about the rest?* **27** *Consider how lilies grow; they don't work hard or spin, but even Solomon in all his splendor wasn't dressed like one of them.* **28** *If God "dresses" the plants in the field that way—here today, burned tomorrow—how much more will he dress you, people with little faith.* **29** *Don't concentrate on what you're going to eat, and don't worry.* **30** *Material things are what Gentiles desire. Your Father knows you need them.* **31** *Seek out his kingdom, and material things will come along with it.* **32** *You don't need to be afraid, little flock. Your Father delights in giving you the kingdom.* **33** *Sell what you own and give it to charity. Make money bags that don't*

wear out, never-ending wealth in heaven, where thieves don't steal and moths don't ruin. **34***Your heart will be where your wealth is.* **Lk 12:22-34**

Watchfulness: Parable About the Waiting Servants

35*"Be dressed and ready with your lamps lit* **36***like servants waiting for their master to come back from a wedding so they can open the door when he knocks.* **37***Blessed are the servants their master finds watching. He'll put on servant's clothes, have them recline at table, and wait on them.* **38***If he comes in the second watch or even the third and finds them ready, they're blessed.* **39***Be sure of this: if the homeowner had known what time the thief would come, he wouldn't have let him break into his house.* **40***<u>You</u> be ready because the Son of Man will come when you don't expect him."*

41Peter said, *"Are you telling <u>us</u> that story or everybody?"*

42He said, *"Who's a wise, reliable property manager that his master puts in charge of providing meals at the right time?* **43***Blessed is the servant that his master finds doing his job when he comes.* **44***He'll put him in charge of everything he owns.* **Lk 12:35-44**

45*"If that servant says to himself, 'It'll be a long time before my master gets back'; and he starts beating on the* other *servants, men and women, eating and getting drunk,* **46***the master will come on a day he doesn't expect him at a time he doesn't know, he'll flog him severely, and assign him the fate of disbelievers.*

47*"The servant that knew his master's will and wasn't ready or didn't act accordingly will get many lashes.* **48***The one that didn't know and committed things that deserve lashes will get few lashes. A lot will be expected of everybody that receives a lot. People ask more from somebody they've entrusted with more.* **Lk 12:45-48**

49*"I came to set the earth on fire, and I wish it was already lit!* **50***I have a baptism to be baptized with, and I'm under duress till it's done.* **51***Do you think my coming will bring peace on earth? No,* it'll bring *division.* **52***From now on five members of a family will team up three against two and two against three:*

53*father against son; son against father;*
mother against daughter; daughter against mother;
mother-in-law against daughter-in-law;
daughter-in-law against mother-in-law."

54He told the crowd as well,

"When you see clouds coming up in the west, right away you say, 'A storm's coming,' and you're right. **55***When you see a south wind blowing, you say, 'It's going to get hot,' and it does.* **56***You foolish people, you can read earth and sky; why don't you know how to read the signs of the times?*

57 *"Why can't you figure out what's right on your own?* **58***While you're on the way to court with your opponent, do your best to settle matters so he doesn't drag you in front of the judge, the judge turn you over to the officer of the court, and the officer put you in jail.* **59***You won't get out till you pay the last penny."* **Lk 12:49-59**

Discourse on Repentance

13:1 At that time, some people told *Jesus* about the Galileans whose blood Pilate had mixed with their sacrifices. **2**He said,

"Do you think those Galileans were more sinful than other Galileans because they suffered this? **3***No, but unless you repent, you'll die too.* **4***Do you think the 18 that the tower of Siloam fell on and killed were the most sinful people in Jerusalem?* **5***No, but unless you repent, you'll die too."*

6He told this story,

"A man had planted a fig tree in his vineyard. He went looking for fruit on it, but didn't find any. **7***He told the vineyard keeper, 'This fig tree hasn't borne any fruit for three years. Chop it down. Why's it taking up space?'*

8 *"He answered, 'Sir, leave it this year too, till I can dig around it and manure it.* **9***If it has fruit on it next year, okay. If not, chop[f] it down.'"* **Lk 13:1-9**

Healing on a Sabbath and the Coming Kingdom

10He was teaching in a synagogue one Sabbath, **11**and a woman there had a spirit that for 18 years made her bent double, and she couldn't straighten up. **12**When Jesus saw her, he called out, *"Dear woman, your deformity's gone."* **13**He laid hands on her, and at once she straightened up and praised God. **14**The synagogue ruler got angry because Jesus healed her on a Sabbath. He told the crowd, *"There are six days for working. Come on those days to be healed, not on a Sabbath."*

15The Lord answered him, "You *foolish people, don't you[pl] untie your ox or donkey and lead it out to water on a Sabbath?* **16***Wasn't it appropriate on a Sabbath to untie this daughter of Abraham that Satan had tied up for18 years?"*

17His critics were disgraced, and the whole crowd was excited about the outstanding things he was doing.

18So he said, *"What's God's kingdom like? What can I compare it to?* **19***It's like a mustard seed a fellow planted in his garden. It became a tree, and birds nested in its branches."*

[20] *"What's God's kingdom like?* [21]*It's like yeast a woman put in three pecks of meal till it made the whole batch rise."* **Lk 13:10-21**

Discussions in Perea

[22]He was teaching from one town and village to another, working his way toward Jerusalem. [23]Somebody said, *"Lord, are few people saved?"*

He said to them,

> [24] *"Make[pl] every effort to go in through the narrow door. Many of you will try to go in but can't.* [25]*Once the homeowner gets up and shuts the door, you'll stand outside and knock, 'Let us in.' He'll answer, 'I don't know where you're from.'* [26]*You'll say, 'We ate with you, and you taught in our streets.'* [27]*He'll tell you straight off, 'I don't know where you're from. Get away from here, you bad people.'* [28]*There'll be crying and gnashing of teeth when you see Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and the prophets in Gods' kingdom and yourselves excluded.* [29]*People will come from every direction and sit down in his kingdom.* [30]*The last will be first and the first last."*

[31]At that time, some Pharisees came up to Jesus, *"You need to get out of here! Herod wants to kill you!"*

> [32] *"Tell that old fox, 'I'll heal[p] and cast out demons today and tomorrow, and finish my work on the third day.'* [33]*But today, tomorrow, and the next day I do need to travel; it's not thinkable that a prophet would perish anywhere but in Jerusalem!*
>
> [34] *"Jerusalem! Jerusalem! that kills the prophets and stones the messengers that have been sent to you! How many times I've wanted to gather your inhabitants like a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, but you didn't want to.* [35]*I'm leaving your house [abandoned][ms]. You won't see me till you say,* ***'Blessed be the One that's coming in the name of the LORD'"*** **[Ps 118:26].Lk 13:22-35**

Healing in a Pharisee's Home on a Sabbath

14[:1]On a Sabbath, when he went into the house of a ruling Pharisee to eat, *the leaders* were watching him closely. [2]In front of him was a man with extreme swelling. [3]Jesus said to the lawyers and Pharisees, *"Is it lawful to heal on a Sabbath?"*

[4]They didn't say anything. He took hold of him and healed him and let him go. [5]He said, *"If a son or ox falls into a well, wouldn't you pull[f] him out right away on a Sabbath day?"* [6]They couldn't answer him.

[7]When he noticed how they were vying for the prominent places *at the table*, he started telling the guests an example.

8 *"When somebody invites you to a wedding banquet, don't recline at table in a place of honor. Someone more distinguished than you may have been invited.* **9** *The one that invited you both will say to you*[sg]*, 'Let this gentleman have* your place.*' Then you'll head for the last place embarrassed.* **10** *Instead, when you're invited, go recline in the last place so when the one that invited you comes, he'll say, 'Friend, move up higher.' Then the others reclining at table will respect you.* **11** *Everybody that exalts himself will be humbled, and the one that humbles himself will be exalted."*

12 He went on to say to his host,

"When you[sg] *have a luncheon or dinner, don't call your friends, brothers, relatives, and wealthy neighbors. They can invite you in return.* **13** *Invite poor, disabled, lame, and blind people. You'll be blessed; they can't repay you.* **14** *You'll get repaid when the righteous resurrect."*

15 When one of those reclining at the table heard that, he said to Jesus, *"Blessed is the one that eats bread in God's kingdom."*

16 Jesus said to him,

"A man prepared a banquet and invited a lot of people. **17** *When the time for the banquet came, he sent a servant to tell them to come; everything was ready.* **18** *But they started making excuses. 'I need to go see a field I bought. Please excuse me.'*

19 *"'I'm on my way to try out five yokes of oxen I bought. Please excuse me.'*

20 *"'I just got married; I can't come.'*

21 *"When the servant came back, he told his master. The homeowner was mad, 'Hurry out into the streets and alleys in town and bring in the poor, disabled, blind, and lame.'*

22 *"'Master, I did what you said, and there's still room.'*

23 *"'Go out into the country lanes and paths and urge them to come in so my house will be full.* **24** *None of the people I invited will taste my banquet."*

Lk 14:1-24

The Cost of Discipleship

25 Large crowds were traveling with him. He turned and told them,

26 *"Nobody that comes to me can be my disciple unless he loves me more than his father, mother, wife, children, brothers, sisters—even his own life.* **27** *Whoever doesn't carry his own cross and follow me, can't be my disciple.* **28** *Which of you that wants to build a tower, doesn't sit down first and figure out what it'll cost, to see if you have enough money to finish it?* **29** *Otherwise, when*

you've laid the foundation and can't finish it, people will make fun of you, **30** *'This fellow started to build and couldn't finish.'*

31 *"What king engages another king in battle without sitting down first to figure out if with 10,000 he can meet one with 20,000?* **32** *If he can't, while the other is still a long way off, he'll send ambassadors to ask for terms of peace.* **33** *In the same way, none of you can be my disciple unless you give up everything you own.*

34 *"Salt is good, but if it loses its saltiness, what can make it salty?* **35** *It's useless for the ground or manure pile. People throw it out. Whoever has ears, listen!"* **Lk 14:25-35**

Parable About the Lost Sheep

15:1 Tax collectors and sinners were coming to listen to him. **2** The Pharisees and scribes started grumbling, *"This fellow welcomes sinners and eats with them."*

3 He told them this story.

4 *"What man that has a 100 sheep and loses one, doesn't leave the 99 in the open country and go looking for the one that's lost?* **5**

When he finds it, he puts it on his shoulders happy. **6** *When he gets home, he calls his friends and neighbors, 'Let's celebrate; I've found the sheep I lost.'* **7** *There'll be more celebration in heaven over one sinner that repents than over 99 good people that don't need to repent."* **Lk 15:1-7**

Parable About the Lost Coin

8 *"What woman that has 10 coins and loses one, doesn't light a lamp, sweep the house, and keep looking till she finds it?* **9** *When she does, she calls her friends and neighbors, 'Let's celebrate; I found the coin I lost.'* **10** *In the same way, God's angels celebrate over one sinner that repents.* **Lk 15:8-10**

Parable About the Prodigal Son

11 *"A man had two sons.* **12** *The younger one said to his father, 'Give me my share of the assets.' He divided his assets between the two sons.*

13 *"A few days later the younger son got everything together and left home for a distant country, and wasted his assets there, living immorally.* **14** *When he'd spent everything, a severe famine arose in that country, and he was out of money.* **15** *He went to work for a citizen in that country, who sent him into his fields to feed pigs.* **16** *He was so hungry he wanted to eat the carob pods the pigs were eating, but nobody would give him anything.*

[17] *"He came to himself, 'How many of my father's hired hands have more than enough to eat, and I'm starving here.* [18]*I'll go to my father and say, "I've sinned against Heaven and you.* [19]*I don't deserve to be your son anymore. Make me one of your hired hands."*

[20] *"He went to his father. While he was still a long way off, his father saw him, felt sorry for him, and he ran and hugged him and kissed him.* [21]*The son said, 'Dad, I've sinned against Heaven and you. I don't deserve to be your son anymore.'*

[22] *"But his dad told the servants, 'Quick, bring a robe—the best one—and put it on him. Put a ring on his finger and sandals on his feet.* [23]*Get the grain-fed calf and butcher it; let's eat and celebrate.* [24]*This son of mine was dead and has come back to life; he was lost and is found.' They started celebrating.*

[25] *"His older son was out in the field. When he got close to the house, he heard music and dancing.* [26]*He called one of the servants over and asked* him *what was going on.*

[27] *"'Your brother came back, and your father has butchered the grain-fed calf because he received him back in good health.'*

[28] *"He was mad and wouldn't go in. His dad came out and urged him.*

[29] *"But he answered, 'I've slaved*[p] *for you all these years and never neglected a thing you told me to do, and you've never given me a kid to celebrate with my friends.* [30]*But when that son of yours comes who wasted your living with prostitutes, you butcher the grain-fed calf!'*

[31] *"He said, 'Son, you're always here, and everything I have is yours.* [32]*But we needed to be happy and celebrate because this brother of yours was dead and is alive; he was lost and is found.'"* **Lk 15:11-32**

Parable About an Unjust Steward

16:[1]He also told his disciples,

"A rich man had a property manager that was reportedly wasting the rich *man's holdings.* [2]*He called him in, 'What's this I hear about you? Give me your record books for your work; you can't continue being manager.'* [3]*The fellow thought to himself, 'What am I going to do? My boss is firing me. I'm not strong enough for hard work; I'm ashamed to beg.* [4]*I know what I'll do, so when I've been let go, people will welcome me into their homes.'*

[5] *"He called in each debtor and said to the first, 'How much do you owe my employer?'*

[6] *"'800 gallons of olive oil.'*

"'Take your bill, sit down quick and write "400."'

7 *"'How much do you[sg] owe?'*

"'1,000 bushels of wheat.'

"'Take your bill and write, "800."'

8 *"The employer had to admire the conniving fellow. The children of this world are smarter among their own kind than the children of light are.* **9** *Make friends with your material wealth so when it runs out, they'll welcome you into permanent shelters.*

10 *A person that's reliable in little things will be reliable in big ones. Someone that's unreliable in little things will be unreliable in big ones.* **11** *So if you're not reliable with what has nothing to do with being good, who'll trust you with true wealth?*

12 *If you're not reliable with other people's things, who's going to give you your own?*

13 *No one can serve two masters. You'll disregard one and care about the other. You can't serve God and wealth."* **Lk 16:1-13**

The Law and God's Kingdom

14 The Pharisees, who loved money, heard these things and started laughing at him. **15** He told them,

"You try to make yourselves look good to other people, but God knows your hearts. What people prize, God detests. **16** *The Law and the Prophets were operating until John came. Since then,* the coming of *God's kingdom is being presented, and people keep trying to get into it by force.* **17** *But it's easier for earth and sky to pass away than for one serif* of the Law to fail."*

18 *Everybody that divorces his wife and marries someone else commits adultery, and whoever marries a divorced woman commits adultery."* **Lk 16:14-18**

Parable About the Rich Man and Lazarus

19 *"A rich man dressed in purple and fine linen, celebrated every day in splendor.* **20** *A poor man named Lazarus had been brought regularly to his gate. The man was covered with sores,* **21** *and he wanted to eat what fell from the rich man's table. The dogs even came and licked his sores.*

22 *"The poor man died, and angels carried him away into Abraham's arms. The rich man died, too, and was buried.* **23** *In hell he looked up in torment and saw Abraham far away and Lazarus in his arms.*

24 *"He called out, 'Father Abraham, have mercy on me, and send Lazarus to dip his finger in water and cool my tongue; I'm in agony in this flame.'*

25 *"Abraham said, 'Son, remember, you received your good things in life, and Lazarus received bad things. Now he's comforted here, and you're in torment.* **26** *Besides, a wide chasm lies between us and you[pl], so people can't cross over from one place to the other.'*

27 *"'Then send him to my father's house—* **28** *I have five brothers—to warn them so they won't come to this place of torment.'*

29 *"Abraham said, 'They have Moses and the Prophets. They can listen to them.'*

30 *"'No, Father Abraham, if somebody goes to them from the dead, they'll repent.'*

31 *"Abraham told him, 'If they won't listen to Moses and the Prophets, they won't be convinced even if somebody rises from the dead.'"* **Lk 16:19-31**

Comments on Offences and Faith

17:1 He said to his disciples,

"Inevitably offenses will come, but woe to the ones that bring them. **2** *It'd be better to have a big millstone put around their necks and be thrown into the sea than to make one of these little ones sin.* **3** *Be careful. If your friend sins, reprimand him; if he repents, forgive him.* **4** *If he sins against you seven times in a day and comes back seven times and says, 'I'm sorry,' forgive him."*

5 The apostles said to the Lord, *"Give us stronger faith."*

6 He said,

"If you have faith the size of a mustard seed, you can say to this mulberry tree, 'Be uprooted and planted in the sea,' and it'll obey you.

Parable About an Unprofitable Servant

7 *"Which* one *of you that has a servant plowing or tending sheep will say when he comes in, 'Sit down and eat'?* **8** *Won't you say[sg], 'Change clothes, fix me something to eat, and wait on me till I'm done eating; then you can eat'?* **9** *You don't thank him, do you, for doing what you've told him?* **10** *You[pl] too, when you've done what* God's *told you, say, 'We're not special; we've* just *done what we were supposed to."* **Lk 17:1-10**

Healing 10 Lepers

11 On the way to Jerusalem, he was passing along between Samaria and Galilee. **12** As he came into one village, ten lepers met him. They stood a long way off **13** and shouted, *"Jesus, Master, have mercy on us!"*

[14]When he saw them, he said, *"Go show yourselves to the priests."*

As they went, they were cleansed. [15]When one of them saw he was healed, he came back, loudly praising God, [16]and fell on his face to Jesus and thanked him. He was a Samaritan.

[17]Jesus responded, *"Weren't there ten cleansed? Where are the nine?* [18]*Was this foreigner the only one to come back and praise God?*

[19] *"Get up and go; your faith has saved you."* **Lk 17:11-19**

The Time of the Coming of the Kingdom

[20]The Pharisees asked when God's kingdom was coming.

He answered, *"It won't come in a way you can watch.* [21]*People won't say, 'Here,' or 'There,' because God's kingdom is interpersonal."*[lit]

[22]He told his disciples, *"The time's coming when you'll really want to see one of the days of the Son of Man and you won't see it.* [23]*People will tell you, 'Look, there* he is'*; 'look, here* he is*.' Don't go anywhere or follow them.* [24]*As lightning flashes from one end of the sky to the other, that's the way the Son of Man will come.* [25]*First, he has to suffer many things and be rejected by people here now.*

[26] *"As in Noah's day, it'll be in the Son of Man's day.* [27]*They were eating and marrying till Noah went into the ark, and the flood came and destroyed them all.* [28]*As in Lot's day, they were eating, buying, selling, planting, building.* [29]*The day Lot left Sodom, fire and sulfur rained from the sky and destroyed them all.* [30]*It'll be the same way when the Son of Man comes back.* [31]*At that time, someone on the roof must not go down to get things out of the house. A person in the field must not go back for things at the house.* [32]*Remember Lot's wife.* [33]*Whoever tries to preserve their life will lose it, and whoever loses it will save it.* [34]*That night two will be in one bed; one*[mas] *will be taken and the other*[mas] *left.* [35]*Two women will be grinding at the same place; one will be taken and the other left. [*[36]*]*[ms]*"*

[37]They answered[p], *"Where?"*

He said, *"The vultures will gather where the carcass is."* **Lk 17:20-37**

Parable About the Unjust Judge

18[:1]He told a story to the effect that people should always pray, and not give up.

[2] *"There was a judge in a town who didn't fear God or respect people.* [3]*A widow in that town kept coming to him to defend her against her accuser.* [4]*At first he wouldn't help her, but after a while he said to himself, 'I don't fear God or respect people,* [5]*but this widow keeps hounding me. I'll see that she gets justice so she won't wear me out, coming to me all the time.'*

[6] *"Listen to what the unjust judge illustrates.* [7]*Won't God provide justice for his chosen ones that call to him for help day and night, and be patient with them?* [8]*I'm telling you, he'll provide it right away. But, when the Son of Man comes, will he find* people with *faith on the earth?"* **Lk 18:1-8**

The Pharisee and the Publican

[9]He told this story to some people that trusted in their own goodness and looked down on everybody else.

[10] *"A Pharisee and a tax collector went up to the Temple to pray.* [11]*The Pharisee stood, praying to himself, 'God, I'm glad I'm not like everybody else—swindlers, unjust, adulterers—or this tax collector.* [12]*I fast twice a week and give a tenth of everything I gain.'*

[13] *"The tax collector stood a good way off and wouldn't even look up to heaven, but kept beating his chest, 'God, have mercy on me; I'm such a sinner.'* [14]*I'm telling you, he's the one that went home justified instead of the other one. Everybody that exalts himself will be humbled, but whoever humbles himself will be exalted."* **Lk 18:9-14**

Jesus and the Little Children

[15]People were bringing *their* babies for Jesus to touch. When the disciples saw it, they fussed at them. [16]But Jesus invited them, *"Let the little kids come over here. People like them are what make up God's kingdom.* [17]*I'm telling you, whoever doesn't welcome God's kingdom like a little kid won't get into it."* **Lk 18:15-17**

The Rich Young Ruler

[18]An official asked him, *"Good Rabbi, what do I need to do to inherit eternal life?"*

[19]Jesus said, *"Why are you calling me good? Nobody's good but God.* [20]*You know the commandments:* ***'do not commit adultery[f], murder[f], steal[f], or lie[f]*** **[Ex 20:13-16]*****; honor your parents'*** *"* **[Ex 20:12].**

. [21] *"I've done that since I was a boy."*

[22]Jesus said, *"There* <u>*is*</u> *one thing you can do: sell everything you own and distribute it to the poor, and you'll have wealth in heaven; then come with me."*

[23]When he heard that, he got really discouraged because he was very wealthy. **Lk 18:18-23**

The Peril About Wealth

[24]When Jesus saw him so downcast, he said*, "It's hard for wealthy people to get into God's kingdom.* [25]*It's easier for a camel to go through a needle's eye than for a rich person to get into God's kingdom.*

26The ones that were listening said, *"Who can be saved then?"*

27Jesus said, "*Things impossible for people are possible for God."*

28Peter said, *"We've left our homes to follow you."*

29He said to them, *"Everybody that has left behind a home, a wife, brothers, parents, or children for the sake of God's kingdom* **30***will receive many times more in this age and eternal life in the age to come."* **Lk 18:24-30**

Another Prediction of His Death

31He took the Twelve aside and told them, *"We're going up to Jerusalem to accomplish everything the prophets wrote about me.* **32***I'll be handed over to the Gentiles, and be made fun of, abused, spit on.* **33***When they've flogged me, they'll put me to death; but on the third day I'll resurrect."* **34**None of that made <u>any</u> sense to them. **Lk 18:31-34**

Healing Two Blind Men at Jericho

35Near Jericho a blind man was sitting by the road, begging. **36**When he heard a crowd go by, he asked what was happening. **37**They told him Jesus the Nazarene was going past.

38He yelled out, *"Jesus son of David, have mercy on me!"*

39The people out in front told him to quiet down, but he yelled all the more, *"Son of David, have mercy on me."*

40Jesus stopped and told him to come over. When he got there, Jesus asked him, **41** *"What do you want me to do?"*

"Lord, give me sight back."

42Jesus said, *"Receive it. Your faith has delivered you."*

43Instantly he could see again; and he went with Jesus, praising God. When the people saw it, they praised God *too*. **Lk 18:35-43**

Jesus and Zacchaeus

19:1 Jesus was passing through Jericho, **2**and a wealthy tax collector named Zacchaeus **3**wanted to see what he looked like, but he couldn't because of the crowd; he was too short. **4**So he ran ahead and climbed up in a sycamore tree that Jesus was heading toward. **5**When Jesus got there, he looked up, *"Zacchaeus, hurry and climb down. I need to stay at your place today."* **6**He hurried and climbed down and welcomed him happily.

7When people saw it, they started grumbling, *"He's going in to be a guest with a sinner!"*

8Zacchaeus stopped and said to the Lord, *"Half of what I own, I'm going to give to the poor. If I've cheated anybody, I'll repay it four times over."*

[9]Jesus said *this* about him, *"Salvation has come to this house today; he's a son of Abraham too.* [10]*The Son of Man came to seek and save sinners."* **Lk 19:1-10**

Parable About the Pounds

[11]While he had their attention, he told a story. Since he was close to Jerusalem, *people* were supposing God's kingdom would appear right away:

[12]*"A nobleman was about to go to a distant country to receive a kingdom.*
[13]*He called ten servants and passed out ten minas*, 'Do business with these till I get back.'*
[14]*"His citizens hated him and sent a delegation after him, 'We don't want him to rule us.'* [15]*When he got back from receiving the kingdom, he had the servants called that he gave the silver so he could find out what they'd earned.*
[16]*"The first came up, 'Master, your mina has made 10 more.'*
[17]*"'You did well. Since you've been reliable in a small matter, assume responsibility for ten cities.'*
[18]*"The second came, 'Your mina has made five minas.'*
[19]*"'Govern five cities.'*
[20]*"Another came, 'Master, here's your mina. I've kept it in a handkerchief.* [21]*I was afraid of you; you're an exacting man that picks up what you didn't lay down and reaps what you didn't sow.'*
[22]*"'I'll judge you out of your own mouth, you worthless servant. You knew, did you, that I'm an exacting man that picks up what I didn't lay down and reaps what I didn't sow?* [23]*Why didn't you put my silver in the bank? When I got back, I would've collected it plus interest.'*
[24]*"He told the bystanders, 'Take his mina and give it to the one that has ten.'*
[25]*"'Sir, he has ten.'*
[26]*"'I'm telling you, everybody that has will receive, and the ones that don't have will lose even what they do have.* [27]*But, bring those enemies that didn't want to be under my rule and put them to death in front of me.'"*

[28]After he said that, he took the lead up to Jerusalem. **Lk 19:11-28**

The Triumphal Entry

[29]When he got close to Bethphage and Bethany, to the hill called *The Mount* of Olives, he sent two disciples: [30]*"Go in the village over there. When you go in, you'll find a colt tied that*

nobody has ever ridden. Untie it and bring it. [31]*If anybody asks why you're untying it, say the Lord needs it."*

[32]They went and found the colt like he said. [33]As they were untying it, its owners said, *"Why are you untying the colt?"*

[34] *"The Lord needs it."*

[35]They brought it, threw their cloaks over it, and put Jesus on it. [36]As he was going along, people started spreading their cloaks on the road. [37]Near the descent from the Mount of Olives, the whole crowd of disciples started celebrating. They were loudly praising God for the miracles they'd seen,

> [38]***"Blessed be*** *the king* ***that's coming***
> ***in the name of the LORD*** **[Ps 118:26].**
> *Peace in heaven and*
> *glory in the highest."*

[39]Some Pharisees in the crowd said, *"Rabbi, rein in your disciples."*

[40]He answered, *"If they go silent, the rocks will start shouting!"*

[41]As he got close and saw the city, he cried over it,

> [42] *"If you only knew today what's in store for the peace you have now . . . ; but you can't see it.* [43]*The time's coming when your enemies will put up a siege wall around you and box you in from every direction.* [44]*They'll level you to the ground and your residents along with you. They won't leave one stone on another, because you didn't know when it was coming."* **Lk 19:29-44**

Second Cleansing of the Temple (cp Jn 2:13-22)

[45]He went into the Temple and started chasing the merchants out, [46] *"Scripture says,*

> ***'My house will be a house for prayer'*** **[Is 56:7].**
> *You've made it* ***'a den for thieves!'*** **[Jer 7:11]***"*

[47]Every day he taught in the Temple, and the chief priests, scribes, and leaders of the people were looking for some way to destroy him, [48]but they couldn't find one; the people were eagerly listening to him. **Lk 19:45-48**

Jesus' Authority Challenged

20[:1]One day he was teaching the people in the Temple and delivering good news. The chief priests, scribes, and elders confronted him: [2] *"What right do you have to do this? Who gave you that right?"*

[3] *"I'll ask you something too. Tell me,* [4]*Was John's baptism from heaven or humans?"*

[5]They talked it over, [6]*"If we say, 'From heaven,' he'll say, 'Why didn't you believe him?' If we say, 'From humans,' the people will stone us; they're convinced John was a prophet."* [7]They said they didn't know.

[8]Jesus said, *"I won't tell you either what right I have to do what I'm doing."* **Lk 20:1-8**

The Parable About a Vineyard

[9]He started telling the people this story:

"A man planted a vineyard, rented it out to tenants, and went on an extended trip. [10]*At harvest time he sent the tenants a servant to receive the fruit from the vineyard. But the tenants beat him up and sent him away empty-handed.*

[11]*"He proceeded to send another servant. They beat him up, too, and treated him shamefully, and sent him away with nothing.* [12]*He sent a third. They wounded him and threw him out.* [13]*The owner said, 'What am I going to do? I'll send my dear son. Maybe they'll respect him.'* [14]*When the tenants saw him, they started talking among themselves, 'That's the heir. Let's kill him so the vineyard will belong to us.'* [15]*They threw him out of the vineyard and killed him. What's the owner going to do to them?* [16]*He'll come and destroy them and give the vineyard to other tenants."*

The *audience* said, *"Surely not!"*

[17]He looked at them and said, *"What then does this scripture mean,*

'The stone the builders rejected
has become the cornerstone' **[Ps 118:22]**?

[18]*Everybody that falls on that rock will get bruised. Whoever it falls on will get crushed."*

[19]The scribes and chief priests were ready to seize him right then, but they were afraid of the people. They knew he'd told that story on them. **Lk 20:9-19**

The Question About Tribute to Caesar

[20]They kept a close eye on him and sent spies pretending to be honest men so they could latch onto something he said. That way they could turn him over to the governor's authority.

[21]They asked him, *"Rabbi, we know you're straightforward when you teach. It doesn't matter who you're talking to; you teach the way of God correctly.* [22]*Is it lawful to pay tribute to Caesar?"*

[23]He saw through their deception, [24]*"Show me a denarius. Whose image and inscription does it have on it?"*

"Caesar's."

[25]*"Then pay Caesar what you owe Caesar and pay God what you owe God."*

[26]They couldn't make anything out of what he said in front of his audience. They were dumbfounded by his answer and didn't say anything. **Lk 20:20-26**

The Question About the Resurrection

[27]Some Sadducees—who deny there's resurrection—came and asked him,

[28]*"Rabbi, Moses wrote to us,* ***'If a brother dies*** *and has a wife* ***but no children, his brother is to marry his wife and raise up offspring to his brother'*** **[Deut 25:5; Gen 38:8].** [29]*There were seven brothers, and the first married a wife and died childless.* [30]*The second and* [31]*third through the seventh married her and died and didn't leave any children.* [32]*Last of all, the woman died too.* [33]*Whose wife will she be in the resurrection? They all had her as a wife."*

[34]Jesus said,

"People in this age get married. [35]*The ones considered worthy of receiving that age and the resurrection of the dead don't get married.* [36]*They can't die anymore either, they're like angels. They're like God and participate in the resurrection.*

[37]*"But, that the dead are raised, even Moses showed when he said in the 'bush passage,'* 'I'm *the* ***LORD, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob's God'*** **[Ex 3:6, 15-16]**. [38]*He's not a God of the dead, but of the living; everybody is alive to him."*

[39]Some scribes responded, *"Rabbi, that was a good answer."* [40]After that, nobody tried to trip him up with *loaded* questions. **Lk 20:27-40**

The Question About the Son of David

[41]He said to them, *"How do they say the Messiah is David's son?* [42]*He says himself in the Book of Psalms,*

'The LORD said to my Lord,
"Sit at my right hand
[43]***till I make your enemies your footstool"'"*** **[Ps 110:1].**

[44]*If David calls him 'Lord,' how can he be his son?"* **Lk 20:41-44**

Denouncing the Scribes and Pharisees

[45]Right in front of everybody, he told the crowd and his disciples, [46]*"Watch out for the scribes. They like to walk around in long robes and love greetings in the marketplaces, chief seats in the synagogues, places of honor at banquets.* [47]*They confiscate widows' houses and offer long prayers for show. They'll get a more severe condemnation."* **Lk 20:45-47**

The Widow's Mite

21:[1]He looked up and saw wealthy people putting contributions in the Treasury [2]and a poor widow putting in two leptons*. [3]*"I'm telling you, that poor widow put in more than anybody.* [4]*They contributed from their abundance, but she put in everything she had to live on."* **Lk 21:1-4**

The Olivet Discourse

[5]Some were talking about the Temple, because it was decorated with beautiful stones and memorial gifts.

[6]He said, *"The time's coming when what you see here won't be left stone on stone."*

[7]*"Rabbi, when's that going to happen? What will show it's about to happen?"*

[8]He said,

"Make sure nobody misleads you. Many men will come, saying, 'I'm the Messiah,' and, 'It's time.' Don't follow them. [9]*When you hear about wars and rebellions, don't be terrified.* [10]*Nation will attack nation; kingdom will attack kingdom.* [11]*There will be severe earthquakes, famines, and plagues in many places—dreadful events, and great signs from the sky.* **Lk 21:5-11**

[12]*"But before all that, they'll persecute you and arrest you. They'll deliver you to synagogues and jails and take you in front of kings and governors because of me.* [13]*Those times will provide opportunities to speak for me.* [14]*Be determined not to prepare your defense ahead of time.* [15]*I'll give you what to say and wisdom that none of your opponents can argue with.* [16]*Even parents, relatives, and friends will betray you and execute some of you.* [17]*People will hate you because of me.* [18]*Yet not a hair of your head will perish.* [19]*You'll gain your souls by standing firm.*

[20]*"When you see Jerusalem being surrounded by armies, you'll know its destruction is coming.* [21]*People in Judaea need to flee to the hill country, people in* the city *need to leave, people in the countryside must* <u>*not*</u> *go into the city.* [22]*This will be*[p] *a time of revenge to fulfill scripture.* [23]*Woe to the women that are pregnant or nursing then; there'll be great distress in the land and God's displeasure on this people.* [24]*They'll fall by the sword and go captive into foreign countries. Gentiles will trample Jerusalem underfoot till the times of the Gentiles are over.*

[25]*"There'll be signs in the sun, moon, and stars, and turmoil among nations in despair at the roaring of the sea.* [26]*People will faint from fear and foreboding over what's coming on the world, because the powers in the sky will be shaken.* [27]*People will see* ***'the Son of Man coming on a cloud'*** **[Dan 7:13]** *with great power and glory.* [28]*When these things start to happen, look up; your deliverance is on its way.* **Lk 21:12-28**

[29] *"Look at a fig tree—or any tree.* [30]*As soon as it begins to sprout leaves, you can tell summer's coming.* [31]*The same way when you see these things, you'll know God's kingdom is on its way.* [32]*That will take place in* <u>*this*</u> *generation.* [33]*Earth and sky will pass away, but what I say won't pass away.*

[34] *"Be careful that pleasures, drunkenness, life's worries don't make you insensitive, and* <u>*that*</u> *day comes on you unexpectedly* [35]*like a trap. It'll come on everybody on earth.* [36]*Be alert all the time. Pray so you'll be strong enough to get away from everything that's coming and to stand in front of the Son of Man."*

[37]Jesus was spending the days teaching in the Temple and the nights on the hill called *The Mount* of Olives. [38]The people would come early to listen to him in the Temple. **Lk 21:29-38**

Fifth Prediction of His Death

22[:1] The Festival of Unleavened Bread (called Passover) was coming up. [2]The chief priests and scribes were looking for some way to destroy him because they were afraid of the people. **Lk 22:1-2**

Judas' Plot to Betray Jesus

[3]Satan got into Judas, called Iscariot, one of the Twelve. [4]He went to talk to the chief priests and soldiers about delivering Jesus to them. [5]They were elated and offered him money. [6]He agreed and started looking for a chance to turn him over away from a crowd. **Lk 22:3-6**

Preparation for the Passover Meal

[7]The day of Unleavened Bread came when the Passover lamb needed to be sacrificed. [8]Jesus sent Peter and John, *"Go get the Passover ready for us."*

[9] *"Where should we do that?"*

[10] *"On the way into the city, you'll meet a man carrying a clay pot of water. Follow him into the house he enters* [11]*and say to the owner, 'The Rabbi says, "Where's the guest room where I can eat the Passover with my disciples?"'* [12]*He'll show you a big upstairs room furnished. Get things ready there."* [13]They went and found it like he'd said and got things ready. **Lk 22:7-13**

The Passover Meal;
The Lord's Supper Instituted

[14]When the time came, he and his disciples reclined at table. [15]He said, *"I've really wanted to eat this Passover with you before I suffer;* [16]*I won't be eating* this meal *till* its meaning *is fulfilled in God's kingdom."*

[17]He took a cup, gave thanks, and said, *"Take this and distribute it among yourselves.* [18]*This is the last time I'll drink the fruit of the vine till God's kingdom comes."* [19]He took a loaf,

gave thanks, and passed it around to them, *"This is my body that's given for you. Do this in my memory."* **20**In the same way, he took the cup after they ate, "*This cup that's poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood.* **21***But the hand of my betrayer is with me on the table.* **22***I'll go the way it's been pre-determined, but woe to the one that betrays me."* **23**They tried to figure out with each other which of them would do such a thing. **Lk 22:14-23**

Another Argument About Rank

24An argument arose about which of them would have the highest rank.

25He said,

"Gentile kings lord it over their people; the ones that wield authority they call benefactors. **26***You're not to be like that. The greatest among you needs to be like the youngest and the leader like a servant.* **27***Who has higher rank, someone reclining at table or a waiter? Isn't it the one at the table? But I'm here like a waiter.* **28***You've stayed with me in my difficulties.* **29***I'm passing the kingdom on to you like the Father passed it on to me* **30***so you can eat at my table in my kingdom and sit on thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel.* **Lk 22:24-30**

The Disciples Warned

31 *"Simon, Satan asked to sift you*[pl] all *like wheat,* **32***but I prayed that your*[sg] *faith wouldn't fail. When you get stable again, stabilize your brothers."*

33Peter said, *"Lord, I'm ready to go to prison and to die with you."*

34Jesus said, *"I'm telling you, Peter, before a rooster crows in the morning, you'll deny three times that you* even *know me."*

35He said, *"When I sent you out with no money bag, knapsack, or shoes, you didn't lack anything, did you?"*

"No."

36 *"But now, if you have a money bag, take it—and a knapsack too. If you don't have a sword, sell your coat and buy one.* **37***I have to fulfill what this scripture says about me:* ***'They considered me a criminal'*** **[Is 53:12]**. *What refers to me will happen."*

38 *"Lord, here are two swords."*

"That's enough." **Lk 22:31-38**

Agony in the Garden

39He left and went to the Mount of Olives as he often did, and his disciples went with him. **40**When he got to where he was going, he said, *"Pray so you won't be tempted."*

41He went away about a stone's throw, and knelt down and prayed, **42** *"Father, if you're willing, take this cup away from me. Yet not my will but yours be done."* [[**43**An angel from heaven

appeared to him to strengthen him. **44**In agony he prayed more intensely. His sweat became like drops of blood dripping on the ground.]][ms]

45He got up and went back and found the disciples sleeping from grief. **46**He said, *"Why are you sleeping? Get up and pray so you won't be tempted."* **Lk 22:39-46**

The Arrest

47While he was still talking, a crowd came with Judas in front. He came up to Jesus to kiss him.

48Jesus said, *"Judas, you're betraying me with a kiss?"*

49When the ones around him saw what was about to happen, they said, *"Lord, should we attack with a sword!?"* **50**One of them struck a servant of the high priest and cut off his right ear.

51Jesus responded, *"Back off!"* He touched the servant's ear and healed him.

52He said to the chief priests, soldiers, and elders, *"You're coming out* here *with swords and clubs as if you're capturing an insurgent?* **53***I was with you in the Temple every day, and you didn't lay a hand on me—but . . . this is your time—the power of darkness."* **Lk 22:47-53**

The Trial Before Caiaphas;
Peter's Denials; Condemnation by the Sanhedrin

54They arrested him and led him *away* to the high priest's residence. Peter followed at a distance. **55**After they started a fire in the middle of the courtyard and sat down together, Peter was sitting with them. **56**A servant girl saw him sitting *there*, facing the light. She looked at him closely, *"This fellow was with him too."*

57He denied it, *"I don't know him."*

58A little later someone else saw him, *"You <u>are too</u> one of them."*

Peter said, *"Sir, I am not."*

59About an hour later, another man started insisting, *"This man <u>was too</u> with him. He's a Galilean."*

60Peter said, *"Sir, I don't know what you're talking about."*

While he was still speaking, a rooster crowed. **61**The Lord turned and looked at him, and he remembered what Jesus had said, *"Before a rooster crows in the morning, you'll deny three times that you* even *know me."* **62**He went out and broke down sobbing.

63The men that held Jesus in custody were making fun of him, **64**blindfolding him, slapping him, and asking, *"Say! Who slapped you?"* **65**They were saying lots of other insulting things to him.

66When it got daylight, the people's council of elders, chief priests, and scribes convened and brought him into their Court, **67**asking, *"Are you the Messiah? Tell us."*

"If I tell you[pl], you won't believe me. **68***If I ask a question; you won't answer me.* **69***From now on,* ***"the Son of Man will sit in a position of power at God's right hand"*** **[Ps 110:1]**.

70They all said, *"So are you God's 'Son'?"*

"Yes."

71They said, *"What do we need witnesses for? We've heard him say it ourselves."*

Lk 22:54-71

The First Trial Before Pilate

23:1 The whole assembly got up and took him to Pilate. **2**They started accusing him, *"This man's misleading our nation, forbidding people to pay tribute to Caesar, and claiming to be* the *Messiah, a king."*

3Pilate asked him, *"Are you king of the Jews?"*

"Yes."

4Pilate said to the chief priests and the crowd, *"This man's not guilty of anything!"*

5They kept insisting, *"He stirs up the people, teaching everywhere from Galilee to here."*

Lk 23:1-5

Trial Before Herod Antipas

6When Pilate heard that, he asked if he was a Galilean. **7**When he found out Jesus was from Herod's jurisdiction, he sent him on to Herod, who was in Jerusalem at the time. **8**Herod was glad to see him. He'd wanted to see him for a long time because of what he'd been hearing about him; he'd hoped to see him do a sign. **9**He asked him lots of questions, but Jesus didn't answer him.

10The chief priests and scribes were standing *there,* accusing him aggressively. **11**After treating him with contempt and making fun of him, Herod and his soldiers dressed him in a splendid robe and sent him back to Pilate. **12**Herod and Pilate became friends that day. They'd been at odds with each other. **Lk 23:6-12**

The Second Trial Before Pilate

13Pilate called together the chief priests, rulers, and the people, **14***"You brought* me *this fellow as someone that's inciting the people to revolt. I examined him in your presence and didn't find him guilty of what you claimed.* **15***Herod didn't either; he sent him back. He hasn't done anything worth executing him for.* **16***I'll flog him and release him."* [**17**][ms]

18They shouted out together, *"Away with him! Release Barabbas to us!"* (**19**Barabbas had been put in prison for a riot in the city and for murder.) **20**Pilate wanted to release Jesus and addressed them again, **21**but they kept yelling, *"Crucify him! Crucify him!"*

22For the third time he said, *"What's he done? I haven't seen anything worth executing him for. I'll flog him and release him."*

23But they kept pressing with loud demands to crucify him, and they were getting the upper hand.

[24]Pilate decided to give in to them [25]and release the one they were asking for—the one in prison for riot and murder—and sentenced Jesus to death like they wanted. **Lk 23:13-25**

The Way to Golgotha

[26]As they were leading him away, they made Simon—a Cyrenian coming in from the countryside—carry the cross in front of Jesus. [27]A big crowd followed him, including women that were mourning and crying over him.

[28]Jesus turned and said, *"Daughters of Jerusalem, don't cry for me. Cry for yourselves and your children.* [29]*The time's coming when they'll say the barren are fortunate, the wombs that never bore, the breasts that never nursed.* [30]*They'll say to the mountains, 'Bring an avalanche on us,' and to the hills, 'Cover us.'* [31]*If they're doing this when the wood's green, what'll they do when it's dry?"* **Lk 23:26-31**

The Death of Jesus

[32]They took two others to execute with him. [33]When they got to a place called The Skull, they crucified him and the two criminals, one on each side of him. [[[34]Jesus said, "Father, forgive them; they don't know what they're doing."]][ms] They cast lots to divide up his clothes.

[35]The people stood watching. The rulers were making fun of him, *"He saved other people; let him save himself if he's God's Messiah, the Chosen One."*

[36]The soldiers mocked him too and offered him some sour wine, [37]*"If you're King of the Jews, save yourself."*

[38]The inscription above him was, *"King of the Jews."*

[39]One of those hanged with him lashed out, *"Save yourself and us. You're the Messiah, right?"*

[40]The other reprimanded him, *"Don't you even fear God? You're under the same condemnation!* [41]*We're getting what we deserve, but he hasn't done anything wrong."*

[42]He said, *"Jesus, remember me when you come into your kingdom."*

[43]Jesus said, *"You'll be with me in Paradise today."*

[44-45]About noon, it got dark over the whole country till 3 o'clock, and the Temple curtain tore in two. [46]Jesus shouted, *"Father,* ***I'm committing my spirit to you****!"* **[Ps 31:5]** and quit breathing. **Lk 23:32-46**

Other Miracles at Messiah's Death

[47]When the centurion saw what happened, he praised God, *"Surely this man was innocent."* [48]When the crowd that had gathered for this spectacle saw what all happened, they went home beating their chests. [49]His acquaintances and the women that came with him from Galilee stood a long way off, watching. **Lk 23:47-49**

The Burial

50A member of the Sanhedrin named Joseph, a good, upright man, **51**hadn't been in agreement with what they did. He was from Arimathea, a town of the Jews, and was waiting for God's kingdom. **52**He went to Pilate and asked for Jesus' body. **53**He took it down, wrapped it in a linen cloth, and put him in a new rock-hewn tomb. **54**It was getting late on Preparation Day, and Sabbath was about to start. **55**The women that came with him from Galilee followed along and saw where they put the body. **56**They went back to fix spices and ointment, and rested on the Sabbath like *the Law* commanded. **Lk 23:50-56**

The Resurrection; The Women's Report;
Peter and John's Visit

24:1 But early in the morning on the first day of the week, *the women* went to the tomb, carrying the spices they'd prepared. **2**They found the stone rolled away from the tomb, **3**but when they went in, didn't find the body of the Lord Jesus. **4**While they were wondering what happened, two men stood by them in dazzling clothes. **5**The women were scared and lowered their faces toward the ground. The men said, *"Why look for the living among the dead?* **6***He's not here; he resurrected. Remember how he told you back in Galilee* **7***that he had to be betrayed to sinners, be crucified, and resurrect the third day."*

8They remembered what he'd said, **9**and left the tomb to tell the eleven and the rest. (**10**They were Mary the Magdalene, Joanna, Mary mother of James, and others.) They told the apostles, **11**but it seemed to them like idle talk. **12**But Peter ran to the tomb, stooped down, and saw only the linen wrappings. He went back puzzled. **Lk 24: 1-12**

Appearance to Two
on the Way to Emmaus

13That same day *Jesus* appeared to two disciples as they were making their way to Emmaus, a village about seven miles from Jerusalem. **14**They were talking about what all had happened. **15**Meanwhile, Jesus caught up with them, **16**but they didn't recognize him[lit].

17He said, *"What were you talking about while you walked?"*

18One named Cleopas said, *"Are you the only one visiting Jerusalem that doesn't know what happened there lately?"*

19 *"What?"*

"About Jesus the Nazarene, a prophet powerful in word and deed in the presence of God and all the people. **20***The chief priests and our rulers delivered him over to the death sentence and had him crucified.* **21***We were hoping he was the One that would free Israel. It's been three days since that happened,* **22***but some women from our number astounded us. They'd arrived at the tomb early this morning.*

[23]*When they didn't find his body, they came and said they'd seen angels who claimed he was alive.* [24]*Some that were with us went to the tomb and found it like they'd said, but they didn't see him."*

[25]Jesus said, *"Foolish men, hesitant to believe everything the prophets have said.* [26]*Didn't the Messiah need to suffer those things and enter his glory?"* [27]Beginning with Moses and all the prophets, he explained the scriptures that referred to himself.

[28]When they got close to home, he acted like he was going on, [29]but they urged him to stay with them, *"It's getting late; the day's almost over."* So he went in.

[30]While he was reclining at table, he took bread, blessed it, broke it, and handed it to them. [31]They recognized him, and he disappeared. [32]They said to each other, *"Didn't we feel an eerie sensation while he was talking to us on the road and explaining the scriptures?"*

Lk 24:13-32

Report by the Two

[33]They got up and went right back to Jerusalem and found the eleven with some others, [34]who told *them* that the Lord really did resurrect and had appeared to Simon. [35]In turn, they recounted what happened on the road and how they recognized him when he broke the bread. **Lk 24:33-35**

Appearance to the Ten
with Further Commission

[36]While they were talking about it, Jesus himself stood among them, *"Hello*." [37]They were startled and scared; they thought they were seeing a ghost.

[38] *"Why are you at a loss, wondering what's happening?* [39]*Look at my hands and my feet; it's really me. Touch me. A spirit doesn't have flesh and bones like you can see I have."* [[40]]

[41]They couldn't believe it, they were so happy.

"Do you have anything here to eat?"

[42]They gave him a piece of baked fish, [43]and he took it and ate it in front of them.

[44] *"This is what I told you when I was still with you: I needed to fulfill everything the scripture says about me in the Law of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms: [[45]]* [46]*the Messiah would suffer and resurrect the third day,* [47]*and in his name repentance for forgiveness would be presented in every country. Beginning in Jerusalem,* [48]*you'll testify to these things.* [49]*I'll send*[p] *on you what the Father promised, but stay in the city till I clothe you with power from on high."*

Lk 24:36-49

The Ascension

[50]He led them out to Bethany, raised his hands, and blessed them. [51]While he was blessing them, he was carried up into the sky. [52]They [worshiped him and][ms] returned to Jerusalem elated, [53]and were continually in the Temple, praising God. **Lk 24:50-53**

JOHN

The Pre-Existence and
Incarnation of the Messiah

1:1 In the beginning the Word was *there*. The Word was with God, and the Word was deity. **2**He was in the beginning with God. **3**He made everything; nothing came into existence without him. What has come **4**in him was life, life that gave people light. **5**The light shined[p] in the darkness, but the darkness tended not to accept it.

6God sent a man named John **7**to tell about the light so everybody would believe. **8**He wasn't the light, but came to reveal **9**it, the true light for enlightening everyone in the world. **10***The Word* was in the world and made the world, but it didn't know him. **11**He came into his own things, but his own people tended not to accept him. **12**But, to as many as did accept and believe in him, he gave the right to become God's offspring, **13**not born by blood, physical desire, or a husband's will, but by God.

14The Word took on a physical nature and lived with us. We saw his glory, glory like the only One from the Father, full of grace and reality.

15John testified[p] about him, shouting, *"He's the One I was talking about when I said, 'After me a man is coming that has become before me because he existed before me!'"* **16**From his full measure we've all received grace on top of grace. **17**Moses gave law, but Jesus the Messiah brought grace and reality. **18**Nobody's ever seen God, *but* the unique deity—the One dear to the Father—has shown what he's like. **Jn 1:1-18**

John's Defense of His Ministry

19This is what John said when Jews from Jerusalem sent priests and Levites to ask him who he was.

20 *"I'm not the Messiah."*

21 *"Are you Elijah, then?"*

"I'm not Elijah."

"Are you 'the prophet'?"

"No."

22 *"Who are you, so we can answer the ones that sent us? What do you say about yourself?"*

23 *"I'm one* ***shouting in the desert, 'Make the LORD's road straight!'*** **[Is 40:3]** *like Isaiah the prophet said."*

24The Pharisees had sent the ones that came. **25**They asked him, *"Why are you baptizing if you're not the Messiah, Elijah, or 'the prophet'?"*

26 *"I'm baptizing in water, but there's a man you don't know standing among you.* **27***He'll succeed me, a man whose sandal strap I'm not worthy to unfasten."*

28That happened at Bethany beyond the Jordan *River*, where John was baptizing.

Jn 1:19-282:1

John's Identification of Jesus as the Messiah

29The next day he saw[p] Jesus coming,

"Look, the Lamb of God that takes away the sin of the world! **30***He's the One I was talking about when I said, 'After me a man is coming that has become before me because he existed before me.'* **31***I didn't know who he was; but to point him out to Israel, I came immersing in water.* **32***I've seen the Spirit coming down from the sky like a dove and remaining on him.* **33***The One that sent me to immerse people in water told me, 'Whoever you see the Spirit coming down and remaining on is the One that will 'immerse'* them *in the Holy Spirit.'* **34***I've seen* that*, and I'm telling you, this is God's Son."* **Jn 1:29-34**

The First Disciples of Jesus

35The next day John was standing with a couple disciples. **36**When he saw Jesus walk by, he said, *"Look, the Lamb of God!"* **37**His two disciples followed Jesus. **38**Jesus turned around and saw them,

"What are you looking for?"

"Rabbi (Teacher), where are you staying?"

39 *"I'll show you."*

So they went and stayed with him that day. It was about 4 o'clock.

40Andrew, Simon Peter's brother, was one of the two that followed Jesus. **41**The first thing Andrew did was go[p] and find[p] his brother Simon, *"We've found the Messiah (the Christ)."* **42**When he brought him to Jesus, Jesus looked at him, *"You're Simon Barjonah; you'll be called Cephas (Peter)."*

43The next day Jesus wanted to leave for Galilee. He found[p] Philip, *"Come with me."* **44**Philip was from Bethsaida, where Andrew and Peter lived. **45**Philip found[p] Nathanael, *"We've found the One that Moses and the Prophets wrote about in the Law: Jesus son of Joseph from Nazareth."*

46Nathanael said, *"Can anything good come out of Nazareth?"*

"I'll show you."

47Jesus saw Nathanael coming, *"A true Israelite with no deceit in him."*

48Nathanael said[p], *"Where do you know me from?"*

"Before Philip called you, I saw you under the fig tree."

49Nathanael answered, *"Rabbi, you're the Son of God, the king of Israel!"*

50 *"You believe because I said I saw you under the fig tree? You're going to see greater things than that.* **51***You'll see the sky opened up and God's angels ascending and descending on the Son of Man."* **Jn 1:35-51**

The First Miracle—at Cana

2:[1]Three days later there was a wedding at Cana in Galilee. Jesus' mother was there, [2]and he and his disciples were invited. [3]When the wine ran out, his mother told[p] him they'd run out of wine.

[4]Jesus said[p], *"What is this? It's not my time yet."*

[5]His mother told[p] the help, *"Do whatever he tells you."*

[6]Six big stone water jars were standing there that the Jews use for purification. They held 20 or 30 gallons apiece. [7]Jesus said[p], *"Fill the jars with water."* They filled them to the brim. [8]*"Dip some out and take it to the master of ceremonies."* [9]When he tasted it, he didn't know where it had come from—but the help that drew the water knew. He called the groom, [10]*"Everybody serves good wine first. When guests have had a lot to drink, they serve wine that's not as good. You've kept the good wine till now."* [11]So Cana was where Jesus performed his first sign and demonstrated his glory, and his disciples believed in him. **Jn 2:1-11**

Visit to Capernaum

[12]After that, he went down to Capernaum for a few days with his mother, his brothers, and his disciples. **Jn 2:12**

The First Cleansing of the Temple

[13]The Jews' Passover was coming, and Jesus went up to Jerusalem. [14]In the Temple he found moneychangers sitting and merchants selling oxen, sheep, and doves. [15]He made a whip out of cords and drove the sheep and oxen out of the Temple. He poured out the moneychangers' coins and turned their tables over. [16]He told the ones that were selling doves, *"Get them out of here! Don't make my Father's house a marketplace."* [17]His disciples remembered the scripture, ***"Zeal for your house has consumed me"*** **[Ps 69:9a]**.

[18]The Jews said, *"What sign do you do to show us you have a right to do this?"*

[19]Jesus answered, *"Destroy[pl] this Temple, and I'll rebuild it in 3 days."*

[20]*"It took 46 years to build; you're going to rebuild it in 3 days?"* [21](He was talking about his body, "the Temple." [22]When he resurrected, his disciples remembered he'd said that and believed it and the scripture.)

[23]While he was in Jerusalem at the Passover, many believed in him because they saw the signs he did. [24]But he didn't entrust himself to them because he knew everybody. [25]He didn't need anybody to tell him about anyone; he knew what each person was like. **Jn 2:13-25**

Conversation with Nicodemus

3:[1]Nicodemus, a ruler of the Jews, [2]came to Jesus at night, *"Rabbi, we know you're a teacher from God. Nobody can do the signs you do unless God's with him."*

3Jesus answered, *"Unless a person has been born again, he can't see God's kingdom."*

4Nicodemus said[p], *"How can you be born when you're an adult? You can't get into your mother's womb a second time and be born, can you?"*

5Jesus answered,

"Unless you've been born of water and spirit, he can't get into God's kingdom. **6***What's born out of the physical is physical; what's born out of the spiritual is spiritual.* **7***Don't be surprised that I told you[sg] you[pl] have to be born again.* **8***The wind blows where it wants to. You[sg] hear it, but you can't tell where it's from or where it's going. That's how everybody is that's born out of the spirit."*

9Nicodemus responded, *"What <u>are</u> you talking about?"*

10*"You're a teacher in Israel and don't understand that?* **11***I'm telling you[sg], we're talking about what we know and have seen, and you[pl] don't accept what we're telling you.* **12***If you[pl] don't believe my earthly illustrations, how will you believe if I tell you heavenly ones?* **13***Nobody has gone up to heaven except the One that came down from heaven, the Son of Man.* **14***As Moses held up the* brazen *viper in the desert, the Son of Man needs to be held up* **15***so everybody that believes can in him have eternal life."*

16God cared about the world so much he gave his only Son so anybody that trusts in him wouldn't perish but have eternal life. **17**God didn't send his Son to the world to condemn it, but to save it. **18**Whoever trusts in him is not condemned, but whoever doesn't, stands condemned for not trusting in God's only Son. **19**Here's the condemnation: light has come into the world, but people like darkness better than light because they do bad things. **20**People that do bad things hate light and don't come to it; they don't want their deeds condemned. **21**But people that do the truth come to the light to show that they're doing what God wants. **Jn 3:1-21**

Jesus' Growing Ministry and
John's Waning Ministry at Aenon

22After that, Jesus and his disciples went to Judaea, and he stayed there baptizing. **23**John was baptizing too—at Aenon close to Salem; there was a good supply of water there. **24**(Herod hadn't put John in prison yet.)

25A controversy about purification came up between John's disciples and a Jew. **26**They came to John and said, *"Rabbi, the man that was with you on the other side of the Jordan—the one you vouched for—is baptizing, and everybody's going to him."*

27John answered,

"A person can't receive anything unless Heaven lets him. **28***You heard me say I'm not the Messiah; 'I've been sent ahead of him.'* **29***The groom has the bride, but the best man enjoys listening to him talk. I'm perfectly content, then, with this situation.* **30***He needs to increase; I need to decrease.*

31*"The One from above is above everything; someone from the earth talks about the earth.* **32**The One from above *talks about what he's seen and heard, and people tend not to accept what he says.* **33***Whoever does accept it, is acknowledging that God tells the truth.* **34***The One that God sent speaks God's message; he gives the spirit without measure.* **35***The Father loves the Son and has turned everything over to him.* **36***Whoever trusts in him has eternal life; whoever doesn't, won't see life. God's displeasure rests on him."* **Jn 3:22-36**

The Ministry in Samaria

4:1 When Jesus found out that the Pharisees heard he was making and baptizing more disciples than John **2**(though Jesus didn't perform the baptisms himself; his disciples did them), **3**he left Judaea and headed back to Galilee. **4**He had to go through Samaria. **5**He came[p] to a town in Samaria called Sychar, near the plot of land Jacob gave his son Joseph. **6**Jacob's well was there. Jesus was sitting on the well *wall* about noon, tired from the trip.

7A Samaritan woman came[p] to draw water, and he said to her, *"Please give me a drink."* **8**(His disciples had gone into town to buy food.)

9The woman said[p], *"How does a Jewish man ask a Samaritan woman for a drink? Jews don't have anything to do with Samaritans."*

10Jesus answered, *"If you knew God's gift and who's asking you for a drink, you'd be asking <u>him</u> to give <u>you</u> <u>living</u> water."*

11*"Sir, you don't even have a bucket, and the well is deep. Where are you going to get 'living water'?* **12***You aren't greater than our ancestor Jacob, are you? He gave us the well and drank from it himself—his sons and herds too."*

13Jesus answered, *"Everybody that drinks this water gets thirsty again.* **14***Whoever drinks the water I give him won't get thirsty again. It'll become a well inside him that springs up into eternal life."*

15*"Give me that water so I won't get thirsty and have to come here to draw it!"*

16Jesus told her[p], *"Go get your husband and come back."*

17*"I don't have a husband."*

18*"You said it well. You've had five husbands; the one you're living with now isn't your husband. You told the truth."*

19The woman said[p], *"Sir, you must be a prophet.* **20***Our ancestors worshiped on this mountain. You[pl] say people should worship in Jerusalem."*

21Jesus told[p] her,

"Believe me, the time's coming when you[pl] won't worship the Father on this mountain <u>or</u> in Jerusalem. **22***You[pl] don't know what you're worshiping. We do, because salvation does come from the Jews.* **23***But, the time's coming—it's here now—when true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth. The Father's looking for people to worship him like that.* **24***God's a spirit. and those who worship him need to worship him in spirit and truth."*

25*"I know Messiah's coming [called Christ]. He'll explain everything to us."*

26Jesus said[p], *"I <u>am</u> the Messiah."*

27At that point his disciples got back and were surprised that he was talking to a woman. But nobody said, *"What are you trying to find out?" "Why are you talking to her?"* **28**She left her water pot and went into town and told[p] the men, **29***"Come see a fellow that told me everything I ever did. He's not the Messiah, is he?"* **30**They left the town and were on the way to him.

31Meanwhile the disciples kept saying, *"Rabbi, eat something."*

32But he said, *"I have 'food' to eat that you don't know about."*

33They said to one another, *"Nobody's brought him anything to eat, have they?"*

34Jesus said[p],

"My 'food' is doing the will of the One that sent me and finishing it up. **35***Aren't you[pl] saying harvest is still four months away? Look; the fields are ready for harvest now.* **36**Whoever *reaps earns wages and gathers grain for eternal life.* **37***In this respect, the saying holds true, 'One sows, another reaps.'* **38***I've sent you to reap what you haven't worked on. Other people have worked, and you've joined in their work."*

39From that town many Samaritans believed in him because the woman said, *"He told me everything I ever did."* **40**So when the Samaritans got to where he was, they asked him to stay with them; he stayed two days. **41**Many more believed because of what he said. **42**They told the woman, *"We don't believe just because of what you said. We've heard him ourselves and know this really is the One that will save the world."* **Jn 4:1-42**

Introductory Statements About the Galilean Ministry

43Two days later, Jesus left for Galilee. **44**He observed that a prophet doesn't get any respect in his hometown.

45Yet when he got to Galilee, the Jews welcomed him because they'd seen what he'd done in Jerusalem; they'd attended the festival themselves. **Jn 4:43-45**

Healing the Official's Son

46Then he went to Cana in Galilee, where he'd turned the water into wine. An official's son in Capernaum was sick. **47**When he heard that Jesus had come from Judaea to Galilee, he went to ask him to come down and heal his son, who was about to die.

48Jesus told him, *"Unless you*[pl] *see signs, you won't believe, will you?"*

49The official said[p], *"Sir, come on down before my little boy dies."*

50Jesus told him[p], *"Go on, your son's alive."*

The man took his word for it and went on back.

51As he was going back down *to Capernaum*, his servants met him and said his child was alive. **52**He asked what time he recovered. *"Yesterday at 1 o'clock the fever broke."* **53**So his dad knew it was when Jesus said, *"Your son's alive."* He and his whole family believed. **54**That was a second sign Jesus did in Galilee, *which he did* after he came back from Judaea. **Jn 4:46-54**

Healing and Controversy at the Pool of Bethesda

5:1 After that, Jesus went up to a festival of the Jews in Jerusalem. **2**By the Sheep *Gate* in Jerusalem there's a pool with five porches, called Bethzatha in Hebrew. **3**A crowd of sick, blind, lame, and paralyzed people was lying in those porches. [**4**][ms] **5**One fellow had been in his condition for 38 years.

6Jesus saw him and knew he'd been there a long time. *"Do you want to get well?"*

7The crippled man answered, *"Sir, I don't have anybody to take me into the pool when the water stirs. While I'm making my way down, somebody else gets there ahead of me."*

8Jesus told[p] him, *"Get up, pick up your bedroll, and walk."*

9Right away the fellow was sound. He picked up his bedroll and started walking. **Jn 5:1-9a**

It was a Sabbath, **10**so the Jews started telling him, **11** *"It's against the Law to be carrying your bedroll."*

He answered, *"The One that made me well told me to pick it up and walk.'"*

12 *"Who told you that?"*

13He didn't know because he hadn't noticed Jesus leave in the crowd. **14**Later, Jesus found him in the Temple, *"You've been made well. Don't sin anymore so something worse doesn't happen to you."*

15The man left and told the Jews it was Jesus that had cured him. **16**They started harassing Jesus because he did it on a Sabbath.

17But Jesus answered them, *"My Father has been working till now, and so am I."*

18Now the Jews tried to do more to him—to put him to death. Not only had he broken the Sabbath; he said God was his Father. That made him equal to deity. **Jn 5:9b-18**

19Jesus answered them,

"The Son of Man can't do anything on his own. He does what he sees the Father do. **20***The Father loves the Son and shows him what he's doing; he'll show him greater deeds than these to amaze you.* **21***As the Father raises the dead, so the Son makes alive the ones he wants to.* **22***The Father doesn't judge anybody; he's given judgment to the Son* **23***so everybody will respect the Son like they do the Father. Whoever doesn't respect the Son doesn't respect the Father that sent him.* **24***Whoever listens to what the Son says and believes the One who sent him, has eternal life and doesn't end up condemned. He's crossed over from death to life.* **25***The time's coming—it's already here—when the dead will hear the Son and come to life.* **26***As the Father has life in himself, he's enabled the Son to have life in himself.* **27***And he's given him authority to judge because he's a human being.*

Jn 5:19-27

28 *"Don't be surprised that the time's coming when everybody in the tombs will hear him.* **29***The ones that did good things will come out to a resurrection that leads to life. The ones that did bad things* will come out *to a resurrection that leads to condemnation*.

30 *"I can't do anything on my own. As I hear I judge, and my judgment is just, because I'm not trying to accomplish my own purpose, but the purpose of the One that sent me.*

31 *"If I speak for myself, you might consider suspect what I'm saying.* **32***There's somebody else that vouches for me, and I know his testimony about me is true:* **33***you've sent to John, and he's vouched for the truth.* **34***I don't receive people's claims about me, but I do say this so you can be saved:* **35***John was a burning, shining lamp, and you were happy for a while in his light.* **36***But I present greater testimony than John did. The works the Father has given me to accomplish speak for the fact that he sent me.* **37***The Father that sent me has spoken for me. You haven't heard him speak or seen him,* **38***and you don't believe in the One he sent.* **39***Search the scriptures, because you suppose you have eternal life in them, and they talk about me.* **40***You don't want to come to me to have life.*

Jn 5:28-40

41 *"I don't accept honor from people;* **42***I know you don't love God.* **43***I've come in my Father's name, and you don't accept me. If others comes in their own name, you*[pl] *accept them.* **44***How can you believe when you accept honor from one another instead of striving for the honor that only comes from God?* **45***Don't suppose I'm going to accuse you to the Father. Moses accuses you, the one you've put your faith in.* **46***If you believed Moses, you'd believe me because he wrote*

about me. [47]*If you don't believe what he wrote, how can you believe what I say?"*

Jn 5:1-47

Retirement with the Apostles;
Feeding the 5,000

6:[1]After that, Jesus went to the other side of Lake Galilee (*Lake* Tiberias). [2]A big crowd followed him because they saw the signs he was performing on the sick. [3]He went up on a hillside and sat down with his disciples. [4]The Jews' Passover Festival was coming up. [5]Jesus looked up and saw a huge crowd arriving, and said to Philip, *"Where are we going to buy enough bread for these people to eat?"* ([6]He said that to test him because *Jesus already* knew what he was going to do.)

[7]Philip answered, *"Bread worth 200 denarii won't be enough for each person to get even a little bit."*

[8]Andrew, Simon Peter's brother, said[p], [9]*"There's a boy here that has five barley loaves and two fish, but what good is that for this big crowd?"*

[10]Jesus said, *"Have them sit down."* There was lots of grass there, so they sat down—about 5,000 men. [11]Jesus took the loaves, blessed them, and gave them to the ones that were sitting there—the fish too, as much as people wanted.

[12]When they were full, he told his disciples, *"Pick up the leftover pieces so nothing's wasted."* [13]So they filled twelve baskets with scraps from the five barley loaves that Jesus had multiplied.

[14]The people that saw the sign said, *"This really is the prophet that's supposed to come."* [15]Jesus knew they intended to take him by force to make him king, so he withdrew up the hill alone.

Jn 6:1-15

Jesus Walking on the Water

[16]When evening came, his disciples went down to the lake, [17]got in a boat, and headed over to Capernaum. It was dark now, and Jesus hadn't come. [18]The lake was getting rough because a strong wind was blowing. [19]When they'd rowed three or four miles, they saw Jesus walking on the lake, getting close to the boat, and it scared them. [20]But he said[p], *"It's me; don't be afraid."* [21]So they came to take him into the boat, and presently the boat landed where they were headed.

Jn 6:16-21

Jesus' Refusal to Be a Political Messiah

[22]The next day the crowd that was standing back on the other side of the lake, saw that no other small boat had been there except the one Jesus hadn't got into with his disciples; they'd left by themselves. [23]Other small boats came from Tiberias to where the people ate the bread the Lord had blessed. [24]When the crowd saw that he and his disciples weren't around, they got in *those* small boats and went to Capernaum, looking for him.

[25]When they found him on the other side of the lake, they said, *"Rabbi, when did you get here?"*

[26]Jesus answered, *"You're looking for me, not so much because you saw signs, but because you ate bread till you were full.* [27]*Don't work for bread that molds, but for bread that stays freesh forever. That's the* kind of *bread the Son of Man will give you, because he's the One the Father has marked with a seal."*

[28]They asked him, *"What'll we do to be working God's works?"*

[29]Jesus answered, *"This is God's 'work': believe in the One he sent."*

[30]They said, *"What sign are you doing so we can see it and believe? What 'work' do you do?* [31]*Our ancestors ate manna in the desert like scripture says,* ***'He gave them bread from heaven to eat'"*** **[Ps 78:24].**

[32]Jesus said, *"Moses didn't give you bread from heaven. My Father is giving you the real 'bread from heaven.'* [33]*God's 'bread' is the One that has come down from heaven to give life to the world."* **Jn 6:22-33**

[34]They said, *"Sir, give us that bread all the time!"*

[35]Jesus said,

> *"I'm the life-giving bread. Whoever comes to me will never get hungry; whoever trusts in me will never get thirsty.* [36]*But, you've seen me and not believed.* [37]*Everything the Father gives me will come to me, and whoever comes to me I won't reject;* [38]*because I haven't come down from heaven to do my will, but the will of the One that sent me.* [39]*This is his will: that I not lose anything he's given me,* [40]*that everybody who sees the Son and believes in him may have eternal life, and I raise him up in the end."*

[41]The Jews started grumbling because he said, *"I'm the bread that's come down from heaven."* [42]They were saying, *"Isn't this Jesus, Joseph's son? We know his parents. How can he be saying now that he has come down from heaven?"* **Jn 6:34-42**

[43]Jesus answered,

> *"Don't grumble around with one another.* [44]*Nobody can come to me unless the Father that sent me is drawing him.* [45]*The prophets wrote,* ***'God will teach them all'*** **[Is 54:13].** *Everybody that listens to the Father and learns, comes to me—*[46]*not that anybody has seen him except the One that's come from him; he's seen him.* [47]*Whoever believes has eternal life.* [48]*I'm the life-giving 'bread.'* [49]*Your ancestors ate manna in the desert and died.* [50]*Nobody that eats this 'bread' from heaven will die.* [51]*I'm the life-giving 'bread' that comes from heaven. Everybody that eats this 'bread' will live forever. Yes, and the 'bread' I'll give for the life of the world is my own flesh."* **Jn 6:43-51**

[52]The Jews started quarreling with one another, *"How can he give us his flesh to eat?"*
[53]Jesus said,

"Unless you 'eat' the flesh of the Son of Man and 'drink' his blood, you don't have any life in you. [54]*People that 'eat' my flesh and 'drink' my blood have eternal life, and I'll raise them up in the end.* [55]*My flesh is real 'food,' and my blood is real 'drink.'* [56]*People that 'eat' my flesh and 'drink' my blood remain in me and I in them.* [57]*As the living Father has sent me and I live because of him, whoever 'eats' me will live because of me.* [58]*This is the 'bread' from heaven; it's not like what the ancestors ate and died. Whoever 'eats' this bread will live forever."*

[59]He said that as he was teaching in the synagogue in Capernaum. [60]When they heard it, many disciples said, *"That's hard to understand. Who can make sense of it?"* **Jn 6:52-60**

[61]Jesus knew his disciples were grumbling about it,

"Does that shock you? [62]*What if you see the Son of Man ascending to where he was before?* [63]*The spirit of what I've said is the point, not the literal words. What I've said I mean figuratively.* [64]*But some of you don't believe*. (Jesus knew from the start who wouldn't believe and who'd betray him.) [65]*That's why I told you that people can't come to me unless the Father lets them."*

[66]At that point, many disciples quit traveling with him. [67]Jesus said to the Twelve, *"You don't want to go too, do you?"*

[68]Simon Peter answered, *"Lord, who would we go to? You have the life-giving message.* [69]*We believe and have come to know that you're God's Holy One."*

[70]Jesus answered, *"Didn't I choose you twelve, and one of you is a devil?"* ([71]He was referring to Judas, Simon Iscariot's son, the one that would betray him.) **Jn 6:61-71**

Attack of the Jerusalem Pharisees
About Traditions

7[:1]After that, Jesus was traveling around in Galilee. He didn't want to travel around in Judaea because the Jews were trying to kill him. **Jn 7:1**

Jesus and His Unbelieving Brothers

[2]The Jews' Festival of Unleavened Bread was coming up. [3]Jesus' brothers told him, *"Go to Judaea so your disciples can see what you're doing.* [4]*Nobody does something privately when he's trying to get known publicly. If you're doing these things, show yourself to the world."* ([5]Even his brothers didn't believe in him.)

6Jesus told[p] them, *"It's not time for me to go yet. You can go anytime.* **7***The world can't hate you; it hates me because I speak to the fact that it does sinful things.* **8***You go on up; it's not time for me to go up to this festival yet."*

9He stayed in Galilee. **Jn 7:2-9**

Jesus at the Feast of Tabernacles

10Then Jesus went up secretly. **11**The Jews were looking for him at the festival, *"Where is he?"* **12**A lot of murmuring was going on in the crowds. Some were saying, *"He's a good man."* Others said, *"No, he's misleading the crowd."* **13**But, people wouldn't talk openly about him because they were afraid of the Jews.

14In the middle of the festival, Jesus did go up to the Temple and start teaching. **15**The Jews were amazed, *"How does he know letters without going to school?"*

16Jesus answered,

> *"My teaching's not mine; it's the teaching of the One that sent me.* **17***If anybody wants to do his will, he'll know if my teaching is from God or if I'm speaking on my own.* **18***Somebody that speaks on his own is looking for his own honor. Somebody that's looking for the honor of the One that sent him is genuine; there's nothing dishonest about him.* **19***Didn't Moses give you the Law? But none of you keep it. Why are you trying to kill me?"* **Jn 7:10-19**

20The crowd answered, *"You've got a demon. Who's trying to kill you?"*

21Jesus responded,

> *"I did one thing, and it amazed you all.* **22***Moses gave you circumcision—not that it originated with him but with the ancestors—and you circumcise a man on a Sabbath.* **23***If you circumcise a man on a Sabbath to avoid breaking the Law, are you mad at me because I made a whole man well on a Sabbath?* **24***Don't make superficial judgments; base your judgments on what's real."*

25Some that lived in Jerusalem were saying, *"Isn't this the One they're trying to put to death?* **26***And look, he's speaking openly, and they're not saying anything to him. Do the rulers know maybe that he is the Messiah?"*

27 *"But we know where this man's from. Nobody knows where the Messiah's from."*

28Then, as he was teaching, he shouted, *"You know me, and you know where I'm from! I haven't come on my own; the One that's true sent me. You don't know him;* **29***but I do, because he sent me."* **Jn 7:20-29**

30They were trying to arrest him, but nobody laid a hand on him because it wasn't time yet. **31**Many in the crowd believed in him, *"When the Messiah comes, he won't do more signs than this man's done, will he?"*

32The Pharisees heard the crowd murmuring those things, and the chief priests and Pharisees sent officers to arrest him. **33**Jesus said, *"I'll be with you for a little while yet; then I'll go back to the One that sent me.* **34***You'll look for me, but you won't find me. You can't go where I'm going."*

35The Jews said to each other, *"Where's he going that we won't find him? He's not going to the Diaspora among the Greeks to teach the Greeks, is he?* **36***What does he mean, 'You'll look for me and won't find me,' and, 'You can't go where I'm going'?"* **Jn 7:30-36**

37On the last day of the festival, the main day, Jesus stood and shouted, *"If anybody's thirsty, come to me and drink.* **38***Everyone that believes in me, like the scripture has said, will have streams of living water flowing from within him."* **39**(He said that about the Spirit the ones who believed in him would receive. The Spirit hadn't come yet because Jesus hadn't been glorified.)

40Some in the crowd said, *"This really is 'the prophet'"*; some said, *"He's 'the Messiah.'"* **41**Others said, *"The Messiah's not supposed to come from Galilee, is he?* **42***Doesn't scripture say he descends from David and comes from Bethlehem, where David lived?"* **43**So a difference of opinion about him arose in the crowd. **44**Some wanted to arrest him, but nobody laid a hand on him.

45The officers came back to the chief priests and Pharisees, *"Why didn't you bring him?"*

46The officers answered, *"Nobody's ever spoken like that."*

47The Pharisees answered them, *"You haven't been deceived too, have you?* **48***None of the rulers or the Pharisees have believed in him, have they?* **49***This crowd that doesn't know the Law is accursed."*

50Nicodemus said[p] to them—the one who came to him at first, **51***"It's not legal, is it, to convict someone without a hearing?"*

52They answered him, *"You're not from Galilee, too, are you? Search* the Scriptures *and see that no prophet is supposed to arise from Galilee."* [[**53**Each one went home.]][ms] **Jn 7:37-53**

Woman Caught in Adultery

[[8:1 Jesus went to the Mount of Olives. **2**Early in the morning he went back to the Temple. The people came, and he sat down and started teaching them. **3**The scribes and Pharisees brought[p] a woman they'd caught in adultery and stood her in front of everybody, **4***"Rabbi, we caught this woman in adultery—in the very act.* **5***In the Law Moses commanded us to stone a woman like this. What do* <u>you</u> *say?"* **6**(They were trying to trap him so they could accuse him.)

Jesus squatted down and scribbled on the ground with his finger. **7**When they kept badgering him, he stood up, *"The one of you that doesn't have any sin, throw the first stone at her."* **8**He squatted down again and scribbled on the ground. **9**They began to go away one by one, starting with the oldest, and left him alone with the woman standing there.

10Jesus stood up, *"Where are they? Hasn't anybody condemned you?"*
11 *"No, Sir."*
"I'm not condemning you either. Go and don't sin anymore."]][ms] **Jn 8:1-11**

Sermon on the Light of the World

12Jesus started talking to the audience again. *"I'm the light of the world. You that follow me won't be living in the dark; you'll have the light to live by."*
13The Pharisees said, *"You're testifying for yourself; your testimony's not valid."*
14Jesus answered,

"Although I'm testifying for myself, my testimony is valid because I know where I'm from and where I'm going. You don't. **15***You condemn* people *by legal standards; I don't condemn anybody that way.* **16***If I do render judgment, my judgment's valid because I'm not the only witness. There's me and the Father that sent me.* **17***Your[pl] Law says the testimony of two is valid.* **18***I testify for myself, and the Father testifies for me."*

19 *"Where is your Father?"*

Jesus answered, *"You don't know me or him. If you knew me, you'd know him."* **20**He said that in the Temple Treasury, and nobody arrested him; it wasn't time yet.

21He told them again, *"I'm going away. You'll[pl] look for me and die in your sin[sg]. You can't go where I'm going."* **Jn 8:12-21**

22The Jews said, *"He's not going to kill himself, is he?*—because he said, *"You can't go where I'm going."*

23He said, *"You're from below; I'm from above. You're from this world; I'm not.* **24***I said you'd die in your sins because if you don't believe who I am, you will die in your sins."*

25 *"Who are you?"*

"Exactly what I've been telling you all along. **26***I have a lot to say about you and judgments to make, but the One that sent me is the real basis for it. What I've heard from him is what I'm telling the world."* **27**(They didn't know he was talking about the Father; **28**so he said,)

"When you lift up the Son of Man, you'll know who I am and that I'm not saying anything but what I got from the Father. **29***The One that sent me is with me. He hasn't left me alone, because I always do what pleases him."* **30**While he was saying that, many believed in him.

31Then he told the Jews that believed him, *"If you keep following what I say, you really are my disciples.* **32***You'll know the truth, and the truth will set you free."* **Jn 8:22-32**

33 *"We're Abraham's descendants. We've never been servants to anybody. What do you mean, 'You'll be free'?"*

34 *"Everybody that sins is a servant to sin.* **35***A servant is not a part of the family. A son is.* **36***So if a son sets you free, you really are free.* **37***I know you're Abraham's descendants, but you're trying to kill me because you don't want to hear what I'm saying.* **38***I'm telling you what I've seen my Father do, and you're doing what you've seen your father do."*

39 *"Abraham's our father."*

"If you were Abraham's children, you'd be acting like Abraham. **40***But you're trying to kill me now, a man that's told you the truth I heard from God. Abraham didn't act like that.* **41***You're doing what your father does."*

"We're not illegitimate children; we have one Father—God."

> **42** *"If God were your Father, you'd love me because I've came from him. I haven't come on my own; he sent me.* **43***Why don't you understand what I'm saying? Can't you hear?* **44***You belong to your father the devil, and you want to do what he wants you to do. He was a murderer from the beginning and doesn't stand for the truth. There's no truth in him. When he tells a lie, he's doing his own thing because he's a liar and invented lying.* **45***Because I'm telling the truth, you don't believe me.* **46***Which of you can convict me of wrongdoing? If I'm telling the truth, why don't you believe me?* **47***Whoever belongs to God listens to God. Here's the reason you don't listen: you don't belong to him."*

48 *"Wouldn't we be right to say you're a Samaritan with a demon?"* **Jn 8:33-48**

49Jesus answered, *"I don't have a demon, but I do respect my Father, and you disrespect me.* **50***I'm not trying to honor myself. There is One who seeks and condemns.* **51***Truth is, if anybody keeps what I say, he'll never die."*

52The Jews said, *"Now we know you've got a demon. Abraham died and the prophets died, but you're saying, 'If anybody keeps what I say, he'll never die.'* **53***You aren't greater, are you, than our ancestor Abraham that died and the prophets that died? Who do you think you are anyway?"*

54 *"If I honor myself, it's not important. My Father honors me—who you say is your God.* **55***You don't even know him, but I do. If I said I didn't, I'd be lying like you[pl]. But I know him and keep his word.* **56***Your ancestor Abraham was overjoyed at the thought of seeing my day; he saw it and was happy."*

57 *"You're not even 50 years old, and you've seen Abraham?"*

58 *"Truth is, I existed before Abraham."*

59They picked up stones to throw at him, but he was hidden and left the Temple. **Jn 8:49-59**

Healing the Man Born Blind

9:1 As he was walking along, he saw a man that had been blind from birth. **2**His disciples asked him, *"Rabbi, who sinned, him or his parents, that caused him to be born blind?"*

3 *"Neither he nor his parents sinned* to cause his blindness. *That has happened so I could demonstrate God's work in him.* **4** *We need to work for the One that sent me while it's daylight. Night's coming when nobody can work.* **5** *While I'm in the world, I'm the light of it."*

6 When he'd said that, he spit on the ground and made some mud and smeared it on the blind man's eyelids, **7** *"Go wash it off in the Pool of Siloam ('Sent')."*

He went and washed it off and came back able to see. **8** Neighbors and people that had seen him begging said, *"Isn't that the fellow that sits and begs?"*

9 *"It <u>is</u> him."*

"No, he just looks like him."

"It <u>is</u> me."

10 *"How did you get your sight?"*

11 *"The man they call Jesus made mud and smeared it on my eyelids and told me to go to Siloam and wash it off. So I did, and I could see."*

12 *"Where is he?"*

"I don't know." **Jn 9:1-12**

13 They took[p] him to the Pharisees. **14** It was a Sabbath day when Jesus made the mud and gave him sight. **15** The Pharisees, too, asked him how he'd received his sight. He told them, *"He put mud on my eyelids. I washed it off and I can see."*

16 Some Pharisees said, *"That man's not from God; he doesn't keep Sabbath."*

Others said, *"How could a man that's a sinner do such a thing?"* So they were divided over it.

17 They said[p] to the blind man again, *"You're the one he made see. What do <u>you</u> think about him?"*

"He's a prophet."

18 The Jews doubted that he'd been blind till they called his parents, **19** *"Is this your son that you claim was blind? How can he see now?"*

20 *"He's our son, and he was born blind.* **21** *We don't know how he can see now or who gave him his sight. Ask him; he's legal age; he can speak for himself."* **22** (They said that because they were afraid. The Jews had already agreed to excommunicate from the synagogue anybody who agreed that Jesus was the Messiah. [**23**][repeat])

24 They called the man a second time, *"Give <u>God</u> the credit; we know that man's a sinner."*

25 He responded, *"I don't know if he's a sinner. I do know one thing: I was blind; now I can see."* **Jn 9:13-25**

26 They said, *"What did he do to you? How did he make you able to see?"*

27 *"I already told you and you didn't listen. Why do you want to hear it again? You don't want to become his disciples too, do you?"*

28 *"You're his disciple; we're Moses' disciples.* **29** *We know God spoke to Moses, but we don't know where this man's from."*

30 *"It's amazing that you don't know where he's from: he gave me my sight.* **31** *We know God doesn't listen to sinners, but if anybody is devout and does his will, he listens to him.* **32** *From eternity past nobody ever heard of someone giving sight to a man born blind.* **33** *If he weren't from God, he couldn't have done anything."*

34 *"You were totally born in sins, and you're trying to teach us?"* They excommunicated him. **Jn 9:26-34**

35 Jesus heard they'd excommunicated him. When he found him, he said, *"Do you believe in the Son of Man?"*

36 *"Who is he so I can believe in him?"*

37 *"You've seen him; he's the One talking to you."*

38 *"I believe, Lord,"* and knelt down to him.

39 Jesus said, *"I came to the world to render judgment so the ones that can't see can see, and the ones that can see can go blind."*

40 The Pharisees that were with him heard it, *"We aren't blind too, are we?"*

41 *"If you were blind, you wouldn't be guilty. But you say, 'We can see.' You're still guilty."* **Jn 9:35-41**

Sermon on the Good Shepherd

10:1 *"Whoever doesn't go through the gate into the sheep pen but climbs up somewhere else, is a thief.* **2** *A shepherd comes through the gate.* **3** *The gatekeeper lets him in, and the sheep recognize his voice. He calls them by name and leads them out.* **4** *When he gets them out, he goes in front of them, and they follow him because they know his voice.* **5** *They won't follow a stranger. They'll run away because they don't recognize his voice."*

6 They didn't understand what Jesus meant by the illustration.

7 Again, Jesus said,

"I'm the gate for the sheep. **8** *The ones that came before me were thieves and insurrectionists, but the sheep didn't listen to them.* **9** *If anybody comes in through me, he'll be safe and can go in and out and find pasture.* **10** *A thief comes to steal, slaughter, and destroy. I've come so they can live and live more abundantly.* **11** *I'm a good shepherd; a good shepherd risks his life for his sheep.* **12** *A hired hand sees a wolf coming and runs away because the sheep don't belong to him. A wolf snatches them and scatters them.* **13** *A hired hand doesn't care*

about them. [14]*I'm a good shepherd; I know my sheep, and they know me.* [15]*I know the Father like the Father knows me, and I risk my life for my sheep.*

[16]*"And, I have other sheep that aren't part of this fold. I need to lead them too. They'll hear my voice and become one flock under one shepherd.* [17]*The Father loves me because I lay down my life to take it back again.* [18]*Nobody's taking it away from me. I'm laying it down voluntarily. I have the authority to lay it down and the authority to pick it up again. That's what my Father told me to do."*

[19]Again a division arose among the Jews over what he said. [20]A number of them said, *"He's got a demon; he's crazy. Why are you listening to him?"*

[21]Others said, *"A demon-possessed man doesn't talk like that. A demon can't make blind people see, can it?"* **Jn 10:1-21**

Jesus at the Feast of Dedication

[22]The Festival of Dedication *[Hanukkah]* took place in Jerusalem during the winter, [23]and Jesus was walking in the Temple in Solomon's Colonnade. [24]The Jews surrounded him and said, *"How long are you going to keep us in suspense? Are you the Messiah? Tell us plainly."*

[25]Jesus answered, *"I've told you, and you don't believe me. The things I do in my Father's name speak for me.* [26]*But you don't believe me because you're not my sheep.* [27]*My sheep listen to my voice, and I know them. They follow me,* [28]*and I give them eternal life. Nobody is going to snatch them from me.* [29]*My Father, who gave them to me, is stronger than anyone. Nobody is going to snatch them from him.* [30]*The Father and I are at one."*

[31]Again the Jews picked up stones to stone him. [32]Jesus replied to them, *"I've shown you many good deeds from the Father. Which of them are you ready to stone me for?"*

[33]*"We're not ready to stone you for doing something good, but for blasphemy. You're a mere mortal, and you're trying to make yourself deity."*

[34]Jesus responded, *"Doesn't your Law say,* ***'I said, you are gods'****?* **[Ps 82:6]** [35]*If he called them 'gods' that the word of God came to—and scripture can't be broken—*[36]*how can you say that the One the Father sanctified and sent into the world is blaspheming because I said I'm God's Son?* [37]*If I'm not doing what my Father does, don't believe me.* [38]*If that's what I <u>am</u> doing, even if you don't believe <u>me</u>, believe <u>what I do</u>, so you can know that the Father's in me and I'm in him."* [39]They tried to grab him again , but he got away. **Jn 10:22-39**

Retirement from Jerusalem to Perea

40He went away again to the other side of the Jordan *River*—where John was baptizing at first—and stayed there. **41**Many people came to him. They said, *"John didn't do any sign, but everything he said about this man is true."* **42**Lots of people believed in him there. **Jn 10:40-42**

Raising Lazarus

11:1 There was a man sick, Lazarus of Bethany, the village where Mary and her sister Martha lived. **2**That was the Mary who anointed the Lord with perfume and wiped his feet with her hair. Lazarus was her brother. **3**His sisters sent to Jesus, *"Lord, the one you love is sick."*

4When he heard it, he said, *"He's not going to die from this sickness; it's for God's praise so it can praise God's Son."*

5Now Jesus loved Martha, her sister, and Lazarus. **6**So when he heard Lazarus was sick, he stayed where he was for two days, **7**then said[p] to the disciples, *"Let's go back to Judaea."*

8They said[p], *"Rabbi, the Jews were trying to stone you just the other day, and you're going back there?"*

9Jesus answered, *"Aren't there twelve hours of daylight? If you walk in the daylight, you won't stumble, because you have light.* **10***If you try to walk in the dark, you stumble because you doesn't have light coming out of yourself."* **Jn 11:1-10**

11After he said that, he told them, *"Our friend Lazarus is sleeping; I'm going to wake him up."*

12His disciples said, *"Lord, if he's sleeping, he'll get better."*

13Jesus was talking about <u>death</u>, but they thought he was talking about <u>rest</u>. **14**Then he told them plainly, *"Lazarus has died.* **15***For your sake I'm glad I wasn't there, so you can believe. Let's go to him."*

16Thomas, called Didymus, said, *"Let's go, too, so we can die with him."*

17When Jesus got there, he found that Lazarus had already been in the tomb four days. **18**Bethany was about a mile and three-quarters from Jerusalem, **19**and many Jews had come to console Martha and Mary about their brother. **20**When Martha heard Jesus was coming, she went to meet him, but Mary stayed in the house. **21**Martha said, *"Lord, if you'd been here, my brother wouldn't have died.* **22***But I know even now that whatever you ask God for, he'll give you."*

23 *"Your brother will rise again."*

24Martha said[p], *"I know he'll rise again in the end."*

25Jesus said, *"<u>I'm</u> resurrection and life. Whoever believes in me will live even though he dies.* **26***Everybody that lives and believes in me will never die. Do you believe that?"*

27 *"Yes, Lord; I've believed you're the Messiah, God's Son, who comes to the world."*

28When she'd said that, she went and called Mary privately, *"The Rabbi's here; he's asking for you."* **Jn 11:11-28**

29She got up quickly and went to him. **30**He hadn't come into the village yet; he was still where Martha met him. **31**When the Jews in the house saw her get up quickly and leave, they followed her. They supposed she was going to the tomb to mourn. **32**Mary came to where Jesus was and fell down to him, *"Lord, if you'd been here, my brother wouldn't have died."*

33When Jesus saw her crying and the Jews crying that had come with her, he was deeply moved, **34** *"Where have you*[pl] *laid him?"*

They said[p], *"We'll show you."*

35Jesus began to cry.

36The Jews said, *"See how much he loved him."*

37Some said, *"Couldn't this man that gave sight to the blind man have kept this man from dying?"* **Jn 11:29-37**

38When Jesus got to the tomb, he was deeply moved. It was a cave with a stone lying against it. **39**He said[p], *"Take the stone away."*

Martha said[p], *"Lord, by now he smells; he's been dead four days."*

40Jesus said[p] to her, *"Didn't I tell you that if you believe, you'd see how great God is?"*

They took the stone away. **41**He looked up and said, *"Father, thank you for listening to me.* **42***I know you always do, but I've said it for the crowd standing here so they would believe you've sent me."* **43**Then he shouted, *"Lazarus, come out!"* **44**The dead man came out wrapped hand to foot with strips of cloth; his face was wrapped in a facecloth.

Jesus said[p], *"Unwrap him and set him free."* **Jn 11:38-44**

Plots to Kill Jesus

45Many Jews that came to Mary believed in Jesus when they saw what he did; **46**but some of them went and told the Pharisees what he'd done. **47**So the high priests and the Pharisees called the Sanhedrin into session. *"What are we going to do? This man is doing lots of signs.* **48***If we let him keep doing this, everybody's going to believe in him, and the Romans will come and take away our place and nation."*

49Caiaphas, high priest that year, said, *"There's something you don't understand:* **50***It's to your advantage that one man die for the people so the whole nation doesn't perish."* **51**He didn't say this on his own; but as high priest that year, he prophesied that Jesus would die for the nation, **52**and not just for the nation, but that he'd gather into one *body* the children of God scattered abroad. **53**From then on, they conspired to put him to death. **54**So Jesus quit moving around openly among the Jews and went away to the territory close to the desert—to a town called Ephraim and stayed there with his disciples. **Jn 11:45-54**

Jesus' Arrival in Bethany;
The Anointing by Mary

[55]Now the Jews' Passover was coming up, and people from around Ephraim went up to Jerusalem ahead of time to purify themselves ceremonially. [56]People were looking for Jesus and saying to one another in the Temple, *"What do you think? Surely he won't come to the festival."* [57]The chief priests and the Pharisees had passed laws that anybody that knew where he was should report it so they could arrest him. **Jn 11:55-57**

12[:1]Six days before Passover, Jesus arrived at Bethany, where Lazarus lived that Jesus had raised from the dead. [2]They made him a meal there. Martha was waiting on him and Lazarus was reclining at table with him. [3]Mary took twelve ounces of ointment—very expensive pure nard—and poured it on Jesus' feet and started wiping them with her hair. The scent from the ointment filled the house.

[4]Judas Iscariot, Jesus' disciple that would betray him, said[p], [5]*"Why didn't she sell that ointment for 300 denarii [up to a year's wages] and give it to the poor?"* ([6]He didn't say that because he cared about the poor, but because he was a thief. He took care of the money pouch and had been stealing from it.)

[7]Jesus said, *"Let her keep it for my burial.* [8]*You always have poor people around; you won't always have[p] me around."*

[9]A large crowd of the Jews found out that Jesus was there. They hadn't come just because of him, but to see Lazarus. [10]The chief priests planned to kill Lazarus, too, because lots of Jews were [11]believing in Jesus because of him. **Jn 12:1-11**

The Triumphal Entry

[12]The next day the huge crowd that attended the festival heard Jesus was coming into Jerusalem, [13]and took fronds from the palm trees and went out to meet him, shouting,

"'Hosanna!
Blessed be the One that's coming in the name of the LORD,'
the King of Israel!" **[Ps 118:25-26].**

[14]Jesus found a young donkey and rode on it, like scripture says,

[15]***"Don't be afraid, people of Zion.***
Look! Your king's coming,
riding on a donkey's colt" **[Zech 9:9].**

([16]His disciples didn't understand what was going on; but when he was glorified, they remembered that the scripture had said these things about him and that people had done these things to him.) [17]The crowd that was with him when he called Lazarus out of the tomb, was telling about it. [18]That's also the reason that the crowd met him: they heard he'd done that sign. [19]The Pharisees said to each other, *"See how you don't get anywhere. The world has gone after him!"* **Jn 12:12-19**

Sermon on the Significance of Life and Death

20Some Greeks that went up to worship at the festival **21**came to Philip, who was from Bethsaida in Galilee, *"Sir, we'd like to see Jesus."*

22Philip went[p] and spoke[p] to Andrew, and the two of them spoke[p] to Jesus.

23Jesus answered[p] them, *"It's time to honor the Son of Man.* **24***Unless a grain of wheat falls on the ground and dies, it's alone. But if it dies, it yields lots of grains.* **25***Those who love their life will lose it; those who look on past their life in the world will keep it for eternal life.* **26***If people serve me, they need to follow me, and they'll be where I am. If they serve me, the Father will honor them.*

27 *"I'm torn now: Will I ask the Father to save me from this hour? But this is why I came to this hour.* **28***Father, glorify your name."* **Jn 12:20-28a**

A voice came out of the sky, *"I've glorified it, and I'll glorify it again."*

29The crowd standing there heard it and said it had thundered.

Others said, *"An angel spoke to him."*

30Jesus responded, *"That voice didn't come for my sake so much as for yours.* **31***Now judgment is in the world; the ruler of this world will be thrown out.* **32***And if I'm lifted up from the ground, I'll draw everyone to me."* **33**(He said that to indicate how he'd die.)

34The crowd responded, *"We've heard out of the Law that Messiah will remain[p] forever. How do you say the Son of Man has to be lifted up? Who is this 'Son of Man'?"*

35Jesus said, *"The light's still among you for a little while. Walk while you have it so darkness doesn't overtake you. People that walk in the dark can't tell where they're going.* **36***While you have light, believe in it so it will enlighten you."* After saying that, Jesus went away and was hidden *from them*. **Jn 12:28b-36**

37Despite doing so many signs in their presence, they weren't believing in him—**38**just like Isaiah the prophet said,

"LORD, who has believed our report, and
who has the arm of the LORD been revealed to?" **[Is 53:1]**

39Here's the reason they couldn't believe: Isaiah said again,

40 ***"He blinded their eyes***
and hardened their heart,
so they couldn't see with their eyes,
understand with their heart,
be converted,
and he would heal them" **[Is 6:10].**

41Isaiah said that because he saw the Messiah's glory and spoke about him. **42**Nevertheless a number even of the rulers did believe in him, but because of the Pharisees they didn't admit it and get excommunicated from the synagogue. **43**They cared more about honor from people than glory from God.

44Jesus shouted, *"Whoever believes in me doesn't* just *believe in me, but in the One that sent me.* **45***Whoever sees me sees the One that sent me.* **46***I've come to the world as a light so nobody that believes in me will be in the dark.* **47***I don't condemn anybody that hears what I'm saying and doesn't do it. I didn't come to condemn the world, but to save it.* **48***People that reject me do have something that will condemn them in the end: the message I'm delivering.* **49***I haven't spoken on my own. The Father has told me what to say.* **50***I know that what he says leads to eternal life; so I say what he's told me to say."* **Jn 12:37-50**

Jesus Washes the Disciples' Feet

13:1 Before the Passover Festival, Jesus knew the time had come *for him* to go to the Father. He loved his own that were in the world and loved them to the end. **2**During the supper, the devil had already prompted Judas, Simon Iscariot's son, to betray him. **3**Jesus knew the Father had turned everything over to him. **4**He got[p] up from supper, laid[p] his outer clothes aside, and took a towel and hung it over his *shoulder*. **5**He put[p] some water in a basin and started washing his disciples' feet and drying them with the towel.

6When he came[p] to Simon Peter, Peter said[p], *"Lord, you're going to wash my feet?"*

7Jesus answered, *"You don't understand right now what I'm doing, but you will in a little bit."*

8Peter said[p], "*Don't you <u>ever</u> wash <u>my</u> feet!"*

"*If I don't wash you, you don't have anything to do with me."*

9Simon Peter said[p], *"Lord, don't wash just my feet, but my hands and head too."*

10Jesus said[p], *"Someone that's taken a bath doesn't need to wash anything but his feet. He's clean everywhere else. You're[pl] clean, but not all of you."* **11**(He knew who would betray him; that's why he said, *"You[pl] are not all clean."*) **Jn 13:1-11**

12When he'd washed their feet and put his outer clothes back on, he sat down again,

> *"Do you understand what I've done?* **13***You call me 'Rabbi' and 'Lord,' and rightly so.* **14***If I—'Lord' and 'Rabbi'—washed your feet, then you should wash each other's feet.* **15***I've given you an example to do like I've done to you.* **16***A servant has it no better than his master; a messenger has it no better than the one that sent him.* **17***If you understand that, you're blessed if you act that way.* **18***I'm not talking about all of you. I know who I've chosen, but like the scripture says:*
>
> ***'The one that eats my food***
> ***has lifted up his heel against me'*** **[Ps 41:9]**.

[19]*From now on, I'll tell you before things happen so when they do, you'll believe who I am.* [20]*Whoever receives somebody I send, receives me, and whoever receives me receives the One that sent me."* **Jn 13:12-20**

Judas Identified as Traitor

[21]After he said that, he began to feel deeply distressed, *"One of you is going to betray me."*

[22]The disciples looked at one another at a loss who he meant. [23]One disciple was reclining at table in front of Jesus—one that Jesus loved. [24]Simon Peter motioned to him to find out who Jesus meant. [25]So he leaned back on Jesus and said[p], *"Lord, who is it?"*

[26]Jesus answered[p], *"The one I dip the piece of bread and give it to."* He dipped it and handed[p] it to Judas. [27]After the piece of bread, Satan entered Judas. Jesus said[p], *"Do what you're going[p] to do."* [28]Nobody at the table knew why he spoke to him. [29]Since Judas had the money pouch, some supposed Jesus meant to go buy something we needed for the festival or to give something to the poor. [30]He took the piece of bread and went out immediately. It was dark.

Jn 13:21-30

The Disciples Warned

[31]When Judas had gone out, Jesus said[p], *"Now God will glorify the Son of Man, and the Son of Man will glorify him,* [32]*and God will glorify him soon.* [33]*Little children, I'll be with you a little while yet. You'll look for me and, like I told the Jews, 'You can't go where I'm going'; now I'm telling you.* [34]*I'm commanding you something new: love one another like I've loved you.* [35]*If you love one another, people can tell you're my disciples."*

[36]Simon Peter said[p], *"Where are you going, Lord?"*

"Where I'm going you[pl] can't go now; you'll go later."

[37]Peter said[p], *"Why can't I follow you now? I'll lay down my life for you."*

[38]Jesus answered, *"Will you? Truth is, before a rooster crows, you're going to deny three times that you know me."* **Jn 13:31-38**

Jesus' Farewell Discourse

14:1 *"Don't worry. You believe in God; believe in me too.* [2]*There are many rooms in my Father's house. If that weren't so, I would've told you, because I'm going to get a place ready for you.* [3]*When I've done that, I'll come back[p] to get you so you can be with me.* [4]*You know how to get to where I'm going."*

[5]Thomas said[p], *"We don't know where you're going. How can we know how to get there?"*

[6]*"I'm the way, truth, and life. No one gets to the Father except through me.* [7]*If you've come to know me, you'll know my Father too. From now on you know him and have seen him."*

[8]Philip said[h[], *"Lord, show us the Father; that'll be enough."*

9 *"Have I been with you*[pl] *all this time, Philip, and you*[sg] *haven't seen* <u>*me*</u>*?*
Whoever has seen <u>*me*</u> *has seen the* <u>*Father*</u>*. How can you*[sg] *say, 'Show us the*
Father'? **10** *Don't you*[sg] *believe I'm in the Father and the Father's in me? What I*
say I'm not saying on my own, but the Father that's in me is working through me.
11 *Believe*[pl] *that I'm in the Father and the Father's in me. If not, believe*[pl] *because*
of the things I do. **12** *Whoever believes in me will do what I do and more because*
I'm going to the Father. **13** *I'll do whatever you ask in my name so I can praise the*
Father. **14** I repeat, *if you ask anything in my name, I'll do it.* **Jn 14:1-14**

15 *"If you love me, you'll do what I tell you.* **16** *I'll ask the Father to give*
you another Helper to be with you permanently. **17** *He's the truth-revealing Spirit*
that the world can't receive because they don't see him or know him. But you
know him because he stays with you and will be in you. **18** *I won't leave you as*
orphans; I'll come to you. **19** *In a little while, the world won't see me, but you'll*
see me. You'll be living because I'll be living. **20** *Then you'll know I'm in the*
Father and you're in me and I'm in you. **21** *The ones that love me are the ones that*
have my commands and keep them. My Father will love the ones that love me, and
I'll love them and show myself to them." **Jn 14:15-21**

22 Judas (not Iscariot) said[p], *"Lord, what's happened that you're going to show yourself to us, but not to the world?"*

23 Jesus answered, *"If people love me, they'll follow what I say, and my*
Father will love them. We'll come and make our home in them. **24** *People that*
don't love me, don't follow what I say. The message you hear is not mine, but the
Father's.

25 *"I've said this while I'm with you.* **26** *The Helper—the Holy Spirit the*
Father will send in my name—will teach you everything and remind you of what
<u>*I've*</u> *told you.* **27** *I'm leaving my peace with you, not the kind the world gives. Don't*
worry or be afraid. **28** *You heard me say I'm going away, but I'll come back to*
you. If you loved me, you'd be happy that I'm going to the Father because the
Father is greater than I am.

29 *"I've told you now before it happens so when it does, you'll believe.*
30 *Lots of things I'm not going to tell you now because the ruler of this world is on*
his way, and he doesn't have anything to do with me. **31** *But I'm doing what the*
Father told me to do so the world can know I love him.

"Let's go." **Jn 14:22-31**

The Parable About a Vine

15:1 *"I'm the true vine; my Father is the vinedresser.* 2 *He cuts off every branch in me that doesn't bear fruit. He prunes every branch that does bear fruit so it'll bear more fruit.* 3 *The message I've spoken to you has already pruned you.* 4 *Stay in me and I in you. A branch can't bear fruit by itself; it has to stay connected to the vine; you can't either unless you stay in me.* 5 *I'm the vine; you're the branches. If you stay in me and I in you, you'll bear lots of fruit. You can't bear any by yourselves.* 6 *If you don't stay in me, you're cut off like a branch that dries up and people burn up.* 7 *If you stay in me and what I say stays in you, ask whatever you want, and you'll receive it.* 8 *This is what honors my Father: you becoming my disciples and bearing lots of fruit.* 9 *I've loved you like the Father has loved me. Stay in my love.* 10 *If you do what I tell you, you'll be staying in my love like I've done what my Father told me and stay in his love.* **Jn 15:1-10**

11 *"I've told you that so you can have the complete joy I have.* 12 *This is my command: love one another like I've loved you.* 13 *Nobody loves more than a person that lays down his life for his friends.* 14 *You're my friends if you do what I tell you.* 15 *I don't consider you servants anymore; servants don't know what their master's doing. I consider you friends because I tell you everything I've heard from my Father.* 16 *You didn't choose me; I chose you and appointed you to bear fruit that lasts, so my Father will give you whatever you ask for in my name.* 17 *I'm commanding these things so you'll love one another.*

18 *"If the world hates you, understand that it hated me first.* 19 *If you were like the world, it would love its own kind. But because you're not like it, it hates you—but I've chosen you out of it.* 20 *Remember that I told you servants are not better off than their master. If they persecuted me, they'll persecute you. If they kept my word, they'll keep yours.* 21 *They'll do that to you because of me, because they don't know the One that sent me.* **Jn 15:11-21**

22 *"If I hadn't come and spoken to them, they wouldn't be guilty; but now they don't have any excuse for their sin.* 23 *Whoever hates me hates my Father too.* 24 *If I hadn't done among them what no one else has done, they wouldn't be guilty; but now they've seen and hated both me and my Father.* 25 *What they've done fulfills what their Law says,* ***'They hated me for no reason'*** **[Ps 35:19; 69:4]**.

26 *"When the Helper comes that I'll send from the Father—the truth-revealing Spirit—he'll speak on my behalf.* 27 *You will, too, because you've been with me since I began* my ministry. **Jn 15:22-27**

Further Solemn Instruction

16:[1] *"I've told you that, so you won't get caught off guard.* [2]*They'll excommunicate you from the synagogues, but—more than that—the time's coming when anybody that kills you will think they're serving God.* [3]*That's because they don't know the Father or me.* [4]*So when it happens, remember that I told you it would.*

"I didn't tell you those things at first because I was with you. [5]*But now I'm going to the One that sent me, and you don't need to ask where I'm going.* [6]Because *I've told you* that*, you feel sad.* [7]*But it's to your benefit that I go away because the Helper wouldn't be coming to you. If I go, I'll send him.* [8]*When he comes, he'll convict the world of sin and goodness and judgment—*[9]*of sin because they don't believe in me;* [10]*of goodness because I'm going to the Father and you won't see me anymore;* [11]*and of judgment because the ruler of this world has been judged.* **Jn 16:1-11**

[12]*"I still have so much to tell you, but you can't deal with it now.* [13]*But when the truth-revealing Spirit comes, he'll lead you in all truth. He won't speak on his own; he'll tell you what he's heard and what's going to happen.* [14]*He'll honor me because he'll take from me and tell you.* [15]*Everything the Father has is mine. That's why I've said the Spirit will take from me and tell you.*

[16]*"In a little while you won't see me; and a little while after that you'll see me again."*

[17]Some disciples said to one another, *"What's this, 'In a little while you won't see me; in a little while you'll see me again'; and 'because I'm going to the Father'?* [18]*What's this 'little while' mean? We don't understand it."*

[19]Jesus knew they wanted to ask him,

"Are you talking about what I said, 'In a little while, you won't see me; in a little while, you'll see me again'? [20]*You'll mourn, but the world will be happy. You'll grieve, but your grief will turn to joy.* [21]*When a woman's in labor, she has grief; but when she has the child, she doesn't think about the anguish anymore because of the joy of bringing a person into the world.* [22]*You'll*[p] *grieve now, but I'll see you again, and you'll be happy. Nobody will take*[p] *your happiness away.* [23]*At that time you won't be asking me for anything. Whatever you ask the Father for in my name* now *he'll give you.* [24]*Up till now you haven't asked for anything in my name. Ask and you'll receive so you'll be completely happy.* **Jn 16:12-24**

[25]*"I've been using illustrations. The time's coming when I'll speak plainly about the Father.* [26]*Then you'll ask in my name; and, rest assured, I'll ask the Father for you.* [27]*The Father himself loves you because you love me and believe I*

came from him. **28***I did come from him to the world. Again, I'm leaving the world and going back to him."*

29The disciples said[p], *"Now you're speaking clearly.* **30***Now we know that you know everything and don't need anybody to ask you. That's why we believe you've come from God."*

31Jesus responded, *"Do you?* **32***The time's coming—it's almost here—when you'll all scatter and leave me alone. But I'm not alone, because the Father's with me.* **33***I've told you these things so you'll have peace. In the world you have trouble, but take heart, I've overcome the world."* **Jn 16:25-33**

The High Priestly Prayer

17:1 Jesus looked up to heaven,

"Father, it's time. Honor your Son so he can honor you. **2***You gave him the right to give eternal life to everybody you've given him.* **3***Eternal life means knowing you, the only true God, and Jesus the Messiah you sent.* **4***I've honored you on the earth and finished the work you gave me to do.* **5**Now*, glorify me and yourself with the glory I had with you before the earth existed.*

6*"I've shown you to the ones you gave me out of the world, and they've kept your word.* **7***Now they know that the message I've given them came from you,* **8***They know that I really did come from you, and believe you sent me.* **9***I'm not asking about the world* right now*, but about the ones you gave me.* **10***My things are yours and yours are mine, and they've honored me.* **11***I'm not in the world anymore, but they are, and I'm coming to you. Holy Father, keep them in your name—which you've given me—so they can be one like we are.* **12***When I was with them, I kept them in your name, and none of them have perished except the one headed for destruction—to fulfill scripture.* **13***I'm saying these things so they can fully experience my joy.* **14***The world hates them because they're not like it.* **15***I'm not asking you to take them out of the world, but to keep them from the evil one.* **16***They're not like the world as I'm not.* **17***I've sanctified them with the truth—with your message.* **18***As you sent me into the world, I've sent them into it.* **19***I've sanctified myself for them so the truth can sanctify them.*

20*"Father, I'm not just asking that these be one, but that their converts also be one.* **21***That way the world will know you sent me.* **22***I've given them the honor you gave me so they can be one like we are—***23***so the world can know you love them like you love me.* **24***What you've given me I want to be with me where I am so they can see the honor you gave me because you loved me before the world existed.*

[25] *"Righteous Father, the world doesn't know you, but I know you, and these know you sent me.* [26]*I'll continue to make you known to them so the love you loved me with can be in them like I am."* **Jn 17:1-26**

Agony in the Garden;
The Arrest; Peter's First Denial

18:[1]When Jesus finished, he went out with his disciples past the wadi Kidron to an orchard [2]Judas knew about, because Jesus often went there with his disciples. [3]Judas had received a cohort as well as officers from the chief priests and Pharisees. They came there with lanterns, torches, and weapons. [4]Jesus knew what was coming and went out to meet them, *"Who are you looking for?"*

[5] *"Jesus the Nazarene."*

"I'm Jesus." (Judas was standing with them.) [6]When he said, *"I'm Jesus,"* they drew back and fell to the ground.

[7]He asked them again, *"Who are you looking for?"*

"Jesus the Nazarene."

[8] *"I told you I'm Jesus. If you're looking for me, let these go"* ([9]like he'd said, *"I haven't lost any you gave me."*). **Jn 18:1-9**

[10]Then Simon Peter, who had a sword, drew it and struck the high priest's servant and cut off his right ear. His name was Malchus.

[11]Jesus said, *"Put your sword back in its sheath. Am I not going to drink the cup the Father gave me to drink?"*

[12]Then the cohort, the tribune, and the officers of the Jews arrested Jesus and bound him. [13]They led him to Annas first because he was the father-in-law of Caiaphas, the high priest that year. [14]He's the Caiaphas who counseled the Jews that it was expedient for one man to die for the people.

[15]Simon Peter and another disciple followed Jesus. That disciple was acquainted with the high priest and went in with Jesus to the courtyard. [16]Peter stood outside at the gate. The other disciple went out and spoke to the gatekeeper and brought Peter in.

[17]The gatekeeper, a servant woman, said[p] to Peter, *"You're not one of this man's disciples, are you?"*

"No."

[18]Servants and officers were standing there. They'd built a charcoal fire because it was cold, and they were warming themselves. Peter was standing with them, warming himself.

Jn 18:10-18

The Trial Before Annas

[19]The high priest asked Jesus about his disciples and his teaching.

[20]He answered, *"I spoke openly to the world and taught constantly in synagogue and in the Temple, where the Jews all gather. I haven't done anything secretly.* [21]*Why ask me? Ask the ones that heard me. They know what I said."*

[22]One of the officers standing by slapped him, *"Do you answer the high priest that way?"*

[23]*"If I said something wrong, what was it? If I didn't, what are you hitting me for?"*

[24]Then Annas sent him bound to Caiaphas the high priest. **Jn 18:19-24**

Peter's Final Denials

[25]While Simon Peter was standing there, warming himself, *the officers* said, *"You're not one of his disciples too, are you?"*

"No."

[26]One of the high priest's servants, a relative of the one whose ear Peter had cut off, said[p], *"I saw you in the orchard with him, didn't I?"*

[27]Peter denied it again. Immediately a rooster crowed. **Jn 18:25-27**

The Trials Before Pilate

[28]They led[p] Jesus from Caiaphas to the Praetorium. It was early. They didn't go into the Praetorium themselves. They didn't want to defile themselves and not be able to eat the Passover. [29]So Pilate came out to them, *"What charges are you bringing against this man?"*

[30]*"If he wasn't a criminal, we wouldn't have delivered him to you."*

[31]Pilate said, *"You take him and judge him by your Law."*

"It's illegal for us to <u>execute</u> anybody" ([32]fulfilling Jesus' statement about how he would die).

[33]Pilate went back into the Praetorium and called Jesus, *"Are you the King of the Jews?"*

[34]*"Are you asking that yourself, or have other people prompted you?"*

[35]*"I'm not a Jew, am I? Your nation and the chief priests delivered you to me. What have you done?"*

[36]*"My 'kingdom' is not an earthly kingdom. If it was, my servants would be fighting to keep me from being delivered to the Jews."*

[37]*"So you're a 'king' then?"*

"Yes, I'm a 'king.' That's why I was born—why I came into the world—to speak about truth. Everybody that's committed to truth listens to me."

[38]Pilate said[p], *"What's truth?"*

When he said that, he went out to the Jews, *"He's not guilty of anything.* [39]*You have a custom that I release a prisoner to you at Passover. Do you want me to release 'the King of the Jews'?"*

[40]They shouted again, *"Not him! Barabbas!"* (an insurgent). **Jn 18:28-40**

19:[1]Then Pilate took Jesus and had him flogged. [2]The soldiers twisted thorns together to make a crown and put it on his head. They put a purple robe on him [3]and started coming up to him and saying, *"Hail, King of the Jews!"* and slapping him.

[4]Pilate brought him out again, *"I'm bringing him out to let you know I don't find him guilty of anything."* [5]So he brought Jesus out wearing the crown of thorns and the purple robe. *"Look at the man!"*

[6]When the chief priests and officers saw him, they shouted, *"Crucify him! Crucify him!"*

Pilate said[p], *"<u>You</u> take him and crucify him. I don't find him guilty of anything."*

[7]The Jews answered, *"According to our Law he should die because he's claimed to be God's Son."*

[8]When Pilate heard that, he got more concerned. [9]He went into the Praetorium and said[p] to Jesus, *"Where are you from?"*

Jesus didn't answer him. **Jn 19:1-9**

[10] *"You're not going to talk[p] to me? You know, don't you, that I can release you or crucify you?"*

[11] *"You wouldn't have any authority over me if God hadn't let you have it. So the one that betrayed me to you has committed a worse sin."*

[12]Pilate tried to release him over that comment.

But the Jews shouted, *"If you release him, you're no friend of Caesar! Anybody that makes himself king is rebelling against Caesar!"*

[13]When Pilate heard that, he brought Jesus out and sat on the judgement seat at a place called The Pavement (Gabbatha in Hebrew). [14]It was Preparation *Day* during Passover *week*, about the sixth hour. He said to the Jews, *"Look, your 'king'!"*

[15]They yelled, *"Away with him! Away with him! Crucify him!"*

"You want me to crucify your 'king'!?"

The chief priests answered, *"We don't have any king but Caesar."*

[16]Then he delivered him over to be crucified. **Jn 19:10-16**

The Way to Golgotha

[17]They took Jesus, and he went out carrying his own cross to The Place of the Skull ("Golgotha" in Hebrew). [18]They crucified him along with two others, one on each side of him.

Jn 19:17-18

The Death of Messiah

[19-20]Pilate wrote an inscription in Hebrew, Latin, and Greek, and put it on the cross: *"Jesus the Nazarene, King of the Jews."* A lot of Jews read it because the place where they crucified him was close to the city.

[21]The chief priests said to Pilate, *"Don't write 'King of the Jews,' but that he said, 'I am King of the Jews.'"*

[22]Pilate answered, *"What I've written I've written."*

[23]After the soldiers had crucified Jesus, they divided his clothes four ways, one for each soldier—except for the tunic. It was seamless, woven from the top throughout. [24]They said, *"Let's not tear it apart; cast lots for it."* So they did—fulfilling the scripture,

"They divided up my garments among them,
and cast lots for my clothes" **[Ps 22:18].** **Jn 19:19-24**

[25]Beside Jesus' cross stood his mother, the sister of his mother; Mary, wife of Clopas; and Mary the Magdalene. [26]When he saw his mother and the disciple he loved standing there, he said[p] to his mother, *"Your son."* [27]and to the disciple, *"Your mother."* From that time the disciple took her to his home.

[28]Since he knew they'd done everything that fulfilled the scripture, Jesus said[p], *"I'm thirsty."* [29]A jar was sitting there full of sour wine. They put a sponge full of it on a hyssop branch and held it up to his mouth. [30]When he'd taken it, he said, *"It's done!"* He dropped his head and quit breathing. **Jn 19:25-30**

The Burial of Jesus

[31]Since it was Preparation *Day*, the Jews asked Pilate to break the legs of the crucified men and take *their bodies* away so they wouldn't be on the cross on a Sabbath. (That Sabbath was a high day.) [32]So the soldiers broke the legs of the first and of the other man crucified with him. [33]When they saw that Jesus was already dead, they didn't break his legs. [34]One soldier thrust his spear into Jesus' side, and blood and water drained out immediately. [35](The one that watched *it himself* has submitted this report. He knows what he's telling you is true so you can believe *it* too.) [36]That reminds *us* of the scripture, ***"Don't break any of its bones"*** **[Ex 12:46; Num 9:12; (Ps 34:20)].** [37]Another scripture says, ***"They'll look at the one they speared"*** **[Zech 12:10].**

[38]After that, Joseph of Arimathea—a disciple of Jesus secretly for fear of the Jews—asked Pilate to let him take Jesus' body, and Pilate granted it. He went and took his body away. [39]Nicodemus—who at the first came to Jesus at night—also brought some 70 pounds of myrrh mixed with aloes. [40]They wrapped his body in linen wrappings along with the aromatic spices, which is the Jews' burial custom. [41]A garden close to where they crucified Jesus had a new, unused tomb in it. [42]That's where they put Jesus because it was the Jews' Preparation *Day*.

Jn 19:31-42

The Resurrection of Messiah;
The Report of the Women;
The Visit of Peter and John

20:1On the first day of the week, Mary the Magdalene came[p] to the tomb while it was still pretty dark and saw that the stone was rolled away from it. 2She ran[p] to Simon Peter and the disciple Jesus loved, *"They've taken the Lord out of the tomb, and we don't know where they put him."*

3So Peter and the other disciple ran to the tomb. 4The other disciple outran Peter, 5stooped down and saw[p] the linen wrappings, but didn't go in.

6Then Simon Peter got[p] there and went on in and saw[p] the linen wrappings 7and the facecloth they'd put over his head. It wasn't with the linen wrappings; it was folded up by itself. 8Then the other disciple went in and looked and believed. 9They didn't yet understand the scripture that he had to rise from the dead. 10So they went back to their quarters. **Jn 20:1-10**

Appearance to Mary the Magdalene

11Mary stood outside the tomb crying. While she was crying, she stooped down and looked inside the tomb. 12She saw[p] two angels in white, sitting at the head and foot of where Jesus' body had been.

13They said[p], *"Dear woman, why are you crying?"*

"They've taken my Lord, and I don't know where they've put him." 14When she'd said that, she turned around and saw Jesus standing there, but didn't recognize him.

15He said[p], *"Why are you crying? Who are you looking for?"*

She thought he was the gardener, *"Sir, if you've carried him off, tell me where you've put him, and I'll take him away."*

16 *"Mary."*

She turned around and said[p] in Aramaic, *"Rabboni (Teacher)!"*

17Jesus said[p], *"You don't need to hang onto me. I haven't gone up to the Father yet. Go tell my disciples I'm going up to my Father and yours[pl], my God and yours[pl]."*

18Mary went[p] and told them, "*I've seen the Lord!"* and what he'd told her to say.

Jn 20:11-18

Appearance to the Ten

19That evening, the first day of the week, the disciples had locked the doors for fear of the Jews. Jesus came and stood among them, *"Hello."* 20He showed them his hands and side. They were excited to see him.

21He said again, *"Peace to you. I'm sending you like the Father sent me."* 22Then he blew on them, *"Receive the Holy Spirit.* 23*The ones whose sins you forgive are forgiven; the ones whose sins you hold against them are held against them."* **Jn 20: 19-23**

Appearance to the Eleven

24Thomas, one of the Twelve, called Didymus, wasn't with them when Jesus came. The other disciples told him, *"We've seen the Lord!"*

25But Thomas said, *"Unless I see the imprints from the spikes in his wrists and put my finger in them and put my hand in his side, I'm not believing* it*."*

26A week later, his disciples were behind locked doors again. Jesus came and stood among them and said, *"Hello."* **27**He said[p] to Thomas, *"Look at my wrists; put your finger here. Put your hand in my side. Don't keep on not believing."*

28Thomas answered[p], *"My Lord and my God!"*

29Jesus said[p], *"You believe because you've seen. They're blessed who believe and haven't seen."*

30Jesus did an endless number of signs in front of his disciples that I haven't recorded here. **31**I've written these down so you'll believe he's the Messiah, God's Son, and have life by believing in him. **Jn 20: 24-31**

Appearance to Seven by Lake Galilee

21:1 After that, Jesus appeared again to his disciples at Lake Tiberias. **2**Simon Peter, Thomas, Nathanael from Cana in Galilee, Zebedee's sons, and two other disciples were together.

3Simon Peter said[p], *"I'm going fishing."*

"We'll go with you."

They went out and got in the boat, and that night didn't catch anything. **4**When morning came, Jesus stood on the shore, but the disciples didn't know it was him.

5 *"Fellows, you haven't had anything to eat, have you?"*

"No."

6 *"Throw the net on the right side of the boat; you'll find some."*

So they did, and they couldn't haul it in for the number of fish.

7The disciple Jesus loved said[p] to Peter, *"It's the Lord!"*

When Simon Peter heard that, he put on his outer garment (he'd stripped down) and dived into the lake. **8**The rest of the disciples came in the small boat because they were only about 300 feet from shore, dragging the net full of fish. **9**When they got out of the boat, they saw[p] a charcoal fire with a fish and a loaf laid on it.

10Jesus told[p] them, *"Bring some of the fish you just caught."*

11Simon Peter got up and pulled the net up onto land full of big fish—153. Although there were so many, the net didn't tear.

12Jesus said[p], *"Come eat breakfast."*

None of the disciples dared to ask him who he was; they knew it was the Lord. **13**He gave[p] them the bread and fish. **14**That was a third time Jesus appeared to his disciples after he resurrected.

15When they'd finished breakfast, Jesus said[p], *"Simon* Bar*jonah, do you love me more than these do?"*

"Yes, Lord, you know I love you."

"Tend my lambs."

16He said[p] the second time, *"Simon* Bar*jonah, do you love me?"*

"Yes, Lord, you know I love you."

"Tend my sheep."

17He said[p] the third time, *"Simon Barjonah, do you love me?"*

It pained Peter that Jesus asked a third time, *"Do you love me?"* He said[p], *"Lord, you know everything; you know I love you."*

18Jesus told him, *"Tend my sheep. When you were younger, you'd get dressed and walk wherever you wanted to. When you get old, you'll stretch out your hands, and somebody else will dress you and carry you where you don't want to go."* **19**(He said that to indicate by what kind of death he would honor God.) When he'd said that, he told him. *"Follow me."*

20Peter turned around and saw[p] the disciple Jesus loved, following, the one that leaned back on Jesus' chest at the supper and asked, *"Lord, who's going to betray you?"* **21**Peter said[p], *"What about him?"*

22Jesus said[p], *"If I want him to live till I come back, what's that to you? You follow me."*

23So the rumor got out among the believers that he wouldn't die. But Jesus didn't say he wouldn't die; he said, *"If I want him to live till I come back, what's that to you?"* **Jn 21:1-23**

Epilogue

24I'm the disciple that wrote this *book*. I know what I'm telling you is true. **25**Jesus did a lot of other things too, but if every one was written down, I suppose the world couldn't hold all the books. **Jn 21:24-25**

ACTS OF APOSTLES

Jesus Promises the Spirit

1:1 In the earlier volume, most excellent Theophilus, I gave an account of what Jesus did and taught **2**up to when by the Holy Spirit he commissioned the apostles he'd chosen. **3**During 40 days after he suffered, he showed himself alive to them in a variety of unmistakable proofs and discussed God's kingdom. **4**While he was eating with them, he told them to wait in Jerusalem for *"the Father's promise I told you about:* **5***John immersed in water, but you'll be 'immersed' in the Holy Spirit in a few days."* **Acts 1:1-5**

The Ascension of Jesus

6While they were with him, they asked, "*Lord, is that when you'll restore Israel's independence?"*

7*"You[pl] aren't to know the dates and circumstances the Father has scheduled by his authority.* **8***You'll receive power when the Holy Spirit comes on you, and you'll represent me in Jerusalem, Judaea, Samaria, and all over the world."*

9Then he ascended and a cloud took him out of sight. **10**While they were staring up at the sky, two men in dazzling clothes stood next to them. **11***"Galileans, why stand here staring at the sky? He'll come back the way you've watched him go."*

12They went back to Jerusalem from the hill called *The Mount* of Olives, about six-tenths of a mile from the city. **13**When they went inside, they got together in the upstairs room: Peter, John, James, Andrew, Philip, Thomas, Bartholomew, Matthew, James son of Alphaeus, Simon Zelotes; and Judas son of James. **14**They were praying with the women there; with Mary, Jesus' mother; and with his brothers. **Acts 1:6-14**

Choosing Judas' Replacement

15During that time Peter stood up among the brothers. (There was a crowd of about 120 there.)

> **16***"Brothers, it needed to happen what the Holy Spirit predicted through David about Judas, who guided the ones that arrested Jesus.* **17***He had a part in this ministry.* (**18**He bought a field with the payment for his sin. He swelled up and burst open, and his entrails gushed out. **19**Everybody in Jerusalem heard about it, so in their *[Aramaic]* language they called that field Haceldama, Field of Blood.) **20***Scripture says in the Psalms,*
>
> ***'Let his house be deserted***
> ***and nobody live in it'*** **[Ps 69:25]**;
>
> *and,*
>
> ***'Let someone else have his office of oversight'*** **[Ps 109:8]**.

[21-22]*So we need to choose a replacement to serve as a witness with us about the resurrection of the Lord Jesus, someone that's been with us from* the time of *John's baptizing to the Lord's ascension."* **Acts 1:15-22**

[23]They put forward Matthias and Joseph Barsabbas called Justus. [24]They prayed, *"Lord, you know everybody's heart. Show which one you've chosen* [25]*to receive this apostleship that Judas left to go to his own place."* [26]They cast lots, and *the lot* fell on Matthias; he joined the eleven apostles. **Acts 1:23-26**

The Spirit's Coming

2:[1]When Pentecost came, they were together. [2]All of a sudden a roar from the sky like a violent windstorm filled the house where they were sitting. [3]Divided tongues like fire sat on each one of them. [4]The Holy Spirit filled them, and they started speaking in other languages as the Spirit enabled them. **Acts 2:1-4**

[5]Devout Jews from many countries were living in Jerusalem. [6]When that roar erupted, the crowd came together bewildered. Each one was surprised to hear them speaking in their own language.

[7]*"Aren't these men Galileans?* [8]*How can we be hearing our native languages?* [9]*Parthians, Medes, Elamites; people living in Mesopotamia, Judaea, and Cappadocia, Pontus and Asia,* [10]*Phrygia and Pamphylia, Egypt and the parts of Libya near Cyrene; Roman visitors,* [11]*Jews and proselytes; Cretans and Arabians—we're hearing them speak in our own languages about those outstanding things God has done."*

[12]They were surprised and asked each other what was happening.

[13]Others joked, *"They're drunk on sweet new wine."* **Acts 2:5-13**

Peter's Sermon on Pentecost

[14]Peter, standing with the eleven, spoke up,

"Judeans and you that are living in Jerusalem, listen. [15]*These men aren't drunk like you're trying to make out; it's only 9 o'clock.* [16]*This is what the prophet Joel was referring to,*

[17]***"In the last days,"*** *God says,*

"I'll pour my Spirit out on all **kinds of** ***people:***
your sons and daughters will prophesy,
your young men will see visions,
your old men will dream dreams, and
[18]***my servants and handmaids*** *will prophesy.*

[19]***"I'll show*** *you* ***wonders in the sky above, and***

signs ***on the earth*** *below—*
blood, fire, and smoke.
[20]***The sun will go dark, and***
the moon will turn red,
before the great day of the LORD comes.
[21]***"Whoever calls on the LORD will be saved"'*** **[Joel 2:28-32].** **Acts 2:14-21**

[22]*"Israelites, listen. God approved Jesus the Nazarene by miracles, wonders, and signs you know God did by him among you.* [23]*You handed him over to God's* pre*determined foreknowledge and plan. You condemned him to death and got people to crucify him that weren't under the Law.* [24]*God released him from a painful death and resurrected him because death couldn't hold him.* [25]*David said,*

'I always see the LORD in front of me;
he's at my right hand so I'm secure.
[26]***So I'm glad and rejoice;***
even my flesh will rest in hope,
[27]***because you won't leave me in the grave, or***
let your Holy One decay.
[28]***You've made the way of life known to me;***
you'll make me happy with your presence' **[Ps 16:8-11].**
Acts 2:22-28

[29]*"Brothers, let me speak frankly about the patriarch David: he died and was buried, and his grave's still here.* [30]*So, as a prophet, he knew 'God had* ***solemnly sworn*** *that* ***his descendant would sit on his throne'*** **[Ps 132:11].** [31]*He saw that ahead of time and was referring to the Messiah's resurrection when he said,* ***'He wouldn't remain in the grave, and*** *his flesh* ***wouldn't decay'*** **[Ps 16:10].** [32]*God resurrected this Jesus, as we can all vouch for.* [33]*He ascended to God's right hand, received from the Father the Holy Spirit he promised, and poured out what you're seeing and hearing.* [34]*David didn't ascend to heaven; he said himself,*

'The LORD said to my Lord,
"Sit on my right hand
[35]***till I make your enemies your footstool"'*** **[Ps 110:1].**

[36]*So Israel can know without a doubt that God has made this Jesus you crucified both 'Lord' and Messiah."* **Acts 2:29-36**

3,000 Respond

[37]Those comments cut his audience to the heart. They said to Peter and the other apostles, *"What are we going to do, brothers!?"*

[38]Peter said,

"Repent, and each of you get baptized to Jesus the Messiah for the forgiveness of your sins, and you'll receive the Holy Spirit as a gift. [39]*The promise applies to you, your descendants, and everybody afar off—as many as the* LORD *our God calls."*

[40]With a lot of additional presentation, he urged them, *"Be saved from this crooked generation."* [41]The ones that accepted his message were baptized: about 3,000 were added together that day. [42]They devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching, to fellowship, breaking bread, and prayer. **Acts 2:37-42**

[43]Reverence came over them everyone, and the apostles worked many wonders and signs. [44]The believers were together and shared everything; [45]they started selling property and possessions and distributing them according to need. [46]They continued together every day in the Temple, breaking bread by families, and receiving food with sincere gladness. [47]They kept praising God and being gracious to the people. Every day the LORD was adding together the ones that were being saved. **Acts 2:43-47**

Healing the Lame Man at Gate Beautiful

3:[1]Peter and John were going up into the Temple at 3 o'clock prayer. [2]Daily, people had been carrying a man crippled from birth *and taking him* to the Temple gate called *Gate* Beautiful to ask for alms from people going into the Temple. [3]When he saw Peter and John about to go in, he asked for alms. [4]Peter looked at him with John and said, *"Look at us."*

[5]He gave them his full attention, expecting to receive something.

[6]Peter said, *"I don't have any money, but I'll give you what I do have. In the name of Jesus the Messiah, the Nazarene, get up and walk."*

[7]He took his right hand and lifted him up. Instantly his feet and ankles strengthened. [8]He jumped up and stood and started walking around. He went into the Temple with them, walking and jumping and praising God. [9]The people saw him [10]and recognized him as the beggar at Gate Beautiful. They were astounded. **Acts 3:1-10**

Peter's Sermon at Solomon's Portico

[11]While he kept holding onto Peter and John, the people rushed to them in Solomon's Portico, utterly astonished. [12]When Peter saw it, he responded,

"Israelites, why are you amazed at him? Why stare at us as if we made him walk by <u>*our*</u> *power or godliness?* [13]***Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob's God—our ancestors' God*** **[Ex 3:6, 15]**—*has glorified his Son Jesus. He's the One you delivered up to Pilate when he'd decided to release him.* [14]*You rejected the Holy and Just One, and asked Pilate to grant you a murderer.* [15]*You killed the author*

of life that God has resurrected, the One we're witnesses for. [16]*He's the One that made this man strong. Faith working through him has made this man you know completely well as you can see.* **Acts 3:11-16**

[17]*"Now brothers, I know you didn't realize what you were doing—your rulers didn't either.* [18]*But that's the way God fulfilled what he announced beforehand by many prophets: that his Messiah would suffer.* [19]*So repent: God will erase your sins.* [20]*Times of renewal will come from the LORD, and he'll send the Messiah Jesus that he appointed for you.* [21]*Heaven needs to receive him till God establishes everything he said through his holy prophets so long ago.* [22]*Moses said,*

'From among you the LORD your God will raise up a prophet for you like me. Listen to everything he tells** you.* [23]Every person that doesn't will perish from the people'*** **[Deut 18:15-16].**

[24]*The prophets from Samuel on have told about our time.* [25]*You're descendants of the prophets and of the covenant God made with your ancestors. He told Abraham,*

'Your descendants will bless all the nations' **[Gen 22:18; 26:4].**

[26]*God has resurrected his Son Jesus and sent him first to you to 'bless' you when you turn away from your sins."* **Acts 3:17-26**

Peter and John Before the Sanhedrin

4:[1]While they were speaking to the people, the priests, the captain of the Temple, and the Sadducees confronted them. [2]They resented them teaching the people and claiming in Jesus the resurrection. [3]They arrested them and put them in jail till the next day because it was already evening. [4]Many who heard the message believed; the number of men rose to about 5,000.

Acts 4:1-4

[5]The next day their rulers, elders, and scribes assembled in Jerusalem with [6]Annas the high priest and Caiaphas, John, Alexander, and the members the high priest's family. [7]They stood Peter and John in the assembly, *"By what power or name did you do this?"*

[8]Peter was filled with the Holy Spirit and said,

"Rulers of the people and elders, [9]*if you're examining us today to find out what good deed has cured this crippled man,* [10]*know this, you and all the people of Israel: he stands here cured by Jesus the Messiah, the Nazarene you crucified and God resurrected.* [11]*This is*

'the stone** you **builders rejected
that's become the cornerstone' **[Ps 118:22].**

[12]*Salvation lies only in him; no one else under heaven can save us."* **Acts 4:5-12**

[13]When they saw Peter and John's boldness and took note that they were unschooled, common men, they were amazed, knowing they'd been with Jesus. [14]They looked at the man standing with them cured and couldn't say anything against it. [15]They told them to go outside the Sanhedrin while they conferred,

> [16]*"What are we going to do with these men!? It's obvious to everybody in Jerusalem that they've done a notable sign; we can't deny that.* [17]*But, to keep it from spreading any further among the people, let's strictly threaten them not to speak to anybody again in this name."*

[18]They called them and commanded them never to teach again in the name of Jesus.

[19]But Peter answered, *"In front of our God, you decide if it's right to listen to you or to him.* [20]*We have to say what we've seen and heard."*

[21]When they'd threatened them some more, they let them go. They couldn't find anything to punish them for, and the people were praising God for what had happened. [22]The man they'd healed was over 40 years old. **Acts 4:13-22**

Praying for Boldness

[23]After their release, they reported to their people what the chief priests and elders had said. [24]When they heard it, they said to God together,

> *"Master, who made earth, sky, and sea, and everything in them,* [25]*you spoke by the Holy Spirit through our ancestor David your servant,*
>
> ***'Why did the Gentiles rage,***
> ***and the peoples plot pointless threats?***
> [26]***The kings of the earth stood together, and***
> ***the rulers assembled as one***
> ***against the LORD and his Messiah'*** **[Ps 2:1-2].**
>
> [27]*Truly in this city, Herod and Pontius Pilate with the 'Gentiles' and the 'people' of Israel 'assembled against your Holy Servant Jesus'* [28]*to do what you already determined would happen.* [29]*Now, LORD, look at their threats, and make us* [your servants] *bold to speak your message* [30]*while you heal and bring about signs and wonders through your Holy Servant Jesus."*

[31]After they'd prayed, the place where they'd gathered shook, and they were filled with the Holy Spirit and continued to speak God's message boldly. **Acts 4:23-31**

Having All Things in Common

[32]The great number of believers united in heart and soul. Nobody considered anything his own; they held everything in common. [33]The apostles were powerfully defending the Lord's

resurrection and experiencing a lot of good will. **34**Nobody lacked what they needed, because the ones who owned land or houses were selling them **35**and taking the proceeds to the apostles. It was distributed as needed. **36**Joseph—that the apostles called Barnabas (Encourager), a Levite, a Cypriot—**37**sold a field and gave the apostles the proceeds. **Acts 4:32-3**

Ananias and Sapphira

5:1A man named Ananias and his wife Sapphira also sold a piece of land. **2**He kept part of the price and took the rest to the apostles. (She was in on it.)

3Peter said, *"Ananias, why did Satan prompt you to lie to the Holy Spirit, when you kept part of the price of the field?* **4***While you had it, wasn't it yours? When you sold it, didn't you control it? Why decide to do this? You didn't just lie to people, but to God."* **5**When Ananias heard that, he collapsed and died. Great respect came on everybody that heard about it. **6**The young men got up, wrapped him up, carried him out, and buried him.

7Some three hours later his wife came in, not knowing what had happened. **8**Peter asked her, *"Did you[pl] sell the field for such and such?"*

"Yes."

9Peter said, *"Why'd you[pl] agree to test the Spirit of the Lord? The ones that buried your husband are at the door, and they'll carry you out."*

10She collapsed right there and died. The young men carried her out to bury her beside her husband. **11**People that heard about what happened came to greatly respect the church.

Acts 5:1-11

Miracles Among the People

12The apostles did many signs and wonders among the people, and they were getting together in Solomon's Portico. **13**People hesitated to join them, but they held them in high regard. **14**Believers kept coming to the Lord, large numbers of men and women. **15**As a result, they were bringing sick people out into the streets and putting them on cots and stretchers so when Peter came, even his shadow might fall on some of them. **16**Crowds even came from towns around Jerusalem, carrying sick people and people harassed by unclean spirits. They were all healed.

Acts 5:12-16

The Apostles Persecuted

17The high priest and his associates—Sadducees—were jealous. **18**They arrested the apostles and put them in public custody. **19**During the night an angel of the LORD opened the gates of the jail and let them out, **20***"Go into the Temple and speak to the people the message about this life."* **21**They went in about daylight and started teaching. The high priest and his associates convened Israel's Sanhedrin, the senate, and sent to the jail to bring the apostles. **22**But the officers didn't find them. They came back and reported, **23***"We found the jail securely locked and the guards standing at the doors; but when we opened it, we didn't find anybody inside."*

24The captain of the Temple and the chief priests were dumbfounded about what this might lead to. **25**A fellow came and told them, *"They're standing in the Temple, teaching the people."* **26**The captain went with the officers and brought them without force because they were afraid the people would stone them. **Acts 5:17-26**

27They took them into the Sanhedrin, and the high priest asked them, **28***"Didn't we strictly charge you not to teach in this name? You've filled Jerusalem with your teaching and intend to bring this man's blood on us."*

29Peter and the apostles said,

> *"We have to obey God instead of you.* **30***Our ancestors' God raised up Jesus that you did murder on a tree.* **31***God exalted him as Leader and Savior to his right hand to offer repentance and forgiveness to Israel.* **32***We speak to that fact and so does the Holy Spirit God has given to ones that obey him."*
>
> **Acts 5:27-32**

Gamaliel's Advice

33They were furious and wanted to execute them. **34**But a Pharisee in the Sanhedrin named Gamaliel, a respected teacher of the Law, stood up and told them to put the men out *of the council chamber* for a while,

> **35***"Israelites, be careful what you do to them.* **36***Before now, Theudas rose up, claiming to be somebody. About 400 men joined him. He was killed, and everybody that obeyed him scattered and didn't amount to anything.*
>
> **37***"After that, Judas the Galilean rose up during the census, and drew people to him. He perished too, and the ones that obeyed him scattered.* **38***Now I tell you, leave these men alone. If this effort is coming from men, it'll be overthrown.* **39***If it's from God, you won't overthrow them, and you can be fighting against God."*

They agreed. **40**They called the apostles, beat them, charged them not to speak in Jesus' name, and released them. **41**They left the Sanhedrin, elated over being considered worthy of suffering for The Name. **42**Every day in the Temple and from house to house, they continued to preach that Jesus was the Messiah. **Acts 5:33-42**

Appointing the 7

6:1 At that time when the number of disciples was multiplying, the Hellenists started grumbling against the Hebrews for overlooking their widows in daily food distribution. **2**The Twelve assembled the disciples,

> *"We shouldn't step aside from serving God's message to serving tables.* **3***So pick out seven men with good reputations, who have the Spirit and wisdom, and we'll appoint them to take care of this.* **4***We'll continue in prayer and serving the message."*

[5]That pleased the crowd, and they chose Stephen, a man with great faith and the Holy Spirit; Philip, Prochorus, Nicanor, Timon, Parmenas; and Nicolaus, a proselyte from Antioch. [6]They presented them to the apostles, who prayed and laid hands on them. [7]God's message grew, and the number of disciples multiplied tremendously in Jerusalem. A large group of priests obeyed the faith. **Acts 6:1-7**

Stephen's Arrest

[8]With grace and power, Stephen was doing great signs among the people. [9]Some rose up from The Synagogue of the Freemen, Cyrenians, Alexandrians, Cilicians, and Asians, trying to argue with him; [10]but they couldn't stand up to his wisdom and spirit. [11]So they bribed some guys to say, *"We heard him blaspheme Moses and God."* [12]They stirred up the people, the elders, and the scribes; seized him, and took him to the Sanhedrin. [13]False witnesses stood up, *"He keeps speaking against this Holy Place and the Law.* [14]*We've heard him say Jesus the Nazarene will tear this place down and change the customs Moses delivered."* [15]Everybody sitting in the Sanhedrin looked at him intently and saw his face like the face of an angel.

Acts 6:8-15

Stephen's Defense

7:[1]The high priest said, *"Is that true?"*

[2]He said,

"Brothers and fathers, listen. Our glorious God appeared to Abraham our ancestor in Mesopotamia before he settled in Haran. [3]***He said, 'Leave your land and relatives, and go to the land I'll show you'*** **[Gen 12:1].** [4]*He left Chaldea and settled in Haran. After his father died, God moved him to where we live now.* [5]*He didn't give him an inheritance in it, not even a place to put his foot, but promised* ***'to give it to him and his descendants'*** **[Gen 12:7]** *even though he didn't have a child yet.* [6]*God said* ***his descendants would live in a foreign land that would enslave them and abuse them for 400 years.*** [7]***'I'll judge that nation, and afterwards I'll bring them out, and they'll serve me here'*** **[Gen 15:13-14].** [8]*He gave them the covenant of circumcision, so Abraham became the father of Isaac and circumcised him the eighth day. Isaac became the father of Jacob, father of the twelve patriarchs.* **Acts 7:1-8**

[9]*"The* other *patriarchs resented Joseph and sold him into Egypt, but God was with him.* [10]*He delivered him from difficult circumstances and gave him grace and wisdom in front of Pharaoh king of Egypt. Pharaoh made him governor over Egypt as well as his own household.*

[11]*An especially stressful famine came over Egypt and Canaan, and our ancestors couldn't find food.* [12]*Jacob heard there was grain in Egypt and sent our fathers first.* [13]*The second time Joseph made himself known to his brothers, and*

Joseph's family became acquainted with Pharaoh. [14]*Joseph called his father Jacob and all his relatives—75 people.* [15]*Jacob went down to Egypt, and he and our ancestors died there.* [16]*They were carried over to Shechem and put in the tomb Abraham had bought from the sons of Hamor in Shechem.* **Acts 7:9-16**

[17] *"As the time came for God's promise to Abraham, the people multiplied in Egypt* [18]*until* ***'another king arose that didn't know Joseph'*** **[Ex 1:7-8].** [19]*He took advantage of our people and abused our ancestors by making them cast out their babies to die.*

[20] *"At that time Moses was born, an especially good-looking baby raised for three months in his father's house.* [21]*When he was exposed, Pharaoh's daughter picked him up and raised him as her own son.* [22]*He was educated in the wisdom of the Egyptians, capable in word and deed.* **Acts 7:17-22**

[23] *"When he was 40, it occurred to him to visit his kin, the Israelites.* [24]*When he saw one of them mistreated, he avenged him by striking down the Egyptian.* [25]*He supposed his kin understood that God was going to use him to deliver them, but they didn't.*

[26] *"The next day he showed up as two were fighting and tried to make peace, 'Men, you're brothers. Why are you mistreating each other?'*

[27] *"The one mistreating his neighbor pushed him away,* ***'Who made you a ruler and judge over us?*** [28]***You don't intend to kill me, do you, like you killed the Egyptian yesterday?'*** **[Ex 2:13-14]**

[29] *"At this, Moses fled from Egypt and became an exile in Midian, where he fathered two sons.* **Acts 7:23-29**

[30] *"After 40 years,* ***'an angel appeared to him in the flame of a burning bush in the desert'*** **[Ex 3:2-3]** *around Mt. Sinai.* [31]*Moses was amazed at the sight. When he came for a closer look, the* LORD *spoke,* [32]***'I'm your ancestors' God, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob.'*** **[Ex 3:6].** *Moses began to tremble and didn't dare to look.* [33]***The LORD said, 'Take your sandals off; you're standing on holy ground.*** [34]***I've certainly seen the abuse of my people in Egypt and have come down to deliver them. Go now; I'm sending you to Egypt"'*** **[Ex 3:4-10].**

[35] *"The Moses they rejected, saying,* ***'Who made you a ruler and judge'*** **[Ex 2:14]**, *God sent as ruler and deliverer by the angel that appeared to him in the bush.* [36]*He led them out and performed wonders and signs in Egypt, the Red Sea, and in the desert for 40 years.* [37]*That's the Moses who said to the Israelites,* ***'From among your people God will raise up a prophet for you like me'*** **[Deut.18:15].** [38]*That's the one who was in the congregation in the desert with the*

angel that spoke to him on Mt. Sinai and with our ancestors. That's the one who received life-giving oracles for us. [39]*That's the one our forefathers didn't want to obey, but shoved away, turned in heart back to Egypt,* [40]*and told Aaron,* ***'Make us gods to go ahead of us. We don't know what's happened to this Moses who brought us out of Egypt'*** **[Ex 32:1, 23].** [41]*They made a calf, offered sacrifice to the idol, and celebrated over what they had made with their hands.* **Acts 7:30-41**

[42]*"God turned away and gave them up to serve the host of heaven, like scripture says in the Book of the Prophets,*

'You didn't just ***offer <u>me</u> slain victims and sacrifices***
for 40 years in the wilderness, did you, Israel?
[43]***You carried the tabernacle of <u>Moloch</u>***
and the star of <u>Rephan</u>,
images you made *to worship.*
I'll carry you away beyond *Babylon'* **[Amos 5:25-27].** **Acts 7:42-43**

[44]*"Our ancestors had the tabernacle as a testimony to them in the desert. The One that spoke to Moses directed him to make it according to the design he'd seen.* [45]*That's what our ancestors brought in with Joshua when they took over the nations God forced out till David's time.* [46]*David found favor with God and asked to build a house for him.* [47]*Solomon did build a house for God,* [48]*but the Most High doesn't live in handmade houses. The prophet says,*

[49]***'"The sky's my throne;***
the earth's my footstool.
What kind of house are you going to build me," the LORD says?
"Where will I rest?
[50]***Haven't I made all this?"'*** **[Is 66:1-2]**

[51]*"You stiff-necked and uncircumcised in heart and ears, you always resist the Holy Spirit just like your ancestors did!* [52]*Which prophet didn't they persecute? They killed the ones that predicted the coming of the Righteous One that you've betrayed and murdered,* [53]*you that received the Law ordained by angels and haven't kept it!"* **Acts 7:44-53**

[54]They were enraged and gritted their teeth at him. [55]Filled with the Holy Spirit, he looked intently into heaven and saw God's glory and Jesus standing to his right. [56]He said, *"I see heaven opened and the Son of Man standing on the right side of God."*

Stephen Martyred

[57]They shouted out and covered their ears and rushed at him together. [58]They threw him out of the city and started stoning him. The witnesses laid their clothes at the feet of a young man called Saul. [59]As they stoned Stephen, he called out, *"Lord Jesus, receive my spirit!"* [60]He

knelt down and shouted out, *"Lord, don't hold this sin against them!"* Then he died. **8:1**Saul was approving of his death. **Acts 7:54-8:1a**

Paul Leads a General Persecution

Severe persecution broke out against the church in Jerusalem. Disciples scattered all over Judaea and Samaria—except for the apostles. **2**Devout men buried Stephen and mourned him greatly. **3**Saul continued to destroy the church, entering every house, dragging men and women to jail. **Acts 8:1b-3**

Philip Preaches to Samaritans

4The ones that scattered went around presenting the message. **5**Philip went down to the city of Samaria and presented the Messiah to them. **6**The crowds paid attention to what he said and to the signs he did. **7**Unclean spirits came out crying loudly, and he healed paralyzed and lame people. **8**A lot of joy came to that city.

9A man named Simon had previously practiced sorcery in the city. He amazed the Samaritan nation, claiming to be somebody great. **10**Least to greatest looked up to him, *"This is The Power of God Called Great."* **11**They looked up to him because for a long time he had amazed them with sorcery. **12**When they believed Philip's preaching about God's kingdom and about Jesus *as* the Messiah, men and women were baptized. **13**Simon himself believed and after his baptism he stayed close to Philip, impressed with *his* outstanding miraculous signs. **Acts 8:4-13**

Peter and John in Samaria

14When the apostles in Jerusalem heard the Samaritans had accepted God's message, they sent Peter and John **15**to go down and pray for the Samaritans to receive the Holy Spirit. **16**The Spirit hadn't fallen on any of them; they'd only been baptized into the Lord Jesus. **17**The apostles laid hands on them, and they received the Holy Spirit.

18When Simon saw that the apostles were giving the Spirit by laying on hands, he offered them money, **19***"Give me that authority, too, so whoever I lay my hands on will receive the Spirit."*

20Peter told him,

> *"Your silver perish with you! You thought you could buy God's gift with money!* **21***You don't have any part in this. Your motives aren't right in front of God.* **22***Repent of this wickedness and pray that maybe he'll forgive your motives.* **23***As far as I'm concerned, you're in the bitterness that gall has and the addiction that sinning brings."*

24Simon answered, *"You*[pl] *pray to the Lord for me so nothing like that happens to me."*

[25]When they'd given their testimony and presented the Lord's message, they headed back to Jerusalem. On the way they delivered the good news to many Samaritan villages. **Acts 8:14-25**

Philip and the Ethiopian Eunuch

[26]An angel of the LORD told Philip, *"Go south to the road from Jerusalem down to Gaza, which is open country."* [27]*So* he went. An Ethiopian, a eunuch, an official, the treasurer for Candace, queen of the Ethiopians. had come to Jerusalem to worship and [28]was going back in his carriage, reading the prophet Isaiah.

[29]The Spirit told Philip, *"Make contact with that carriage."*

[30]Philip ran toward it and heard him reading Isaiah, *"Do you understand what you're reading?"*

[31] *"How can I unless somebody explains it me?"* He invited Philip to come up and sit with him *in the carriage*. [32]This is the passage he was reading:

"They led him like a sheep to slaughter;
like a lamb silent in front of its shearers,
he didn't open his mouth.
[33]**In** his **humble condition he received no justice.**
Who can speak of his descendants?
his life has been taken from the earth?" **[Is 53:7-8 LXX] Acts 8:26-33**

[34]The eunuch asked, *"Who's the prophet talking about, himself or somebody else?"* [35]Philip started at that scripture and presented to him the good news about Jesus.

[36]As they rode along, they came to some water, the eunuch said, *"Here's some water; does anything keep me from being baptized?"* [37]ms [38]He stopped the carriage, and they both went down into the water, and Philip baptized him. [39]When they came up out of the water, the Spirit of the LORD caught Philip away, and the eunuch never saw him again. He went on his way happy. [40]Philip showed up in Azotus. As he traveled, he delivered the good news to towns all along the way to Caesarea. **Acts 8:34-40**

Saul's Conversion

9:[1]Saul was still making murderous threats against the Lord's disciples. He went to the high priest [2]and asked for letters to synagogues in Damascus so, if he found any belonging to The Way—men or women, he could bring them bound to Jerusalem. [3]As he was getting close to Damascus, all of a sudden, a light from the sky shined around him. [4]He fell to the ground and heard a voice,

"Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?"

[5]He said, *"Who are you, Sir?"*

"I'm Jesus that you're persecuting. [6]*Get up and go into the city. Someone will tell you what to do."*

[7]The men traveling with him stood speechless. They heard the voice but didn't see anyone. [8]Saul got up; and when he opened his eyes, he couldn't see. They took him by the hand into Damascus. [9]For three days he couldn't see and didn't eat or drink anything. **Acts 9:1-9**

[10]There was a disciple in Damascus named Ananias. The Lord said to him, *"Ananias."*

"Yes, Lord."

[11] *"Go to Straight Street and ask for Saul of Tarsus in Judas' house. He's praying* [12]*and has seen a man named Ananias coming in and laying hands on him so he could see."*

[13]Ananias answered, *"Lord, I've heard from lots of people how many evil things he's done in Jerusalem.* [14]*He has authority from the chief priests to bind everybody here that calls on you."*

[15]The Lord said, *"Go on; I've chosen him to carry my name to Gentiles, kings, and Israelites.* [16]*I'll show him how much he has to suffer for me."*

[17]Ananias went into Judas' house, laid hands on him, and said, *"Brother Saul, the Lord Jesus that appeared to you on the road has sent me so you can see again and be filled with the Holy Spirit."* [18]Immediately scales, as it were, fell from his eyes, and he could see again. He got up and was baptized. [19]After he ate, he regained his strength. **Acts 9:10-19a**

Saul Preaches in Damascus

He was with disciples in Damascus for some days. [20]Right away in the synagogues, he started presenting Jesus as God's Son. [21]The ones that heard him were amazed, *"Isn't he the one that executed people in Jerusalem for calling on this Name and has come here to lead them bound to the chief priests?"* [22]Paul grew stronger and confounded the Jews in Damascus, proving that this was the Messiah.

[23]After a while the Jews plotted to kill him, [24]but he found out about it. They were watching the gates day and night. [25]During the night his disciples lowered him in a big basket through *an opening in* the wall. **Acts 9:19b-25**

Jewish Plot Against Saul

[26]When he got back to Jerusalem, he tried to associate with the disciples, but they were afraid of him. They didn't believe he'd become a disciple. [27]But Barnabas took him to the apostles, and told them how he'd seen the Lord, how the Lord had spoken to him, how he'd presented the Lord boldly in Damascus. [28]Saul was moving freely among them in Jerusalem, presenting the Lord boldly. [29]He was disputing with the Hellenistic Jews, who were trying to get hold of him to kill him. [30]But the brothers found out, took him down to Caesarea, and sent him to

Tarsus. [31]Then, all over Judaea, Galilee, and Samaria the church had peace and multiplied. They were living with respect for the Lord and comfort from the Holy Spirit. **Acts 9:26-31**

Peter Heals Aeneas

[32]As Peter circulated through the region, he went down to the saints in Lydda. [33]He found a man there named Aeneas, who'd been confined to for bed eight years paralyzed. [34]Peter said, *"Aeneas, Jesus the Messiah is healing you. Get up and make your bed."* Immediately he stood up. [35]Everyone in Lydda and Sharon saw him, and turned to the Lord.

Peter Resurrects Dorcas

[36]In Joppa a disciple named Tabitha (Dorcas) was always doing good things for people and giving gifts to those in need. [37]She got sick and died. They bathed her and laid her in an upstairs room. [38]Lydda was close to Joppa, and the disciples heard that Peter was there. They sent two men, *"Come right away."* [39]Peter went with them. When he got there, they took him upstairs. The widows stood beside him mourning and showing him shirts and *other* clothes Dorcas had made for them. [40]Peter had them step out; he knelt and prayed, and turned to the body, *"Tabitha, get up."*

When she opened her eyes and saw Peter, she sat up. [41]He gave her his hand and raised her up. He called the saints and widows and presented her alive. [42]The news spread all over Joppa, and many came to believe in the Lord. [43]For some time, Peter stayed in Joppa with Simon the tanner. **Acts 9:32-43**

The Conversion of Cornelius

10[:1]A centurion in Caesarea named Cornelius, from the Italian cohort, [2]was a devout God-fearer along with his household. He gave considerable charitable gifts to the people and prayed to God constantly. [3]In a vision about 3 o'clock, he saw an angel of God coming in and saying, *"Cornelius."*

[4]He looked at him and was afraid, *"Yes, Sir?"*

"Your prayers and charitable gifts have come up as a memorial to God. [5]*Send* some *men to Joppa and summon Simon called Peter.* [6]*He's staying with Simon a tanner whose house is by the sea."* [7]When the angel left, he called two household servants—his personal assistants—and a devout soldier. [8]He went through everything with them and sent them to Joppa. **Acts 10:1-8**

[9]The next day, as they were getting close to the town, Peter went up on the housetop about noon to pray. [10]He was getting hungry. While they were fixing lunch, he fell into a trance. [11]He watched the sky open up and something like a big sheet was let down to earth by four corners. [12]It held reptiles, birds, and four-footed animals.

[13]A voice said, *"Kill and eat them, Peter."*

14 *"No, Sir; I've never eaten anything unclean."*

15The voice spoke again, *"Don't <u>you</u> consider unclean what <u>God</u> has cleansed."*

16That happened three times, and the vessel went back up into the sky. **Acts 10:9-16**

17While Peter was wondering what the vision could possibly mean, Cornelius' men had asked around for Simon's house and were standing at the gate. **18**They called out, asking if Simon called Peter was staying there.

19While he kept trying to figure out the vision, the Spirit said, *"Three men are looking for you.* **20***Go down and go with them without scruples. I've sent them."*

21He went down and said, *"I'm the one you're looking for. Why have you come?"*

22They said, *"Cornelius is a centurion, a God-fearer with a good reputation in the Jewish nation. A holy angel directed him to invite you to his house to hear what you have to say."* **23**So he invited them in and put them up for the night. The next day he went with them, and some brothers from Joppa went along. **Acts 10:17-23**

24On the second day, he came to Caesarea. Cornelius was expecting them and had called his relatives and close friends. **25**When Peter came in, Cornelius met him and fell down to him in homage. **26**Peter raised him up, *"Please stand up; I'm just a man too."* **27**As they talked, Peter went in and found a large group.

28He told them, *"You know a Jew's not supposed to associate at home with a foreigner, but God has shown me not to consider anybody* ceremonially *unclean.* **29***So without objecting, I came when you called. Why did you send for me?"*

30Cornelius said,

> *"Four days ago about this time, I was observing 3 o'clock prayer in my house. A man stood in front of me in bright clothes* **31***and said, 'Cornelius, God has heard your prayer and remembered your charitable gifts.* **32***Send to Joppa for Simon called Peter. He's staying with Simon, a tanner next to the sea.* **33***Right away I sent for you. Thank you for coming. We're here in front of God to hear what the Lord has commanded you."* **Acts 10:24-33**

34Peter said,

> *"I perceive that God doesn't show favoritism with people.* **35***But, in every nation he accepts people that respect him and live right.* **36***He sent the message to the people of Israel, delivering good news about peace through Jesus the Messiah, who is Lord of all.* **37***You know what took place all over Judaea, beginning in Galilee after the baptism that John preached.* **38***God anointed Jesus the Nazarene with the Holy Spirit and power. He went around doing good and healing people the devil had oppressed, because God was with him.* **39-40***We witnessed what he did in the country of the Jews and in Jerusalem. On the third*

day God raised up the One they killed on a tree and presented him clearly, [41]*not to everybody, but to witnesses he'd previously chosen—to us who ate with him after his resurrection.* [42]*He sent us to tell the people that he's the One God appointed to judge the living and the dead.* [43]*The prophets show that through him everybody who trusts in him has his sins forgiven."* **Acts 10:34-43**

Gentiles Receive the Spirit

[44]While Peter was speaking, the Holy Spirit fell on the audience. [45]The believers from the Circumcision who had come with Peter were surprised that God poured out the Holy Spirit on Gentiles too. [46]They heard them speak in languages and praise God.

Peter responded, [47]*"Nobody can forbid water, can they, for baptizing these who have received the Holy Spirit like we did?"* [48]He commanded to baptize them into Jesus the Messiah.

They asked him to stay for several days. **Acts 10:44-48**

Peter Reports to Jerusalem

11:[1]The apostles and believers in Judaea heard that Gentiles had accepted God's message. [2]When Peter went up to Jerusalem, members of the Circumcision took issue with him, [3]*"You went in and ate with uncircumcised men."*

[4]Peter explained step by step,

[5]*"I was in Joppa praying when I saw a vision in a trance, something like a big sheet came down from the sky by four corners. It came to me,* [6]*and I stared into it and saw four-footed animals, wild animals, reptiles, and birds.* [7]*I heard a voice, 'Kill and eat them, Peter.'*

[8]*"I said, 'No, Sir; I've never eaten anything unclean.'*

[9]*"The voice spoke a second time out of the sky, 'Don't <u>you</u> consider unclean what <u>God</u> has cleansed.'* [10]*That happened three times, and everything went back up into the sky.*

[11]*"Right then, three men from Caesarea stood at the house where we were staying.* [12]*The Spirit told me to go with them without scruples. These six brothers went along and entered the man's house.* [13]*He told us how he'd seen an angel standing in his house, saying, 'Send to Joppa for Simon called Peter.* [14]*He'll tell you what will save you and your household.'*

[15]*"While I was speaking, the Holy Spirit fell on them like on us in the beginning.* [16]*I remembered what the Lord had said, 'John immersed in water, but <u>you'll</u> be "immersed" in the Holy Spirit.'* [17]*If God gave <u>them</u> the same gift he gave us when <u>we</u> trusted in the Lord Jesus the Messiah ('Christ'), who was I to oppose God?"*

[18]When they heard that, they backed off and praised God, *"Then God has also offered Gentiles repentance to life."* **Acts 11:1-18**

The Good News in Antioch

[19]The ones scattered by the ordeal surrounding Stephen traveled as far as Phoenicia, Cyprus, and Antioch, speaking the message just to Jews. [20]But some Cypriots and Cyrenians went to Antioch and started presenting the Lord Jesus to Greeks as well. [21]The Lord was with them, and a large number turned to the Lord. [22]The church in Jerusalem heard about them and sent Barnabas to Antioch. [23]When he got there and saw *the evidence of* God's grace, he was glad and encouraged them with heartfelt purpose to remain with the Lord. [24]He was a good man, full of the Holy Spirit and faith; and a significant number joined the Lord. [25]He went to Tarsus to look for Paul. [26]When he found him, he brought him to Antioch. For a year they gathered in the church and taught a sizable crowd. They called the disciples Christians first in Antioch.

[27]At that time, prophets from Jerusalem came down to Antioch. [28]One, named Agabus, signified by the Spirit that a severe famine would come over the whole *Roman* empire, which took place in the *reign of* Claudius. [29]The believers, as they could, made up their mind to send relief to the Christians in Jerusalem. [30]They sent it to the elders by Barnabas and Saul.

Acts 11:19-30

Herod Kills James, Jails Peter

12:[1]About that time, King Herod *Agrippa I* reached out to abuse some in the church. [2]He killed James, John's brother, with a sword. [3]When he saw the Jews liked that, he arrested Peter too (during the days of Unleavened Bread). [4]He put him in jail, with four detachments of four soldiers to guard him. After Passover he meant to bring him out to the people, [5]but the church prayed sincerely to God about him. **Acts 12:1-5**

[6]The night before Herod meant to bring him out, Peter was sleeping between two soldiers, bound with two chains. There were guards at the door, keeping the jail. [7]An angel of the LORD stood beside him, and a light glowed in the cell. He tapped Peter on the shoulder to wake him up, *"Get up quick!"* The chains fell off his hands.

Peter Delivered from Jail

[8] *"Fasten your belt and put your sandals on. Put your cloak on and follow me."*

[9]He followed him, not knowing it was real; he thought he was dreaming. [10]They went through the first and second guard posts and came to the iron gate into the city. It swung open on its own, and they went out and passed down one street. Then the angel disappeared. **Acts 12:6-10**

[11]When Peter came to himself, he said, *"Now I'm sure the* LORD *sent his angel to deliver me from Herod and the Jews."*

[12]After he came to grips with what happened, he went to the house of Mary, John Mark's mother, where a large number had gathered to pray. [13]He knocked on the door in the gate, and a girl named Rhoda came to answer it. [14]She recognized Peter's voice. Instead of letting him in, she ran excited to tell them that he was standing at the gate.

[15]They said, *"You're out of your mind."*

But she insisted.

They started saying, *"It must be his angel."*

[16]Peter kept knocking; and when they opened the door, they were surprised to see him.

[17]He motioned for them to hold it down and recounted how the LORD had led him out of the jail, *"Tell James and the brothers what's happened."* He left and went somewhere else.

[18]The next morning there was a huge stir among the soldiers over what had become of Peter. [19]When Herod looked for him and didn't find him, he examined the guards and commanded to lead them off for execution. He went down from Judaea to Caesarea and spent some time there. **Acts 12:11-19**

The Death of Herod

[20]He was mad at the residents of Tyre and Sidon. As a group they came to him and befriended Blastus, who was in charge of the king's sleeping quarters. They asked for peace because his country supplied their food. [21]On a set day, Herod dressed in royal garb, sat on the judgment seat, and gave an oration.

[22]The public assembly shouted, "It's *the voice of a god, not a man!"*

[23]Immediately an angel of the LORD struck him because *he accepted the credit* and didn't give it to God. He got worms and died. [24]God's message grew and multiplied. [25]Barnabas and Saul went back from Jerusalem when they'd finished their service and took John Mark with them. **Acts 12:20-25**

Barnabas and Saul Commissioned

13[:1]In the church at Antioch, there were prophets and teachers: Barnabas; Simeon called Niger; Lucius the Cyrenian; Manaen, brought up with Herod the tetraarch; and Saul. [2]As they served the Lord and fasted, the Holy Spirit said, *"Set Barnabas and Saul apart to the work I've called them for."* [3]They fasted and prayed, laid hands on them, and sent them off. **Acts 13:1-3**

Paul and Barnabas in Cyprus

[4]So sent by the Holy Spirit, and they went down to Seleucia and sailed to Cyprus. [5]At Salamis they delivered God's message in the synagogues of the Jews, with Mark as their assistant. [6]When they'd gone the length of the island, they came upon a sorcerer, a Jewish false prophet named Barjesus. [7]He was with the proconsul Sergius Paullus, an intelligent man, who

called for Barnabas and Saul, and wanted to hear God's message. [8]Elymas ("Sorcerer") opposed them and tried to turn the proconsul away from the faith.

[9]But Saul, or Paul, filled with the Holy Spirit, looked him in the eye [10]and said, *"Deceitful, unscrupulousness son of the devil, enemy of goodness, you continually pervert the upright ways of God.* [11]*Now, his hand is on you. You'll be so blind for a while you can't see the sun."* Immediately darkness fell on him, and he went around trying to find someone to lead him by the hand. [12]When the proconsul saw what happened, he believed, astonished at the Lord's teaching. **Acts 13:4-12**

Paul and Barnabas in Antioch of Pisidia

[13]The ones that were with Paul sailed from Paphos to Perga in Pamphylia. John left and went back to Jerusalem. [14]From Perga, they arrived at Antioch in Pisidia. On the Sabbath they went into the synagogue and sat down. [15]After the reading of the Law and the Prophets, the synagogue rulers sent to them, *"Brothers, if you have something encouraging to say to the people, go ahead."*

[16]Paul stood up and motioned with his hand,

> *"Israelites and God-fearers,* [17]*our God chose our ancestors and raised them up while they were living as foreigners in Egypt. Afterwards he brought them out of there in stupendous fashion* [18]*and put up with them for 40 years in the desert.* [19]*In Canaan he destroyed 7 nations and gave their land to* his people *as an inheritance—*[20]a process that covered *about 450 years. After that, he gave them judges till Samuel the prophet.* [21]*When they asked for a king, he gave them Saul son of Kish from the tribe of Benjamin for 40 years.* [22]*He removed him and raised up David to be king,* ***'I've found David*** *son of Jesse,* ***a man after my own heart, who'll do my will'*** **[1 Sam 13:14; Ps 89:20].** [23]*As he'd promised, God raised up from* David's *descendants a savior, Jesus.* [24]*Ahead of him John prepared for his coming by presenting to Israel a baptism of repentance.* [25]*As John was carrying out his role, he said, 'What do you suppose I am? I'm not the One, but after me One is coming whose sandals I'm not worthy to unfasten.'* **Acts 13:13-25**
>
> [26]*"Brothers, members of Abraham's nation and God-fearers among you, God has sent you the message about this salvation.* [27]*Those living in Jerusalem and their rulers didn't recognize him and, by condemning him, fulfilled the prophets they read every Sabbath.* [28]*Although they didn't find any capital offence, they petitioned Pilate to crucify him.* [29]*When they'd fulfilled everything scripture said about him, they took him down from the tree and put him in a tomb.* [30]*But God resurrected him.* [31]*For many days, he appeared to the ones that came up with him from Galilee to Jerusalem.* [32]*We're bringing you the good news that the*

promise God made to our ancestors [33]*he's fulfilled to us by resurrecting Jesus. Scripture says in Psalm 2,*

'You're my Son;
I've inaugurated you today' **[Ps 2:7].**

[34]*So he didn't decay, like it says,*

'I'll give ***you David's sure blessings'*** **[Is 55:3 LXX]**;

[35]*and in another psalm,*

'You won't let your Holy One decay' **[Ps 16:10 LXX].** **Acts 13:26-35**

[36]*"When* <u>David</u> *had served God's will in his own time, he died, was buried with his ancestors, and decayed.* [37]*But the One God resurrected didn't decay.* [38]*Know, then, that through him we're offering forgiveness of sins—something the Law of Moses couldn't do.* [39]The Messiah *justifies everybody that trusts* in him. [40]*Be careful so what the prophets said won't apply to you,*

[41]***'Look, you despisers;***
be amazed and perish.
I'll do something in your day you wouldn't believe
if somebody explained it to you'" **[Hab 1:5 LXX].**

Acts 13:36-41

Paul Asked to Preach Again

[42]As Paul and Barnabas were leaving, the synagogue rulers invited them to deliver that message the next Sabbath. [43]After the synagogue dismissed, lots of Jews and devout proselytes followed Paul and Barnabas, who urged them to continue in God's grace.

[44]The following Sabbath nearly the whole city came to hear the Lord's message. [45]When the Jews saw the crowd, they got jealous and contradicted Paul and slandered *what he presented*. [46]Paul and Barnabas spoke out boldly, *"We needed to deliver God's message to you first. Since you're rejecting it and consider yourselves not worthy of eternal life, we're turning to the Gentiles.* [47]*That's what the* LORD *commanded us,*

'I've made you a light for the Gentiles
so you can save the whole world'" **[Is 49:6].**

[48]When the Gentiles heard that, they praised the Lord's message, and as many as were appointed to eternal life believed. [49]His message spread out through the region. [50]But the Jews stirred up devout, respected women and prominent men of the city, and instigated persecution against Paul and Barnabas to force them out of their territory. [51]They shook the dust off their feet at them and went to Iconium. [52]The disciples were full of joy and the Holy Spirit. **Acts 13:42-52**

Paul at Iconium

14:[1]At Iconium they went into the Jews' synagogue as usual and spoke so convincingly that a great number of Jews and Greeks believed. [2]But the disbelieving Jews stirred up the

Gentiles and poisoned their minds against the Christians. [3]For a good while, they stayed and kept speaking boldly for the Lord, and he confirmed his message about grace by providing signs and wonders they performed. [4]The city was divided, some with the Jews, some with the apostles. [5]The Gentiles and Jews instigated an attempt to mistreat them and stone them. [6]When the apostles found out, they hurried to Lycaonia to the cities Lystra and Derbe, as well as the surrounding area. [7]They were delivering the good news there as well. **Acts 14:1-7**

Healing a Crippled Man

[8]At Lystra a man crippled in his feet from birth, had never walked. [9]He was listening to Paul speak. Paul looked at him and saw he had faith to be cured. [10]He shouted, *"Stand up!"* He jumped up and started walking.

[11]When the crowd saw what Paul did, they shouted out in Lycaonian, *"Gods have come down to us in human form!"* [12]They started calling Barnabas "Zeus" and Paul "Hermes" because Paul did most of the speaking. [13]The priest of Zeus Propolis took bulls decked with wreaths of flowers to the gates and wanted to offer sacrifice with the crowd. [14]When the apostles Barnabas and Paul heard about it, they tore their clothes and rushed into the crowd, shouting,

> [15]*"Why are you doing this? We're normal men like you, bringing you good news to turn away from these meaningless things to the living God who made earth, sky, and sea, and everything in them.* [16]*In the past, he let nations go their own ways,* [17]*but left evidence of himself by doing good, giving you rain and crops, filling you with food and happiness."*

[18]With that, he barely stopped the crowds from offering sacrifices to them. **Acts 14:8-18**

Paul Stoned at Lystra

[19]Then Jews from Antioch and Iconium came and persuaded the crowds to stone Paul. They dragged him out of the city, thinking he was dead. [20]But with the disciples standing around him, he got up and went back into the city. The next day he left for Derbe with Barnabas.

[21]When they'd presented the good news in that city and made a significant number of disciples, they went back to Lystra, Iconium, and Antioch *of Pisidia*. [22]They were strengthening the disciples and encouraging them to continue in the faith and to enter God's kingdom through many difficulties. [23]When they'd appointed elders in every city, they prayed and fasted, and commended them to the Lord they'd trusted in.

Return to Antioch of Syria

[24]They passed through Pisidia to Pamphylia. [25]After they'd presented the message in Perga, they went down to Attalia [26]and sailed back to Antioch *of Syria*, where they'd been committed to God's grace for the work they'd done. [27]When they arrived and assembled the

church, they recounted what God had done with them and how he'd opened a door of faith for the Gentiles. [28]They stayed there a good while with the disciples. **Acts 14:19-28**

The Conference on Circumcision

15:[1]Some men came down from Jerusalem and started teaching the believers, *"Unless you're circumcised according to the custom of Moses, you can't be saved."* [2]Paul and Barnabas strongly opposed them. The believers appointed Paul, Barnabas, and some others to go up to the apostles and elders in Jerusalem about this controversy. [3]The church sent them forward through Phoenicia and Samaria, reporting extensively on Gentile conversions and bringing a great deal of excitement to those Christians.

[4]When they got to Jerusalem, the church, apostles, and elders welcomed them; and they recounted what God had done with them. [5]But some Pharisees that believed got up to say they needed to circumcise them and charge them to keep the Law of Moses. **Acts 15:1-5**

[6]The apostles and elders got together to look into the issue. [7]After considerable discussion, Peter stood up,

> *"Brothers, you know that some time ago God decided Gentiles would hear the good news from me and believe.* [8]*God knows people's hearts and testified to them by giving them the Holy Spirit like he did to us* Jews. [9]*He didn't make any distinction between them and us. He purified their hearts by trust.* [10]*So why test God now by putting a yoke on the disciples' neck that our ancestors and we couldn't bear?* [11]*We believe that the grace of the Lord Jesus has saved us the same way it has them."* **Acts 15:6-11**

[12]The assembly remained quiet and listened to Barnabas and Paul explain what signs and wonders God had done through them among the Gentiles.

[13]Then James responded,

> [14]*"Simon has recounted how God first took people out of the Gentiles for himself.* [15]*That fits what the prophets have written,*
>
> [16]'***"After that, I'll return***
> ***and rebuild David's fallen tabernacle.***
> ***I'll rebuild it and set it up.***
> **I'll do that so**
> [17]***the rest of mankind can seek the LORD,***
> ***that is, the Gentiles who wear my name,"***
> ***says the LORD that's doing this'*** **[Amos 9:11-12 mainly < LXX],**
> [18]*who is* known from of old.'
>
> [19]*So my judgment is that we stop troubling Gentiles who turn to God,* [20]*but write to them to abstain from defilements with idols, sexual immorality, things*

strangled, and blood; [21]*because for generations people have preached Moses in every city and read about him in the synagogues every Sabbath."* **Acts 15:12-21**

The Conference Answers

[22]The apostles, elders, and the whole church thought it would be good to choose men to send to Antioch with Paul and Barnabas: Silas and Judas called Barsabbas, leaders among the *Jewish* Christians. [23]They wrote,

"Apostles and elders, to Gentiles in Antioch, Syria, and Cilicia. Greetings. [24]*We've heard that some have gone out from us on their own and upset you with their message.* [25]*We met and considered it good to send select men with our dearly loved Barnabas and Paul,* [26]*who've risked their lives for our Lord Jesus* the *Messiah.* [27]*So we've sent Judas and Silas to tell you the same thing orally.* [28]*The Holy Spirit and we considered it good not to lay any burden on you but this:* [29]*abstain from things sacrificed to idols, from blood and things strangled, and from sexual immorality. If you keep yourselves from those, you'll do well. Goodbye."* **Acts 15:22-29**

[30]The ones they sent went down to Antioch, gathered the crowd, and delivered the letter. [31]They were elated over the consolation. [32]Judas and Silas, being prophets, confirmed the converts with additional presentation. [33]When they'd spent *some* time, the Christians there let them go back in peace. [[34]]ms [35]Paul and Barnabas stayed, teaching and preaching the Lord's message along with a host of others. **Acts 15:30-35**

The Parting of Paul and Barnabas

[36]After a time Paul said to Barnabas, *"Let's go back to the towns and cities where we presented the Lord's message and see how the converts are doing."* [37]Barnabas wanted to take John Mark along, [38]but Paul didn't think it was wise to take him because he'd deserted them at Pamphylia instead of going on with them to the work. [39]Such a serious disagreement arose that they separated. Barnabas took Mark and sailed to Cyprus; [40]Paul chose Silas and went out, commended to God's grace. [41]Paul went through Syria and Cilicia, strengthening the churches.

Acts 15:36-41

Paul Continues with the Second Tour

16:[1]He arrived at Derbe and Lystra. A disciple was there named Timothy, son of a Greek father and a Jewess who believed. [2]The Christians in Lystra and Iconium spoke well of him. [3]Paul wanted him to go with him; so he circumcised him because of the Jews in the region; everybody knew his father was a Greek. [4]As they went through the cities, they delivered the decrees to keep that the apostles and elders in Jerusalem had determined. [5]So the churches were growing in faith and number every day. **Acts 16:1-5**

Paul's Vision About Macedonia

[6]They went through Galatia and Phrygia, but the Holy Spirit kept them from presenting the message in Asia. [7]They came up to the border of Mysia and tried to go into Bithynia, but the Spirit of Jesus didn't let them. [8]They went on past Mysia down to Troas. [9]During the night Paul had a vision—a Macedonian man standing and urging him, *"Come over to Macedonia and help us."* [10]When he saw the vision, we planned right away to go to Macedonia because we concluded that God had called us to evangelize them. **Acts 16:6-10**

Paul and Silas at Philippi

[11]We sailed from Troas directly to Samothrace and the next day to Neapolis. [12]*We traveled* from there to Philippi, the main city in that district of Macedonia, *and* a Roman colony. We spent several days there. [13]On the Sabbath we went outside the gate beside the river, where we supposed there was a place of prayer. We sat down and talked to the women who gathered. [14]A woman named Lydia was listening, from the city of Thyatira, a businesswoman dealing in purple fabrics, a God-fearer. The Lord opened her heart to what Paul was saying. [15]When she and her household were baptized, she invited us, *"If you consider me faithful to the Lord, stay at my house."* **Acts 16:11-15**

[16]As we were going to the place of prayer, a servant girl with a spirit of divination met us. Her handlers were profiting from her fortunetelling. [17]She dogged Paul and us, crying out, *"These men serve God Most High. They're telling you how to be saved."* [18]She did that for days on end. Paul was really annoyed and turned to the spirit, *"In the name of Jesus* the *Messiah, come out of her."* It came out that hour.

Paul and Silas Beaten and Jailed

[19]When her handlers saw their prospect for profit disappear, they grabbed Paul and Silas and dragged them to the magistrates in the marketplace, [20]*"These fellows are Jews. They're causing trouble in our city,* [21]*promoting customs that aren't legal for us Romans to observe."* [22]The crowd joined the attack, and the soldiers tore their clothes off and commanded to beat them with rods. [23]When they'd laid many blows on them, they put them in jail and charged the jailor to keep them secure. [24]So he put them in the inner jail and fastened their feet in stocks.

Acts 16:16-24

The Jailor's Conversion

[25]About midnight Paul and Silas were praying and singing hymns to God, and the inmates were listening. [26]Suddenly a severe earthquake shook the foundations of the jail. The jail doors came open, and everybody's bonds came loose. [27]The jailor woke up, saw the doors of the jail open, and drew his sword to kill himself because he assumed the inmates had escaped. [28]But Paul yelled, *"Don't harm yourself; we're all here!"* [29]He asked for a light, rushed in, trembling

with fear, and fell down to Paul and Silas. **30**He brought them outside and said, *"What do I need to do to be saved?"*

31They said, *"Trust*[sg] *in the Lord Jesus, and you and your family will be saved."*

32They spoke the Lord's message to him and everybody in his family. **33**That hour of the night he washed their wounds, and he and his whole family were baptized right then. **34**He took them up to his house, set the table, and rejoiced with his family, having trusted[pl] in God.

Acts 16:25-34

Paul Leaves Philippi

35At daylight, the magistrates sent the police to release Paul and Silas.

36The jailor conveyed that to Paul, *"The magistrates have sent word to release you. Now, have a good day."*

37But Paul told them, *"They beat us in public without a hearing—being Roman citizens—and threw us in jail. Now they send us away secretly? Oh no! They need to lead us out themselves."*

38The police reported that to the magistrates. They were afraid when they heard they were Roman citizens. **39**They came and appealed to them, brought them out, and asked them to leave the city. **40***Paul and Silas* left the jail and went to Lydia's house. When they'd met with the church and encouraged them, they left. **Acts 16:35-40**

Paul in Thessalonica

17:1 They traveled through Amphipolis and Apollonia to Thessalonica. A Jewish synagogue was there. **2**As usual, Paul went in and for three Sabbaths reasoned with them from the scriptures. **3**He showed from predictions that the Messiah had to suffer and arise from the dead, and that, *"This Jesus I'm presenting to you is the Messiah."*

4Some were persuaded and joined Paul and Silas—a good number of God-fearers and prominent women. **5**The Jews got jealous and took some riffraff from the marketplace to form a mob. They set the city in an uproar and assaulted Jason's house, intending to bring *Paul and Silas* out to the public assembly. **6**When they didn't find them, they dragged Jason and some *other* converts to the city authorities, shouting, *"These insurgents against the empire elsewhere have come here too.* **7***Jason has welcomed them. They act contrary to Caesar's decrees, saying there's another king—Jesus."* **8**That stirred up the crowd and the authorities, **9**who made Jason and the rest post bond, then released them. **Acts 17:1-9**

Paul in Berea

10That night their converts sent Paul and Silas to Berea. When they arrived, they went into the Jews' synagogue. **11**These Jews were more open-minded than the ones in Thessalonica. They welcomed the message and examined the scriptures daily to check these things out. **12**Many of them believed, together with quite a few prominent Greek men and women.

[13]When Jews from Thessalonica heard Paul was presenting God's message in Berea, they went there, too, and upset the crowds. [14]Right away the converts sent Paul away as far as the sea, but Silas and Timothy stayed. [15]The ones that went with Paul conducted him to Athens and brought back word for Silas and Timothy to join him as soon as they could. **Acts 17:10-15**

Paul Goes to Athens

[16]While Paul waited for them in Athens, seeing the city full of idols upset him. [17]He reasoned with the Jews and God-fearers in the synagogues and every day with people in the marketplace. [18]Some Epicurean and Stoic philosophers were bantering with him, *"What's this scavenger trying to say?"* Others commented, *"He seems to be presenting strange gods"* (because he was presenting Jesus and the resurrection).

[19]They escorted him to the Areopagus, *"Can we know what this new teaching is you're talking about?* [20]*You're bringing some strange things to us. We want to know what they mean."* ([21]Athenians and foreign visitors typically spent their time telling or hearing something new.)

Acts 17:16-21

Paul's Sermon on the Areopagus

[22]Paul stood up in the Areopagus and said,

> *"Athenians, I observe that you're quite religious in every way.* [23]*As I was looking at your objects of worship, I ran across an altar inscribed, 'To the Unknown God.' What I'm presenting to you then is what you worship without knowing him.* [24]*The God who made the world and everything in it, is LORD of earth and sky;* [25]*so he doesn't live in handmade sanctuaries. People don't serve him as if he needs anything; he gives everybody life, breath, and everything.* [26]*He made the whole human race with one nature to live all over the world, and appointed their times when and boundaries where they live.* [27]*People are to look for God if by chance they grope around and find him, though he's not far from any of us.* **Acts 17:22-27**
>
> [28]*We live and move and exist in him, like some of your poets have said,*
>
> *'We're his offspring.'*
>
> [29]*Since we're God's offspring, we shouldn't think of deity as like gold or silver or stone or an image made from human art and imagination.* [30]*God has overlooked the times of ignorance, but now he tells people everywhere to repent.* [31]*So he has established a time to judge the world in regard to goodness as measured by the man he's appointed. He's given assurance to everybody by resurrecting him."*

[32]When they heard "resurrection," some made fun of it; others said, *"We'll hear you again about this."* [33]So Paul left them. [34]Some *listeners* joined him and believed. Among them was Dionysius the Areopagite, a woman named Damaris, and some others. **Acts 17:28-34**

Paul's Ministry in Corinth

18:1After that, he left Athens for Corinth. 2He found a Jew named Aquila, a native from Pontus, who was recently displaced from Italy with his wife Priscilla. Claudius had ordered all Jews to leave Rome. *Paul* went to them. 3Since he had the same trade, he stayed with them and worked because they were leatherworkers. 4He reasoned in the synagogue every Sabbath in an effort to persuade Jews and Greeks. **Acts 18:1-4**

5When Silas and Timothy came down from Macedonia, Paul started devoting himself to the message. He was solemnly telling the Jews that Jesus was the Messiah. 6When they opposed and slandered *him*, he shook *the dust from* his clothes *at them*, *"Your blood's on your own heads; I'm innocent. From now on I'm going to the Gentiles."*

7He moved from there to the house of Titius Justus, a God-fearer whose house was next to the synagogue. 8Crispus, the synagogue ruler, believed in the Lord along with his household. Many Corinthians heard and believed and were baptized. 9At night the Lord told Paul in a vision, *"Don't be afraid. Speak out* 10*because I'm with you; nobody will harm you. I have lots of people in this city."* 11For a year and a half he settled there and taught God's message. **Acts 18:5-11**

Paul Before Gallio

12While Gallio was proconsul of Achaia, the Jews as a group rose up against Paul and took him to the judgment seat, 13*"This man is persuading people to worship God contrary to* our *Law."*

14Paul was about to speak up when Gallio told them, *"Jews, if it were some crime or fraud he committed, I'd have a reason to hear your case.* 15*But if there are questions about words, names, and your Law, see to it yourselves. I'm not willing to render judgment on such things."* 16He made them leave the judgment seat. 17The bystanders grabbed Sosthenes, the synagogue ruler, and started beating him in front of the judgment seat. Gallio didn't concern himself with any of that. **Acts 18:12-17**

Paul Returns to Antioch

18Paul stayed quite a few more days, said goodbye to the converts, and set sail for Syria with Priscilla and Aquila. He cut his hair in Cenchrea to keep a vow. 19They arrived at Ephesus, and Paul left them there while he went into the synagogue and dialogued with the Jews. 20Although they asked him to stay longer, he declined, 21*"I'll come back, God willing"*; and sailed from Ephesus.

22When he landed at Caesarea, he went up and greeted the church and went down to Antioch. 23After he spent some time there, he left and passed through Galatia and Phrygia, strengthening the disciples. **Acts 18:18-23**

Apollos Preaches at Ephesus

[24]A Jew named Apollos, born in Alexandria, an eloquent speaker, arrived at Ephesus. He knew the scripture well. [25]He'd been orally instructed in the way of the Lord. An enthusiastic man, he was teaching accurately things about Jesus, but he only knew about John's baptism. [26]He began to speak boldly in the synagogue. When Priscilla and Aquila heard him, they took him aside and presented the way of God to him more completely. [27]When he wanted to cross over to Greece, the disciples encouraged him and wrote letters to them to welcome him. When he arrived, he greatly helped the ones that believed by *God's* grace. [28]He powerfully refuted the Jews in public and showed by the scriptures that Jesus was the Messiah. **Acts 18:24-28**

Paul Enters Ephesus

19:[1]While Apollos was in Corinth, Paul took the route through the higher country, and came down to Ephesus and found some disciples. [2]He said, *"Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you believed?"*

They said, *"We've not even heard if the Holy Spirit has come."*

[3]*"So, what were you baptized into?"*

"John's baptism."

[4]Paul said, *"John baptized to repentance and told the people to trust in the One that would come after him, that is, in Jesus."* [5]When they heard that, they were baptized into the Lord Jesus. [6]When Paul laid hands on them, the Holy Spirit came on them, and they began to speak in languages and prophesy. [7]There were about twelve of those men.

[8]He went into the synagogue and spoke boldly for three months, persuading them about God's kingdom. [9]When some started resisting and saying negative things about The Way in public, he separated the disciples from them and reasoned every day in the school of Tyrannus. [10]That went on for two years, so many Jews and Gentiles in Asia heard the Lord's message.

Acts 19:1-10

The Sons of Sceva

[11]God was doing extraordinary miracles through Paul. [12]Even towels and aprons carried from his body made diseases go away and evil spirits come out. [13]Some Jewish traveling exorcists tried to name the Lord Jesus over people that had evil spirits, *"I adjure you by Jesus that Paul preaches."* [14]Seven sons of a Jew named Sceva, a chief priest, were doing that. [15]But the evil spirit answered, *"I know Jesus, I recognize Paul, but who are you?"* [16]The man with the evil spirit overpowered them all, and they fled from the house naked and injured. [17]The Jews and Greeks in Ephesus all heard about it. Everyone became afraid and respected the name of the Lord Jesus. [18]Many believers came and confessed things they'd done. [19]A large number that practiced witchcraft brought their books together and burned them in public. They calculated their value at 50,000 drachmas. [20]That's how powerfully the Lord's message was growing.

[21]After that, Paul decided to go through Macedonia and Greece on the way to Jerusalem. *"After I've been there, I need to see Rome too."* [22]He sent two aides on ahead—Timothy and Erastus, while he stayed in Asia for a while. **Acts 19:11-22**

The Riot in Ephesus

[23]About that time a major disturbance came up about The Way. [24]A silversmith named Demetrius, who made silver shrines of Artemis, was bringing a thriving business to the craftsmen. [25]He gathered them and similar tradesmen,

> *"You know our livelihood depends on this craft. [26]You also see that in Ephesus and most of Asia this Paul has misled a sizable crowd, saying that handmade gods aren't gods. [27]Our business is in danger of losing its reputation, people will discount the Temple of the great goddess Artemis, and she that Asia and the world worship will lose her grandeur."* **Acts 19:23-27**

[28]That infuriated them, and they started shouting, *"Great* is *Artemis of the Ephesians!"* [29]The city was in turmoil. They rushed into the amphitheater, dragging Gaius and Aristarchus of Macedonia, Paul's companions. [30]When he wanted to go into the amphitheater, the disciples wouldn't let him. [31]Some Asiarchs that were friendly to him also sent word, urging him not to go into the theater. [32]Some were shouting one thing, some another. The mob descended into confusion; most didn't know what the gathering was about. [33]Some people supposed Alexander had caused the uproar since the Jews had put him forward. He motioned with his hand to make a defense to the people. [34]But when they realized he was a Jew, one outcry erupted from everybody for about two hours, *"Great* is *Artemis of the Ephesians!"* **Acts 19:28-34**

[35]After the secretary of the city quieted the crowd, he said,

> *"Ephesians, who doesn't know that Ephesus is temple keeper for the great Artemis and the image that fell from Zeus? [36]Since no one can deny that, you need to come to order and not do something rash. [37]You haven't accused these men of committing sacrilege or blaspheming our goddess. [38]If Demetrius and associate craftsmen want to file suit against them, the courts are in session and proconsuls are available. They can bring charges against one another. [39]If you want anything else, it'll be settled in lawful assembly. [40]We're in danger of being charged with rioting over today's affair because there's no reason for it. We won't be able to account for this uproar."*

[41]He dismissed the assembly. **Acts 19:35-41**

Paul Travels Through Macedonia and Greece

20[:1]After the uproar, Paul sent for the disciples. When he'd encouraged them and said goodbye, he left for Macedonia. [2]After he passed through that area and encouraged them a lot, he

went to Greece [3]for three months. The Jews laid a plot against him as he was getting ready to sail to Syria; so he decided to go back through Macedonia. [4]With him were Sopater son of Pyrrhus from Berea; the Thessalonians Aristarchus and Secundus; Gaius of Derbe; Timothy, and the Asians Tychicus and Trophimus. [5]They went on ahead and waited for us in Troas. [6]After the days of Unleavened Bread, we sailed from Philippi and met them in Troas in five days and stayed seven. **Acts 20:1-6**

Paul's Farewell to Troas

[7]On the first day of the week, when we got together to break bread, Paul started speaking, He intended to leave in the morning and kept speaking till midnight. [8]Quite a few lamps were in the upstairs room where we gathered. [9]A young man named Eutychus was sitting on the windowsill. As Paul kept speaking for a long time, Eutychus went sound asleep and fell from the third floor. They picked him up for dead. [10]When Paul went down, he knelt beside him, took him in his arms, and said, *"Don't worry; he's alive."* [11]He went back up and broke the bread and ate. After he talked for a long time till daybreak, he went out directly like he was. [12]They brought the boy alive and were really relieved. **Acts 20:7-12**

Paul Sails from Troas to Miletus

[13]We went on ahead to the ship and sailed to Assos, intending to pick up Paul there. That's the arrangement he'd made; he planned to go on foot himself. [14]We took him on board at Assos and went on to Mitylene. [15]From there, we arrived the following day across from Chios, the next day came near Samos, and the day after that made it to Miletus. [16]Paul had decided to sail on past Ephesus to keep from spending time in Asia. He was pushing to get to Jerusalem by Pentecost if he could. **Acts 20:13-16**

Paul Addresses the Ephesians

[17]From Miletus he sent to Ephesus for the church elders. [18]When they came, he said,

"From the day I first came to Asia, you know how I operated among you.
[19]I served the Lord with humility, tears, and trials that came on me from plots by the Jews. [20]I told you everything profitable as I taught you publicly and from house to house. [21]To Jews and Greeks I solemnly preached repentance toward God and trust in our Lord Jesus. [22]Now I'm determined to go to Jerusalem. I don't know what will happen there. [23]In every city the Holy Spirit declares that bonds and sufferings are waiting for me. [24]But I don't consider my life of any value to myself, so I can finish my course in the ministry I received from the Lord—to speak the good news about God's grace. **Acts 20:17-24**

[25] *"Now I've presented God's kingdom among you, and I know you won't see me again.* [26]*So I tell you today, I'm innocent of everybody's blood.* [27]*I've explained to you God's whole plan.* [28]*Pay attention to yourselves and the flock the Holy Spirit has given you to oversee. Shepherd God's church that he bought with the blood of his own Son.* [29]*After I leave, I know fierce wolves are going to come in and not spare the flock.* [30]*Even from you, men will rise up and say perverse things to lure away disciples.* [31]*So pay attention; remember that for three years day and night I warned each one with tears.* [32]*Now I entrust you to God and his grace. It can build you up and provide you an inheritance among the sanctified.* [33]*I haven't coveted anybody's gold, silver, or clothes.* [34]*You know these hands have provided for my needs and the ones that were with me.* [35]*In everything I've shown you that by working this way you should help the weak and remember the words of the Lord Jesus,* 'It's more blessed to give than to receive*.'"*

[36]Then he knelt down with them and prayed. [37]They began to cry out loud, hug him, and kiss him. [38]They grieved especially over his comment that they wouldn't see him again. They went with him to the ship. **Acts 20:25-38**

Paul Continues to Jerusalem

21[:1]When we'd left them, we sailed directly to Cos, the next day to Rhodes, and from there to Patara. [2]We found a ship crossing over to Phoenicia, boarded it, and set sail. [3]We came within sight of Cyprus; we passed it on the left, kept sailing to Syria, and landed at Tyre, where the ship was to unload its cargo. [4]We looked up the disciples and stayed there a week. They kept telling Paul by the Spirit not to go to Jerusalem. [5]When our time there was over, we started our trip. With their wives and children, they escorted us outside the city. After kneeling on the beach and praying, [6]we said goodbye to one another. We got on the ship, and they went back home.

Acts 21:1-6

[7]When we'd finished the voyage from Tyre and to Ptolemais, we greeted the disciples and stayed with them for a day. [8]The next day we reached Caesarea and went into the house of Philip the evangelist—one of the seven—and stayed with him. [9]He had four virgin daughters that prophesied.

[10]During our several days there, a prophet from Judaea named Agabus came down. [11]He took Paul's belt and tied up his own hands and feet, and said, *"This is what the Holy Spirit says, 'The man this belt belongs to, the Jews in Jerusalem are going to tie up and deliver to Gentiles.'"* [12]When we heard it, we and the locals urged and urged Paul not to go up.

[13]He answered, *"What are you doing, crying and breaking my heart? I'm ready to be bound and even to die in Jerusalem for the Lord Jesus."*

[14]When we couldn't change his mind, we quit *trying*, *"The Lord's will be done."*

[15]After those days we got ready and went up to Jerusalem [16]along with some disciples from Caesarea. They took us up to Mnason of Cyprus, a long-time disciple we would stay with.

Acts 21:7-16

Paul Visits James

[17]The believers in Jerusalem welcomed us warmly. [18]The next day Paul went in with us to see James, and the elders were there. [19]After he'd greeted them, he recounted one thing after another that God had done among the Gentiles through his ministry. [20]The ones that heard it, began to praise God,

> *"You see, how many thousands among the Jews believe, all zealous for the Law.* [21]*People have told them that you teach the Jews among the Gentiles to leave Moses, not circumcise their children, or keep the customs.* [22]*So what can we do? They'll certainly find out you're here.* [23]*We have four men under a vow.* [24]*Take them and purify yourself with them; sponsor them so they'll shave their heads. Everybody will know there's nothing to what people have told them about you, but that you live orderly and keep the Law.* [25]*As to Gentile believers, we wrote that they should abstain from meat offered to idols, blood, things strangled, and sexual immorality."*

[26]The next day Paul took the men, purified himself with them, went into the Temple, and gave notice that they'd completed *their* days of purification, till the sacrifice for each one was offered.

Acts 21:17-26

Paul's Arrest in the Temple

[27]Near the end of the seven days, Jews from Asia saw him in the Temple and stirred up the crowd and attacked him, [28]*"Men of Jerusalem, help. This is the man that teaches everybody against the people, the Law, and this place. Now he's brought Gentiles into the Temple and profaned this holy place."* [29]Previously they'd seen Trophimus the Ephesian in the city with Paul and supposed he'd taken him into the Temple. [30]The city erupted into an uproar. The people ran together, grabbed Paul, and dragged him out of the Temple. Immediately they shut the doors. [31]While they were trying to kill him, a report went up to the tribune of the Roman cohort that Jerusalem was in an uproar. [32]At once he took soldiers and centurions and ran down to them. When they saw the tribune and the soldiers, they stopped beating Paul. [33]The tribune came and took him and told *the soldiers* to bind him with two chains. He began asking who he was and what he'd done. [34]Some in the crowd shouted one thing, some another. He couldn't find out the truth because of the uproar, so he told *the soldiers* to take him into the barracks. [35]When *Paul* got on the stairs, the soldiers carried him because of the crowd violence. [36]The people were following, yelling, *"Away with him!"*

Acts 21:27-36

Paul Speaks to the Tribune

[37]At the entrance to the barracks, Paul said to the tribune, *"Can I speak to you?"*

He said, *"You know Greek?* [38]*So you're not the Egyptian that master-minded a revolt some time back and led the 4,000 Assassins out into the desert?"*

[39]Paul said, *"I'm a Jew from Tarsus in Cilicia, a citizen of a prominent city. Please, let me speak to the people."*

[40]With his permission, Paul stood on the stairs and motioned to the people. After a great hush settled in, he spoke in Hebrew. **Acts 21:37-40**

Paul Recounts His Conversion

22:1 *"Brothers and fathers, listen to my defense."* [2]When they heard him speaking Hebrew, they got quieter.

[3] *"I'm a Jew;* I was *born in Tarsus in Cilicia but raised in this city. I was educated under Gamaliel strictly according to the law of our ancestors and was as zealous for God as you are today.* [4]*I persecuted The Way to death, binding and jailing men and women* [5]*as the high priest and presbytery can confirm. I got letters to go to Damascus and bind the ones that had gone there and extradite them to Jerusalem to punish them.* **Acts 22:1-5**

[6]*As I got close to Damascus about noon, a bright light suddenly shined around me.* [7]*I fell on the ground and heard a voice, "Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?'*

[8] *"I answered, 'Who are you, Sir?'*

'I'm Jesus the Nazarene that you're persecuting.'

[9] *"The ones that were with me saw the light but couldn't make out what he was saying to me.*

[10] *"I said, 'What should I do, Lord!?'*

"'Get up and go into Damascus. Somebody there will tell you.'

[11] *"When I couldn't see from the brilliance of that light, the ones that were with me led me by the hand into Damascus.* **Acts 22:6-11**

[12] *"A man was there named Ananias. He was devout according to the Law, a man the Jews living there vouched for.* [13]*He came and stood by me, 'Brother Saul, receive your sight.' I looked at him that very hour.*

[14] *"He said, 'Our ancestors' God chose you ahead of time to know his will, to see the Righteous One, and to hear him.* [15]*You're to speak for him to all people about what you've seen and heard.* [16]*Now why wait? Get baptized and wash your sins away, calling on him.'* **Acts 22:12-16**

[17] *"When I came back to Jerusalem and was praying in the Temple, I fell into a trance,* [18]*and saw him telling me, 'Get out of Jerusalem now; they won't accept your testimony about me.'*

[19] *"I said, 'Lord, they know that in every synagogue I was jailing people in bonds who believed in you.* [20]*When Stephen your witness shed his blood, I stood by approving and keeping the clothes for the ones that were killing him."*

[21] *"He said, 'Go; I'm sending you away to the Gentiles.'"* **Acts 22:17-21**

Responses to His Address

[22]They listened that far, but then they started shouting, *"Away with such a fellow. Don't let him live!"* [23]They started yelling and tearing their clothes and throwing dust in the air. [24]The tribune ordered the soldiers to bring him into the barracks and interrogate him by scourging to find out why they were shouting about him that way.

[25]As they were stretching him out with straps, Paul said to the centurion supervising, *"Is it legal to scourge a Roman that hasn't been condemned?"*

[26]When the centurion heard that, he went to the tribune, *"What are you doing? This man's a Roman!"*

[27]The tribune came and said, *"Tell me, are you a Roman?"*

"Yes."

[28]He responded, *"This citizenship cost me a lot of money."*

Paul said, *"I was born Roman."*

[29]At once the ones that were going to interrogate him stepped away. The tribune was worried when he found out Paul was a Roman and he'd bound him. **Acts 22:22-29**

Paul Before the Sanhedrin

[30]The next day he was still wanting to know why the Jews were accusing Paul. The tribune took off Paul's bonds and commanded the chief priests and full Sanhedrin to meet. He took Paul down and put him in front of them. **23:1**Paul looked straight at the Sanhedrin, *"Brothers, in good conscience I've conducted myself as a citizen toward God up to this day."* [2]Ananias the high priest commanded the ones that were standing by him to slap him in the mouth.

[3]Paul said, *"God's going to slap you, you whitewashed wall! You sit judging me by the Law and command them to slap me in violation of the Law."*

[4]The ones that were standing there said, *"You insult God's high priest?"*

[5]Paul said, *"Brothers, I was not aware that he was a high priest. The scripture does say,*

'Don't say bad things about a ruler of your people'" **[Ex 22:28].** **Acts 22:30-23:5**

[6]Knowing one part was Sadducees and the other was Pharisees, he started shouting, *"I'm a Pharisee, the son of a Pharisee! I'm on trial for having hope in the resurrection!"*

[7]Dissension erupted between the Pharisees and Sadducees. [8]Sadducees say there's no resurrection, angel, or spirit; Pharisees profess them all. [9]During the uproar, some scribes from

the Pharisees' party stood up, protesting violently, *"We don't find anything wrong with this man! What if a spirit or angel spoke to him?"*

10As the conflict grew, the tribune was afraid they'd tear Paul limb from limb. He commanded the troops to rescue him and bring him back into the barracks.

11That night the Lord stood by him, *"Don't be afraid. As you've spoken for me in Jerusalem, you need to speak* for me *in Rome."* **Acts 23:6-11**

Jewish Plot to Kill Paul

12The next day, some Jews took a binding oath not to eat or drink till they'd killed Paul. **13**More than 40 men instigated that plot. **14**They came to the chief priests and elders, *"We've taken a binding oath not to taste anything till we've killed Paul.* **15***Now* <u>*you*</u> *and the Sanhedrin inform the tribune to bring him down as if to find out more accurately the issues about him. Before he gets close,* <u>*we're*</u> *prepared to kill him."*

16Paul's nephew heard about the ambush, went into the barracks, and let Paul know. **17**Paul called a centurion, *"Take this young man to the tribune; he has something to tell him."*

18He took him to the tribune, *"The prisoner Paul asked me to bring you this young man. He has something to tell you."*

19The tribune took his hand and withdrew privately, "*What do you have to report?"*

> **20***"Some Jews have agreed together to ask you to take Paul down into the Sanhedrin tomorrow as if to ask something more accurately about him.* **21***Don't let them persuade you. More than 40 of them are lying in ambush. They've taken an oath not to eat or drink till they've killed him. They're ready now and waiting for your promise.*

22The tribune let him go, *"Don't tell anybody you told me about this."* **Acts 23:12-22**

23He called 2 centurions, *"Get 200 soldiers ready, 75 cavalrymen, and 200 infantrymen to leave for Caesarea at 9:00 tonight.* **24***Provide mounts to deliver Paul safely to Felix the governor."*

25He wrote a letter to this effect:

> **26***"Claudius Lysias to most excellent Governor Felix.*
>
> **27***The Jews arrested this man and were trying to kill him when I came on them with troops and rescued him, when I discovered he was a Roman citizen.* **28***To learn why they were accusing him, I took him down into their Sanhedrin.* **29***I found out they were accusing him about questions in their Law, not about anything that deserves bonds or death.* **30***I was informed about a plot against him and sent him to you at once. I have instructed his accusers to bring charges against him in your hearing."* **Acts 23:23-30**

Paul Sent to Caesarea

[31]So the soldiers took Paul to Antipatris during the night. [32]The next day they left the cavalrymen to go with him the rest of the way while they came back to the barracks. [33]When they got to Caesarea and delivered the letter to the governor, they also presented Paul to him. [34]After he read it, he asked what province he was from. When he learned he was from Cilicia, [35]he said, *"I'll give you*[sg] *a hearing when your accusers get here."* He gave orders to keep Paul in Herod's Praetorium. **Acts 23:31-35**

Paul's Accusers Come

24:[1]Five days later, the high priest Ananias came down with some elders and an orator, Tertullus. They brought charges to the governor against Paul. [2]After Felix called for Paul, Tertullus began accusing him to the governor,

> *"We've experienced considerable peace because of you, and your foresight has led to reforms for this nation.* [3]*With gratitude we welcome them, most excellent Felix, in every way and everywhere.* [4]*But not to detain you further, kindly grant us a brief hearing.* [5]*We've found this man a troublemaker, who stirs up Jews all over the empire, the ringleader of a sect, the Nazarenes.* [6]*He even tried to desecrate the Temple, and we arrested him. [*[7]*]*[ms] [8]*You can question him yourself and find out the things we're accusing him of."*

[9]The Jews joined in the attack, claiming those things were so. **Acts 24:1-9**

Paul's Defense Before Felix

[10]When the governor nodded to him, Paul spoke:

> *"I know that for many years you've judged this nation, so I'm glad to make my own defense about these claims.* [11]*You can learn that not more than twelve days ago I went up to Jerusalem to worship.* [12]*They didn't find me debating or attacking anybody in the Temple, in the synagogues, or in the city.* [13]*They can't prove to you any of these accusations.* [14]*I do admit that according to The Way, which they're calling a 'sect,' I serve our ancestors' God, and believe everything written in the Law and the Prophets.* [15]*In God I have a hope these men themselves share, that the just and unjust will resurrect.* **Acts 24:10-15**
>
> [16]*I always do my best to have a clear conscience toward God and* other *people.* [17]*After some years I was bringing offerings and charitable gifts to my nation.* [18]*In that connection they found me in the Temple, not with a crowd or making a disturbance.* [19]*Some Jews from Asia—they should be here to raise accusation if they have anything against me.* [20]*Or, let* <u>*these*</u> *men specify what they*

found wrong with me when I stood in the Sanhedrin—[21]*other than I shouted, 'I'm being judged today about the resurrection from the dead!'"* **Acts 24:16-21**

Paul Kept in Custody

[22]Because he knew more accurately about The Way, Felix put them off, *"When Lysias the tribune comes down, I'll decide your case."* [23]He ordered the centurion to keep him in custody but give him some freedom and let his friends help him.

[24]After some time, Felix with Drusilla his wife, a Jewess, sent for Paul and was listening to him about faith in Jesus the Messiah. [25]As he talked about right living, self-control, and judgment to come, Felix became uneasy, *"Go away for now; I'll call you when I have time."* [26]Besides, he was hoping Paul would give him a bribe; so he would send for him often and talk to him.

[27]After two years, Porcius Festus succeeded Felix. To gain favor with the Jews, Felix left Paul behind in prison. **Acts 24:22-27**

Paul's Appeal to Caesar

25:[1]Festus arrived in the province and after three days went up to Jerusalem from Caesarea. [2]The chief priests and leading men of the Jews filed charges against Paul. [3]They were demanding a favor against him—to call him to Jerusalem (laying an ambush along the way). [4]Festus answered that he would keep Paul in Caesarea and that he himself was going there soon. [5]*"Have qualified men come down with me and prosecute him if something's wrong with him."*

Acts 25:1-5

[6]Eight or ten days later, he went down to Caesarea. The next day he sat on the judgment seat and commanded to bring Paul. [7]When he arrived, the Jews from Jerusalem stood around him and brought many serious accusations they couldn't prove.

[8]Paul spoke on his own behalf, *"I haven't done anything against the Law of the Jews, the Temple, or Caesar."*

[9]Felix wanted to do the Jews a favor, so he asked Paul, *"Are you willing to go up to Jerusalem and stand trial in front of me there about these matters?"*

[10]Paul said, *"I'm standing at Caesar's judgment seat, where I should be judged. I've not done anything against the Jews, as you very well know.* [11]*If I'm guilty of something that deserves death, I'm willing to die. But, if there's nothing to these accusations, nobody can hand me over to them. I appeal to Caesar."*

[12]Festus conferred with the council and said, *"You've appealed to Caesar; you'll go to Caesar."* **Acts 25:6-12**

Festus Presents Paul's Case to Agrippa

13Several days later, King *Herod* Agrippa *II* and Bernice arrived in Caesarea and greeted Festus. **14**When they'd spent several days there, Festus presented Paul's case to the king,

"Felix left a prisoner behind. **15***When I was in Jerusalem, the chief priests and elders of the Jews filed charges against him and asked for his condemnation.* **16***I told them that Roman law doesn't hand anyone over till the accused meets the accusers and has a chance to defend himself.* **17***After they assembled here, I didn't lose any time. The next day I sat on the judgment seat and had the man brought in.* **18***The accusers stood up and started bringing accusations against him that weren't like the crimes I'd supposed.* **19***They disagreed with him about their religion and about a dead Jesus that Paul claimed was alive.* **20***Uncertain what to do with the controversy, I asked if he'd go to Jerusalem and stand trial on these things.* **21***When he appealed to Caesar, I commanded that he be held in custody till I sent him up to Caesar."*

22Agrippa said, *"I've been wanting to hear him myself. Tomorrow I will."* **Acts 25:13-22**

23The next day Agrippa and Bernice came with great pomp and went into the auditorium with the tribunes and prominent men of the city. Festus commanded to bring Paul.

24Festus said,

"King Agrippa and you[pl] that are here with us, you see this man that the Jews in Jerusalem and here have appealed to me about, shouting that he has to die. **25***I didn't find that he'd committed any capital offense. Since he appealed to Caesar, I decided to send him.* **26***I don't have anything definite to write to my superior; so I've brought him to you[pl], especially you, King Agrippa, to have something to write after this investigation.* **27***It doesn't make sense to send a prisoner without specifying the charges."* **Acts 25:23-27**

Paul's Defense Before Agrippa

26:1 Agrippa said to Paul, *"You can speak for yourself."*

Paul stretched out his hand,

2*"In light of the things the Jews accused me of, King Agrippa, I consider myself fortunate to present my own defense today,* **3***especially since you're familiar with Jewish customs and issues. So please listen patiently.*

4*The Jews know my way of life from my youth, which I spent in my own nation in Jerusalem.* **5***If they're willing to admit it, they know I lived before as a Pharisee, the strictest sect of our religion.* **6***Now I stand in judgment for having hope in God's promise to our ancestors.* **7***Our twelve tribes sincerely hope to obtain that promise as they serve God every day. In regard to that hope, the Jews are accusing me.* **8***Why do you[pl] consider it unbelievable that God raises the*

dead? [9]*At one time I thought I needed to do a lot of things against Jesus the Nazarene.* [10]*That's what I did in Jerusalem. Not only did I lock up many saints in jail with authority from the chief priests; but when they were being sentenced to execution, I voted against them.* [11]*I punished them often in every synagogue and tried to make them blaspheme. I was insanely furious and persecuted them even to foreign cities.* **Acts 26:1-11**

The Third Account of Paul's Conversion

[12] *"In that effort, I was traveling to Damascus with authority from the chief priests.* [13]*In the middle of the day, King Agrippa, I saw a light from the sky brighter than the sun, shining around me and the ones that were with me.* [14]*When we'd fallen to the ground, I heard a voice speaking in Hebrew, 'Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me? It's hard for you to keep kicking against the goads.'*

[15] *"I said, 'Who are you, Sir?'*

"I'm Jesus that you're persecuting. [16]*Get up. I've appeared to you to appoint you as a witness to what you've seen and what I'll show you.* [17]*I'll protect you from the people and from the Gentiles, where I'm sending you.* [18]*Open their eyes so they'll turn from darkness to light, from the power of Satan to God, so they'll receive forgiveness and an inheritance among the ones that become holy by trusting in me."*

[19] *"So, King Agrippa, I obeyed the heavenly vision.* [20]*First to the people in Damascus, Jerusalem, and Judaea, then to the Gentiles, I continually declared they should repent toward God and do what's appropriate to repentance.* [21]*That's why some Jews grabbed me in the Temple and tried to murder me.* [22]*I've obtained help from God till today and speak to small and great simply what the Prophets and Moses said would happen:* [23]*the Messiah needed to suffer, and by resurrection he would present light first to the* Jews *and* then *to the Gentiles."*

Acts 26:12-23

Paul Appeals to Agrippa to Believe

[24]While Paul was delivering his defense, Festus shouted, *"Paul, your extensive learning is driving you crazy!"*

[25] *"I'm not crazy, most excellent Festus; I'm speaking sensible truth.* [26]*The king that I'm confidently speaking to, knows about these matters. I'm sure none of it has escaped his attention; it didn't happen off in a corner somewhere.* [27]*King Agrippa, do you believe the prophets? I know you do."*

[28]Agrippa said, *"With a little* urging *are you trying to persuade me to become a Christian?"*

[29]Paul said, *"I wish to God, whether by little or much, you and everybody listening today would become like me except for these bonds."*

[30]The king, the governor, Bernice, and those sitting with them got up. [31]When they'd gone aside, they said to one another, *"He hasn't done anything that deserves bonds or death."*

[32]Agrippa told Festus, *"He could've been released if he hadn't appealed to Caesar."*

Acts 26:24-32

Paul's Voyage to Rome

27:[1]When they decided we would sail to Italy, they turned Paul and some other prisoners over to Julius, a centurion of the Augustan cohort. [2]We boarded a ship out of Adramyttium, ready to sail to places along the coast of Asia. We put out to sea along with Aristarchus, a Macedonian from Thessalonica. [3]The next day we harbored at Sidon. Julius was nice to Paul and let him go to friends and refresh himself. [4]We launched from there and sailed under the shelter of Cyprus because the winds were against us. [5]After we navigated the open sea along the coast of Cilicia and Pamphylia, we landed at Myra in Lycia. [6]The centurion found an Alexandrian ship there that was sailing for Italy and put us on board. [7]For a number of days, we sailed slowly, and barely made it to Cnidus. Since the wind didn't let us sail under the shelter of Crete along Salmone, [8]we drifted along it with difficulty and came to a place called Fair Havens near the city of Lasea.

[9]When considerable time had passed and the voyage was getting risky—even the Fast *[Yom Kippur]* was past, Paul started advising them, [10]*"Men, I sense the voyage will involve damage and considerable loss of cargo, the ship, and our lives."* [11]But the centurion listened more to the captain and the ship owner than to Paul. [12]Because the harbor wasn't suitable for wintering, the majority decided to sail from there if they could just get to Phoenix—a harbor at Crete facing southwest and northwest—and winter there. **Acts 27:1-12**

The Storm at Sea

[13]When a gentle breeze came up, they supposed they'd achieved their purpose. They weighed anchor and started sailing along Crete as close to shore as they could. [14]But not long afterwards, a nor'easter called Euraquilo rushed down from land [15]and caught the ship. It couldn't face the gale; so we gave way to it and scudded along. [16]We ran under a small island called Cauda and were barely able to secure the dinghy. [17]After they hoisted it up, they used cables to gird up the ship. They were afraid they might run aground on Syrtis, so they let down the sail and drifted along. [18]The next day, the storm tossed us violently, and *the crew* began to throw cargo overboard*. [19]The third day, they threw the ship's tackle overboard by hand. [20]When the sun and stars didn't appear for several days, and the monstrous storm bore down on us, we lost all hope of surviving. **Acts 27:13-20**

[21]When they'd gone a long time without eating, Paul stood up among them,

"Men, you should've listened to me and not sailed from Crete and incurred this damage and loss. [22]*Now I urge you to take heart. There won't be any loss of life, just the ship.* [23]*Last night an angel of the God I serve stood by me,* [24]*'Don't be afraid, Paul; you need to stand in front of Caesar, and God has granted you everybody that's sailing with you.'* [25]*So take heart; I believe it will turn out like he said,* [26]*but we have to run aground on an island."* **Acts 27:21-26**

[27]The fourteenth night, the storm was driving us around in the *Sea of* Hadria. About midnight the sailors sensed we were nearing land, [28]so they took a sounding and found the depth was 120 feet. A little farther on, another sounding showed 90 feet. [29]Fearing we might run aground on a rocky coast, they cast four anchors out the stern and longed for daylight. [30]The sailors tried to jump ship by lowering its dinghy into the water on the pretense of laying out anchors from the bow. [31]Paul told the centurion and *his* soldiers, *"If those* sailors *don't stay on the ship, you*[pl] *won't make it."* [32]The soldiers cut the ropes to the dinghy and let it fall off.

[33]At early dawn, Paul started urging everybody to eat, *"Today makes two weeks you've been on edge, not eating.* [34]*Eat for your survival. Not a hair of your head will perish."*

[35]When he'd said that, he took a loaf, thanked God in front of them all, broke it up, and starting eating. [36]They took heart and started eating too. [37]There were 276 of us on board. [38]When they'd eaten enough, they lightened the ship by throwing the wheat overboard.

Acts 27:27-38

The Shipwreck on Malta

[39]When it got daylight, they didn't recognize the land, but they noticed a creek with a beach. They decided, if possible, to save the ship. [40]They cut the anchors loose and left them in the sea. At the same time, they took loose the ropes of the rudders, hoisted the foresail to the wind, and headed for the beach. [41]But they struck a mud bar where two currents met. The prow stuck fast and wouldn't budge, and the force of the waves started tearing the stern apart. [42]The soldiers intended to kill the prisoners so none of them could swim away and escape. [43]But the centurion wanted to take Paul safely through and stopped them. He told the ones that could swim to jump overboard and get to land first. [44]The rest would float there on planks or items from the ship. That way everybody got to shore. **Acts 27:39-44**

Paul's Winter Stay on Malta

28[:1]When we'd made it safely, we learned the island was Malta. [2]The locals were especially nice to us and received us all. Because of the rain and cold that had set in, they built a fire. [3]When Paul had gathered a bundle of sticks and laid them on the fire, a snake came out of the wood from the heat and fastened on his hand. [4]The locals saw it and said to one another, *"He*

must be a murderer that survived the sea, but Justice didn't let live." [5]He shook it loose into the fire and wasn't harmed. [6]They were expecting him to swell up or suddenly fall down dead. But after a good while not seeing anything unusual, they started saying he was a god.

[7]Around that place were lands that belonged to Publius, the Principal in the island. He welcomed us and entertained us for three days. [8]His father lay sick with dysentery and bouts of fever. Paul went in to see him, prayed, laid hands on him, and healed him. [9]After that, other sick people on the island started coming to be healed. [10]They greatly honored us; and *later,* when we set sail, they put on board what we needed. **Acts 28:1-10**

Paul's Arrival in Rome

[11]After three months, we sailed on an Alexandrian ship that had wintered on the island—it had The Twin Brothers (Dioscuri/Twin Sons of Zeus) as its figurehead. [12]We harbored at Syracuse for three days, [13]then sailed around to Rhegium. A day later, a south wind came up, and the second day we made it to Puteoli. [14]We found disciples there, who invited us to stay with them for a week. And so we got to Rome. [15]From there disciples heard about us and came to meet us as far as Three Taverns and The Forum of Appius. When Paul saw them, he thanked God and took heart. [16]When we went into Rome, *the centurion* let Paul stay by himself with a soldier guarding him. **Acts 28:11-16**

Paul's Witness in Rome

[17]Three days later he called together the Jewish leaders,

> *"Brothers, though I hadn't done anything against the people or the customs of the forefathers, the Jews delivered me to the Romans as a prisoner from Jerusalem.* [18]The Romans *examined me and were willing to release me because there wasn't any reason to execute me.* [19]*When the Jews objected, I had to appeal to Caesar, though I didn't have anything against my nation.* [20]*I asked to speak to you because I'm wearing this chain on account of Israel's hope."*

[21]They said, *"We haven't received any letters about you from the Jews, and none of the brothers have come to report anything bad about you.* [22]*We do want to hear what you think, because we know that people everywhere speak against this sect."* **Acts 28:17-22**

[23]On a day they appointed him, quite a number came to where he roomed. From morning to evening, from the Law of Moses and the Prophets, he talked about God's kingdom and made efforts to persuade them about Jesus. [24]What he said persuaded some, but not others. [25]When they disagreed with each other, they left at Paul's one comment,

"The Holy Spirit described your ancestors well in Isaiah the prophet,

[26]***'Tell this people,***

"You certainly hear, but don't understand;

you certainly see, but don't perceive
[27]because you've become insensitive;
you're hard of hearing, and
you've closed your eyes
so you don't see or hear,
understand or change
so I can heal you"' **[Is 6:9-10].**

[28]*Understand, then, that God has sent this salvation to the Gentiles; they'll listen."* [[29]]ms **Acts 28:23-29**

Paul's Two-Year Imprisonment in Rome

[30]For two whole years Paul stayed in his own rented quarters and received everyone that came to him. [31]He presented God's kingdom without interference and taught boldly about the Lord Jesus as the Messiah. **Acts 28:30-31**

ROMANS

Salutation

1:1 Paul, servant of Christ[Messiah] Jesus, called *to be* an apostle, and set apart to deliver the good news **2**God promised through his prophets in the scriptures. **3-5**That news is about his Son, David's son by descent—physically, and God's Son by designation—spiritually as to holiness. *God* powerfully *designated him such* by raising him from the dead. Through Jesus Christ our Lord we've received grace and apostleship for making obedient faith available to Gentiles. **6**Among them you, too, are the called *people* of Jesus Christ.

7To God's loved ones in Rome, called *to be* holy: grace and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ. **Rom 1:1-7**

Desire to Visit the Romans

8First, I'm grateful to my God for you, *grateful* through Jesus Christ because everywhere in the world people are talking about your faith. **9**God's my witness—that I serve in my spirit for the good news about his Son—I think about you constantly. **10**In my prayers I always plead that, somehow by God's will, I can eventually come to you. **11**I long to see you so I can share some spiritual gift that will help make you secure *in the faith*. **12**That way I'll be encouraged among you by the faith we share. **13**I want you to know that I've often intended to come but couldn't. *I've wanted* to accomplish something among you like I've done among the rest of the Gentiles. **14-15**I'm obligated to preach to Gentiles and barbarians, to wise and foolish, and to you in Rome.

Rom 1:8-15

Life by Trust

16I'm not ashamed of the good news. It's God's power for bringing salvation to everybody that trusts, to Jews first and to Gentiles. **17**The good news reveals a goodness that comes from God through a growing trust *in him.* The scripture says, ***"A good person will have life by trusting"*** **[Hab 2:4]**. **Rom 1:16-17**

Foolishness of Disbelief

18God reveals from heaven his displeasure at ungodliness and at unjust people that suppress the truth by *their* injustice. **19**He does that because what they know about God is evident in them because he made it clear to them. **20**Ever since he created the universe, what he's created clearly makes visible the invisible things about him, namely his eternal power and divine nature. So people don't have any excuse. **21**They knew God but didn't give him his rightful place as God or practice gratitude. They gave themselves over to foolish speculation and their senseless hearts went dark. **22**While they claimed to be smart, they became dumb **23**and exchanged the glory of the immortal God for images of mere mortals, birds, four-footed animals, reptiles. **Rom 1:18-23**

God's Giving People Up

[24]So because of lusts in their hearts, God gave them up to unclean *behavior*—to dishonoring their bodies between themselves. [25]They exchanged the truth about God for a lie and worshiped and served what was created instead of the One that created, who is blessed forever. Amen. [26]God gave them up to dishonorable desires. Their females exchanged *their* natural sexual relationships for what's contrary to nature. [27]Males left their natural sexual relationships with females and burned in lust for other males, males with males, committing shameful acts and receiving in themselves the payback that's appropriate to their delusion. [28]Even as they didn't see fit to have God in what they knew, God gave them over to a perverted mind. [29]*They were* filled with sinfulness, wickedness, greed, malice, jealousy, murder, strife, deception, meanness, gossip, [30]slander, hatred for God, arrogance, boasting, disloyalty, evil scheming, disobedience to parents. [31]*They were* without understanding, untrustworthy, unloving, unmerciful. [32]They knew God's standards and *knew* that people who practice such things deserve to die; but they did them *anyway* and delighted in people that did them. **Rom 1:24-32**

God's Just Judgment

2[:1]So you[sg] that condemn don't have any excuse. When you condemn someone else, you condemn yourself, because you're doing the same things. [2]You know it's right for <u>God</u> to condemn people that do things like that. [3]Do you suppose—condemner of another while doing the same things yourself—that <u>you</u> are going to escape his condemnation? [4]Do you disregard his rich kindness, tolerance, and patience, and not understand that his kindness is for leading you to repentance? [5]Because of your stubborn, unrepentant heart, you're storing up displeasure for yourself when God reveals his just condemnation. [6]He'll pay back every person for what they've done. [7]*That will mean* eternal life for people who strive for glory, honor, and immortality by carrying through in good works. [8]*It'll mean* displeasure and anger for people that chase after injustice. [9]*There'll be* trouble and distress for everybody that does evil, for Jews first and for Greeks. [10]But *there'll be* honor and peace for everybody that does good, for Jews first and for Greeks. [11]God doesn't play favorites: [12]as many as have sinned without having the Law will perish without *having* it; as many as have sinned under it will be condemned by it. [13]It's not who <u>hears</u> the Law that's good, as far as God's concerned; it's who <u>does</u> *the Law*. [14]When Gentiles that don't have the Law, naturally do what's in it, they are governing themselves. [15]They show that the Law is written on their hearts. Their conscience testifies, and *their* thoughts defend or accuse one another. [16]*That's the basis for judgment* when God by Christ Jesus judges people's secrets by the good news I'm presenting. **Rom 2:1-16**

Criticism and Moral Consistency

[17]But if you wear the name Jew, rely on the Law, take pride in God—[18]*if you* know his will, approve of superior things because of what the Law teaches you—[19]*if you*'re confident that you're a guide to the blind, a light to people in the dark, [20]a corrector of the foolish, a teacher of the ignorant because you have the knowledge and truth that's in the Law—[21]then do you teach others, but not learn yourself? You that preach against stealing, do you steal? [22]You that say people shouldn't commit adultery, do you commit adultery? You that detest idols, do you steal from temples? [23]You that take pride in the Law, do you dishonor God by breaking it? [24]***"Gentiles blaspheme God because of you"*** **[Is 52:5]**, like the scripture says. [25]Circumcision benefits you if you practice *the* Law. If you transgress it, your circumcision amounts to uncircumcision. [26]If then the uncircumcised keep the Law's standards, won't their uncircumcision be considered circumcision? [27]If the naturally uncircumcised keep the Law, won't they condemn literal-and-circumcised transgressors of the Law? [28]It's not the Jew outwardly that's *a Jew*, and it's not outward circumcision that's *circumcision*. [29]It's the Jew inwardly that's a Jew, and it's the circumcision of the heart—spirit, not letter—that's circumcision. Their praise doesn't come from people, but from God. **Rom 2:17-29**

The Advantage Jews Had

3:[1] So, what advantage does a Jew have? What's the benefit of circumcision? [2]A lot, in a lot of ways. *The* first *advantage is* that God entrusted *the Jews* with his messages. [3]So what if some *Jews* were unfaithful? Their <u>un</u>faithfulness doesn't do away with <u>God's</u> faithfulness, does it? [4]Goodness, no! Let God be true and everyone else a liar, like the scripture says,

" . . . that you can be regarded
as right in what you say
and correct in the judgments you make" **[Ps 51:4].**

[5]If our unrighteousness highlights God's righteousness, we wouldn't say, would we, that God's not fair in inflicting *his* displeasure? (I'm speaking here for the sake of argument.) [6]Goodness, no! How would he judge the world? [7]*We wouldn't say, would we, that* since our lie highlights God's truth, he shouldn't consider us sinners? [8]We wouldn't *say, would we*—as some accuse us of saying, *"Let's do evil to bring about good"*? (They deserve condemnation!) **Rom 3:1-8**

Nobody's Good

[9]So are we any better *than Gentiles*? Not at all! We've already said *that* Jews and Gentiles are both sinners [10]like the scripture says,

"Not one is good,
not one.
[11]***Nobody understands;***
nobody seeks God.

[12]***They've all turned away;***
as a group they've become depraved.
None of them are kind,
not even one does good **[Ps 14:1-3; 53:1-3].**
[13]***Their throat's an open grave;***
they deceive with their tongues **[Ps 5:9]*;***
there's snake venom behind their lips **[Ps 140:3]*;***
[14]***their mouth is full of cursing and spite*** **[Ps 10:7]*;***
[15]***their feet run to shed blood;***
[16]***ruin and misery lie in their paths;***
[17]***they don't know the path to peace*** **[Is 59:7-8].**
[18]***There's no respect for God in their eyes*** **[Ps 36:1].**

[19]We know that what the Law is saying *here*, it's saying to people that are under it; so *by saying "not a one,"* it shuts everybody up, *including Jews.* The whole world—*Gentiles* <u>*and*</u> *Jews*—becomes exposed to God's condemnation, [20]because what people <u>do</u> under <u>law</u> doesn't make them good; law *only* tells them what's sinful. **Rom 3:9-20**

Goodness by Trust

[21]Now, aside from <u>law</u>, a goodness from <u>God</u> has come to light, *a goodness* the Law and prophets talk about: [22]a goodness from <u>God</u> through <u>trusting</u> in <u>Jesus Christ</u> whether by <u>Jew or Gentile</u>. [23]Everybody has sinned and falls short of God's glory; [24]his grace freely justifies them through the redemption that comes through Christ Jesus. [25]He's the One that God appointed *as a* basis for forgiveness by trusting in his blood. *Putting him forward* demonstrates God's goodness in overlooking sins previously committed [26]during the time when he puts up with *them*. *Putting Christ forward* demonstrates *God's* goodness now, so he's both just and justifier of people that trust in Jesus. **Rom 3:21-26**

Humility Under Justification by Trust

[27]So where can boasting come in? It can't. By what kind of "law"? *Can it come by a "law"* caused by what we do *under law?* No, *it's replaced* by a "law" conditioned on trust *in another—God*. [28]We reason that trust justifies us apart from what we do under law. [29]Or is God the God over Jews only? Isn't he God over Gentiles too? Yes. [30]Since there's one God, he's the One that justifies the Circumcision <u>and</u> the Uncircumcision *and does it the same way*—by trust. [31]So are we contradicting law by *advocating* trust? Goodness, no! We're establishing *the purpose of* law *another way*. **Rom 3:27-31**

Abraham and David

4:[1]What can we say, then, our ancestor Abraham discovered? [2]If what he did, justified him, he had something to feel good about, but not toward God. [3]What does the scripture say? ***"Abraham trusted God, and God considered him righteous"*** **[Gen 15:6]** *because of it.* [4]In the case of people that are producing *righteousness*, the consequence—*being considered righteous*—doesn't come from God or his grace; he would owe it to them *to consider them righteous*. [5]But for those who are not producing *righteousness* but are trusting the One that considers the ungodly as righteous, their trusting God *to do that* is considered righteousness. [6]David speaks about the "good fortune" of people *God* considers righteous aside from law,

> [7]***"'Fortunate' are the ones whose unlawful deeds God forgives,***
> ***whose sins he covers.***
> [8] ***'Fortunate' are the people whose sin the LORD***
> ***doesn't hold against them"*** **[Ps 32:1-2]**.

[9]Is the "good fortune" *only* on the circumcised, or *is it* on the uncircumcised too? We've said, ***"God considered Abraham righteous because he trusted"*** **[Gen 15:6]**. [10]When did God consider him righteous? When he was circumcised or uncircumcised? When he was uncircumcised. [11]He received the circumcision sign as a seal for the righteousness he'd received by trusting when he was uncircumcised. *And he received it as a seal* that he would be the father of everybody that, without being circumcised, trust that God will consider them righteous *like he did Abraham*. [12]*His circumcision was* also *a seal* that he would be the father of the uncircumcised who walk in his footsteps while he was uncircumcised. **Rom 4:1-12**

The Promise to Abraham

[13]The promise to Abraham and his descendants—that he'd inherit the world—didn't come by law, but by righteousness conditioned on trusting. [14]If law can cause people to be heirs, trust is null and promise is void. [15]Law brings *God's* displeasure, but where there's no law there's no violation of it. [16]So righteousness comes by trust so it can come by grace and make the promise sure for all of *Abraham's* seed, whether they're under law or under the trust he had who is "father" of us all: [17]the scripture says, ***"I've appointed you to be the father of many nations"*** **[Gen 17:5]**. He trusted God, who makes the dead live and speaks of things that aren't *yet* as if they *already* are. [18]Hoping against hope, he trusted that he would become *"the father of many nations,"* like God said, ***"That's how your seed will be"*** **[Gen 15:5]**. [19]He wasn't weak in trust but considered his own body as good as dead—he was about 100—and Sarah's womb as dead too. [20]He didn't hesitate to trust God's promise but grew strong in trust. He praised God, [21]confident that what he'd promised, he could do. [22]So, ***"God considered him righteous"*** **[Gen 15:6]**. [23]Now that wasn't written just about him, [24]but about us too. God will consider us "righteous" who trust in the One that resurrected our Lord Jesus—[25]who was delivered up for our trespasses and resurrected for our justification. **Rom 4:13-25**

Extreme Grace

5:[1]We've been justified by trusting, and we express trusting God by trusting our Lord Jesus Christ. [2]*The Christ* gives us access to this grace that we stand in. *Because of it*, we rejoice in the hope that comes from *our* glorious God. [3]Not only that, but we can even rejoice in hardships because we know they produce endurance, [4]which produces character, which produces a hope [5]that doesn't disappoint because God keeps pouring out his love into our hearts through the Holy Spirit he gave us. [6]When we were still weak, in due time Christ[Messiah] died for the ungodly. [7]Hardly anybody is *willing* to die even for somebody that's good. Somebody might, [8]but God has shown[p] us how much he cares about us because Christ[Messiah] died for us while we were still sinners. [9]More than that, if his blood has justified us, we're safe from God's displeasure. [10]If the death of his Son reconciled us to God while we were estranged, now that he's reconciled us, his life will continue to save us from condemnation. [11]All the while, we take pride in God through his Son who reconciled us. **Rom 5:1-11**

Adam and Christ in Contrast

[12]So, as through one man, sin—hence death—entered the world, death passed on to everybody because everybody has sinned. [13]Before the Law, there was sin in the world, but sin isn't held against a person if there's no law. [14]But, death did prevail from Adam to Moses even over the ones that hadn't sinned like Adam did—who corresponds to the One that was to come. **Rom 5:12-14**

[15]But the gracious gift isn't like the sin. In the one case, many died because one sinned. In the other case, many received abundant grace because of God's gracious gift and the one man Jesus Christ. [16]The gracious gift isn't like what came through the one sinner; the judgment *that came* in connection with one sin *led* to condemnation, but the gracious gift *that came* in connection with many sins *led* to justification. [17]If death prevailed because of one man's sin, much more will life prevail—in the ones that receive abundant grace and bestowed righteousness—because of the One, Jesus Christ. [18]As by the sin of one *there was what led* to condemnation for all people, so by one act of righteousness *there is* justification that leads to life for all people. [19]As by one man's disobedience many became sinners, so by One *man's* obedience many will become righteous. [20]The Law came in besides to increase sin, but where sin increased grace multiplied. [21]So as sin prevailed in death, grace could prevail in righteousness to eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord. **Rom 5:15-21**

Death to Sinning

6:[1]So should we say, *"Let's keep sinning so there'll be more grace"*? [2]Goodness, no! How can we who died to sin keep living in it? [3]Don't you know that we who were baptized into

Christ Jesus, were baptized into his death? [4]Baptism buried us with him into death. As the Father gloriously raised Christ from the dead, we too can live in a new life. [5]If we've participated in what's like his death, we'll participate in what's like his resurrection. [6]Know this: our old self was crucified with him to destroy the sinful body so we wouldn't serve sin anymore. [7]Whoever dies is justified from sin. [8]If we've died with Christ, we believe we'll live with him. [9]We know that since Christ arose from the dead, he won't die again, and death doesn't have control over him. [10]The death he died, he died to sin once and for all; the life he lives now, he keeps living to God. [11]We consider ourselves dead to sin too, but alive to God in Christ Jesus. **Rom 6:1-11**

"Enslaved" to Righteousness

[12]So don't let sin prevail in your mortal body by yielding to its drives. [13]Don't keep offering your members as tools for unrighteousness. Offer yourselves to God as alive from the dead, and offer your members to him as tools for righteousness. [14]Sin won't be controlling you because you're under grace, not law.

[15]What then? Should we sin because we're under grace instead of law? Goodness, no! [16]Don't you know that whatever you yield to, you're 'slaves' to—*'servants'* to sin, *which leads* to death or 'servants' to obedience, *which leads* to righteousness? [17]Thank God, though you used to be servants to sin, you've obeyed from the heart the type of teaching you received. [18]You've been freed from sin and put 'in servitude' to righteousness ([19]an illustration to help you understand). As you 'put yourselves in servitude' to unrighteousness and increasing lawlessness, now 'put yourselves in servitude' to righteousness and holiness. [20]When you were servants to sin, you were 'free' from righteousness. [21]So, what things were you producing then that you're ashamed of now? Their outcome *was* <u>death</u>. [22]Now that you're free from sin and 'in servitude' to God, you're producing holiness, whose outcome *is* eternal <u>life</u>. [23]The wages of sin *is* death, but the gracious gift of God *is* life in Christ Jesus our Lord. **Rom 6:12-23**

The Marriage Comparison

7:[1]Don't you know, you that know the Law, that it applies to someone as long as the person's alive? [2]The Law ties a woman to her husband as long as he's alive. If he dies, she's free from the law about husbands. [3]So while he's alive, she'd be an adulteress if she joined herself to another man. But if her husband dies, she's free from the law, and she's not an adulteress if she joins herself to another man. [4]So, through the Christ's body you also died to the Law and united with someone else—who resurrected—so you could bear fruit to God. [5]When you were in the flesh, *its* sinful desires that were through the Law worked in your members to bear fruit that led to death. [6]Now you're released from the Law because you've died to what imprisoned you. As a result, you're serving in the new spirit, not in the old letter. **Rom 7:1-6**

Indwelling Sin

[7]What should we say then? *Is* the Law sinful? Goodness, no! But I wouldn't have known sin if it weren't for the Law. I wouldn't have known coveting if the Law hadn't said, ***"Do not covet"*** **[Ex 20:17; Deut 5:21]**. [8]Sin used the commandment to produce all kinds of covetousness in me. Apart from law, sin *is* dead. [9]I was alive apart from law at one time; but when the commandment came, sin came to life [10]and I died. The commandment that was meant to bring me life turned out to bring *me* death. [11]Sin used the commandment to lead me astray and kill me. [12]So the Law *is* holy, and the commandment *is* holy, just, good. **Rom 7:7-12**

Inner Conflict

[13]So, did what was good kill me? Goodness, no! Sin—to show itself for what it was—killed me by using the commandment. By using the commandment, sin became extremely sinful. [14]We know the Law is spiritual, but I'm physical, sold like a servant to sin. [15]I can't figure out what I'm doing. I don't do what I want to do; I do what I hate. [16]If I'm doing what I don't want to do, I agree the Law's good. [17]I'm no longer doing it; sin's doing it in me. [18]I know nothing good lives in me—in my flesh. Wanting to do good is present, but doing it isn't. [19]I don't do the good I want to do; I do the evil I don't want to do. [20]If I'm doing what I don't want to do, I'm not doing it; sin's doing it in me. [21]I find the principle that evil lies in me who wants to do good. [22]In my heart of hearts, I delight in God's Law, [23]but in my members I see another pattern of operation that's in conflict with the pattern of operation that's in my mind. That pattern is imprisoning me in the sin that's in my members. [24]Miserable man! Who's going to rescue me from this death-filled body? [25]Thank God, our Lord Jesus Christ! So, I serve God with *my* mind but serve sin with *my* flesh. **Rom 7:13-25**

Freedom Through Christ

8:[1]So *there's* no condemnation in Christ Jesus. [2]The life-producing spirit that operates in him has freed you from law that produces sin and death. [3]What the Law couldn't do because it operated through weak flesh, God *did* by sending his Son in the form of sin-oriented flesh to deal with sin in the flesh and put it in its place. [4]So the goodness the Law called for, you can fulfill by living according to the spirit instead of the flesh. [5]People that live in a flesh-oriented way focus on material things; people that live in a spirit-oriented way focus on things that are not material. [6]The fleshly mentality leads to a dead end; the spiritual mentality leads to life and peace. [7]So the flesh-oriented mentality opposes God because it doesn't—and can't—be in submission to his Law. [8]People that live in a flesh-oriented way can't be pleasing God. [9]But, we're not flesh-oriented, but spirit-oriented if God's Spirit lives in us. If we don't have Christ's spirit, we don't belong to him. [10]If Christ is in us, the body *is* dead because of sin, but the spirit *is* alive because

of goodness. [11]If the Spirit of the one that resurrected Jesus is living in us, the One that resurrected Christ will make our mortal bodies alive by the Spirit that is living in us. **Rom 8:1-11**

Living Above the Flesh

[12]So, we're not obliged to live in a flesh-oriented way. [13]We'll die if we live that way. But, we'll live if by spirit we put to death the misdeeds of flesh. [14]As many as God's spirit leads, are God's children. [15]We didn't receive again a sense of bondage resulting in fear, but a sense of sonship that calls out *'Father!'* [16]The Spirit himself testifies with our spirit that we're God's children. [17]If *we're* children, then *we're* heirs, God's heirs, fellow heirs with Christ—if we suffer with *him* so we can be glorified with *him*. **Rom 8:12-17**

Longing for the Eternal

[18]I don't consider the sufferings of this time worth comparing to the glory that'll be revealed. [19]Creation's deep longing waits for *that* revelation to God's children. [20]Creation's been subjected to worthlessness, not willingly, but by the One who subjected it in hopes [21]of freeing it from bondage to decay *and delivering it* to the glorious freedom of God's children. [22]Up till now the whole creation has been groaning in birth pains. [23]We, too, who have the firstfruits of the Spirit, long to be adopted as children, and to have our bodies redeemed. [24]Hope has saved us but hope that we can see isn't hope. [25]We hope for what we don't see, and patiently long for it.

[26]And, the Spirit helps our weaknesses. We don't know what to pray for, but he intercedes for us with sighs we can't say. [27]The One who examines hearts understands what our spirits mean and intercedes for the saints in a way that harmonizes with God's will. [28]We know everything works out for good for those who love God and are called in a way that fits with his purpose. [29]The ones he foreknew he predestined to conform to the image of his Son so he'd be the oldest of many brothers. [30]The ones he predestined he called, justified, and glorified.

Rom 8:18-30

Trials Don't Show Separation from God

[31]What's that tell us? If God's for us, who's against us? [32]If he didn't spare his own Son, but offered him up for us all, how will he not graciously give us everything we need? [33]Who's going to level accusation against God's chosen people? He justifies; who condemns? [34]Jesus Christ *is* the One that died and, beyond that, resurrected to God's right hand to intercede for us. [35]What's going to separate us from the love Christ has for us? Trouble, distress, persecution famine, nakedness, danger, or sword? [36]As the scripture says,

"We're killed all day long for your sake;
we're considered sheep for slaughter" **[Ps 44:22].**

[37]In all these things, we more than conquer through the One who loved us. [38]I'm confident that death or life, angels or rulers, present or future things, powers, [39]height or depth, or any other created thing, can't separate us from the love God has for us in Christ Jesus our Lord. **Rom 8:31-39**

God's Choice of Israel

9[:1-2]Truth is, in Christ I have constant sorrow in my heart. I'm not lying; my conscience confirms *it* in the Holy Spirit: [3]I'd be willing to be cut off from the Christ[Messiah] for my fellow Jews, my physical relatives, [4]Israelites, who have the adoption as children, the honor, the covenants, the Law, the *divine* service and worship, the promises. [5]They're the ones that descended from the ancestors, and from them physically came the Christ[Messiah], who's over all, God blessed forever! Amen! **Rom 9:1-5**

[6]It's not that God's message has failed. Not all of Israel's descendants *are* "Israel." [7]Not all of Abraham's descendants *are* "children": ***"Your lineage will be counted through Isaac"*** **[Gen 21:12]**. [8]That means it's not physical children that are God's children, but promised children that God counts as descendants. [9]The promise was, ***"At that time I'll come, and Sarah will have a son"*** **[Gen 18:10, 14]**. [10]That's not all. Rebekah conceived from our ancestor Isaac. [11-12]Before she had *the twins* or they had done anything good or bad, God told her, ***"The older will serve the younger"*** **[Gen 25:23]**. That pictures how God's purpose would come from his choosing, not their doing—*a purpose that came* from the One who called. [13]As the scripture says,

"I loved Jacob more than Esau" **[Mal 1:2-3]**.

[14]We aren't going to say God's unjust, are we? Goodness, no! [15]He told Moses,

"I'll decide who to give grace
and who to show mercy" **[Ex 33:19]**.

[16]So things don't happen because somebody wants them to or because somebody's controlling things, but because God's showing mercy. [17]The scripture tells Pharaoh, ***"I raised you up specifically to show my power in connection with you and to make myself known in the whole world"*** **[Ex 9:16]**. [18]So he has mercy on whoever he wants to and makes stubborn whoever he wants to. **Rom 9:6-18**

God's Displeasure and Mercy

[19]Will you say to me then, *"Why does he find fault? Who's resisting his will?"* [20]Mere mortal, who are you to get smart with God? What's formed doesn't say to the one who formed it, *"Why'd you make me like this?"* [21]Doesn't a potter have the right from the same lump to make a container for elegant purposes or menial ones? [22]So what if God, wanting to demonstrate his displeasure and make his power known, puts up with containers fit for destruction [23]so he can make known his abundant honor on containers he shows mercy to—containers he prepared

ahead of time for honor? [24]We're *those containers that have been prepared for honor*, that he called from Jews and Gentiles. [25]As he says in Hosea,

"I'll call them my people that weren't my people;
I'll call them friends that weren't friends **[Hos 2:23].**
[26]***Where it was said, 'You're not my people,'***
they'll be called 'children of the living God'" **[Hos 1:10].**

[27]Isaiah cried out in regard to Israel,

"Though the number of Israelites is like sand by the sea,
only a remnant will be saved.
[28]***The LORD will thoroughly and quickly***
carry out his word in the world" **[Is 10:22-23; Hos 1:10].**

[29]As Isaiah said before,

"If the LORD hadn't left us a seed,
we'd be like Sodom and Gomorrah" **[Is 1:9]** **Rom 9:19-29**

Righteousness by Law *vs.* Trust

[30]What are we going to say then? *We're going to say* that Gentiles received righteousness who didn't pursue it, a righteousness that comes from trust. [31]But Israel pursued a righteousness that comes from law and didn't attain it. [32]Why? Because they didn't pursue it by trust, but by what they did themselves. They stumbled over the stone that "trips" people up. [33]Like the scripture says,

"I'm laying a stone in Zion that people trip over,
a rock that causes *them* ***problems.***
Whoever trusts him won't be disappointed" **[Is 28:16].** **Rom 9:30-33**

10[:1]My heart's desire and prayer to God is for their salvation. [2]I admit they have a zeal for God, but they don't know what they're doing. [3]They don't understand the righteousness that comes from God, and they try to establish their righteousness by themselves. They haven't submitted to the righteousness God gives. [4]For everybody that trusts, Christ puts an end to law as a way to achieve righteousness. **Rom 10:1-4**

[5]As to righteousness under law, Moses writes, ***"The one that does them is the one that will have life by them"*** **[Lev 18:5].** [6]But goodness that comes from trust says, ***"Don't say in your heart, 'Who'll go up into the sky?*** **[Deut 30:12]"** (that is, to bring Christ down); [7]or, *'Who'll go down into the ground'***?** (that is, to raise Christ up from the dead).*"* [8]But what does it say?

"The message is near you—
in your mouth and in your heart" **[Deut 30:14].**

That's the "message" about trust, *the message* we preach. [9]If you acknowledge Jesus *as* Lord and trust in your heart that God raised him from the dead, he'll "save" you. [10]With your heart you

trust to *be* <u>*considered*</u> upright; with your mouth you confess to <u>receive</u> salvation. **11**The scripture says, ***"He won't disappoint those who <u>trust</u> in him"*** **[Is 28:16]**. **12**There's no difference between Jew and Greek because the same Lord is Lord of both; he's rich toward <u>everybody that calls on him</u>. **13*"The LORD will save <u>everybody that calls on him</u>"*** **[Joel 2:32]**. **Rom 10:5-13**

Making Salvation by Trust Available

14How will people call on somebody they don't <u>believe</u> in? How will they believe in somebody they haven't heard about? How will they hear *about him* without a messenger? **15**How will they <u>bring</u> the message if they're not sent? Like the scripture says, ***"How welcome they are that <u>bring</u> <u>good news</u>!"*** **[Is 52:7; Nah 1:15]** **16**But not everybody has obeyed the <u>good news</u>. Isaiah says,

"LORD, who's believed our report?" **[Is 53:1]**

17So faith *comes* from hearing—hearing *the message* about Christ. **18**But I say, the Israelites have heard, haven't they?

"Their testimony went out all over the world,
and their words to the ends of the earth" **[Ps 19:4]**.

19But I say, Israel surely didn't know, did they? First, Moses says,

"I'll make you jealous by what's not a nation;
I'll anger you by a nation that doesn't understand" **[Deut 32:21]**.

20Isaiah is bold,

"People found me that weren't looking for me;
they saw me who weren't asking about me" **[Is 65:1]**.

21He tells Israel,

"All day long I've held out my hands
to a disobedient, stubborn people" **[Is.65:2 LXX]**. **Rom 10:14-21**

Israel's Remnant

11:1 So God hasn't set his people aside, has he? Goodness, no! I'm an Israelite too, a descendant of Abraham from the tribe of Benjamin. **2**God hasn't set aside the people he chose ahead of time. Don't you know what the scripture says in the passage about Elijah? He pleads with God against Israel,

3*"LORD, they've killed your prophets*
***and torn down your altars*;**
I'm the only one left,
and they're trying to kill <u>me</u>" **[1 Kg 19:10]**.

4How does God answer him?

"I've reserved for myself 7,000
that haven't bent a knee to Baal" **[1 Kg 19:18]**.

[5]It's the same way now. By God's grace there's a remnant. [6]If it's by *God's* grace, it's not from what *the remnant* does. Otherwise, grace wouldn't be grace. [7]So what's the point? What Israel's looking for, it hasn't found, but the Chosen have found *it.* The rest became stubborn. [8]Like the scripture says,

> ***"To this day, God has put them in a stupor,***
> ***eyes that can't see,***
> ***ears that can't hear"*** **[Deut 29:4; Is 29:10].**

[9]David says,

> ***"Let their table become a snare and a trap,***
> ***a <u>stumbling</u> block and payback.***
> [10]***May their eyes grow dim so they can't see;***
> ***bend their backs always"*** **[Ps 69:22-23].**

[11]So, they didn't <u>stumble</u> and fall down, did they? Goodness, no! By their sin, salvation has come to the Gentiles to make the Jews jealous. [12]If their sin enriches the world and their failure enriches the Gentiles, how much more their full number!

[13]I'm talking to you Gentiles now. Since I'm an apostle to Gentiles, I highlight my ministry [14]if somehow I can make my fellow Jews jealous and save some of them. [15]If the Jews' rejecting means reconciling the world, what will their accepting *be* except a return from the dead? [16]If the original piece *of dough is* holy, the whole lump's holy. If the root's holy, so are the branches. **Rom 11:1-16**

The Olive Tree Parable

[17]If some branches were removed and you, a wild olive tree, were grafted in among them and partook of the nourishment from the root of the olive tree, [18]don't feel superior to the *original* branches: you don't *support* the root; it *supports* you. [19]You may say, *"Branches were removed so I could be grafted in."* [20]Right. But they were removed because they didn't trust, and <u>you</u> stand by trust *as well*. Don't get smug; be reverent. [21]If God didn't spare the natural branches *because they didn't trust*, he won't spare you *either*. [22]So pay attention to God's kindness <u>and</u> severity. For the ones that fell, severity; but for you, God's kindness—<u>if</u> you stay in his kindness. Otherwise, <u>you</u>'ll be removed too. [23]And if <u>they</u> don't keep distrusting, God will graft them back in; he can do that. [24]If God took <u>you</u> out of a naturally wild olive tree and grafted you unnaturally into a cultivated olive tree, much more will he graft <u>them</u> into their own olive tree. **Rom 11:17-24**

Israel's Salvation by Trust

[25]I want you to understand this mystery so you won't feel smug: a hardening has come over Israel in part till the full number of Gentiles comes in. [26]That's the way all Israel will be saved, like the scripture says,

"A deliverer will come out of Zion;
he'll turn away ungodliness from Jacob.
[27]***That's my covenant with them***
when I take away their sins" **[Is 59:20-21].**

Israel's Continuing Responsibility

[28]As far as the good news is concerned, *they're* enemies for your sake; as far as *God's* choice is concerned, *they're* highly regarded for their ancestors' sake. [29]God's gifts and calling *to them* aren't being revoked *here*. [30]You once disobeyed God but have now received mercy because they disobeyed. [31]In turn, they've now disobeyed because God showed mercy to you to prod them to receive mercy. [32]God has locked everyone up in disobedience so he could have mercy on everyone. **Rom 11:25-32**

[33]The depth of God's wealth, wisdom, and knowledge! His judgments are so unknowable, his ways so unfathomable!

[34]***"Who has known the LORD's mind?***
Who was his counselor? **[Is 40:13 LXX; Job 15:8; Jer 23:18]**
[35]***Who gave to him first***
to have it paid back **to him*?"*** **[Job 35:7; 41:11]**

[36]Everything is from him, by him, and for him. Glory to him forever! Amen. **Rom 11:33-36**

Christians as Living Sacrifices

12[:1]So I urge you by God's mercies to present your bodies *as* living sacrifices, holy *and* pleasing to God; *that's* your spiritual service. [2]Don't conform yourselves to this world; transform yourselves by renewing your mind so you can discern what God's will *is—what's* good, pleasing, and perfect.

[3]By the grace God gave me, I say to everyone among you not to think more of yourselves than you should. Think properly as measured by the faith God has allotted to each *of you*. [4]There are many parts to one body, and they don't all serve the same purpose. [5]That's how it is with the many of us that are in Christ. Individually we're interdependent parts with one another. [6]We have different gifts according to God's grace. If *our gift is* prophecy, *let's prophesy* in accordance with our faith. [7]If *it's* service, *let's carry out our commitment to him* in *our* service. If *it's* teaching, *let's do it* in teaching. [8]If *it's* encouraging, *let's do it* in encouragement. If *it's* sharing, *let's do it* liberally. If *it's* leading, let's *do it* diligently. If *it's* showing mercy, *let's do it* cheerfully. **Rom 12:1-8**

[9]Love has to be genuine. Hate what's bad; hold onto what's good. [10]*Devote yourselves* to one another in brotherly love. Look up to one another in showing honor. [11]Be diligent, *be* enthusiastic in spirit, serve the Lord. [12]Rejoice in hope, endure adversity, devote yourselves to

prayer, [13]share in the saints' needs, show hospitality to strangers. [14]Bless people that persecute you; don't curse them. [15]Rejoice with those who are rejoicing; cry with those who are crying. [16]Take the same attitude toward other people that *you take toward* yourself. Don't be proud; associate with humble people. Don't consider yourself smart. [17]Don't pay back evil for evil. Be careful to do what's good in front of everybody. [18]As much as comes from <u>your</u> part, live peacefully with everyone. [19]Don't take revenge, dear friends; walk away from anger. The scripture says,

> ***"'Revenge belongs to me;***
> ***I'll take care of it,' the LORD says"*** **[Lev 19:18]**.

[20]But,

> ***"If your enemy's hungry, feed him;***
> ***if he's thirsty, give him a drink.***
> ***If you do that,***
> ***you'll pour hot coals on his head"*** **[Pro 25:21-22]**.

[21]Don't let evil overcome you; you overcome evil with good. **Rom 12:9-21**

Respect for Political Rulers

13:[1]Every person needs to submit to higher authorities, because there's no authority except by God's *approval*. God has established the authorities that exist. [2]So if a person resists them, he's resisting what God has established, and he'll be condemned for it. [3]Rulers don't bring fear for good behavior, but for bad. You shouldn't be afraid of authority. Do what's right, and you'll be praised for it. [4]They're God's ministers to you for good. If you do what's wrong, be afraid; they don't carry a sword for nothing. They punish people for doing bad things. [5]So you need to submit, not only to avoid punishment, but for conscience sake. [6]For the same reason, pay *your* taxes, because they're God's ministers, who dedicate themselves to those very things. [7]Pay everybody what's due to them—taxes, customs, respect, honor. **Rom 13:1-7**

Call for Renewed Goodness

[8]Don't owe people anything except to love them. The one that loves another fulfills the Law. [9]***"Do not commit adultery, murder, steal, covet"*** **[Ex 20:13-15, 17; Deut 5:17-19, 21]** or any other commandment is summed up in ***"Love your neighbor as yourself"*** **[Lev 19:18]**. [10]Love doesn't do anything bad to a "neighbor;" so it fulfills the Law.

[11]*Do* that because you know it's time to get up from sleeping. Your salvation's nearer now than when you came to believe. [12]Nighttime is far gone and daytime's coming; so lay aside what people do in the dark and pick up the tools used in daylight. [13]Live respectably in the daylight, not with carousing and indecency, rivalry and jealousy. [14]Put on the Lord Jesus Christ, and don't cater to physical drives. **Rom 13:8-14**

Cautiously Accepting Weak Brothers

14:1 Accept people that are weak in faith, and don't pass judgment on the way they think. **2**One person believes he can eat anything, but a weak person *just* eats vegetables. **3**The one that eats must not look down on the one that doesn't; the one that doesn't eat must not criticize the one that does. **4**What right do you have to criticize somebody else's household servant? He stands or falls to his own Lord. And, he will stand because the Lord can make him stand. **5**One person considers one day more important than another; another person considers every day alike. Each one should be fully confident in his own mind. **6**The one that observes a day observes *it* to the Lord; the one that eats, eats to the Lord because he thanks God. The one that doesn't eat, doesn't eat to the Lord, and thanks God. **7**None of us live to ourselves or die to ourselves. **8**If we live, we live to the Lord; if we die, we die to the Lord. So whether we live or die, we're the Lord's. **9**That's why Christ died and came to life so he could serve as Lord of the living and the dead. **10**And why criticize[sg] your fellow Christians or look down on them? We'll all stand at God's judgment seat. **11**The scripture says,

> ***"'As sure as I live,' the LORD says,***
> ***'every knee will bend to me;***
> ***every tongue will acknowledge me'"*** **[Is 49:18 + 45:23].**

12So each one of us will give account of himself to God. **Rom 14:1-12**

13Don't criticize one another anymore. Determine[pl] not to make your brother or sister stumble. **14**I'm convinced that no thing *is* unclean in itself, but it is unclean to someone that considers it unclean. **15**If you're grieving your fellow Christian by what you're eating, don't destroy with food the one Christ died for. **16**Don't let people slander your goodness. **17**God's kingdom doesn't have to do with what you eat or drink; it has to do with goodness, peace, joy in the Holy Spirit. **18**A person that serves Christ that way is acceptable to God and respectable to people. **19**So let's follow what makes for peace and what helps one another. **20**Don't tear down God's work by what you eat. Everything's pure, but it's not pure for people that feel like they're offending *God* when they eat it. **21**It's good not to eat meat or drink wine or *do* anything that makes someone stumble. **22**Exercise your faith in front of God according to your own convictions *on such matters*. People are fortunate that don't condemn themselves by what they approve of. **23**If they have doubts about what they're eating, they stand condemned because they're not doing it out of a good conscience. Anything that doesn't arise from a good conscience is sin. **Rom 14:13-23**

Bearing with the Weak

15:[1]We that are strong need to bear with people's weaknesses, instead of pleasing ourselves. [2]Let's make every effort to be pleasing to our neighbors for *their* good, so we can build them up. [3]Christ didn't please himself; like the scripture says,

"The insults from the ones that insulted you
have fallen on me" **[Ps. 69:9b].**

[4]What was written earlier was written to instruct us so that by patience and the scriptures' encouragement we could have hope. [5]May God, who is patient and encouraging, influence you to take the attitude toward one another that Jesus Christ takes *toward us*. [6]That way with united voice you can praise the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ. **Rom 15:1-6**

[7]So accept one another like Christ accepted you to God's honor. [8]I tell you, the Christ has become a minister for the Circumcision for God's truth, for confirming *his* promises to the ancestors, [9]and for the Gentiles to praise God for *his* mercy—like the scripture says,

"I'll acknowledge you among the Gentiles;
I'll sing praises to you" **[Ps 18:49].**

[10]Again it says,

"Gentiles, rejoice with his people" **[Deut 32:43];**

[11]and,

"Praise the LORD, every nation;
praise him, all peoples" **[Ps 117:1].**

[12]Again Isaiah says,

"A root will come out of Jesse,
One who rises up to govern the Gentiles.
They'll put their hope in him" **[Is 11:10].**

[13]Now may the God who gives "hope," fill you with joy and peace in your faith so you'll have high "hopes" by the power of the Holy Spirit. **Rom 15:7-13**

[14]My siblings *in Christ*, I'm confident that you're good and knowledgeable, and able to admonish one another. [15]On some things I've written to you boldly to remind you. Because of the grace God gave me, [16]I minister God's good news to the Gentiles as a priest for Christ Jesus. I do it so they can become an acceptable offering that's sanctified by the Holy Spirit. [17]In Christ Jesus I have something to take pride in, as far as God's things are concerned. [18]I won't take it on myself to say anything but what Christ has accomplished through me in the Gentiles' obedience by word and deed. [19]*What he accomplished through me came* by the power of signs and wonders *that I did* by the power of God's Spirit. So, from Jerusalem to Illyricum I've presented the good news about Christ. [20]I've aimed to preach where people have not known Christ. I didn't want to build on somebody else's foundation, [21]but like the scripture says,

"People that haven't received the news about him, will see;
those who haven't heard will understand" **[Is 52:15].** **Rom 15:14-21**

Paul's Plans

22-23 Over the years I've wanted to come to you, but I've been prevented from doing it. Now I don't have anywhere left in these regions. **24**When I go to Spain, I hope to see you, and to have you send me forward after I've refreshed myself with your company for a while. **25**At present I'm headed to Jerusalem to serve the saints. **26**Macedonia and Achaia wanted to take up a collection for the poor saints in Jerusalem. **27**They've wanted to do that because they owe them. If the Gentiles have benefited from their spiritual things, they do well to minister to them from physical things. **28**When I've finished that *project* and safely delivered the collection, I'll go through you to Spain. **29**When I come, I know I'll have Christ's full blessing. **Rom 15:22-29**

30Now I urge you by our Lord Jesus Christ and the love of the Spirit, to pray sincerely with me that God will deliver me from the ones who disobey in Judaea, **31**that the saints will accept my ministry in Jerusalem, **32**and that with joy I'll come *to you* by God's will and refresh myself with you for a while. **33**Now the God that brings peace *be* with you all. Amen.

Rom 15:30-33

Extensive Greetings

16:1I commend to you our sister Phoebe, a servant in the church in Cenchrea. **2**Welcome her in the Lord in a way appropriate to saints. Help her with whatever she needs. She's helped lots of people, including me.

3Greet Prisca and Aquila, my fellow workers in Christ Jesus. **4**They've risked their necks to save my life. Not only am I grateful to them; so are all the Gentile churches. **5**Greet the church that meets in their house. Hello to Epaenetus, my dear friend, the first convert to Christ in Asia; **6**and to Mary, who has worked hard for you[pl]. **7**Greet Andronicus and Junia, my kin and fellow prisoners. They're well-known among the apostles and have been Christians longer than I have. **8**Give our regards to Ampliatus, my friend in the Lord; **9**to Urbanus, our fellow worker in Christ; and to my close friend Stachys. **10**Greet Apelles[mas], approved in Christ, those *in the family* of Aristobulus, **11**and Herodion, my compatriot. Greet the *family* of Narcissus, who are in the Lord; **12**as well as Tryphaena and Tryphosa, laborers in the Lord. Greet **13**Rufus, chosen in the Lord, and his mother and mine. **14**Say hello to Asyncritus, Phlegon, Hermes, Patrobas, Hermas, and the disciples that are with him; **15**as well as Philologus and Julia; Nereus and his sister Olympas; and the saints that are with them. **16**Greet one another with a holy kiss. All the churches of Christ send their greetings. **Rom 16:1-16**

17I urge you to keep an eye on people that cause division and upset people's faith by teaching things contrary to what you've learned; stay away from them. **18**People like that aren't serving Christ our Lord; *they're serving* their own appetites. With smooth talk and flattery, they deceive unsuspecting people. **19**Everybody's heard about your obedience; so I'm happy over you

and want you to be wise about what's good and innocent about what's bad. **20**The God that brings peace will quickly crush Satan under your feet.

21Timothy, my fellow worker, says hello, as does Lucius, Jason, and Sosipater, my kinsmen. (**22**I, Tertius, the one writing out this letter, greets you in the Lord.) **23**Gaius, host to me and the whole church, sends regards. Erastus, the city treasurer, greets you *as does* Quartus the brother. **Rom 16:17-22**

Closing Doxology

[**24**]ms **25**Now to the One who can give you security by the good news I'm delivering about Jesus Christ, according to the mystery

kept unrevealed from times eternal,

26but revealed now in the scriptures of the prophets by the commandment of the eternal God,

made known to all nations, and

leading to an obedience *rooted in* faith—

27to the only wise God through Jesus Christ *be* glory forever! Amen. **Rom 16:24-27**

FIRST CORINTHIANS

Salutation

1:[1]Paul, apostle of Christ[Messiah] Jesus by God's will, and Sosthenes our brother, [2]to God's church in Corinth, made holy in Christ and called *to be* saints with everyone everywhere that calls on our Lord. [3]Grace and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ. **1 Cor 1:1-3**

Thanksgiving

[4]I always thank God for you *and* for the grace he's given you in Jesus. [5]He has enriched you in word and knowledge, [6]and confirmed in you the testimony about Christ. [7]So you don't lack any gift as you anxiously wait for our Lord's return. [8]He'll continue to confirm you to the end so you'll be blameless then. [9]You can rely on God, who called you into fellowship with his Son. **1 Cor 1:4-9**

Call for Unity

[10]I urge you, by our Lord Jesus Christ, to live in harmony so there's no division among you. Unite in mind and purpose. [11]Chloe's family has told me about the rivalry that's going on among you. [12]This is what I mean: each of you is saying, *"I'm with Paul"; "I'm with Apollos"*; *"I'm with Cephas"*; *"I'm with Christ."* [13]Is Christ divided up? Paul wasn't crucified for you, was he? Were you baptized to Paul? [14]I'm glad I didn't baptize any of you except Crispus and Gaius, [15]so you couldn't say I baptized you to myself. ([16]I did baptize the family of Stephanas; I don't remember baptizing anyone else.) [17]Christ didn't send me to perform baptisms, but to deliver good news, not with an eloquence that could detract from the power of his cross.

1 Cor 1:10-17

Christ as Our Wisdom

[18]The preaching about the cross is foolishness to people that perish; it's God's power to the people that are saved. [19]Scripture says,

"I'll destroy the wisdom of the wise
and set aside the insight of the insightful" **[Is 29:14]**.

[20]Where's the "wise"? Where's the scribe? Where's the skillful reasoner of this world? Hasn't God made foolish the world's "wisdom"? [21]In his wisdom, the world didn't know him by wisdom. It pleased him to save believers by the "foolishness" of what we preach. [22]Jews ask for signs; Greeks look for wisdom; [23]but we preach Christ crucified, a stumbling block to Jews and foolishness to Greeks. [24]But, to those who are called—Jews or Greeks—Christ is God's power and wisdom. [25]God's foolishness is wiser than men; his weakness is stronger than men.

1 Cor 1:18-25

[26]You don't see many wise, powerful, noble people called. [27]God has chosen what's foolish to the world to put the wise to shame, weak things to put strong things to shame,

[28]insignificant and disregarded things—even what's not—to cancel out what is. [29]He did it so nobody could act "proud" in his presence. [30]By him you're in Christ Jesus, who has become for us a wisdom, goodness, sanctification, and redemption that comes from God. [31]Like scripture says, ***"Whoever is proud should be proud of what he has in the LORD"*** **[Jer 9:24].** **1 Cor 1:26-31**

The Message, not the Medium

2:[1]When I came, I didn't use eloquence or wisdom to present what God had not previously revealed. [2]I determined not to know anything among you but Jesus Christ crucified. [3]I was weak and apprehensive while I was with you. [4]I didn't present my message with eloquent words but with powerful demonstration of the Spirit. [5]I did that so your faith wouldn't rest on human wisdom but on divine power.

[6]We do speak a kind of wisdom among mature people, but it's not the kind the world or its rulers offer—who are passing away. [7]It's a previously unrevealed wisdom from God, *a wisdom* predestined before creation to our honor, [8]*a wisdom* that no rulers in the world knew. If they'd known it, they wouldn't have crucified the glorious Lord. [9]Like scripture says,

"Eye hasn't seen, ear hasn't heard,
it hasn't entered people's mind
what God's prepared for those who love him" **[Is 64:4; 52:15;** Sir 1:10**].**

1 Cor 2:1-9

Revelation, Not Philosophy

[10]But God has revealed *them* to us by the Spirit, who examines everything, including the deep things about God. [11]Who knows a person's things except that person's spirit? The same way with God: nobody knows his things except his Spirit. [12]We didn't receive the spirit of the world, but the Spirit from God so we could know what God's graciously given us. [13]We talk about those things, not in terms that human wisdom teaches, but in *terms* the Spirit teaches, explaining spiritual matters in spiritual terms. [14]Material-minded people don't welcome God's spiritual things; they seem like foolishness to them. *Material-minded* people can't figure out spiritual things because spiritual things are examined from a spiritual point of view. [15]Spiritual people have a point of view for examining everything, but nobody can examine them.

[16]***"Who knows the mind of the LORD;***
Who's going to advise him?" **[Is 40:13].**

But we have the mind of Christ. **1 Cor 2:10-16**

Christ, Not His Messengers

3:[1]Members of Christ's family, I couldn't talk to you like spiritual people, but like material-minded ones, like infants in Christ. [2]I gave you milk, not solid food. You couldn't *eat solid food* and still can't. [3]You're still material minded. While jealousy and conflict *exist* among you, aren't you material minded and act like typical people? [4]When any of you says, *"I'm with*

Paul," "I'm with Apollos," aren't you material minded and act like typical people? **5**What's Apollos? What's Paul? Ministers that led you to faith. **6**I planted, Apollos watered, but God made it grow. **7**So the one that plants or waters isn't important, but God who makes it grow. **8**The one that plants and the one that waters combine their efforts, and God will pay each one for his own work. **9**We're God's fellow workers; you're his field, his building. **1 Cor 3:1-9**

Christians as God's Temple

10By God's grace, like a skilled general contractor, I've laid a foundation, and others are building on it. They need to be careful how they do that. **11**Nobody can lay any other foundation than the One I've laid, which is Jesus Christ. **12**If you[sg] build on it with gold, silver, precious stones—wood, hay, straw, **13**time will tell how good your work proves to be; fire will test it and make that obvious. **14**If your[sg] work lasts, you'll get paid. **15**If it burns up, you'll take a loss, but you'll be saved—but as through fire. **16**Don't you[pl] know you're[pl] God's temple, and God's Spirit lives in you[pl]? **17**If you[sg] destroy his temple, he'll destroy you[sg]. His temple is holy; that's what you[pl] are.

18Don't kid yourselves. If any of you think you're wise in the world, you need to become "foolish" to become wise. **19**The world's wisdom amounts to foolishness as far as God's concerned. Scripture says,

"He traps the crafty in their craftiness" **[Job 5:13]***;*

20and,

"The LORD knows that the speculations of the wise are meaningless" **[Ps 94:11]**.

21So, don't anyone take pride in other people. Everything belongs to you: **22**Paul, Apollos, Cephas; the world, life, death; things present, things to come. *They're* all yours, **23**you're Christ's, and Christ is God's. **1 Cor 3:10-23**

Attitude Toward Christ's Ministers

4:1 People should consider us ministers of Christ and stewards of God's mysteries. **2**A steward must be reliable, **3**but it's not important to me that you or any human court would try to evaluate me; I don't even try to evaluate myself. **4**My conscience is clear, but that doesn't make me right. The Lord's the One that evaluates me. **5**So, don't rush to judgment before the Lord comes. He'll bring to light what darkness hides and reveal the motives in *people's* hearts. Then God will do the complimenting. **1 Cor 4:1-5**

6I've applied these matters to me and Apollos to teach you not to go beyond what scripture says, so none of you will get conceited. **7**Who makes you[sg] superior? What do you[sg] have you didn't receive? If you received it, why act proud as if you didn't. **8**You're[pl] full! You're rich! You've become kings without us! I wish you had become kings so we could reign with you. **9**I think God has placed us apostles last as sentenced to death. We've become a spectacle to the

world, to angels, and to people. [10]We're fools for Christ; you're wise in him! We're weak; you're strong! We're disrespected; you're respectable! [11]To this day we're hungry, thirsty, poorly clothed, harassed, homeless, [12-13]and do manual labor. We bless in return for insult and encourage in return for slander. We're patient when persecuted, and still treated like trash—like the scum of the earth. **1 Cor 4:6-13**

[14]I'm not writing this to make you feel bad, but to warn you like children I care about. [15]You may have countless instructors in Christ, but not lots of fathers. I became your father in Christ through the good news. [16]So follow my example. [17]That's why I'm sending Timothy, my dear friend, reliable child in the Lord. He'll remind you about my ways in the Lord like I teach everywhere in every church. [18]Some of you proudly claim that I won't come to you. [19]But I'll come soon, Lord willing, and I'll find out, not the talk of the proud, but their power. [20]God's kingdom is not in talk but in power. [21]What do you want me to do, come with a rod or with love and a gentle spirit? **1 Cor 4:14-21**

Immorality in Corinth

5:[1]Immorality is reported among you that doesn't exist even among Gentiles—someone living with his father's wife. [2]Are you proud *of this* instead of mourning *over it*—a mourning that should lead to removing him from you? [3]I'm absent in body but present in spirit, and already—as if present—I've judged him. [4]In the name of our Lord Jesus, assemble with my spirit and the power of our Lord Jesus Christ, [5]and deliver him to Satan to destroy the flesh but save his spirit when the Lord comes. [6]Your pride is not good. Don't you understand that a little yeast spreads through the whole batch? [7]Get rid of the old yeast so you're a fresh batch. You're a fresh *batch* because Christ our Passover has been sacrificed. [8]So let's celebrate the feast, not with old, evil yeast, but with unleavened bread of sincerity and truth.

[9]I've written to you not to associate with immoral people. [10]*I* don't *mean* immoral people in the world—covetous people, swindlers, idolaters. You'd have to get out of the world *to do that!* [11]Now I'm writing to you not to associate with anyone called a Christian that's immoral or covetous, an idolater, slanderer, or drunk—not to eat with someone like that. [12]What business is it of mine to judge people outside *the church*? Isn't it your responsibility to judge the ones in *the church*? [13]God will judge the rest. ***"Remove the sinful person from you"*** **[Deut 17:7; 19:19; 22:21, 24; 24:7].** **1 Cor 5:1-13**

Christians and Lawsuits

6:[1]If you have something against a *fellow Christian*, do any of you dare go to court in front of sinners rather than saints? [2]You know, don't you, that the saints will judge the world? If you're going to judge the world, can't you *judge* small matters? [3]You know, don't you, that you'll judge angels, much less matters of everyday life? [4]If you have courts that deal with

everyday matters, appoint *as judges* the ones looked down on in the church. [5]I'm saying this so you'll be ashamed: don't you have anybody among you smart enough to decide between his fellow believers? [6]Christians take Christians to court and do it in front of unbelievers? [7]It's a real defect in you that you bring lawsuits against each other. Wouldn't it be better to let yourselves be wronged or defrauded? [8]But <u>you</u> do the wronging and defrauding, and *do it* to fellow Christians, at that. [9]Don't you know that bad people won't inherit God's kingdom? Don't kid yourselves: sexually immoral people, idolaters, adulterers, effeminate *men*, homosexuals, [10]thieves, covetous people, drunkards, revilers, swindlers won't inherit his kingdom. [11]Some of you were like that, but you were washed, sanctified, made good in the Lord Jesus and in the Spirit of our God.

1 Cor 6:1-11

[12]I can do all *kinds of* things, but they're not all beneficial, and I won't put myself under their control. [13]Food's for the stomach, and the stomach's for food, but God will destroy it and them. The body is not for immorality, but for the Lord; and the Lord is for the body. [14]But God has resurrected the Lord, and he'll resurrect us by his power. [15]Don't you know your bodies are parts of Christ? So am I going to take parts of Christ and make *them* parts of a prostitute? Goodness, no! [16]Don't you know that whoever joins himself to a prostitute is one body *with her* physically? *God* says, ***"The two will become one physical identity"*** **[Gen 2:24]**. [17]Whoever joins himself to the Lord is one spiritual identity *with him*. [18]Run from sexual immorality. Every sin a person commits is aside from the body, but sexual sin is a sin against a person's own body. [19]Don't you know your[pl] body is a temple for God's Holy Spirit that's in you[pl]? You[pl] don't own yourselves; [20]you've been purchased. So praise God with your body. **1 Cor 6:12-20**

Teaching About Marriage

7[:1]Regarding the things you wrote about. It's okay for a man to stay single. [2]But, to avoid sexual immorality, each man should have his own wife, and each woman should have her own husband. [3]A husband needs to give his wife what's due her, and vice versa. [4]A wife doesn't have *sole* rights over her own body; her husband *does too*. The same for a husband. [5]Don't refuse sex to one another except for a while by agreement to devote yourselves to prayer. Then come together again so Satan doesn't tempt you because of your lack of self-control. [6]I say that as a concession, not a commandment. [7]I'd like everyone to be like me, but each person has his gift from God—one, one way; another, another way. **1 Cor 7:1-7**

[8]I say to unmarried people and widows, it's good to stay like me. [9]But if you don't have self-control, get married; it's better to marry than to lust. [10]But the Lord, not *just* me, instructs a wife not to divorce her husband—[11]if she does divorce him, she needs to stay single or be reconciled to him—and a husband not to leave his wife. [12]To the rest I say, not the Lord, if a disciple has an unbelieving wife and she's willing to keep living with him, he shouldn't leave her. [13]If a wife has an unbelieving husband and he's perfectly content to keep living with her, she

shouldn't leave him. [14]A *believing* wife legitimizes an unbelieving husband and vice versa; otherwise, your children would be illegitimate. [15]If an unbelieving *spouse* does divorce, let *him or her* divorce. A brother or sister isn't bound in such cases. God has called us in peace. [16]How do you know, wife, that perhaps you'll save *your* husband; or husband, that you'll save *your* wife? **1 Cor 7:8-16**

[17]Keep living in the *societal* circumstance where God called you. That's what I tell everybody in all the churches. [18]Were you called as circumcised? You don't need to get uncircumcised. Were you called as uncircumcised? You don't need to get circumcised. [19]Circumcision or uncircumcision doesn't matter. Keeping God's commandments is what matters.

[20]Keep living in the circumstance where God called you. [21]Were you called as a slave? It doesn't matter. (But, if you can be free, do it.) [22]A person the Lord calls that's a servant is free as far as he is concerned. A person the Lord calls tthat's a freeman is the Lord's 'servant.' [23]You've been purchased for a price; don't become servants to other people. [24]Stay with God in the circumstance where he called you. **1 Cor 7:17-24**

Advice to the Unmarried

[25]About virgins. I don't have any command from the Lord, but I offer *my* opinion as somebody he has been merciful enough to consider dependable. [26]I recommend handling the matter this way in light of present difficulties: it's good for you to stay the way you are. [27]Are you married? Don't get a divorce. Are you single? Don't look for somebody to marry. [28]If you do get married, you haven't sinned; if a virgin gets married, she hasn't sinned. But *married* people will face difficulties in this life, and I want to spare you. [29]I'm telling you, it won't be long till the ones that have wives will be as if they didn't, [30]those crying or rejoicing as if they weren't, [31]and those taking advantage of this world's opportunities as not doing it fully. The situation's changing, [32]and I don't want you to have *distracting* concerns. An unmarried man tends to concern himself with the Lord's things—how to please him; [33]a married man feels a need to concern himself with this world's things—how to be pleasing to his wife [34]and is torn. Unmarried women and virgins tend to be concerned about the Lord's things—being holy in body and spirit; a married woman feels a need to concern herself with this world's things—how to be pleasing to her husband. [35]I'm saying this to help you, not to hold you back—to free you for orderly, undistracted devotion to the Lord. **1 Cor 7:25-35**

[36]If a man thinks he's being insensitive toward his virgin *daughter*, if she's full-grown and wants to get married, he should follow his heart. He's not sinning; do what he's inclined to do; let them marry. [37]But a man that's made up his mind, stands firm in his heart, is under no

pressure, has decided as far as he's concerned to keep his virgin, he's doing a good thing. **38**So, the one who gives his virgin *daughter* in marriage does well, and the one that doesn't does better.

39A wife is married to her husband for as long as he's alive. If he dies, she's free to marry whoever she wants to—only in the Lord. **40**But she'd be happier if she stayed like she is, but that's just me. I think I also have God's Spirit. **1 Cor 7:36-40**

Meat Offered to Idols

8:1 About things offered to idols. We all have knowledge. Knowledge tends to make a person proud; love builds other people up. **2**If anybody thinks he knows, he doesn't know like he should. **3**If anybody loves God, God knows it. **4**So, as to eating things offered to idols, we know idols aren't real and there's no God but one. **5**There are lots of so-called gods and lords in the sky and on earth. **6**But for us

there's one God, the Father—
from whom everything *has come* and
for whom we *live*—and
there's one Lord, Jesus Christ—
by whom everything *has come*
and by whom we *live*. **1 Cor 8:1-6**

7But not everybody knows that. Some people were used to idols before. *They were used* to eating food as an offering to them. Eating that kind of food grates on their conscience now. Their conscience is weak, and it bothers them. **8**Food doesn't make us acceptable to God: if we don't eat, we're not worse; if we do, we're not better. **9**But be careful that your[pl] freedom doesn't make weak people stumble. **10**If someone sees you[pl] that have knowledge reclining at table in an idol's temple, won't their weak conscience be inclined to eat to *the idol* the things offered to the idol? **11**Your[pl] knowledge is destroying a weak Christian Christ died for. **12**When you sin that way against members of Christ's body and grate on their tender conscience, you're[pl] sinning against Christ. **13**So if what I eat makes my fellow Christians stumble, I'll never eat meat because I don't want to make them stumble. **1 Cor 8:7-13**

Paul's Defense of His Apostleship

9:1 Am I not free? Am I not an apostle? Haven't I seen Jesus our Lord? Aren't you my work in the Lord? **2**If I'm not an apostle to other people, I am to you. You're the seal of my apostleship in the Lord.

3Here's my defense to the ones who are criticizing me. **4**Don't I have a right to eat? **5**Don't I have a right to have a wife *that's* a sister *in the faith* like Cephas, the rest of the apostles, and the Lord's brothers? **6**Are Barnabas and I the only ones that don't have a right not to work? **7**What soldier ever serves at his own expense? Who plants a vineyard and doesn't eat its fruit?

Who tends sheep and doesn't drink their milk? [8]I'm not just talking about human custom, am I? Doesn't the Law *of Moses* say that too? [9]***"Don't put a muzzle on an ox while it's threshing"*** **[Deut 25:4].** God's not concerned *here* about oxen, is he? [10]Isn't he speaking for our benefit? He wrote it for our benefit so the one who's threshing should work in hopes of sharing in the crops. [11]If we sowed spiritual things to you, *is it* too much to reap material things from you? [12]If other people share that right, don't we e*ven* more? **1 Cor 9:1-12a**

But we haven't used that right. We endure things to keep from hindering the good news of Christ in any way. [13]Don't you know that the ones who perform sacred services eat from the Temple, *and that* the ones who wait on the altar have a share from the altar? [14]In the same way the Lord has directed that the ones who deliver the good news should have a living from it. [15]But I haven't taken advantage of that provision, and I'm not writing this to change what we've been doing. I'd rather die than let anyone make my pride hollow. [16]If I deliver the good news, I don't have anything to take pride in. I have to do that. Woe to me if I don't! [17]If I do it because I want to, I'm entrusted with a stewardship. [18]Where's my reward then? That I deliver the good news for free and not make use of my rights in it. **1 Cor 9:12b-18**

[19]Although I'm free from everybody, I've made myself a servant to everybody so I can win more of them. [20]To Jews I've become like a Jew to win Jews. To people under law I've become like somebody under law—though I'm not *really*—to win people under law. [21]To people not under law I've become like somebody not under law—though I am under God's law, Christ's 'law'—to win people not under law. [22]To the weak I've become weak to win the weak. By all means I've become all things to all *people* to save some. [23]I do everything for the sake of the good news so I can partake of it.

[24]As you know, everybody in a race runs, but only one wins the garland. Run so you'll be the one that wins it. [25]Everybody that competes in the games exercises self-discipline in everything. They do it for a crown that deteriorates; we *do it* for one that doesn't. [26]I don't *just* run around; I don't just shadow box. I discipline my body and keep it under control so, after I preach to other people, I don't disqualify myself. **1 Cor 9:19-26**

Boundaries of Christian Liberty

10[:1]I want you to know that our forefathers passed through the sea under the cloud. [2]They were baptized to Moses in the cloud and sea. [3]They ate the same spiritual food [4]and drank the same spiritual drink: they drank from the spiritual rock that followed them—the Christ[Messiah]. [5]But God wasn't pleased with most of them and struck them down in the wilderness. [6]What happened with them serves as an example for us not to crave evil things like they did, [7]or worship idols like some of them did, ***"The people sat down to gluttony and got up to revelry"*** **[Ex 32:6]**. [8]*We must not* commit sexual sin like some of them did, and 23,000 fell in one day. [9]Let's not put Christ to trial like some of them did, and snakes killed them; [10]or complain like

some of them did, and the destroyer destroyed them. [11]Scripture recorded those events to warn us later [12]so whoever thinks he's standing would be careful not to fall. [13]You haven't faced anything beyond normal human experience. God's reliable; he won't let you face more than you can handle. He'll provide an escape so you can handle it. **1 Cor 10:1-13**

[14]So run away from idolatry. [15]I'm talking to you as intelligent people; pay attention to what I'm saying. [16]Isn't the cup of blessing that we bless, a sharing in Christ's blood? Isn't the loaf we break a participation in his body? [17]Since there's one loaf, the many of us are one body and share the one loaf. [18]Look at physical Israel. Don't the ones that eat the sacrifices share in the altar? [19]So am I saying that something offered to an idol has value or that an idol has any value? [20]*No*, *I'm saying* that what people sacrifice, *they sacrifice* to demons, not God. And I don't want you involved with demons. [21]You can't drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons. You can't participate in the table of the Lord and the table of demons. [22]Are we trying to make the Lord jealous? We aren't stronger than he is, are we? **1 Cor 10:14-22**

[23]Not everything that's possible is beneficial. [24]Don't look after your own welfare as much as others' welfare. [25]Eat whatever they sell in the marketplace; don't ask any questions for conscience sake, [26]because, ***"The earth and everything in it belong to the LORD"*** **[Ps 24:1; 50:12; 89:11, 27]**. [27]If an unbelever invites you *to dinner* and you want to go, eat anything he sets in front of you without asking any questions for conscience sake. [28]But if somebody says, *"This is offered in sacrifice,"* don't eat it [29]out of consideration for the other person's conscience. Why does someone else's conscience limit my freedom? [30]If I eat with thanks, why am I slandered for it? [31]Whether you eat or drink or whatever you do, do it to God's honor. [32]Don't do anything that hurts Jews or Gentiles or God's church. [33]I aim to be pleasing to everybody in everything I do. I don't try to do what's best for me, but for everybody's benefit so I can save them. **11**:[1]Follow my example like I follow Christ's. **1 Cor 10:23-11:1**

Women's Decorum in Worship

[2]I commend you for remembering me and maintaining the customs I passed on to you. [3]I want you to know that God is the head of Christ, Christ is the head of every husband, and a husband *is head* of a wife. [4]A man that prays or prophesies with his head covered disgraces his head. [5]A woman that prays or prophesies bareheaded disgraces her head. It's the same as shaving it. [6]If a woman is bareheaded, she may as well be bald. If it's shameful for a woman to cut her hair off, she should cover her head. [7]A man shouldn't cover his head because he's the image and delight of God. A wife is her husband's delight. [8]Man didn't come from woman, but woman from man. [9]Man wasn't created for woman, but woman for man. [10]So she should wear *a sign of* authority on her head because of the angels. [11]But, in the Lord a husband and wife exist as a

combination. [12]As woman *came* from man, man *comes* by woman, and everything *comes* from God. [13]Judge for yourselves: is it appropriate for a woman to pray to God bareheaded? [14]Doesn't what's natural teach you that long hair dishonors a man, [15]but it honors a woman? Long hair serves as a covering for her. [16]If someone wants to argue about it, we don't have such a custom; neither do the churches of God. **1 Cor 11:2-16**

The Lord's Supper

[17]In this *next* instruction, I'm not commending you, because your getting together doesn't make things better but worse. [18]To begin with, when you get together for church, I hear there are divisions among you, and I'm inclined to believe it. [19]Divisions even need to exist to show who are approved. [20]When you get together, you can't be eating the Lord's Supper. [21]Each one is bringing out his own supper, and one's hungry while another overeats. [22]Don't you have houses to eat in? Do you disrespect God's church and embarrass people that don't have *anything to eat*? What can I say to you? Can I compliment you? Not for that, I can't. **1 Cor 11:17-22**

[23]I received from the Lord what I passed on to *you*. The night he was betrayed, he took a loaf, [24]gave thanks, broke it, and said, *"This is my body, which is for you. Do this in memory of me."* [25]After the meal *he took* the cup, *"This cup is the New Covenant in my blood. As often as you drink it, do it in memory of me."* [26]As often as you eat this bread and drink the cup, you're expressing the Lord's death till he comes.

[27]So whoever eats this bread or drinks the cup of the Lord in a way that's not appropriate, is guilty of his body and blood. [28]That's why you need to examine yourself and eat the bread and drink the cup that way. [29]If you eat and drink without recognizing the [Lord's][ms] body, you eat and drink condemnation to yourself. [30]That's why many of you are weak and sickly, and a considerable *number* are dying. [31]If we examine ourselves, we won't be condemned. [32]When we judge ourselves, the Lord disciplines us so we won't be condemned along with the world. [33]So when you get together to eat, be considerate. [34]If you're hungry, eat at home to avoid being condemned. I'll straighten out the rest when I get there. **1 Cor 11:23-34**

Teaching on Spiritual Gifts

12[:1]About spiritual *gifts*. [2]You know that when you were pagans, in one way or another, idols that couldn't talk were leading you astray. [3]So I tell you, nobody that speaks by God's Spirit claims, *"Jesus is accursed"*; and nobody can claim, *"Jesus is Lord,"* except by the Holy Spirit.

[4]There's a variety of spiritual gifts, but the same Spirit; [5]a variety of ministries, but the same Lord; [6]a variety of activities, but the same God, who accomplishes everything in everyone. [7]The demonstration each person has from the Spirit serves for the benefit of the rest. [8]The same Spirit gives a message about wise living to one and a message about understanding to another,

[9]faith to one and gifts of healing to another; [10]working miracles to one, prophesying to another, and distinguishing between spirits to another; *speaking* different languages to one and translating languages to another. [11]The same Spirit does them all and distributes to each person as he sees fit. **1 Cor 12:1-11**

The Church as a Body

[12]As one body has many parts, so does Christ. [13]We were baptized in one Spirit into one body—whether Jew or Greek, bond or free—and drank from one Spirit. [14]The body doesn't have one part, but many. [15]If a foot says, *"Since I'm not a hand, I'm not part of the body,"* is it then not part of the body? [16]If an ear says, *"Since I'm not an eye, I'm not part of the body,"* is it then not part of the body? [17]If the whole body *were an* eye, how would it hear anything? If the whole body *were* hearing, where *would* it smell anything? [18]God has placed each part in the body just the way he wants it. [19]If they were all one part, where *would* the *whole* body *be*? [20]There are many parts, but one body. [21]An eye can't tell a hand, *"I don't need you."* The head can't tell the feet, *"I don't need you."* [22]More notably yet, parts we consider weaker are necessary. [23]Parts we consider less honorable we give more attention to; our less presentable parts become more presentable, [24]and parts that are already presentable get less attention. God has put the body together in a way that gives greater honor to the part that lacks *it*, [25]so there's no division in the body because the parts take care of each another. [26]If one part suffers, they all suffer; if one receives honor, they all rejoice. **1 Cor 12:12-26**

[27]*As a group* you're Christ's body, and individually *you're* parts *of it*. [28]In the church, God has appointed apostles first, prophets second, teachers third, then miracles, gifts of healing, helps, administrations, kinds of languages. [29]Not everyone is an apostle or prophet or teacher or miracle worker, are they? [30]Not everyone has gifts for healing or speaks in languages or translates, do they? **1 Cor 12:27-30**

Love , the All-Purpose Virtue

[31]Earnestly desire the more important gifts, but I'll show you something *even* better. **13**[:1]If I speak in the languages of people and angels, but don't love, like a noisy gong or crashing cymbal <u>I *mean nothing*</u>. [2]If I prophesy, understand all mysteries, know everything, have enough faith to move mountains, but don't love, <u>I am nothing</u>. [3]If I give everything I own to feed *the poor* and deliver my body so I can take pride in doing it, but don't love, <u>I gain nothing</u>.

[4]Love is patient and kind, not jealous or proud. [5]It's considerate, not selfish or easily offended; it doesn't dwell on what's wrong. [6]Love doesn't enjoy doing people in; it enjoys the truth. [7]Love bears up under everything; it tends to trust; it hopes for the best. Love lasts.

[8]Love never falls *out of the picture*. But prophesying will pass away; languages will stop; knowledge will disappear. [9]We know partially and prophecy partially. [10]But, when what's final

comes, what's preliminary will disappear. [11]When I was a kid, I talked like one, thought like one, reasoned like one. When I grew up, I quit doing what a kid does. [12]We see in a mirror blurry now, but *we'll see* directly then. I know partly now, but then I'll know as I'm known. [13]There's faith, hope, and love now—those three; but love is the most important. **1 Cor 12:31- 13:13**

How Speaking in Languages Works

14:[1]Focus on practicing love, and earnestly desire spiritual *gifts* so you can communicate. [2]A person that's speaking in *another* language isn't speaking to anybody but God because nobody is understanding *what* the Spirit is enabling him to say. [3]A person that communicates, helps, encourages, comforts *other* people. [4]Somebody that speaks in *another* language helps himself, but a person that communicates helps the church. [5]Now I'm willing for all of you to speak in languages, but so you can communicate. If you communicate, you're doing something more important than speaking in *other* languages—unless you translate so you can help the church. **1 Cor 14:1-5**

[6]If I come to you speaking in *other* languages, how will I be helping you unless I'm giving revelation, knowledge, prophecy, or teaching? [7]Even inanimate things that make sounds—like flutes or harps—if they don't make definite tones, how will listeners recognize what the flute or harp is playing? [8]If a bugle makes random sounds, who's going to arm for battle? [9]In the same way, unless you speak clearly in a language, how are people going to understand you? You'll be talking into the air. [10]There are lots of *languages* in the world, and they all convey meaning. [11]If I don't understand what the sound means, we're foreigners to each other. [12]So since you're enthused about spiritual *gifts*, aim at helping the church *with them*. [13]Whoever speaks in *another* language should pray to be able to translate it. [14]If I'm praying in *another* language, my spirit's praying, but my mind isn't understanding the words I'm saying. **1 Cor 14:6-14**

[15]What, then? I'll pray with the spirit <u>and</u> the mind. I'll sing with the spirit <u>and</u> the mind. [16]Otherwise, if I'm blessing with the spirit, how can the ungifted say, *"Amen,"* when I give thanks? He won't be understanding me. [17]I'll be giving thanks all right, but I won't be helping <u>him</u>. [18]I thank God that I speak in *other* languages more than all of you do, [19]but in church I'd rather say five words with my mind so I can teach other people than 10,000 words in *another* language. **1 Cor 14:15-19**

[20]Don't think like little kids. (Be *innocent* like little kids when it comes to evil.) In your minds, be grown-ups. [21]The Law says,

"'I'll speak to this people
in foreign languages
with the lips of foreigners;
they won't listen to *me* ***even*** *that way,' the* LORD *says"* **[Is 28:11; Deut 28:49].**

[22]So *other* languages serve as signs for unbelievers, *more than* believers; prophecy is for believers, *more than* unbelievers. [23]If the church gets together, and everybody is speaking in *other* languages, and ungifted or unbelievers come in, won't they say you're out of your mind? [24]But if everybody's speaking on behalf of *God* and unbelievers or laymen come in, you'll be convicting them and calling them to account. [25]Their inner yearnings will become clear, and they'll fall on their faces and worship God. They'll declare, *"God has to be among you."*

1 Cor 14:20-25

Orderly Assembly

[26]What, then? When you get together, and each one has a psalm, a teaching, a revelation, a language, a translation, do everything to benefit *one another*. [27]If people speak in *another* language, two or at most three should take turns, and one should translate. [28]If there's no translator, they need to be quiet and talk to themselves and to God. [29]Two or three prophets can speak, and the others think about *what they're saying*. [30]If a revelation comes to somebody else that's sitting *there*, the first should yield the floor. [31]You can all take turns prophesying so everybody can learn and be encouraged. [32]The spirits of prophets are subject to the prophets; [33]God brings peace, not confusion. **1 Cor 14:26-33a**

Women's Decorum in Church

As in all the churches of the saints, [34]women should remain silent in church services and practice deference like the Law says. [35]If they want to find out about something, they can ask their husbands at home; it's embarrassing for a woman to speak out in church. [36]Did the word of God come from you, or did it come just to you?

[37]If you consider *yourself* a prophet or spiritual person, you need to recognize that what I'm writing to you is the Lord's command. [38]If anyone ignores *that*, ignore them. [39]So, *go ahead and* earnestly desire to prophesy and let people speak in *other* languages, [40]but do everything properly and orderly. **1 Cor 14:33b-40**

The Resurrection of Jesus

15:[1]My fellow Christians, I want you to know the most important thing in the good news I delivered to you, that you accepted, that you stand in, [2]that saves you if you hold onto it (unless you've believed for nothing): [3]Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures, [4]was buried, was resurrected the third day according to the scriptures, [5]appeared to Cephas, then the Twelve, [6]then to more than 500 disciples at the same time (most of them are still alive). [7]Next he appeared to James and then to all the apostles. [8]Last, he appeared to me like someone born out of season. [9]I'm the least of the apostles and don't deserve to be called one because I persecuted God's church. [10]But by God's grace I am what I am, and his grace to me has produced results.

I've worked harder than any of them—not *so much* me, but God's grace in me. [11]So whether it's me or them, *Christ's resurrection* is what we proclaimed and what you believed. **1 Cor 15:1-11**

The Resurrection of People

[12]If we proclaimed that Christ resurrected, how can some of you say there's no such thing as resurrection? [13]If that's true, Christ hasn't resurrected. [14]If he didn't, then our preaching is worthless and so's your faith. [15]Besides, we're false witnesses for God because we've claimed he resurrected Christ, which he didn't do if there's no such thing as resurrection. [16]If dead people don't resurrect, Christ didn't. [17]If he didn't resurrect, your faith is useless, you're still in your sins, [18]and the dead in Christ have perished. [19]If we have hope in Christ only in this life, we're the most pitiable people alive. **1 Cor 15:12-19**

[20]But, Christ has resurrected, the firstfruits from the dead. [21]Since death *came* by man, resurrection came by man. [22]As in Adam people die, so in Christ people resurrect—[23]each in sequence: Christ the firstfruits, then the ones that belong to him when he comes back. [24]Then the end will come, when he does away with all *other* rule, authority, and power. [25]He needs to reign till he overcomes all his enemies. [26]The last enemy he'll overcome is death. [27]***"God will subject everything to him"*** **[Ps 8:6].** When it says *"everything,"* obviously it doesn't include the One who did the *"subjecting."* [28]When God subjects *"everything"* to the Son, the Son will be subject to God, so God will be ultimate in everything. **1 Cor 15:20-28**

Ministry and the Hope of Resurrection

[29]Otherwise, what will the ones baptized on behalf of the dead be doing? If the dead don't resurrect, why be baptized on their behalf? [30]Why do we face danger all the time? [31]By the pride we take in you, *the pride* we have in Christ Jesus our Lord, *I tell you,* I die every day. [32]If, figuratively speaking, I fought wild animals in Ephesus, what good *did it do*? If the dead don't resurrect,

"Let's eat and drink;
we're going to die tomorrow" **[Is 22:13; 56:12].**

[33]Don't kid yourselves,

"Bad company ruins good morals."

[34]Come to your senses about goodness, and don't practice sinning. It's a shame to say it, but some *of you* don't know God. **1 Cor 15:29-34**

The Resurrected Body

[35]Somebody might ask, *"How do dead people resurrect? What kind of body do they come with?"* [36]Foolish *one*! What you plant doesn't come to life unless it dies. [37]What you plant isn't the body it's going to become. You plant bare wheat seed, for example. [38]God gives it the body

he wants it to have, and each *kind of* seed has its own shape. [39] People, cattle, birds, and fish all look different. [40]Things in the sky differ from things on the ground in how impressive they are. Things in the sky differ from each other in brightness—[41]the sun's brighter than the moon; the moon's brighter than the stars; the stars differ in how bright they are. **1 Cor 15:35-41**

[42]That's how resurrection is. What's planted in decay resurrects unable to decay; [43]what's planted in dishonor resurrects in honor; what's planted in weakness resurrects in power; [44]what's planted as a physical body resurrects as a spiritual one. There's a physical body and a spiritual body. [45]Scripture says,

"The** first **man** Adam **became a living being" **[Gen 2:7]**;

the last Adam *became* a life-giving spirit. [46]But, the spiritual doesn't come first; the physical comes, then the spiritual. [47]The first man is from the dust of the earth; the second man *is* from heaven. [48]Earthly people are like the earth; heavenly ones are like heaven. [49]As we've been like the earth, we'll be like heaven. **1 Cor 15:42-49**

Victory Through Resurrection

[50]I'm saying that because flesh and blood can't inherit God's kingdom. What perishes doesn't inherit what doesn't perish. [51]I'll tell you a mystery: not everybody will die, but everybody will be changed—[52]in an instant, in the blink of an eye, at the last trumpet blast. The trumpet will blow, and the dead will resurrect imperishable, and we'll be changed. [53]This perishable *body* must put on what's not perishable; this mortal *body* must put on immortality. [54]When that happens, what's written will take place,

"Victory has swallowed up death **[Is 25:8].**

[55]***Death, where's your victory?***

Death, where's your sting?" **[Hos 13:14]**

[56]"Death's sting" is sin, and sin's power is law. [57]Thank God, who gives us the "victory" through our Lord Jesus Christ. [58]So stay steadfast, unmovable, always excelling in the Lord's work. You know your labor in the Lord amounts to something. **1 Cor 15:50-58**

The Collection for Hebrew Christians

16:[1]About the collection for the saints. Do what I told the churches in Galatia. [2]Every first *day* of the week, each of you lay aside in store as things go for you, so there won't be any collecting after I get there. [3]When I arrive, whoever you appoint, I'll send with letters to carry your gift to Jerusalem. [4]If it's appropriate for me to go too, we'll go together.

[5]I'll see you after I go through Macedonia. [6]I can stay with you a while or even spend the winter so you can send me on. [7]I don't want to see you this time in passing, because I hope to stay a while, Lord willing. [8]I'm going to stay in Ephesus till Pentecost [9]because a wide, effective door has opened up for me, although there's a lot of opposition. **1 Cor 16:1-9**

The Activities of Paul's Fellow Workers

10If Timothy comes, see that he's welcome. He's doing the Lord's work like I am. **11**Nobody should disregard him but send him on in peace so he can come back to me. I expect him *to come* with the disciples.

12I strongly urged Apollos to come to you with the *others*, but he really didn't want to come now. He'll come when he can.

13Stay alert, stand firm in the faith; be courageous and strong. **14**Everything you do, do with love.

15-16 You know that the family of Stephanas was the firstfruits of Achaia, and *that* they've devoted themselves to serving the saints. I urge you to cooperate with people like them and with everybody that labors in the work. **17**I was so glad Stephanas, Fortunatus, and Achaicus came, because they supplied what you hadn't yet provided. **18**They've refreshed me—and you. Give recognition to people like them. **1 Cor 16:10-18**

Greetings and Benediction

19The churches in Asia send you greetings. Aquila and Prisca greet you warmly along with the church *that meets* in their house. **20**The disciples all send their regards; greet one another with a holy kiss.

21The salutation with my own hand—Paul.

22If somebody doesn't love the Lord, let him be accursed. Lord, come!

23The grace of the Lord Jesus *be* with you. **24**My love *is* with you all in Christ Jesus. Amen. **1 Cor 16:19-24**

SECOND CORINTHIANS

Salutation

1:[1]Paul, apostle of Christ[Messiah] Jesus by God's will, and Timothy *our* brother, to the church of God in Corinth with the saints everywhere in Achaia. [2]Grace and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ. **2 Cor 1:1-2**

God's Comfort in Sufferings

[3]Blessed *be* the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ. He's our merciful Father and comforting God. [4]He comforts us in every hardship so we can comfort other people in any hardship with the comfort he gave us. [5]As sufferings for Christ increase in us, our comfort through Christ also increases. [6]If we experience hardship, *it's* for your comfort and salvation. If we're comforted, *it's* for your comfort to endure the same sufferings we have. [7]Our hope for you *is* unmovable because we know that as you share *our* sufferings, *you share our* comfort too.

[8]Fellow Christians, we want you to know about our hardships in Asia. It was a burden so much beyond our own power to handle that we weren't sure we'd even live *through* it. [9]We had the death sentence in us so we weren't trusting in ourselves, but in God who raises the dead. [10]He rescued us from a great threat of death, and we've put our hope in him to keep rescuing us. [11]You worked for us by praying so lots of people could be grateful for the grace we've received. **2 Cor 1:3-11**

Paul's Sincerity

[12]We're proud of how clear our conscience feels, especially toward you. We've conducted ourselves in godly holiness and sincerity, not in fleshly wisdom but in divine grace. [13]We're writing what you can understand, and I hope you'll understand it completely. [14]You understand to some extent how proud we are of you—like <u>you</u> *will be* of us when the Lord Jesus comes. **2 Cor 1:12-14**

[15]In this confidence I was intending at first to come so you could have a second grace. [16]I meant to go through you on to Macedonia and back to you, and to have you send me forward to Judaea. [17]With this plan I wasn't being fickle, was I? Do I make fickle plans—*"*Yes*, I will"*; *"*No*, I won't."* [18]As God keeps <u>his</u> word, <u>we</u> don't tell you, "Yes, *I will*" and *then say*, "No, *I won't*." [19]God's Son, Christ Jesus, the One Silvanus, Timothy, and I presented among you, wasn't, "Yes, *I will*"; "No, *I won't*." He's been "Yes, *I will*." [20]However many promises God has made, in Christ is "Yes." He's *our* Amen, to God's honor. [21]In Christ, God has established us, anointed us and you, [22]sealed us, and given us the Spirit as a pledge in our hearts. **2 Cor 1:15-22**

Paul's Delayed Visit

[23]God's my witness: it was to spare you that I changed my mind and didn't come to Corinth. [24]We aren't trying to lord it over your faith; we're fellow workers for your joy. You stand firm in *your own* faith. **2**:[1]I was determined not to come again with sadness. [2]If I make you feel bad, who's going to make me feel good except the ones I made feel bad? [3]I've written this so when I come, I won't be saddened by the ones I need to make me happy. I'm confident that my joy would mean your joy. [4]Out of hardship and anxiety, I wrote to you through many tears, not to make you sad, but to let you know how much I care about you. **2 Cor 1:23-2:4**

Forgiving the Offender in Corinth

[5]If somebody has caused sadness, he hasn't caused it just to me—I'm not exaggerating—but to all of you. [6]That discipline by the majority is enough for someone like him. [7]Now you need to forgive him and comfort *him* so grief doesn't overwhelm him. [8]So show him how much you care about him. [9]That's another reason I've written: to know if you obey in everything. [10]If you've forgiven anybody of anything, I have too. What I've forgiven I've forgiven for your sake in the presence of Christ [11]so Satan can't get the better of us. We know how he works.

2 Cor 2:5-11

Paul's Push to Get to Corinth

[12]When I got to Troas to present the good news about Christ, a door opened up for me in the Lord. [13]*But* I didn't find any peace of mind because I didn't find my brother Titus. So I left and went on over to Macedonia.

[14]Thanks to God, who always leads us in victorious procession in Christ, and reveals through us everywhere the sweet aroma that arises from knowing him. [15]We're the scent of Christ *arising* to God among the saved and the perishing. [16]To the one *we're* the stench that leads to death; to the other *we're* the aroma that leads to life. Who's good enough for that? [17]We're not like many that peddle God's message for money. In Christ we speak sincerely from God in his sight. **2 Cor 2:12-17**

Ministry of the New Covenant

3:[1]Are we beginning to commend ourselves again? We don't need letters of recommendation to you or from you like some do, do we? [2]<u>You</u>'re our letter that everybody can know and read, written on our hearts. [3]You're an open letter from Christ, served by us, not written with ink, but with the spirit of the living God, not on stone tablets, but on human hearts.

[4]We have so much confidence in God through Christ, [5]not because <u>we're</u> adequate to consider anything as our own accomplishment, but adequate because of what comes from God. [6]He has made us adequate ministers of a new covenant, not of the letter, but of the spirit. The letter deadens; the spirit enlivens.

[7]The ministry that brought death—engraved with letters on stone—came with so much glory that the Israelites couldn't look at Moses' face—a fading glory. [8]Won't the ministry of the spirit have *even* more glory? [9]If the ministry that brought condemnation had glory, how much more glory does the ministry have that brings goodness. [10]What *had* glory doesn't have any in comparison to what *has* greater glory. [11]What faded away had glory, but what doesn't fade away has a lot more glory. **2 Cor 3:1-11**

Freedom from Law

[12]With that kind of hope, let's be bold. [13]Let's not be like Moses, who put a veil on so the Israelites wouldn't have to look at what was fading away. [14-15]Their minds were insensitive. To this day when they read the Old Covenant, the same veil is there. They don't understand that Christ[Messiah] removes it. [16]When *their heart* turns to the Lord, the veil disappears. [17]Now the Lord *is* the spirit *of the Old Covenant*, and where his spirit is, *there's* freedom. [18]When with unveiled face we look at the glory of the Lord in a mirror, the Lord, the spirit, transforms us into that same image from glory to *more* glory. **2 Cor 3:12-18**

Preaching Christ

4:[1]So, since we have this ministry, we don't get discouraged because we've received mercy. [2]We've set aside shameful secrets; we don't indulge in trickery or pervert God's message. But by showing what's true, we commend ourselves to everyone's conscience in front of God. [3]If our good news is veiled, it's veiled to people that perish. [4]The god of this world has blinded the minds of disbelievers so the glorious good news about Christ, the image of God, doesn't enlighten them. [5]We don't present ourselves; *we present* Jesus Christ as Lord and ourselves as your servants for his sake. [6]God said, ***"Light will shine out of darkness"*** **[Gen 1:3; Is. 9:2]**; he's the One that will *"shine"* in our hearts and *"enlighten" us* with the knowledge of his glory *that shines* on the face of Jesus Christ. **2 Cor 4:1-6**

Endurance in Conflict

[7]We have this treasure in clay jars so *it'll* be *obvious* that *the* extraordinary power *of the message* does not come from us, but from God. [8]In every *way* we're afflicted, but not crushed; puzzled, but not in despair; [9]persecuted, but not abandoned; knocked down, but not destroyed, [10]always carrying around in *our* body the death of Jesus so his life will be obvious in our body as well. [11]We who are alive keep getting delivered to death because of Jesus so his life can shine in our mortal flesh. [12]So death is at work in us, but life *is at work* in you. [13]We have the same spirit of trust as the scripture says ***"I believed; so I spoke"*** **[Ps 116:10]**. We *"believe"* too; so we *"speak"* [14]because we know that the One who raised Jesus up will raise us up with him and present us

along with you. [15]Everything's for your sake so the grace that has spread out through an increasing number *of people* will increase the gratitude, to God's glory.

[16]So we don't get discouraged. Though our outer self wears out, our inner self renews daily. [17]Our temporary, light hardship produces for us more and more an eternal, weighty glory that's beyond comparison. [18]We don't look at what we can see, but what we can't. What we can see is temporary; what we can't see is eternal. **5**:[1]We know that if our earthly "housing" perishes, we have one from God not made with hands, eternal in heaven. [2]That's what we wait for. [[3]] [4]While we're in this tent, we groan with burdens. We don't want to be "unhoused," but fully housed so life can swallow up what's mortal. [5]God has prepared us for that by giving us the Spirit as a pledge. **2 Cor 4:7-5:5**

Taking Courage in Christ

[6]So we always take courage. We know that while we're at home in the body we're away from the Lord. ([7]We operate by faith more than by sight.) [8]We have courage and prefer to be absent from the body and at home with the Lord. [9]So we aim to please him, whether we're at home or away. [10]We all have to appear at Christ's judgment seat to receive pay for what we did in the body, good or bad.

[11]So, fearing the Lord, we persuade people. We're open and obvious to God and, I hope, in your conscience too. [12]We're not trying to commend ourselves to you again; we're giving you a chance to take pride in us so you can answer people that take pride in appearances instead of heart. [13]Whether we're beside ourselves *is* for God *to decide*; whether we have a sound mind is for you *to decide*. [14]Christ's love controls us because we've concluded that since One died for all, all had died. [15]He died for all so all the living would stop living for themselves and *live* for the One that died for them and resurrected. **2 Cor 5:6-15**

Salvation as Reconciliation

[16]So from now on, we don't know anybody by what they look like. Even though we've known Christ that way, we don't anymore. [17]So if anybody's in Christ, they're a new creation. The old things are gone; they've become new; [18]and they've come from God. He has reconciled us to himself through Christ and has given us a ministry about reconciliation: [19]that in Christ, God was reconciling the world to himself, not holding their trespasses against them, and putting in us the message about reconciliation. [20]We're ambassadors for Christ, and God is making his appeal *to the world* through us, *"Please, for the sake of Christ, be reconciled to God."* [21]The One who hadn't sinned God treated as sinful on our behalf so we could become sinless in him.
2 Cor 5:16-21

Combating Opposition by Authentic Living

6:[1]We're working with him and urging you not to receive God's grace for nothing. [2]He says,

"I listened to you at the right time;
I helped you at a time of salvation" **[Is 49:8]**.

That "right time" is now; *that* "time of salvation" *is* now. [3]We try not to offend in anything so people won't find fault with our ministry. [4]We try to commend ourselves as ministers in endurance, affliction, hardship, distress, [5]beatings, imprisonment, mob violence, labors, sleeplessness, hunger; [6]in purity, knowledge, longsuffering, kindness, a holy spirit, genuine love, [7]in the message about the truth, the power of God; by the weapons of goodness in the right *hand* and the left; [8]through honor and disrespect, bad report and good; as deceitful but true, [9]unknown but well-known, as dying but alive, punished but not put to death; [10]as grieved but always rejoicing, as owning nothing but having everything.

[11]We've spoken freely to you, Corinthians; we've opened our hearts wide open. [12]We're not restraining you; your inward parts are restraining you. [13]Open up to us. (I'm talking as if *I'm talking* to *my* children.) **2 Cor 6:1-13**

Christians as God's Temple

[14]Don't get unequally yoked to unbelievers. How can goodness team up with lawlessness? What does light have in common with darkness? [15]What harmony *is there* between Christ and Belial? What part does a believer have with a disbeliever? [16]What agreement is there between God's sanctuary and idols? We're God's living sanctuary—like he said,

"'I'll live and move among them;
I'll be their God,
and they'll be my people **[Lev 26:12; Jer 32:28; Ezek 37:27]**.
[17]*So* ***come out from among them***
and be separate,' *the* LORD *says*.
'Don't touch anything unclean,
and I'll welcome you in **[Is 52:11; Ezek 20:34, 41]**.
[18]***I'll be your Father,***
and *you'll be* ***my sons*** *and daughters'* **[2 Sam 7:8; Is 43:6; Jer 31:9; Hos 1:10]**,
the LORD *Almighty says"* **[Amos 3:13 LXX; 4:13 LXX]**.

7:[1]Since we have these promises, let's "cleanse" ourselves from all defilement of flesh and spirit, and become perfect in holiness out of respect for God. **2 Cor 6:14-7:1**

The Great Value of Repentance

[2]Make room for us *in your hearts*. We haven't done anything wrong to anybody, misled anybody, taken advantage of anybody. [3]I'm not criticizing *you*; like I said earlier, you're in our

hearts whether that means living or dying together. [4]I'm being bold with you and expressing the great pride I take in you. **2 Cor 7:2-4**

[5]When we came to Macedonia, we couldn't rest. We had troubles on every *side*—conflicts outside and fears inside. [6]But God, who comforts the downhearted, comforted us by Titus' coming [7]and by the comfort he felt over you. He reported your longing, your grieving, *and* your zeal for me, so I rejoiced even more. [8]Though I made you sad by *my* letter, I don't regret *sending it*, though I felt bad that it made you sad for a while. [9]I'm happy now, not because you were grieved, but because you were grieved to repentance. You were sorry in conformity with God's will, so you didn't suffer any loss because of us. [10]Sorrow that conforms *a person* to God's *will* produces a repentance that leads to salvation without regret. The grief of this world leads to a dead end. [11]What earnestness that grieving in conformity to God's will has produced in you! What defense and indignation! What fear and longing! What zeal and avenging of wrong! In everything you've shown yourselves to be innocent in the matter. [12]I didn't write to you just for the offender and the offended; I wrote for your earnestness toward us to become clear to you in front of God. [13]Because of that, we've been comforted. **2 Cor 7:5-13a**

Besides being comforted, we rejoiced over Titus' joy because you all refreshed his spirit. [14]If I ever told him how proud I was about anything in you, I wasn't embarrassed. As we told you the truth about everything, our comments to Titus proved to be true *as well*. [15]His affection for you is all the greater when he remembers your obedience and how you received him with heartfelt respect. [16]I'm glad I can be confident about you in everything. **2 Cor 7:13b-16**

The Collection for Homeland Christians

8:[1]Now I want you to know about God's grace that the churches in Macedonia have given. [2]During a time of obvious great hardship, in their abundant joy and deep poverty their rich generosity abounded. [3]I speak to the fact that by their ability and beyond *they gave* of their own accord. [4]They begged us for the favor of participating in this ministry to the saints, [5]not like we expected, but they gave themselves to the Lord first and to us by God's will. [6]So we urged Titus that, like he made a beginning earlier, he would complete in you this grace too. [7]As you excel in everything—in faith, word, knowledge, diligence, and our love for you—excel in this grace too. **2 Cor 8:1-7**

[8]I'm not telling; I'm testing the sincerity of your love by comparing it to the zeal that others have. [9]You know the graciousness of our Lord Jesus Christ. Though he was rich, he became poor for you so you could become rich from his poverty. [10]I'm offering an opinion for your advantage. A year ago you wanted to do this. [11]Now according to your ability, finish what you started. [12]If people are ready, *it's* acceptable as they have, not as they don't have. [13]The idea is not to make it easy for others and hard on you. It's so there'll be equality. [14]Right now your

abundance supplies their lack so their abundance can supply your lack, so there'll be equality. [15]Like scripture says,

"The one that gathered a lot didn't have too much;
the one that gathered a little had enough" **[Ex 16:18]**. **2 Cor 8:8-15**

Titus' Role in the Collection

[16]Thanks to God, who has put the same earnestness for you in Titus' heart. [17]He accepted the appeal and has earnestly gone out to you of his own accord. [18]We've sent with him a brother that all the churches praise in the gospel. [19]We've chosen him to travel with us in this grace that we're overseeing to the Lord's honor and *to show* our commitment. [20]*We're handling the matter this way* so nobody can find fault with us in this generous gift. [21]We're being careful about what's appropriate in front of the Lord and people. [22]We've sent with them our brother that we've often found diligent in many things. He's all the more diligent because of the confidence he has in you. [23]Titus *is* my partner and fellow worker in respect to you, and our brothers *are* messengers of the churches and Christ's honor. [24]So show the churches the proof of your love and the reason we've been so proud of you. **2 Cor 8:16-24**

Further Comments on the Collection

9:[1]I don't need to write to you about *this* ministry to the saints. [2]I know you're committed to it, and I've told the Macedonians how pleased we are over it—*pleased* that *you in* Achaia have been ready since last year. Your zeal has stirred up many of them. [3]I've sent the brothers so our pride in you in this matter wouldn't be empty talk and, like I said, so you'd be ready. [4]That way, if Macedonians come with me, they'll find you ready, and we won't be embarrassed (much less, <u>you</u>) by this confidence *we've expressed about you*. [5]So I considered it appropriate to urge the brothers to go on to you and prepare ahead of time the blessing you promised before and get it ready as a blessing and not something you'd be doing under pressure. **2 Cor 9:1-5**

[6]Now *I tell you*, whoever doesn't sow much doesn't reap much, and whoever sows a lot reaps a lot. [7]Each person needs to do as he has decided in his heart, not reluctantly, or because he has to. God loves a cheerful giver. [8]He can make grace overflow for you so you can overflow in every good thing you do. You'll always have everything you need, [9]like scripture says,

"He has distributed *to everybody;*
he has given to the poor.
His goodness remains forever" **[Ps 112:9]**.

[10]The One who supplies seed to the sower and bread for food will supply and multiply your seed, and increase the harvest from your goodness. [11]In many ways, *your* generosity will enrich you, and yield thanksgiving to God through us. [12]Ministering this service not only supplies what the

saints need, it overflows with their great thanksgiving to God. [13]By the proof this ministry gives, they'll praise him for your obedience to the good news about Christ that you express by your generous contribution to them and everyone. [14]While they pray for you, they'll really want *to see* you because of the surpassing grace of God that's in you. [15]Thank God for his indescribable gift!
2 Cor 9:6-15

Paul's Defense of His Ministry

10:[1]Now I urge you by the meekness and gentleness of Christ—*I* who *am* meek when around, but bold when away! [2]I pray that when I am present, I won't be as bold as I reckon I could confidently be against some who claim that we live according to the flesh. [3]We do live in the flesh, but we don't fight according to the flesh. [4]Our weapons *aren't* physical; they're powerful in front of God for destroying strongholds. *With them* we destroy speculations [5]and every stronghold that rises up against knowing God. We make every thought captive to obeying Christ. [6]We stand ready to punish every disobedience whenever your obedience is complete.
2 Cor 10:1-6

[7]You look at the outward appearance of things. If anybody thinks they belong to Christ, they need to think about this again: as they belong to Christ, so do we. [8]Even if I'm too proud of our authority—which the Lord gave us for building you up, not for tearing you down—I won't let you disregard me. [9]I wouldn't want to scare you with my letters! [10]*"His letters,"* they say, *"are heavy and strong; but his physical presence is weak, and his speech* is *contemptible."* [11]They need to realize that what we are in word by letters when absent, *we can be* in deed when present. **2 Cor 10:7-11**

[12]We don't take it on ourselves to group *ourselves* and compare ourselves with people that put themselves forward. They measure themselves by themselves and compare themselves with themselves; that doesn't make sense. [13]We aren't going to take credit for more than we should, only in the area God appointed to us—to go as far as *where you are*. [14]We're not engaging in overreach; our work in the good news about Christ was the first to go as far *as where you live.* [15]We don't take credit for other men's labors. But, we hope that you'll hold us in increasingly higher regard in our area *of service*, [16]so we can preach the good news in places beyond you instead of bragging about what's been accomplished in somebody else's area *of service*. [17]***"The one that boasts should boast in the LORD"*** **[Jer 9:24].** [18]It's not who commends himself that's approved, but who the LORD commends. **2 Cor 10:12-18**

Paul in Contrast to Other Ministers

11:[1]Just bear with me in a little foolishness. [2]I'm jealous for you with a godly jealousy. I married you to one husband and presented *you as a* pure virgin. [3]I'm afraid that somehow, like the snake tricked Eve, he'll lead your minds astray from the simplicity [and purity][ms] that's in Christ. [4]If anybody comes presenting another Jesus than the One we've presented, or you receive

a different spirit than you've received, or a different message than you've received, you pay patient attention to *him*! [5]In no way do I consider myself inferior to the most prominent apostles. [6]Even if I'm not skilled in how I speak, I am "*skilled"* in what I know, and *we*'ve made that quite clear to you in everything. **2 Cor 11:1-6**

[7]Did I sin by humbling myself so you could be respected? Did I sin by presenting God's good news to you for free? [8]I robbed other churches, taking support *from them* so I could minister to you. [9]When I was with you and needed *something*, I didn't burden *you*. Brothers came from Macedonia to supply *those needs*. In every way I've kept from being a burden to you, and I'll continue to do that. [10]As Christ's truth is in me, I won't stop taking pride in that approach *to ministering* anywhere in Achaia. [11]Why? Because I don't love you? God knows.

[12]What I'm doing I'll keep doing. *I want to* take away any chance for the ones who want to be considered like us in what they're proud of. [13]People like them are false apostles, deceptive workers that disguise themselves as Christ's apostles. [14]That's no wonder; Satan himself disguises himself as an angel of light. [15]So *it's* not surprising if his minsters disguise themselves as ministers of goodness. They'll end up *rewarded* according to what they've done. **2 Cor 11:7-15**

Recounting Paul's Sufferings

[16]Again let me say, don't anybody consider me foolish. But, if *you do*, receive me as foolish so I can boast a little bit. [17]I'm not speaking here as the Lord would *have me speak*, but foolishly, in confident boasting. [18]Since many take pride in the flesh, I will too. [19]Since you're smart, you gladly put up with foolish people [20]who enslave you, eat you up, take advantage of you, put on airs, slap you in the face! [21]I'm speaking disparagingly *of myself* as if I really have been weak. But, in whatever respect anybody wants to be assertive, I'll be assertive too. [22]Are they Hebrews? So am I. Are they Israelites? So am I. Are they Abraham's descendants? So am I. [23]Are they Christ's ministers? I *am* more: in more labors, in jail more often, in scourgings more severely, in *danger of* death many times. [24]I received 39 lashes 5 times; [25]I was beaten with rods 3 times; I was stoned once; I was shipwrecked 3 times; I've spent a night and a day in the open water. [26]*I've* traveled often in dangers from rivers, robbers, *my* own countrymen, the Gentiles, in the desert, on the sea, among false believers. [27]I've been in labor and hardship, in lots of sleepless nights, hungry and thirsty often, cold and without enough clothes. [28]Besides external things, *there's* daily pressure on me for all the churches. [29]Who is weak and I'm not weak? Who falls into sin, and I'm not distressed? **2 Cor 11:16-29**

[30]If I'm going to be proud, I'll be proud of my weaknesses. [31]The God and Father of the Lord Jesus—blessed forever—knows I'm not lying. [32]In Damascus the ethnarch under King Aretas was guarding the city to capture me, [33]and I was let down in a basket through a window in the wall and escaped. **2 Cor 11:30-33**

Paul's Revelation Experiences

12:[1]Being proud may be appropriate, but *it's* not profitable. I'll go on to visions and revelations from the Lord. [2]I know a man in Christ 14 years ago—whether in the body or not, I don't know; God knows. He was caught up to the third heaven—**[3]repeat 4**to Paradise—and heard things there's no way to talk about. [5]I'll take pride in that man; I won't boast about myself except in my weaknesses. [6]If I do boast, I won't be foolish *about it*; I'll talk about what's real. I don't want anybody to regard me as something more than what they can see for themselves.

The Thorn in the Flesh

[7]Because of the extraordinary greatness of *those* revelations, God gave me a thorn in the flesh—a messenger from Satan—to discipline me so I wouldn't think too highly of myself. [8]I asked the Lord three times to take it away. [9]He said, *"My grace is sufficient for you; my power reaches its highest expression in weakness."* Gladly, then, I'll take pride in my weaknesses so Christ's power can live in me. [10]So I delight in weakness, mistreatment, need, persecution, and difficulty for Christ. When I'm weak I'm strong. **2 Cor 12:1-10**

Concern for Corinth

[11]You've made me become foolish. You should've been commending me. In no way have I been inferior to the most prominent apostles, though I'm nothing. [12]I worked the signs of an apostle among you in an ongoing way—signs, wonders, and miracles. [13]How did I treat you worse than the other churches—unless *it was* by not making myself a burden to you? Forgive me that wrong! [14]I'm ready to come this third time, and I won't be a burden *this time either*. I want you, not yours. Children don't lay up for parents; it's the other way around. [15]I'll gladly spend and be spent for your souls. Do you love me less for loving you more? [16]Anyway, I didn't burden you, because I was sneaky; I took you in by being crafty! [17]Did I take advantage of you through anybody I've sent you? [18]I'm the one that urged Titus and the brother *to come*. Titus hasn't taken advantage of you, has he? Haven't we both conducted ourselves with the same attitude? *Haven't we walked* in the same footsteps? **2 Cor 12:11-18**

[19]Do you think I'm saying all this to defend myself? God is witness, I'm saying this in Christ to help you. [20]I'm afraid that in some way, when I get there, I won't find you like I want to, and you won't find me that way either. I'm afraid *I'll find* rivalry, jealousy, anger, dispute, slander, gossip, pride, disturbances. [21]I'm afraid my God will humiliate me in front of you, and I'll be sad because people that sinned previously haven't repented of their impurity, sexual immorality, and sensuality. **2 Cor 12:19-21**

Self-Examination Before God

13:[1]This will be the third time I'm coming to you. ***"Establish everything by two or three witnesses"*** **[Deut 19:15].** [2]The second time I was there I said this—and I say it again to the ones that sinned previously and to the rest—if I come again, I won't hold back, [3]because you're looking for proof that Christ is speaking in me. He's not weak toward you but is strong among you. [4]Indeed, he was crucified out of weakness, but lives by God's power. We're weak in him too, but we'll live with him by God's power *that's directed* at you. **2 Cor 13:1-4**

[5]Test *to see* if you're in the faith; examine yourselves! Don't you realize that God's among you—unless you fail the test? [6]I hope you'll know we won't fail the test. [7]We pray to God that you won't do anything bad, not that we may appear approved, but that you'll do what's good even if we would fail the test. [8]We can't do anything against the truth, only for it. [9]We are happy to be weak and you to be strong. We pray for this too: your perfection. [10]So I'm writing this while absent so when I'm present, I won't have to be severe in using the authority the Lord gave me for building you up, not for tearing you down. **2 Cor 13:5-10**

Final Greetings

[11]Finally, rejoice, strive for perfection, be comforted, live in harmony and peace, and the God of love and peace will be with you. [12]Greet one another with a holy kiss. [(13)]All the saints greet you.

[13(14)]The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, the love of God, and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit *be* with you all. **2 Cor 13:11-13(14)**

GALATIANS

Salutation

1:[1]Paul, apostle—not appointed by human agency or by human authority, but by Jesus Christ[Messiah] and God the Father who resurrected him—[2]and the Christians that are with me, to the churches in Galatia. [3]Grace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ. [4]He gave himself for our sins to deliver us from this sinful age, as God had willed. [5]Glory to him forevermore. Amen. **Gal 1:1-5**

The Only Gospel

[6]I'm amazed that you're turning away so quickly from the One that called you by the grace that comes from Christ and *turning* to a different kind of gospel that's [7]not really another gospel at all. It's just that some people are confusing you by distorting Christ's gospel. [8]But, even if <u>we</u> or an angel from heaven would present a gospel different from what we presented, consider him under a curse. [9]I repeat, if anybody presents a gospel different from the one you've received, consider him under a curse. [10]Am I trying to please people or God? If I was trying to please people, I wouldn't be serving Christ. [11-12]I'm telling you, the message I presented *to you* didn't come from other people; Jesus Christ revealed it to me. **Gal 1:6-12**

Paul's History

[13]You've heard that when I was in Judaism, I was persecuting God's church to the extreme. I was trying to destroy it. [14]I was moving up *the ranks* in Judaism past many contemporaries in my nation because I was more fanatical about the traditions of my ancestors. [15]But God set me apart at birth and called me by his grace. It pleased him [16]to reveal his Son in me so I could present him among the Gentiles. Right away, I didn't consult other people [17]or go up to Jerusalem to the ones that were apostles before me. I went away to Arabia and then back to Damascus. [18]Three years later I did go up to Jerusalem to visit Peter and stayed with him fifteen days. [19]I didn't see any of the other apostles except James, the Lord's brother. [20]What I'm writing to you is the truth. [21]After that, I went to Syria and Cilicia. [22]Christ's churches in Judaea didn't know me by sight. [23]The only thing they kept hearing was that the one who used to persecute them was now preaching the faith he tried to destroy, [24]and they praised God because of me. **Gal 1:13-24**

Opposition to the Judaizers

2:[1]Fourteen years later, I went up to Jerusalem again, that time with Barnabas, and took Titus along. [2]I went up, directed by revelation, to lay out for them the message I was presenting to Gentiles. I met privately with the recognized leaders so I wouldn't be running or had run for

nothing. [3]They didn't consider it necessary to circumcise Titus, a Gentile. [4]*That trip came about* because false believers had slipped in to spy out the freedom we have in Christ Jesus and to enslave us *to the Law*. [5]To maintain the truth about the good news, we didn't back down for one minute. [6]The recognized leaders *in Jerusalem* didn't contribute anything to me. (Who they were didn't matter. God doesn't pay any attention to that.) [7]Instead, they saw that God had entrusted me with presenting the good news to the uncircumcised like he'd entrusted Peter with presenting it to the circumcised. [8]The One at work in Peter's apostleship was at work in mine for the Gentiles. [9]James, Cephas, and John—recognized pillars—shook hands with me and Barnabas to go to the Gentiles. They'd go to the Circumcision. [10]The only thing was, they wanted us to remember the poor, and I was eager to do that. **Gal 2:1-10**

Paul Confronts Cephas (*Peter*)

[11]When Cephas came to Antioch, I confronted him because he'd condemned himself. [12]Before some men came from James, *[the Lord's brother],* he'd been eating with the Gentiles. But when they got there, he started separating himself because he was afraid of the Circumcision. [13]The rest of the Jews joined him in that hypocrisy—even Barnabas got caught up in it. [14]When I saw they weren't conforming to the true message, I said to Cephas, *"If you're a Jew but live like a Gentile, how is it that you require Gentiles to live like Jews?* [15]We're naturally Jews, not Gentile sinners. [16]We know that no person's made good by doing the Law, but by trusting in Christ. We've put trust in Christ Jesus so trusting <u>him</u> can justify us. What people do under <u>law</u> doesn't make them good. [17]But if while we're trying to be good in Christ, we turn out to be sinners, does that make Christ a minister of sin? Goodness, no! [18]If I rebuild what I used to tear down, I make myself a sinner. [19]By the Law I died to law so I could live to God. I've been crucified with Christ. [20]It's not me that's living, but Christ that's living in me. What I live now in the flesh, I live by trusting God's Son, who loved me and gave himself for me. [21]I don't cancel out God's grace. If law can make us good, there was no reason for Christ[Messiah] to die. **Gal 2:11-21**

Law *vs.* Trust

3:[1]Foolish Galatians! Who cast a spell on you? Right in front of your eyes I portrayed Jesus Christ crucified. [2]This is what I'd like to know: did you receive the Spirit by working under <u>law</u> or by trusting the <u>Person</u> you listened to? [3]Are you foolish enough to start with spirit and try to finish with flesh? [4]Did you suffer so much for nothing—if it was for nothing? [5]Does the one that provides you the Spirit and works miracles among you *do it* by working under law or trusting the Person he listened to? [6]In that way, Abraham ***"<u>trusted</u> God, and God <u>considered</u> him good"*** **[Gen 15:6]**. **Gal 3:1-6**

[7]Rest assured, then, the ones who "trust" are like Abraham. [8]The scripture looked forward to when God would make Gentiles good by trusting. So it "presented the good news" to

Abraham, ***"In you I will bless all the nations"*** **[Gen 12:3; 18:18]**. [9]So God blesses people that trust like Abraham did. [10]Those who work under law are under a curse: scripture says, ***"Everybody's under a curse that doesn't do everything all the time that the Law requires"*** **[Deut 27:26]**. [11]Obviously, law can't make anyone good in front of God: ***"A good person will have life by trusting"*** **[Hab 2:4]**. [12]Law doesn't involve trusting: ***"The one that <u>does</u> them is the one that has life by them"*** **[Lev 18:5]**. [13]Christ redeemed us from the curse that law brings us under by becoming a curse on our behalf. Scripture says, ***"Everybody's under a curse that hangs on a tree"*** **[Deut 21:23]**. [14]So the blessing associated with Abraham can come to Gentiles in Christ Jesus; and by trusting, we can receive the Spirit Christ promised *us*. **Gal 3:7-14**

Law *vs.* Promise

[15]Take an example from everyday life. Even with a human covenant, once it's ratified, nobody annuls it or adds to it. [16]God made promises to Abraham and his seed. The text doesn't say "seeds," plural, but "seed," singular, ***"to your seed"*** **[Gen 12:7; 13:15; 17:7; 24:7]**, *that is*, Christ. [17]Here's the point: the Law, which came 430 years after the promise, didn't annul *the* promise; *it didn't* annul the covenant God had put in place earlier. [18]If inheritance comes by law, it doesn't come by promise. But God gave it to Abraham by *making a* promise. [19]So, what was the Law for? God added it to deal with sins till the "seed" came that he made *his* promise to. Angels ordained the Law through a mediator. [20]A mediator mediates between two parties, not one; but God is *only* one party. **Gal 3:15-20**

Law Prepares for Trust

[21]So, does the Law conflict with God's promise? Goodness, no! If there could've been a law that gave life, the Law would make people good. [22]But scripture locks up everything under sin so trusting could *directly* deliver the promise to the ones who trust *the promise*.

[23]Till trust came into play, law held us in custody. [24]It served as an attendant to lead *us* to Christ so trusting in *him* could make us good. [25]Now that trust has come, we aren't under an attendant anymore. [26]We're God's children by trusting in Christ Jesus. [27]Those of us who were baptized into Christ have put on Christ. [28]Jew-Greek, slave-free, male-female is irrelevant. We're all alike in Christ Jesus. [29]If we're Christ's, we're Abraham's seed[sg] and heirs by promise. **Gal 3:21-29**

Slaves and Children

4:[1]Let me point out that as long as heirs are minors, they're like servants *at present* though owners of everything *in prospect*. [2]They're under guardians and trustees till the time their father specifies. [3]That's like us. When we were minors, we were servants to the material-based notions the world operates by. [4]But when the time came, God sent out his Son—born by woman under law—[5]to redeem us who were under law and to adopt us as children. [6]Since we're

children, God gave us the sense of being that his Son has; we call out, *"Dad."* [7]So we're not servants anymore, but children that became heirs by God*'s promise.* **Gal 4:1-7**

The Inadequacy of Law

[8]Before you knew God, you served what weren't really gods. [9]Now, since you know him—or better, he knows you—why do you want to go back and serve weak, material-based notions again? [10]You're observing days, months, seasons, and years. [11]I'm afraid I've labored over you for nothing. **Gal 4:8-11**

[12]I plead with you, become like me because I'm like you. You haven't wronged me in anything. [13]You know I presented the good news to you at the first because of a physical handicap. [14]You didn't look down on me because of it. You received me like an angel from God, like Christ Jesus. [15]So where's your sense of being blessed? I point out that, if possible, you would've gouged your eyes out and given them to me. [16]So, do I become your enemy by telling you the truth? [17]*The ones that are confusing you* aren't seeking you out for any good reason. They want to lock you out so you'll look to them *to get in*. [18]But it's always good to have someone seek you out in a good way, not just when I'm around. [19]My children, I'm in labor with you again until Christ forms in you. [20]I'd like to be with you now and change my tone. I'm worried about you. **Gal 4:12-20**

The Hagar-Sarah Allegory

[21]You that want to be under law, tell me, are you listening to it? [22]Scripture says Abraham had two sons, one by a servant girl and one by a free *woman*. [23]The one the servant girl had was born physically, but the one the free *woman* had *was born* by promise. [24]These points set up an illustration: the women represent two covenants. [25]Hagar, from Mount Sinai in Arabia, bears children into bondage. She's the mountain that corresponds to present-day Jerusalem because she's in bondage along with her children. [26]But the Jerusalem above is free; that's our mother. [27]Scripture says,

"Celebrate, barren one that doesn't bear;
cry out and scream, woman that's not in labor.
The woman that's single has more children
than the one with a husband" **[Is 54:1].**

[28]You're children like Isaac. [29]The one born physically was persecuting the one *born* spiritually; it's the same way now. [30]But what does the scripture say?

"Send away the servant girl and her son;
her son will not inherit with the son" of the free *woman* **[Gen 21:10].**

[31]So we're not children of a servant girl, but of a free *woman*. **5**[:1]Christ really has set us free; so stand firm; don't put yourselves back under a yoke of bondage. **Gal 4:21-5:1**

Law and Trust, Mutually Exclusive Systems

[2]I tell you, if you accept circumcision, Christ doesn't do you any good. [3]You're obligated to keep the Law completely. [4]You that are trying to gain righteousness by law have cut yourselves off from Christ. You've fallen away from grace *into law*. [5]In spirit we wait by trust for the goodness we hope for. [6]In Christ Jesus, neither circumcision nor uncircumcision is relevant. What matters is trust expressing itself in love. **Gal 5:2-6**

[7]You were running well. Who stopped you from obeying the truth? [8]The persuasion didn't come from the One that's calling you. [9]A little yeast spreads through the whole lump. [10]I have confidence in you in the Lord that you won't adopt something else. The one that's confusing you will face condemnation, whoever he is. [11]If I still preach circumcision, why do *the Jews* still persecute me? [12]I wish the ones that are troubling you would mutilate themselves.

Gal 5:2-12

Christian Freedom

[13]You were called to freedom. Just don't use it as an excuse for the flesh; serve one another with love. [14]One statement fulfills the whole Law, **"Love your neighbor as yourself"** **[Lev 19:18]**. [15]If you nip at and chew on each other, you'll end up eating each other up.

Physical versus spiritual

[16]I tell you, live by what's spiritual and you won't be fulfilling what's fleshly. [17]Flesh pulls against spirit and *vice versa*. They work against each other, and you end up doing what you don't want to do. [18]If spirit is leading you, you're not under law. [19]It's clear what fleshly deeds are: sexual immorality, uncleanness, sensuality, [20]idolatry, sorcery, hostility, rivalry, jealousy, rage, disputes, divisions, factions, [21]envy, drunkenness, carousing, and so on. I tell you ahead of time, like I told you before, people that do such things won't inherit God's kingdom.

[22]But spirit produces fruit like love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, trustworthiness, [23]gentleness, self-control. There's no law against such things. [24]Christ's people have crucified the physical along with its drives and desires. [25]If we have life by spirit, let's conduct life by spirit. [26]Let's not be proud or jealous or irritate each other. **Gal 5:13-26**

Patience with the Sinful

6:[1]If someone gets caught up in some sin, you that are spiritual should humbly restore that person. Keep an eye on yourselves so <u>you</u> don't get caught up in temptation. [2]Share each other's burdens and fulfill Christ's 'law' that way. [3]If we think we're special when we're not, we're kidding ourselves. [4]We each one must examine our own behavior and take pride in it only in respect to ourselves, not *in comparison t*o somebody else. [5]Each one of us has to carry our own load. [6]The one that's being taught the message needs to share everything good with the one

that's teaching it. [7]Make no mistake, we can't mock God. We reap what we sow. [8]If we sow in the flesh, we'll reap decay. If we sow in the spirit, we'll reap eternal life. [9]Let's not get discouraged with doing what's right. In due time we'll reap if we don't give up. [10]So while we've got a chance, let's work at doing good to everybody, especially to members of the family of faith. **Gal 6:1-10**

Closing Encouragements

[11]See what big letters I've written with my own hand. [12]Those who want to make a good impression in the flesh are trying to get you circumcised so they won't suffer persecution for the cross of Christ[Messiah]. [13]They don't keep the Law themselves; they just want to get you circumcised so they can take pride in you physically. [14]But I'm not going to take pride in anything but the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ. Through him the world's crucified to me and me to it. [15]Neither circumcision nor uncircumcision has anything to do with it; *what matters is* a new system *God has* created *in Christ.* [16]Peace and mercy to as many as live by that principle—to God's 'Israel.'

[17]From now on, don't create problems for me. I *already* have on my body the branding marks of the Lord Jesus.

[18]The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ *be* with your spirit. Amen. **Gal 6:11-18**

EPHESIANS

Salutation

1:[1]Paul, apostle of Christ[Messiah] Jesus by God's will, to the saints [in Ephesus][ms] and faithful in Christ Jesus. [2]Grace and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ. **Eph 1:1-2**

The Blessings of Redemption

[3]Blessed *be* the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ. He's blessed us in Christ with every spiritual blessing in high places. [4]Before he founded the world, he chose us in Christ to be holy and blameless in his presence in love. [5]It pleased him to destine us ahead of time to be his children through Jesus Christ. [6]So we praise the glorious grace he freely extended to us in the Beloved. [7]He redeemed us by his blood, and that forgiveness demonstrates the rich grace [8]he lavished on us by providing us wisdom and insight. [9]He let us know his previously unrevealed will that, in his good pleasure, he intended for Christ [10]to oversee when the time came. He chose to sum up everything in Christ in heaven and on earth. [11]In him we've become an inheritance for the One who accomplishes everything according to his own counsel and purpose. [12]As a result of what he's done, we praise his glory—we who have already placed our hope in Christ. [13]You've heard the truth as well—the good news about salvation—and put your trust in him; and he has sealed you with the Holy Spirit he promised. [14]*The Spirit* is *God's* pledge to *give us* our *full* inheritance when he redeems his *people*—to the praise of his glory. **Eph 1:3-14**

Prayer for the Ephesians

[15]I've heard about your faith in the Lord Jesus and your love for the saints. [16]So I keep including you in my prayers and being grateful for you. [17]*I pray* that the God of our glorious Lord Jesus Christ will give you wisdom and revelation by knowing him. [18]That means enlightening you to recognize what the hope of his calling is, *to realize* how rich his inheritance among the saints is, [19]and *to understand* what the unlimited greatness of his power is toward us who believe. [20]God brought about that *hope, inheritance, and power* by raising Christ from the dead and seating him on his own right hand in high places. [21]*Now* he's far above all rule, authority, power, dominion, and everybody else in this age and the next. [22-23]God put him in charge of everything as head of his body the church, the embodiment of the One that fills everything. **Eph 1:15-23**

Spiritual Death from Personal Sinning

2:[1]You were 'dead' because of the sins [2]you once lived in like the rest of the world. *It was a way of living* that corresponded to the ruler of the power in the air, the spirit that operates in disobedient people. [3]Among those people at one time we all lived by fleshly drives. We were

doing what the flesh and imagination desired. Our character made us objects of God's anger like everybody else. [4]But God was so merciful because he loved us so much. [5]We 'died' by sinning, but he 'made us alive' with Christ (by grace he saved us). [6]He raised us up with *him* and seated us with *him* in high places. [7]In the coming ages, what he did will show the tremendous wealth of his grace and kindness toward us in Christ Jesus. [8]By grace we're saved people through faith, and that salvation doesn't come from us; it's God's gift; [9]so we can't be proud. [10]We're his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for living the way God designed us ahead of time to live.

Eph 2:1-10

Jew-Gentile Unity in Christ

[11-12]So, you Gentiles in the flesh—called Uncircumcision by the handmade Circumcision in the flesh, remember that you were separated from Christ at that time. You were excluded from the Commonwealth of Israel, without hope, and without God in the world. [13]But you that were once afar off have come near through Christ's blood. **Eph 2:11-13**

[14-15]Christ is the basis for peace between us. He made both *of us* into one group and tore down the wall that separated *us*. In his flesh he abrogated the Law that's made up of regulations. That way, from the two groups he could create in himself one new united mankind and could make peace *between us*. [16]*He could* reconcile both *of us* to God in one body through the cross. In himself he killed the hostility. [17]He came and offered peace to you that were far away and to us that were close by. [18]Through him we both have access to the Father by one Spirit. [19]So you're not strangers and aliens anymore, but fellow citizens and members of God's family. [20]You're built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets with Christ Jesus as the cornerstone. [21]In Christ the whole building fits together and grows upward to become a holy sanctuary. [22]In him you're growing along with *us* into a spiritual house for God in *the person of* the Spirit.

Eph 2:14-22

Paul's Ministry for Gentiles

3:[1]That's why I'm Christ's prisoner for you Gentiles. [2]You've heard about the stewardship of grace God gave me for you. [3]He revealed to me his previously unrevealed message, like I noted briefly before. [4]When you read it, you can understand my insight into that message about Christ. [5]In other generations God hadn't made it known to anybody, but now the Spirit has revealed it to his holy apostles and prophets. [6]This is the message: Gentiles are fellow heirs, fellow members of the body, fellow partakers of the promise available in Christ Jesus through the good news. [7]I became a minister of that message by the grace God gave me in keeping with his powerful working. [8]To me, the least of the saints, he gave this grace to present to Gentiles Christ's amazing riches [9]and to bring to light the message that in ages past God kept to himself, who created everything. [10]The church can make known to rulers and authorities in high places the many forms of God's wisdom. [11]That comes from the eternal purpose he brought

about in Christ our Lord. [12]In him we have confident bold access because we trust him. [13]So don't get discouraged over my difficulties on your behalf. They honor you. **Eph 3:1-13**

Another Prayer for the Ephesians

[14]So I kneel to the Father; [15]from him every people group in heaven and on earth has identity. [16]I pray that, in keeping with his glorious riches, he'll greatly increase your inner strength by his Spirit. [17]*I pray* that Christ will live in your heart by faith, rooted and grounded in love. [18-19]*I pray* that you'll be able to understand with all the saints the length and breadth, height and depth of Christ's love, which is greater than knowledge. *I pray* that you'll fully experience everything God provides you.

[20]Now to him who can do far more than we think or ask in keeping with the power that's at work in us—[21]glory in the church and in Christ Jesus to all generations. Amen. **Eph 3:14-21**

Christian Unity

4:[1]So I, a prisoner in the Lord, urge you to live appropriate to your calling—[2]with humility and gentleness, with patience toward each other in love. [3]Make every effort to maintain spiritual unity* by being bound together with peace.

[4]*There's* one body, one Spirit, one hope you're called to,
[5]one Lord, one faith, one baptism,
[6]one God and Father of all,
who's above all, through all, and in all.

[7]Christ has measured out grace to each of you, [8]like it says,

"He ascended on high,
and captured captivity;
he gave gifts to people" **[Ps 68:18].** **Eph 4:1-8**

Gifting for Ministry

[9]What does *"he ascended"* involve but that he had also <u>descended</u> to earth? [10]And the One that had descended also ascended above the skies to complete everything. [11]He *"gave"* apostles, prophets, evangelists, and pastor-teachers [12]to equip the saints for service and to build up Christ's body. [13]*That work goes on* till we become one in trusting and knowing God's Son and *are* full-grown as measured by the stature of Christ. [14]That's so we won't stay like little kids, tossed back and forth and blown around by every idea that sly people devise to trick us. [15]Let's speak the truth in love and grow up in Christ in every respect. [16]He's the head that unites the whole body. Every ligament holds it together so each part can contribute properly to the growth of the body as it builds itself up in love. **Eph 4:9-16**

Wise Living with One Another

17So don't live like Gentiles anymore in their pointless way of thinking **18**and darkened understanding. They're strangers to godly living because they're ignorant and hardhearted. **19**They've become insensitive and have given themselves over to doing everything indecent, impure, and greedy. **20**You didn't learn to live that way from Christ. [**21**]repeat **Eph 4:17-21**

22So set aside the former way of living—the old kind of humanity that's ruined by desires that deceive; **23**adopt a new mentality. **24**Put on the new kind of humanity that's like God in the goodness and holiness that lie in the truth. **Eph 4:22-24**

25So don't lie; ***"each of you, speak truthfully with your neighbor"*** **[Zech 8:16]**, because you're members of one another. **26*"If you*pl *feel angry, don't sin"*** **[Ps 4:4]**. Don't letsg the sun set on your anger; **27**don't give the devil a foothold. **28**If you're stealing, stop it. Instead, work with your hands, doing what's good so you can share with people who need help. **29**Take every bad word out of your mouth and replace it with a good word that builds up with graciousness those who hear *you*. **30**Don't grieve God's Holy Spirit that *Christ* sealed you with to the day of *final* redemption. **31**Get rid of bitterness, wrath, anger, angry shouting, blasphemy, hateful feelings. **32**Be kind to one another, tenderhearted, gracious, like God in Christ was gracious to you.

Eph 4:25-32

Imitating God

5:**1**So imitate God like children he loves. **2**Live in love like Christ loved you and gave himself for you *as an* offering, a sacrifice to God for a sweet fragrance. **3**Don't let immorality, impurity, or greed even be mentioned among you, as is appropriate for saints. **4**Don't allow any indecency or foolish, vulgar talk among you; express gratitude instead. **5**Know for certain that no immoral, impure, or covetous person—covetousness amounts to idolatry—will inherit anything in the kingdom of Christ and God. **Eph 5:1-5**

Resisting Human Influence

6Don't let anybody deceive you with meaningless words. Because of things like that, God measures out his anger on disobedient people. **7**So don't take part in their disobedience. **8-9**At one time you were in the dark; now you're in the light that comes from the Lord. (Light produces goodness, uprightness, and truth.) Live like enlightened children **10**and demonstrate what pleases the Lord.

11Don't take part in deeds done in darkness; they don't produce anything; expose them for what they are. **12**It's disgraceful even to talk about what some people do secretly. **13**Everything exposed by light becomes visible; **14**light makes everything visible. So he says,

"Wake up up, sleeper" **(Rom 13:11)**;
"arise from the dead" **(Is 26:19)**,
and Christ will give you light" **(Is 60:1).** **Eph 5:6-14**

[15]So be careful to live like wise people. [16]Make the most of *every* opportunity because this is a sinful time. [17]Don't be foolish; know what the Lord's will is. [18]Don't get drunk on wine in reckless living; be filled with the Spirit. [19]Speak to each other in psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs. Sing and make melody in your hearts to the Lord. [20]In the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, always thank the Father for everything. **Eph 5:15-20**

Family Virtues

[21]Defer to one another out of respect for Christ. [22]Wives defer to your husbands the way *you do* to the Lord, [23]because a husband is responsible above the wife like Christ is responsible above the church and Savior of the body. [24]As the church defers to Christ, wives defer to husbands in the over-all order *of the home*.

[25]Husbands, love your wives the way Christ loved the church and gave himself for it. [26]He did it to sanctify the church and cleanse it by washing *it* with water and the word. [27]He did it so he could present the church to himself without stain or wrinkle or anything like that—so it would be holy and blameless. [28]Husbands, love your wives like your own bodies. Loving your wife amounts to loving yourself. [29]Nobody neglects his own body; he feeds it and takes care of it. Christ does that with the church [30]because we're parts of his body: [31]***"That's why a man is to leave his parents and unite with his wife, and they'll become one"*** **[Gen 2:24]**. [32]That's a profound matter, but the main thing I'm talking about is Christ and the church. [33]But, each one of you needs to love his wife like he loves himself, and wives need to respect their husbands. **Eph 5:21-33**

6:[1]Children, obey your parents in the Lord; it's the right thing to do. [2-3]***"Honor your father and mother so you'll live long and well"*** **[Ex 20:12; Deut. 5:16]** (the first commandment with a promise *attached*). [4]Dads, don't make your kids resent you. Raise them up in the Lord's instruction and discipline.

[5]Servants, obey your masters with fear and trembling, sincerely as if obeying Christ. [6]Don't just try to create impressions to please them; but as Christ's servants, do God's will honestly [7]with good intentions. Be serving the Lord, as it were, not people. [8]Understand that whatever each of you does, you'll receive it back from the Lord whether you're a servant or free. [9]Masters, treat your servants the same way. Give up making threats; you know that their Lord and yours is in heaven, and he doesn't show preferences. **Eph 6:1-9**

The Full Armor of God

[10]Finally, be strong in the Lord and his great power. [11]Put on God's full armor so you can withstand the devil's schemes. [12]You're not fighting a physical war, but rulers, authorities, this world's dark forces, spiritual evil in high places. [13]So put on God's full armor so you can withstand sinful times, overcome everything, and stand firm. [14]So stand firm. Tie truth around

your waist. Make goodness your breastplate. [15]On your feet, wear the good news about peace. [16]Along with everything else, pick up faith as *your* shield so the devil's flaming arrows will ricochet away from you. [17]Take salvation for a helmet and God's word as a spiritual sword. [18]Pray in the spirit on every occasion. Stay alert and persist in petitions for the saints. [19]Pray that I'll speak boldly the unrevealed message that the good news makes known. [20]On behalf of it, I'm an ambassador in chains. *Pray* that I'll speak boldly for him like I need to. **Eph 6:10-20**

Farewells

[21]Tychicus, our dear brother and faithful minister in Christ, will fill you in on my circumstances and how I'm doing. [22]I've sent him to do that so he can comfort you.

[23]Peace to fellow believers and love with faith from God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ. [24]Grace *be* with everybody that has undying love for him. **Eph 6:21-24**

PHILIPPIANS

Salutation

1:[1]Paul and Timothy, servants of Christ[Messiah] Jesus, to the saints in Philippi and *their* bishops and deacons. [2]Grace and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ. **Phil 1:1-2**

Prayer for the Philippians

[3]I'm grateful for the memories I have of you. [4]I gladly mention you in my prayers [5]because of your fellowship in the gospel since day one. [6]I'm confident that the good work God began in you he'll keep perfecting till Christ comes. [7]It's right for me to regard you that way because in my imprisonment and defense of the gospel, you've shared your grace with me. [8]God is witness, I long for you with the affections Jesus has. [9]I pray that your love will keep growing along with knowledge and insight [10]so you'll approve what's excellent, be sincere, and keep your conscience clear till Christ comes. [11]That way the fruit that comes from goodness will fill you, *the fruit* that comes through Jesus Christ to God's glory and praise. **Phil 1:3-11**

Progress Despite Limiting Circumstances

[12]I want you to know that what's happened to me has turned out to promote the good news. [13]My imprisonment has become well-known throughout the Praetorian Guard and elsewhere. [14]More believers have trusted in the Lord and because of my imprisonment have dared to speak the message more boldly. [15]Some people are preaching Christ out of spite and strife; others out of good will. [16]Some do it out of love because they know I'm set to defend the good news. [17]The others present him out of rivalry, not sincerely. They think they can stir up trouble for me in *my* imprisonment. [18]What then? Whether in pretense or truth, Christ is getting presented and I'm glad. [19]I know it'll lead to my release through your prayer and the support of the Spirit of Jesus Christ. [20]That fits with my deep desire and hope that I'll never be ashamed, but
hold Christ in high honor in my body whether by life or death—as always, so now. [21]For me, to live *is* Christ, to die *is* gain. [22]But if living means productive work, I don't know what to choose. [23]I'm torn between wanting to leave and be with Christ (better for me) [24]and *wanting to* stay (more necessary for you). [25]I'm convinced I'll stay and stand with you for your progress and joy in the faith, [26]so the pride you have in Christ Jesus will increase in connection with me when I can be with you again. **Phil 1:12-26**

Living in a Way Fit for Christ

[27]Make sure you conduct yourselves in a way that's appropriate for the good news about Christ. Then, whether I can come to see you or not, I can hear that you're standing firm in one spirit with one mind, that you're striving together by trusting in the good news, [28]and that you're

not alarmed by your opponents. Their opposition is evidence for their destruction and your salvation—a situation that comes from God. [29]For the sake of Christ, you've had the opportunity to believe in him and suffer for him. [30]You're facing the same struggle you saw me face and hear that I'm facing now. **Phil 1:27-30**

Christ's Extreme Example of Humility

2:[1]So, if there's any encouragement in Christ, any comfort from love, any fellowship with the Spirit, any affection and compassion, [2]fill me with happiness. That way you'll have the same attitude, love, purpose, and unity of spirit. [3]Don't do anything selfish out of empty conceit, but in humility consider each other more important than yourself. [4]Don't just look at your own interests, but at the interests of other people too. [5]Take the attitude Christ Jesus took.

[6]Although he was in the form of deity,
he didn't consider being equal to God
something to hang onto.
[7]He emptied himself,
and took the place of a servant.
In the form of a man,
[8]he humbled himself to the point of dying,
even dying on a cross.
[9]So God lifted him up above all others
[10]so every knee in heaven, on earth, and under the earth
would kneel to him;
[11]and every tongue would acknowledge that Jesus Christ is Lord—
to the glory of God the Father. **Phil 2:1-11**

Being Lights in the World

[12]So, as you've always followed my instructions—whether I'm around or not, work out *the implications of* your salvation with fear and trembling. [13]God is at work in you to will and do what he delights in. [14]Do everything without grumbling or arguing [15]so you'll be God's blameless, innocent, well-behaved children. You're living in a crooked, perverse time, where you shine like lights in the world.

[16]Hold onto the life-giving message so when Christ comes, I can take satisfaction in you because I didn't labor for nothing. [17]Even if I get poured out like a drink offering on the altar in service to your faith, I'll rejoice and rejoice with you. [18]You'll[p] rejoice too along with me.
Phil 2:12-18

Timothy's Coming

[19]I hope to send Timothy to lift my spirits by finding out how you're doing. [20]I don't have anybody like-minded who will sincerely concern himself with your welfare. [21]*Other people*

tend to look after their own concerns more than Christ's. [22]But you know how valuable he has proved to be, how he has served with me in the good news like a child with his father. [23]So I hope to send him as soon as I see how my situation *here* turns out. [24]I'm confident in the Lord that I can come soon as well. **Phil 2:19-24**

News About Epaproditus

[25]I've also needed to send Epaphroditus, my brother, fellow worker, fellow soldier, and your messenger to my need. [26]He's been longing to see you; he's been anxious because you heard he was sick. [27]He was sick—to the point of death, but God had mercy on him—and on me so I wouldn't have grief on top of grief. [28]More earnestly, then, I've sent him so when you see him, you can be happy, and I won't feel so sad. [29]Welcome him in the Lord with joy; hold men like him in high regard. [30]He nearly died because of his work for Christ, risking his life to finish your service to me. **Phil 2:25-30**

No Confidence in the Flesh

3:[1]So, family *of Christ*, be happy in the Lord. Writing things like these is not hard for me to do, and it reinforces you. [2]Watch out for dogs, evil doers, the 'false Circumcision.' [3]We are the 'Circumcision,' who serve by God's spirit, who take pride in Christ Jesus, who don't put confidence in what's physical. [4]If anybody could put confidence in that, I sure *could*: [5]*I was* circumcised on the eighth day, from the nation of Israel, tribe of Benjamin, the truest of Hebrews. As to the Law, *I was* a Pharisee. [6]As to zeal, *I* persecuted the church. As to legal goodness, *I was* blameless. [7]*But*[ms] what were gains to me I consider losses for Christ. [8]Everything's a loss compared to knowing Christ Jesus my Lord. I lost everything on account of him and considered it rubbish so I could gain him. [9]I don't have a goodness of my own—from keeping the Law; *I have* a goodness *that comes* from trusting Christ, a goodness that God gives conditioned on trust. [10]*I want* to know him, the power his resurrection has, and fellowship with his sufferings. *I want to live in* conformity with his death [11]so I can attain resurrection from the dead, whatever it takes. **Phil 3:1-11**

Pressing on Toward Perfection

[12]I'm not already perfect, but I press on toward what Christ laid hold of me for. [13]I don't consider myself to have achieved it; but forgetting what's behind and reaching out for what's ahead, [14]I press on toward the goal, the prize that comes from God's upward call in Christ Jesus. [15]As many as are perfect should take that attitude. If in anything you have a different attitude, God will make it clear for you. [16]However, let's keep conducting ourselves at the level we've reached. **Phil 3:12-16**

Following Paul's Example

17Imitate me and watch the ones that follow our example. 18Many live as enemies of the cross, as I used to say and tell you now, weeping. 19Their end is destruction, their God is their stomach, their honor is their shame, their minds are on earthly things. 20Our citizenship lies in heaven, from where we wait for our Savior to come. 21He'll transform our humble bodies to be like his glorious body. *He'll do that* by using the power he used to subject everything to himself. **4:1**So, fellow Christians loved and longed for, my joy and crown, stand firm in the Lord.

Phil 3:17-4:1

Keeping a Positive Outlook

2I urge Euodia and Syntyche to work in harmony in the Lord. 3Yes, and I ask you, loyal yoke fellow, help them. They struggled together with me in the gospel, with Clement and the rest of my fellow workers, whose names *are* in the Book of Life.

4Always be[pl] happy in the Lord; I'll say *it* again, be happy. 5Let everybody see your[pl] gentle *spirit*. The Lord *is* near. 6Don't worry, but in prayer and supplication make your requests to God accompanied by gratitude. 7God's peace, which goes beyond understanding, will keep watch over your hearts and minds in Christ Jesus.

8So think about what's true, honorable, just, pure, worth praising, morally excellent. 9Practice what you've learned and received, *what you've* heard and seen in me; and the God who brings peace will be with you.

10I was so glad when you showed your concern for me once again. For a long time, you didn't have a chance to demonstrate it. 11I'm not saying that because I've been in need. I've learned to be content in any circumstance, 12humble or otherwise. In any and all things, I've learned the secret of how to be full or hungry, to have a lot or to lack. 13I can do everything by the One who enables me. 14But you've done well to share in my difficulties. **Phil 4:2-14**

Appreciation for Philippians' Support

15You Philippians know that back when I'd presented the good news to you and left Macedonia, you were the only church that supported me financially. 16Even in Thessalonica time and again you sent *gifts* to help with my expenses. 17I'm not looking for the gift, but for the balance that's building up in your account. 18I have everything I need and more. Epaphroditus brought me what you sent, a sweet aroma, an acceptable sacrifice that pleases God. 19And in Christ Jesus, my God will take care of your needs out of his wealth in glory. 20To our God and Father *be* glory forevermore. Amen. **Phil 4:15-20**

Greetings

21Greet every saint in Christ Jesus. The Christians that are with me send their regards. 22All the saints say hello, notably the ones in Caesar's household.

23The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ *be* with your spirit. **Phil 4:21-23**

COLOSSIANS

Salutation

1:1 Paul, apostle of Christ[Messiah] Jesus by God's will, and brother Timothy **2**to the saints in Colossae and faithful disciples in Christ. Grace and peace from God our Father. **Col 1:1-2**

Gratitude for Their Faithfulness

3We thank God, the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, and always pray for you. **4**We've heard about your faith in Christ Jesus and your love for the saints **5**because of the hope that's stored up for you in heaven. That hope you heard about in the true gospel message **6**that's in you like it is in the whole world. It's been growing and producing fruit *everywhere* like it has among you since you heard it and came to know the truth about God's grace. **7**You learned *it* from Epaphras, our dear fellow servant. He's Christ's faithful minister for you, **8**and he's made your love in the Spirit clear to us. **Col 1:3-8**

Prayer for Their Progress

9That's why, from the time we heard it, we kept praying that you'd be fully aware of his will in the wisdom and understanding of spiritual things. **10**That way you'll live worthy of the Lord in *your* desire to please *him*; you'll grow in every good deed and bear fruit because you know him. **11**In proportion to his glorious power, he'll greatly enable you to endure with joy, **12**and you'll thank him for qualifying you to share in the inheritance of the saints *who live* in light. **13**He has delivered us from the power of darkness and transferred *us* into the kingdom of his dear Son. **14**We have redemption in his Son, the forgiveness of sins.

15He's the image of the invisible God,
the firstborn over all creation **16**because
he created everything in the sky and on earth,
visible and invisible—
thrones, dominions, powers, authorities.
Everything has been created by him and for him.
17He was before everything,
and everything finds its proper place in relation to him.
18He's the head of the body, the church.
He's the beginning, the firstborn from the dead
so he could have first place in everything.
19The Father saw fit to put everything under his responsibility
20and to reconcile everything to himself through him.
He made peace through the blood Christ[Messiah] shed on the cross—
peace with things on earth and in heaven. **Col 1:9-20**

21At one time you were enemies in mind and deed. **22**Now he has reconciled *you* in his physical body through death to bring you into his presence holy, blameless, without fault. **23**That's the case if you stay in the faith, established and firm, not moved from the hope you heard about in the good news that's been presented in all creation under the sky. I've become a minister of it. **Col 1:21-23**

Ministry for the Mystery

24I feel good about my hardships for you; I'm completing in my flesh what I can add to Christ's[Messiah's] sufferings for his body the church. **25**I became a minister of the church as a stewardship God gave me for you, to fully make known his message. **26**That message was not revealed to past generations, but he has revealed it now to his saints. **27**He wanted to show them the value of this glorious mystery among the Gentiles: Christ among you[pl], the hope for glory. **28**We present him, and instruct and warn everybody as wisely as we can so we can present each person complete in Christ. **29**That's why I strive in proportion to his power at work in me. **2:1**I want you to know how much I am striving for you, for the ones in Laodicea, and for whoever has never met me. **2**I urge you to bond together in love and to gain the valuable confidence that comes from knowing and understanding God's revealed mystery: Christ. **3**All the hidden treasures of knowledge and wisdom lie in him. **4**I say that so nobody will lead you astray with persuasive arguments. **5**Though I'm absent in body, I'm present in spirit, happy to see your orderly living and steadfast faith in Christ. **Col 1:24-2:5**

Urging Continued Faithfulness

6So, as you received Christ Jesus the Lord, keep on living in him. **7**Be rooted and built up in him, firm in faith, like you were taught. **8**Make sure nobody takes you captive with empty philosophy that deceives, after human traditions, according to the world's underlying assumptions rather than after Christ. **9**He fully constitutes deity bodily. **10**In him you have everything you need; he's the head of all rule and authority. **11**In him you were also 'circumcised' without hands. It's not a circumcision that removes flesh from the body; it's Christ's 'circumcision.' **12**You were buried with him in baptism, and raised with *him* by faith in God, who raised him from the dead. **13**You were 'dead' in sins and the uncircumcision of your flesh, but he 'made you alive' with him and pardoned your sins. **14**He canceled the certificate of debt made up of regulations that worked against us, took it out of the way, and nailed it to his cross. **15**He disarmed rulers and authorities and displayed them openly for what they were by overcoming them *in the cross and resurrection*.

Col 2:6-15

Concerns Irrelevant for Christians

16So don't let anybody judge you about food, drink, or participating in festivals, new moons, or Sabbaths. **17**They're just shadows of realities to come; but the body belongs to Christ. **18**And don't let anybody cheat you by promoting pious self-denial and angel worship—taking a stand on insights they claim to have, proud for no reason in their nature-dominated thinking—**19**instead of holding onto the Head. From him the whole body, held up and held together by ligaments and tendons, grows in a way that God brings about.

20If with Christ you've <u>died</u> to the world's underlying assumptions, why subject yourselves to rules and regulations as if you're <u>living</u> in the world—**21***things like*, *"Don't use, don't taste, don't touch"*? **22**Such human rules and regulations deal with things that wear out from use. **23**They look wise with their self-imposed piety, self-denial, and severity to the body; but they don't help manage the physical body. **Col 2:16-23**

Oriented to What's Above

3:1 So since you've resurrected with Christ, strive for things above, where Christ sits on God's right *hand*. **2**Fix your attention on things above, not things on earth. **3**You've died, and your life is hidden away with Christ in God. **4**When Christ, your life, appears, you'll appear with him in glory. **Col 3:1-4**

5So put to death *your* earthly members, *which foster* immorality, uncleanness, passion, sinful desires, and greed, which amounts to idolatry. **6**Because of things like that, God's displeasure comes [on disobedient people][ms]. **7**At one time you lived that way too. **8**Now set it aside: anger, rage, hateful feelings, slander, filthy talk. **9**Don't lie to one other, because you've taken off the old self and its behaviors, **10**and put on the new *self* that's made new unto knowing the One who created that new self in his image. **11**In that image there's no Greek or Jew, circumcision or uncircumcision; barbarian, Scythian; slave or free; Christ *includes us* all and *is* in *us* all. **Col 3:5-11**

Emphasizing the Major Virtues

12So, as God's chosen people, holy and loved, dress in compassion, kindness, humility, gentleness, patience. **13**Bear with one another; be gracious to each other. If you have a complaint against someone, be gracious to them like the Lord was to you. **14**Above all, *dress in* love, the perfect bond for holding you[pl] together. **15**Let the peace that comes from Christ prevail in your hearts—peace is what he called you to in one body—and be grateful. **16**Let Christ's word live in you richly. Teach and encourage each other with psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs. Sing to God with gratitude in your hearts. **17**Whatever you do or say, *do* it in the name of the Lord Jesus and be thankful to God the Father through him. **Col 3:12-17**

Family Virtues

18Wives defer to *your* husbands in a way that's appropriate in the Lord.

19Husbands, love *your* wives; don't be harsh toward them.

20Children, obey *your* parents because that pleases the Lord.

21Dads, don't make your children resentful, so they won't get discouraged.

22Servants, obey *your* physical masters. Don't try to create impressions to please them, but *obey* sincerely, fearing the Lord. **23**Whatever you're doing, do it voluntarily as to the Lord rather than to other people. **24**You know the Lord will reward you, so serve him. **25**The ones that do unjustly will get paid back impartially for what they've done.

4:1 Masters, be just and fair with your servants. Remember, you have a Master too—in heaven. **Col 3:18-4:1**

General Virtues

2Devote yourselves to prayer; stay alert in it with thanksgiving. **3**Pray for us, too, that God will open a door for us to speak the revealed mystery: Christ. I'm in prison because of that message. **4***Pray* that I'll make that message public like I should. **5**Live wisely toward outsiders and make good use of *every* chance *you get to influence them*. **6**Always speak graciously with salt so you'll know how to answer each person. **Col 4:2-6**

Extensive Greetings

7Tychicus, our dear brother, faithful minister, and fellow servant in the Lord, will tell you about my situation. **8**That's why I've sent him so he can comfort you. **9**I've also sent Onesimus, faithful and dear brother, who's one of you. They'll tell you about things here.

10Aristarchus, my fellow prisoner, greets you, along with Mark, Barnabas' cousin (Welcome him if he comes.), **11**and Jesus, called Justus—men from the Circumcision. *At present* they're the only co-workers I have. They've been an encouragement to me. **Col 4:7-11**

12Epaphras, *who's* one of you, greets you. He strives for you in prayers that you'll stand complete and confident in God's will. **13**I can vouch for his deep concern for you and the ones in Laodicea and Hierapolis. **14**Luke, the dearly loved doctor, and Demas send their regards. **15**Hello to the Christians in Laodicea, and to Nympha and the church that meets in her house. **16**When you've read *this* letter, have it read in the church in Laodicea; and you read my *letter* to Laodicea. **17**Tell Archippus to concentrate on fulfilling the ministry he's received in the Lord.

18I, Paul, sign this greeting with my own hand. Remember my bonds.

Grace *be* with you.

Col 4:12-18

FIRST THESSALONIANS

Salutation

1:[1]Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy to the church of the Thessalonians in God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ[Messiah]. Grace and peace. **1 Th 1:1**

Paul's Memories of the Thessalonians

[2]We are always grateful to God for you and include you in our prayers. We [3]remember your work of faith, *your* labor of love, and *your* enduring hope that lies in our Lord Jesus Christ in the presence of our God and Father. [4]Family of Christ loved by God, we know you're chosen [5]because our good news didn't come to you just in words, but in power, *in* the Holy Spirit, *in* complete confidence, like the kind of men you know we proved to be among you on your behalf. [6]You imitated us and the Lord, because you received the message with the joy of the Holy Spirit among lots of difficulties. [7]As a result, you became an example for the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. [8]The Lord's message rang out from you, not only in Macedonia and Achaia, but wherever your faith in God has gone. So we don't have to say anything. [9]People acknowledge how you received us, how you turned from idols to serve the true, living God; [10]how you wait for his Son from heaven—that God raised from the dead, Jesus who rescues us from the fury to come. **1 Th 1:2-10**

Paul's History with the Thessalonians

2:[1]Our coming to you proved to be productive. [2]As you know, after we'd suffered and been treated disgracefully, we gathered up the courage in our God to present his good news to you during our struggles. [3]We didn't pressure *you* with deception, impure motives, or treachery. [4]But, we spoke the way we did since God approved us and entrusted *us* with the good news. *We were*n't trying to please people, but God, who was approving our intentions. [5]God *is* witness: we never stooped to flattery or veiled greed, [6]or tried to get honor from you or anybody else. [7]Though as Christ's apostles, we could've expected you to support us, we were gentle among you like a nurse taking care of her kids. [8]Since you became so dear to us, we enjoyed sharing with you God's good news and our very selves. [9]You remember our labor and hardship, how we worked day and night so we wouldn't burden *you* while we presented his good news to you. [10]Along with God, you can confirm how devoutly, uprightly, blamelessly we carried ourselves among you—[11]like a father with his kids. [12]We urged you, encouraged you, and testified to you to live worthy of the One that was calling you to his kingdom and honor. **1 Th 2:1-12**

Their Openness to the Good News

[13]That's why we're constantly grateful to God. When you heard his message, you accepted it, not as a human message, but as it really is, God's message that's at work in you.

[14]You followed the example of the churches of God in Christ: you suffered the same things from your countrymen that they did from the Jews—[15]who killed the Lord Jesus and the prophets, drove us out, and haven't been pleasing to God. They've been hostile to everybody [16]and tried to keep us from speaking to Gentiles about salvation, always piling up their own sins. But fury will come on them in the end.

[17]We've been away from you for a little while—in person, not in heart. [18]We've really wanted to see you, but Satan prevented it time and again. [19]Who is our hope, our joy, the crown we'll be proud of when the Lord Jesus comes? Aren't <u>you</u> our joy and honor? **1 Th 2:13-19**

Yearning for the Thessalonians

3:[1]When we couldn't contain our concern about you anymore, we decided to stay behind by ourselves in Athens [2]and send Timothy, our brother and fellow worker for God in the good news about Christ. He could strengthen and encourage you in your faith [3]so the troubles you were facing wouldn't disturb any of you. You know we *Christians* are destined for opposition. [4]Even when we were there, we kept telling you we'd run into trouble; and that's what happened. [5]That's why I couldn't contain *my concern for you* anymore and sent to find out about your faith. I didn't want your tempter to somehow make our labor be for nothing. **1 Th 3:1-5**

Timothy Returns with Good News

[6]Now Timothy has come back and brought us good news about your faith and love, that you have fond memories of us and want to see us like we want to see you. [7]So your faithfulness is a relief to us during our own distress. [8]Now we live if <u>you</u> stand firm in the Lord. [9]How can we thank God for the joy you bring us? [10]Day and night we sincerely pray to see you and to supply what your faith may lack.

[11]May God our Father and Jesus our Lord direct us back to you. [12]May the Lord increase your love for one another and everybody else like we *abound in love* for you. [13]May he make your hearts blameless in holiness in front of him when our Lord Jesus comes with his saints. Amen. **1 Th 3:6-13**

Encouragement to Please God

4:[1]Finally, we urge you by the Lord Jesus to live the way you should—like you received from us—so you improve your living even more. [2]You know what commandments we gave you from the Lord Jesus. [3]This is the will of God who sanctifies you: *that* you abstain from sexual immorality, [4]*that* each of you know how to exercise self-control in holiness and honor ([5]not *living* in lust like Gentiles, who don't know God), [6]*that* you not sin and cheat on your fellow Christian in such a matter. The Lord avenges things—like we warned *you*. [7]He didn't call us to impurity, but

to holiness. [8]So whoever rejects *that warning* isn't rejecting us, but God, who puts his Holy Spirit in us.

[9]You don't need *me* to write *to you* about brotherly love. God himself has taught you to love one another. [10]Indeed you do that to the <u>believers</u> throughout Macedonia. But we urge you to step it up [11]and make it your ambition to live quietly, mind your own business, and work with your hands; [12]so you'll be living right toward <u>outsiders</u> and won't need anything. **1 Th 4:1-12**

Hope for the Dead

[13]We want you to know about *Christians* that have died, so you won't mourn like people without hope. [14]If we believe Jesus died and resurrected, we can also believe God will bring with Jesus the ones that have died in him.

[15]We tell you from the Lord that we who are still living when he comes back won't have any advantage over the ones that have died. [16]With the shout of *an* archangel and the trumpet of God, the Lord himself will come down from heaven, and the dead in Christ will resurrect first. [17]Then we who're still living will go up with them in the clouds to meet him in the air; so we'll always be with him. [18]Console one another with that. **1 Th 4:13-18**

The Manner of Christ's Coming

5:[1]You also don't need me to write *about* when and under what circumstances *he'll return*. [2]You know full well that the Lord will come like a thief at night. [3]When people are saying, *"Peace and safety,"* destruction will come on them like a woman's birth pains; they won't escape. [4]But <u>you</u> aren't in the dark, and that time won't overtake <u>you</u> like a thief. [5]You're children of light and day, not of darkness and night. [6]So don't sleep like other *people*; stay awake and be sober. [7]People sleep at night and get drunk at night, [8]but <u>you</u> must stay awake and sober. Put on the breastplate of faith and love, and the helmet of hope for salvation. [9]God didn't destine us to *his* fury, but to salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ. [10]He died for us; so whether we're asleep or awake, we'll live with him. [11]Comfort one another and keep building each other up like you're doing. **1 Th 5:1-11**

[12]We ask you to acknowledge the ones that labor among you, that have responsibility for you in the Lord and instruct you. [13]For their work, regard them highly with love. Be at peace with each other. [14]Warn the unruly, encourage the faint-hearted, help the weak, be patient with everyone. [15]See that nobody repays evil for evil; follow what's good for one another and for all.

[16]Rejoice always, [17]pray constantly, [18]give thanks in everything. That's God's will for you in Christ Jesus. [19]Don't quench the Spirit [20]or disregard prophecies. [21]Examine everything, hold onto what's good, [22]abstain from evil in every way, shape, and form. **1 Th 5:12-22**

Concluding Encouragement

23May the God that brings peace make you completely holy and keep your spirit, soul, and body complete and blameless for when our Lord Jesus Christ returns. **24**The One who's calling you *is* faithful and will do *what he's promised.*

25Pray for us.

26Greet all the fellow believers with a holy kiss.

27By the Lord, I charge you to read *this* letter to the whole church.

28The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ *be* with you[pl]. **1 Th 5:23-28**

SECOND THESSALONIANS

Salutation

1:[1]Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy to the church of the Thessalonians in God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ[Messiah]. [2]Grace and peace from God [our][ms] Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

2 Th 1:1-2

Gratitude for the Thessalonians

[3]We're always obliged to thank God for you because your faith is growing so much and your love for one another keeps increasing. [4]As a result, among the churches, we say how proud we are of you because of your faith despite the persecution and hardships you're dealing with. [5]*Those hardships* show that in God's just judgment you're worthy of his kingdom you're suffering for. [6]He will be just when he pays back trouble to the ones that are giving you trouble, [7]and in paying back relief to you that face trouble along with us. That vengeance will come when the Lord Jesus returns from heaven with his powerful angels [8]in flaming fire. He'll take revenge on people that don't know God or obey the good news about our Lord Jesus. [9]They'll undergo permanent destruction away from his presence and glorious power. [10]*That'll be* the day when he comes, and you saints can praise him and be amazed at him because you believed our testimony. [11]So we always pray for you, too, that our God will count you worthy of *his* calling and powerfully fulfill every good intention and faithful work. [12]That way you'll praise the Lord Jesus, and he'll praise you in proportion to the grace of our God and Lord Jesus Christ.

2 Th 1:3-12

Concerning Christ's Return

2:[1]Now, about our Lord's return and our gathering to him. [2]Don't let a spirit, a message, a letter claiming to be from us disturb you if it says it's time for the Lord to return. [3]He won't return till apostasy occurs and "the lawless one" appears. That "one destined for destruction" [4]will oppose *God* and exalt himself above everything that's called deity or is worshiped. He'll seat himself in God's Temple and claim to be deity. [5]You remember me telling you that, don't you, while I was there? [6]You know what's holding *him* back for now—till he's revealed in his time. [7]That secret lawlessness is already at work, but the one that's holding *him* back now *will continue to do so* till he's gone. [8]Then "the lawless one" will appear, the one the Lord will kill with his breath and destroy at his return. [9]The *lawless one's* coming will be like Satan's working: with power, signs, false wonders, [10]and every sinful deception, all aimed at people that perish, people that haven't welcomed a love for the truth so they'd be saved. [11]So God will send them a deluding influence to cause them to believe a lie. [12]*Then* the truth will judge disbelievers who delight in doing wrong.

2 Th 2:1-12

God's Choice of the Thessalonians

[13]We're always obliged to thank God for you, family of Christ the Lord loves, because God chose you to be the firstfruits of salvation by believing the truth and by the holiness the Spirit brings. [14]He called you to that *truth* by the good news we delivered, which is for obtaining the honor our Lord Jesus Christ has. [15]So, stand firm; hold onto the traditions we taught you by word and letter. [16]Now may our Lord Jesus Christ and God our Father—who loved us and gave *us* eternal comfort and good hope in grace—[17]comfort you and strengthen *you* in every good thing you do and say. **2 Th 2:13-17**

Request for Prayer

3:[1]Finally, pray for us that the Lord's message can make progress and be honored like *it has* with you. [2]Pray for God to deliver us from harmful, evil people, because not everybody believes. [3]But, the Lord is faithful; he'll strengthen you and keep *you* from the evil one. [4]We're confident in the Lord that you're doing and will do what we tell you. [5]May the Lord direct you to God's love and the endurance that Christ gives you. **2 Th 3:1-5**

Warnings About Idleness

[6]Now, in the name of [our][ms] Lord Jesus Christ, stay away from anyone that lives irresponsibly, rather than by the traditions you received from us. [7]You know you need to follow our example. We weren't idle among you [8]and didn't eat other people's food without paying for it. We worked day and night so we wouldn't burden any of you. [9]It's not that we didn't have the right *to receive support*, but we set ourselves up as an example for you to imitate. [10]Besides, when we were with you, we told you that if somebody won't work, they shouldn't eat. [11]We hear that some are living irresponsibly, not doing anything but being busybodies. [12]By the Lord Jesus Christ we direct and urge people like that to work quietly and eat their own food. [13]Don't get discouraged with doing good. [14]If any don't obey what we've said in *this* letter, don't associate with them so they'll be ashamed. [15]Don't consider *them* enemies; warn *them* like members of Christ's family. **2 Th 3:6-15**

Farewell

[16]Now may the Lord that brings peace give you peace in every situation. The Lord *be* with you.

[17]The salutation with my own hand—an identifying mark in every letter *I write*. This is what my handwriting looks like.

[18]The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ *be* with you. **2 Th 3:16-18**

FIRST TIMOTHY

Salutation

1:1 Paul, apostle of Christ[Messiah] Jesus by the authority of God our Savior and Christ Jesus our hope, **2**to Timothy *my* loyal son in the faith. Grace, mercy, *and* peace from God *the* Father and Christ Jesus our Lord. **1 Tim 1:1-2**

Warning Against False Teachers

3When I left for Macedonia, I urged you to stay in Ephesus to instruct certain people not to teach false doctrine **4**or pay attention to myths and endless genealogies. Those things lead to speculation rather than God's plan, which operates by faith. **5**The goal of instruction is love from a pure heart, a clear conscience, and sincere faith. **6**Some have turned away from these to empty talk and got lost. **7**They want to teach the Law, but they don't know what they're talking about so confidently. **1 Tim 1:3-7**

Using the Law Lawfully

8We know the Law is good if you use it 'lawfully.' **9**It's not there *so much* for good people, as for lawless, disorderly, godless, sinful, unholy, profane *people*. It's for murderers, for people that kill *their* fathers and mothers, **10**for immoral people, male homosexuals, kidnappers, liars, perjurers, and anything else that contradicts sound doctrine **11**as set forth in the glorious good news from our blessed God—the good news he entrusted me with. **1 Tim 1:8-11**

Paul's Gratitude for Salvation

12I'm grateful to Christ Jesus who has strengthened me and considered me worth trusting though I'd been a blasphemer, persecutor, insolent person. **13**I received mercy because I did it ignorantly in disbelief. **14**The Lord's grace overflowed with the faith and love that's in Christ Jesus. **15**There's a reliable statement that deserves full acceptance: *"Christ Jesus came to the world to save sinners and I'm the worst."* **16**I received mercy so Christ Jesus could use me to demonstrate *his* extreme patience. The "worst sinner" provided an example to people that would later trust in *Christ* for eternal life. **17**Now to the eternal King and only God, immortal, invisible *be* honor and glory forevermore! Amen. **1 Tim 1:12-17**

18I'm entrusting that instruction to you, Timothy *my* son. I'm doing it because of the prophecies about you early on so that on the basis of them you can fight the good fight **19**with faith and a clear conscience. Some have refused to listen to *their conscience* and have shipwrecked as far as faith is concerned. **20**Hymeneas and Alexander are *two examples*; I've delivered them to Satan to teach them not to blaspheme. **1 Tim 1:18-20**

Attitude Toward Earthly Rulers

2:[1]So I encourage prayers and thanksgiving for everybody—[2]kings and *other* people in authority—that we can lead a peaceful, quiet, godly life. [3]That's good and acceptable to God our Savior. [4]He wants everyone to learn the truth and be saved. [5]*There's* one God and one Mediator between him and us, *the* man Christ Jesus, [6]who gave himself as a ransom for many, *as a* testimony given at the right time. [7]That's why he appointed me to be a herald and apostle, to teach Gentiles about faith and truth. That's the truth. **1 Tim 2:1-7**

Men's and Women's Decorum

[8]So I want believers everywhere to pray, holding up holy hands without anger or argument. [9]*I want* women to dress modestly and decently, not with elaborate hairstyles, gold, pearls, expensive clothes. [10]*They should 'dress'* in good deeds, which is appropriate for women that profess godliness. [11]They should learn in quietness and deference. [12]I don't let a woman teach or exercise authority over a man; she should remain quiet. [13]For Adam was formed first, then Eve; [14]and Adam wasn't deceived; the woman was deceived and fell into transgression. [15]But she'll be saved through *her* child-rearing *role*, if *her children* continue in faith, love, sanctification, and decency. **1 Tim 2:8-15**

Caracteristics of Elders

3:[1]It's a reliable statement: *"If anyone aspires to being an overseer, he's aspiring to do a good thing."* [2]He needs to be above criticism, faithful to his wife, moderate, sensible, respectable, hospitable, able to teach. [3]*He must* not *be* pushy or addicted to wine. *He should be* gentle, not combative or greedy for money. [4]*An overseer needs to* manage his family well; his children *need to be* obedient and well-behaved. ([5]If someone doesn't know how to manage his own family, how can he take care of God's church?) [6]*He should*n't *be* a new convert; he can get proud and fall into the devil's condemnation. [7]He needs *to have* a good reputation among people that aren't Christians so he won't fall into disgrace and the devil's trap. **1 Tim 3:1-7**

Characteristics of Deacons

[8]Deacons, too, need to have good character, not be two-faced, addicted to a lot of wine, or greedy for dishonest gain, [9]*men who* maintain the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience. [10]They should be examined first, then serve as deacons if they're blameless. [11]*Their* wives need to have good character too, not be inclined to malicious gossip, *but* temperate, faithful in every respect. [12]Deacons need to be faithful to their wives, managing *their* children and family well. [13]Deacons that serve well gain good standing and added boldness in the faith that's in Christ Jesus. **1 Tim 3:8-13**

[14]I'm writing to you in hopes of coming soon. [15]But if I'm delayed, *this way* you'll know how to conduct yourself in God's house, the church of the living God, the foundation and pillar of the truth. [16]Everybody agrees that the mystery of godliness is great:

"He was revealed in flesh,
vindicated in spirit,
seen by angels,
presented among nations,
believed on in the world, and
taken up in glory." **1 Tim 3:14-16**

Future Heresies

4:[1]The Spirit says that later on people will abandon the faith. They'll pay attention to deceiving spirits and demons' doctrines, and indulge [2]in the hypocrisy of liars that have a seared conscience. [3]*They'll* forbid marriage and require abstinence from food that God created for faithful people to receive with gratitude. [4]Everything he created is good, and nothing should be rejected if people that know the truth receive it gratefully. [5]God's word and *our* prayers sanctify everything he created. **1 Tim 4:1-5**

[6]If you point this out to the disciples, you'll be serving Christ Jesus well, and you'll be fed by the message about faith and the good teaching you've been following. [7]Stay away from profane, silly myths. Exercise yourself for godliness. [8]Bodily exercise profits a little, but godliness profits a lot because it promises life now and later. [9]The saying is reliable and deserves full acceptance: [10]*"We labor and struggle because we've placed our hope in a living God, everybody's Savior, especially believers.*" [11]Teach and command that. **1 Tim 4:6-11**

Timothy's Interim Ministry

[12]Don't let anybody disregard you because you're young. Set an example for the faithful in what you say and do—in love, faith, purity. [13]Till I get there, give attention to the *public* reading *of scripture*, to encouragement, to teaching. [14]Don't neglect your spiritual gift that you received by prophecy and the laying on of hands by the eldership. [15]Cultivate it; immerse yourself in it so everybody will see your progress. [16]Pay close attention to how you live and to your teaching work. Stay true to the truth so you'll save yourself and your listeners. **1 Tim 4:12-16**

Relating to Church People

5:[1]Don't reprimand an elder; urge *him* like a father. Encourage younger men like brothers; [2]older women like mothers, and younger women like sisters, in purity. **1 Tim 5:1-2**

[3]Honor widows that don't have anybody to depend on. [4]If a widow has children or grandchildren, they should first learn to practice godliness toward their own family and repay parents; that's acceptable with God.

[5]A widow that's by herself has put her hope in God and continues in prayers and thanksgiving day and night. [6]But one that lives in self-interest is dead while she's alive. [7]Tell *widows* to be above criticism.

[8]If people don't take care of their own, especially *their* family, they've denied the faith; they're worse than disbelievers. **1 Tim 5:3-8**

Guidelines for Welfare Recipients

[9]Don't enroll a widow younger than 60, who was faithful to her husband, [10]with a reputation for doing good, who have raised children, shown hospitality, washed the saints' feet, helped people in distress, followed every good deed. [11]Don't enroll younger widows. While they're liable to physical interests, they'll want to remarry, [12]incurring criticism for setting aside their previous pledge *to Christ*. [13]At the same time, they can get in the habit of not doing anything, going around the neighborhood talking about things they shouldn't. [14]So I prefer younger *widows* to remarry, have children, manage the family—so they don't give critics a chance to find fault. [15]Some have already wandered off after Satan.

[16]If a believer[fem] has widows, she should take care of them so the church won't be burdened, and it can help widows that don't have anybody *to take care of them*. **1 Tim 5:9-16**

Commandments About Leaders

[17]Consider elders that do their work well to be worthy of double honor, especially the ones that teach. [18]The scripture says, ***"Don't put[sg] a muzzle on an ox while it's threshing"*** **[Deut 25:4]**, and, *"A worker's worth his wages"* **[Mt 10:10; Lk 10:7]**. [1]

[19]Don't accept an accusation against an elder except from two or three witnesses.

[20]Publicly reprimand people that keep sinning, so the rest will take heed as well.

[21]In front of God, Christ Jesus, and the elect angels, I solemnly charge you to keep these directives without showing favoritism to anyone.

[22]Be careful about laying hands on somebody too soon. Don't take part in other people's sins so you'll keep yourself untainted.

[23]Don't *just* drink water; use a little wine for your frequent bouts with an upset stomach.

[24]Some people's sins are obvious as they lead them into condemnation. *Other people's sins* become obvious *later*. [25]It works the same way with good things. The ones that aren't *obvious* will become obvious someday. **1 Tim 5:17-25**

Servant-Master Relationship

6:[1]Servants should fully respect their masters so God and *his* doctrine aren't slandered. [2]Servants with believing masters must not disregard them because they're equals; they need to serve them even more because the ones that are benefiting from their good service are faithful and loved. **1 Tim 6:1-2a**

Consequences of False Teaching

Teach[sg] and encourage *everyone to do* these things. [3]If anybody teaches something that doesn't agree with sound words from our Lord Jesus Christ and with godly teaching, [4]he's conceited and lacks understanding. He has an unhealthy desire to debate and arguments about words. Things like that produce jealousy, division, slander, suspicion, [5]constant arguing by people depraved in mind and deprived of truth. They think godliness is a way to gain wealth, [6]but godliness <u>with contentment</u> is a great gain. [7]We didn't bring anything into the world, and we can't take anything out. [8]Let's be content with food and clothes. [9]People that want to get rich encounter temptation, which traps *them* in foolish, harmful desires and drags them down to ruin. [10]The love for money is the root of all *kinds of* evil. Some that strain after wealth have wandered away from the faith and pierced themselves with many sorrows. **1 Tim 6:3-10**

Keeping Morals and Priorities Straight

[11]But, man of God, run away from wealth; pursue goodness, faith, love, perseverance, gentleness. [12]Fight the good fight of faith; take hold of the eternal life God called you to, the good acknowledgement you made in front of many witnesses. [13]I charge [you][ms] in front of God, who gives life to everything, and Christ Jesus, who acknowledged who he was in front of Pontius Pilate: [14]be spotless and without blame; keep the commandment until the Lord Jesus Christ comes. [15]At the right time he'll be revealed by

the blessed and only Master,
the King of kings and Lord of lords,
[16]who alone has immortality,
who lives in light so bright you can't approach,
that no one has seen or can see:
to him *be* honor and eternal dominion! Amen. **1 Tim 6:11-16**

Words to the Wealthy

[17]Instruct people that are wealthy now not to be proud or to have *their* hope based on the uncertainty of wealth. *Tell them to put their hope* in God, who supplies us richly with everything we enjoy. [18]*Instruct them* to be rich in good deeds, *to be* generous, willing to share, [19]treasuring up for themselves a firm foundation for the future, so they can experience what's truly life indeed. **1 Tim 6:17-19**

Maintaining the True Knowledge

20Timothy, guard what's been entrusted to you. Avoid profane, empty talk, and the opposing notions that come from knowledge falsely so-called. **21**Some have professed that knowledge and strayed away from the truth.

Grace *be* with you. **1 Tim 6:20-21**

SECOND TIMOTHY

Salutation

1:[1]Paul, apostle of Christ[Messiah] Jesus by God's will in regard to the life he promised in Christ Jesus, [2]to Timothy, my dear son. Grace, mercy, *and* peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord. **2 Tim 1:1-2**

Stirring up Timothy's Gift

[3]As I remember you in my prayers day and night, I thank my ancestors' God that I serve with a good conscience. [4]I really want to see you again because I've been remembering your tears. [5]I remember your sincere faith, *a faith* your grandmother Lois and your mother Eunice had first. I'm sure it's been in you, too, ever since. [6]That's why I'm reminding you to stir up the spiritual gift you have from the laying on of my hands. [7]God hasn't given us a timid mentality, but power, love, and self-discipline. [8]So don't be ashamed of the Lord's mystery or of me his prisoner; suffer with me for the good news as God gives you strength. [9]He has saved us and called us with a holy calling. What we can do ourselves doesn't define *that calling*. His purpose and grace define it, which he gave us in Christ Jesus before time began. [10]The coming of our Savior Christ Jesus now has revealed that purpose and grace. He destroyed death and brought life and immortality to light through the good news. [11]He's appointed me as a preacher, apostle, and teacher *of that good news*. [12]That's why I'm suffering what *I am*. But I'm not ashamed; I know who I've trusted, and I'm confident that he can keep what I entrusted to him till that day. [13]Hold onto the sound form of the message you've heard from me about the faith and love that are in Christ Jesus. [14]By the Holy Spirit who lives in us, keep what he's entrusted *to you.* **2 Tim 1:3-14**

Paul Abandoned in Rome

[15]Be aware that everybody in Asia has deserted me, including Phygelus and Hermogenes. [16]May the Lord show mercy to the family of Onesiphorus. He has cheered me up so many times and hasn't been ashamed of my chains. [17]When he got to Rome, he went all out to find me. [18]May the Lord show him mercy on *judgment* day. <u>You</u> know very well how much he ministered in Ephesus. **2 Tim 1:15-18**

Provisions for Going Forward

2:[1]So, my son, <u>you</u> be strong in the grace that Christ Jesus *gives*. [2]What you've heard from me among many witnesses entrust to faithful men that can teach others. [3]Endure hardship with *me* like a good soldier of Christ Jesus. [4]A soldier doesn't get mixed up in the affairs of daily life while he's a soldier. That way he can please his recruiter. [5]An athlete doesn't win the garland unless he competes by the rules. [6]A laboring farmer should be first to share in his crops. [7]Think about what I'm saying; the Lord will help you understand. **2 Tim 2:1-7**

[8]Remember Jesus Christ, risen from the dead, descendant of David according to the gospel I preach, [9]that I endure hardship for—even to the point of being in chains like a criminal. But God's word is not in chains. [10]So I endure everything for the ones he has chosen so they can obtain the salvation that Christ Jesus gives with endless glory. [11]Here's a reliable saying:

"If we've suffered with him, we'll live with him.
[12]*If we endure, we'll reign with him.*
If we deny him, he'll deny us.
[13]*If we're not faithful, he'll stay faithful*
because he can't deny himself." **2 Tim 2:8-13**

Staying on Course

[14]Remind *the saints* of that, and solemnly charge *them* in front of God not to argue about words. That doesn't accomplish anything, and it ruins people that listen to it. [15]Be diligent about presenting yourself to God as a worker that's not ashamed, who correctly interprets the truth that's in the message. [16]Avoid worldly, foolish talk; it'll lead to more ungodliness [17]and eat away like gangrene. Hymenaeus and Philetus are like that; [18]they've wandered off from the truth and say the resurrection has already happened. They're overturning the faith of some. [19]But, God's foundation stands firm with this seal: **"The *LORD* knows who's his"** **[Num 16:5]**; and *"Everybody that commits themselves to the LORD must quit sinning"* **[Num 16:26]**. [20]A big house has gold and silver containers, but wood and clay ones too. [21]If people keep themselves clean *from foolish worldly ideas*, they'll serve as containers for the Householder's honorable uses—set aside for good uses. [22]Run away from youthful desires and run after goodness, faith, love, and peace with those who call on the Lord with a pure heart. [23]Stay away from foolish, ignorant speculation, because you know it produces conflict. [24]The Lord's servant must not quarrel; he must be kind toward everyone, able to teach, not reacting when he's wronged. [25]*He needs to* correct gently those who oppose *the truth*, because God may allow them to change to *knowing* the truth [26]and to come to their senses out of the devil's trap, who's held them captive under his will.

2 Tim 2:14-26

Future Apostasy

3:[1]Be aware that difficult times will come later on. [2]People will be selfish, money-loving, proud and arrogant, slanderous, disobedient to parents, ungrateful, unholy, [3]without natural affection, heartless, slanderous gossips, without self-control, vicious, not loving what's good, [4]treacherous, reckless, conceited, loving pleasure more than God. [5]They'll have the trappings of religion but deny its power. Avoid people like that. [6]They're the kind that sneak into families and seduce morally weak women that are weighed down with sins and lured on by various desires, [7]*who*[mas] *are* always learning but never able to find the truth. [8]Those who oppose the truth are like Jannes and Jambres, who opposed Moses. They're corrupt in mind; they're rejected as far as the

faith is concerned. [9]They won't get anywhere because their foolishness will be obvious to everybody just like the foolishness of those *men* was. **2 Tim 3:1-9**

Expecting Persecution

[10]But <u>you</u> have followed my teaching, manner of living, faith, endurance, love, perseverance, [11]persecutions, and sufferings like what happened to me in Antioch, Iconium, and Lystra. I bore up under such persecutions, and the Lord delivered me from them. [12]Everybody that wants to live godly in Christ Jesus will face persecution. [13]Evil people and imposters will get worse and worse, deceiving and being deceived. [14]But <u>you</u> stick with what you've learned and become confident about it; you know where you learned it. [15]From the time you were a baby, you knew the holy scriptures, which can make you wise about salvation by trust in Christ Jesus. [16]All scripture *is* breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, refuting error, correcting faults, and training in goodness. [17]That's how God's servant can be qualified and equipped for every good thing he needs to do. **2 Tim 3:10-17**

Maintaining Timothy's Ministry

4:[1]I solemnly charge *you* in front of God and Christ Jesus—who will judge the living and the dead—and by his appearing and his kingdom: [2]proclaim the message. Be ready in normal or unusual times. Refute, reprimand, encourage patiently with teaching. [3]The time will come when *people* won't pay attention to sound teaching. They'll draw teachers to themselves that reinforce their own desires and say what they want to hear. [4]They'll wander off from the true message and turn to myths. [5]<u>You</u> be self-controlled, be willing to suffer hardship, do the work of an evangelist, fulfill your ministry. **2 Tim 4:1-5**

Paul's Near Prospect of Death

[6]I'm already being poured out like a drink offering. The time for me to depart. [7]I've fought a good fight, I've finished the course, I've kept the faith. [8]From now on, a crown for righteousness waits for me. The Lord, the just Judge, will give it to me that day, and not just to me, but to everybody that has loved his coming. **2 Tim 4:6-8**

Urgent Call for Timothy's Coming

[9]Do your best to get here soon. [10]Demas has deserted me and gone to Thessalonica—he loved the present age. Crescens *went* to Galatia; Titus to Dalmatia. [11]Luke's the only one here. Pick up Mark and bring him with you; I can use him for ministry. [12]I sent Tychicus to Ephesus. [13]When you come, bring the coat I left in Troas with Carpus, and get the scrolls, especially the parchments. [14]Alexander, the precious-metal worker, did me a lot of harm. The Lord will repay him accordingly. [15]<u>You</u> be careful around him, too, because he really opposed our message. **2 Tim 4:9-15**

[16]At my first hearing, nobody came to my defense. May *the Lord* not hold it against them. [17]But, the Lord stood by me and strengthened me so I could fully deliver the proclamation for the Gentiles to hear. *He* delivered me out of the lion's mouth. [18]He'll deliver me from every evil deed and save me into his heavenly kingdom. To him *be* glory forevermore. Amen.

2 Tim 4:16-18

Final Greetings

[19]Greet Prisca and Aquila, and the family of Onesiphorus. [20]Erastus stayed in Corinth, and I left Trophimus in Miletus sick. [21]Do your best to get here before winter. Eubulus, Pudens, Linus, Claudia, and all the believers send their greetings. [22]The Lord *be* with your spirit.

Grace *be* with you. **2 Tim 4:19-22**

TITUS

Salutation

1:1 Paul, servant of God and apostle of Jesus Christ[Messiah] for the faith God's chosen *people* have, and for the knowledge of the truth that leads to godliness and **2**hope for eternal life. God our Savior, who doesn't lie, promised that life before times eternal. **3**Then at an appropriate time, he made the message available by the preaching he entrusted to me according to the commandment of our Savior God. **4**To Titus, *my* loyal son in the faith we share. Grace and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Savior. **Tit 1:1-4**

Characteristics of Elders

5I left you in Crete to arrange what still needed to be done and to appoint elders in every city like I instructed you. **6**A man needs to be above criticism, faithful to his wife, whose children aren't accused of reckless living or disobedience—**7**because a bishop needs to be above criticism as God's steward. *He must* not *be* stubborn, quick-tempered, addicted to wine, violent, or greedy for dishonest gain. **8***He needs to be* hospitable, loving what's good, sensible, just, self-controlled. **9***He needs to* hold on tight to the trustworthy message he was taught. That way he can encourage *people* in sound doctrine and show the error of the ones that speak falsely. **Tit 1:5-9**

Silencing Disorderly People

10There are lots of disorderly people, empty talkers, and deceivers, especially from the Circumcision, **11**that need to be silenced. They overthrow whole families by teaching things people don't need to do, and they do it dishonestly to make money. **12**One of their own prophets has said, *"Cretans are always liars, bad animals, lazy gluttons."* **13**That's true; so reprimand them sharply to make them sound in the faith, **14**not caught up in Jewish myths and human rules that distract people from the truth. **15**Everything's pure to people that are pure; nothing's pure to people that are not pure. They've defiled their minds and consciences. **16**They claim to know God, but they deny *it* by how they act. They're detestable, disobedient, and worthless for doing anything good. **Tit 1:10-16**

Older Christian's Decorum

2:1 But you, encourage the kind of living that is appropriate to sound doctrine. **2**Older men should be serious-minded, respectable, sensible; sound in faith, love, and endurance. **3**The same thing applies to older women. They should be reverent in behavior, not prone to gossip or addicted to wine, *but* teaching what's good. **4**Then they can teach young women to love their husbands and children. **5**They *should be* sensible, pure, devoted to their families, kind, *and* deferring to their husbands so people won't slander God's message. **Tit 2:1-5**

Young Men's Decorum

[6]In the same way, *encourage* younger men to be sensible. [7]Present yourself as an example of doing good. *Demonstrate* pure doctrine, respectable conduct, [8]and sound speech that people can't criticize. Then critics will be ashamed because they can't find anything bad to say about you. **Tit 2:6-8**

Salvation Offered to Everybody

[9]*Urge* servants to submit to their masters, to be pleasing, not argumentive, [10]not stealing, but showing good faith so they can adorn the doctrine of God our Savior. **Tit 2:9-10**

[11]God's grace has appeared and offered salvation to everyone. [12]His grace instructs us to set aside ungodliness and worldly pleasures and to live wisely, justly, and godly in the present age. [13]All the while, we look forward to the blessed hope, the glorious appearing of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ. [14]He gave himself to redeem us from lawlessness and to purify a special people for himself, *a people* with zeal zeal for doing good. [15]Speak these things, urge, and reprimand with authority. Don't let anybody disregard you. **Tit 2:11-15**

Respecting Earthly Rulers

3:[1]Remind *people* to submit to rulers and authorities, to be obedient and ready to do everything that's good. [2]*Remind them* not to insult or get pushy, *but* to be considerate and gentle toward everybody. [3]At one time we were foolish too, disobedient, deceived, addicted to various lusts and pleasures. We spent our lives in evil and envy, hated and hating one another. [4]But,

> *"the kindness of God our Savior appeared along with love for* other *people.* [5]*We didn't save ourselves by doing good. In mercy* <u>*he*</u> *saved us by the washing that regenerates and by the renewal the Holy Spirit* gives. [6]God *poured out his Spirit on us richly through Jesus Christ our Savior.* [7]*In grace he justified us so we could inherit the hope for eternal life."* **Tit 3:1-7**

[8]That's a reliable statement. I want you to emphasize doing these things so the ones that have believed God will concentrate on doing good. *Such things* are good and profitable. [9]But, avoid foolish controversies, genealogies, rivalries, legal disputes; they're pointless and unprofitable. [10]After a first and second warning, quit having anything to do with people who cause division. [11]They're perverted sinners that have condemned themselves. **Tit 3:8-11**

Plans for Further Ministry

[12]When Artemas or Tychycus get to you—that I'm sending—do your best to meet me at Nicopolis. I've decided to spend the winter there. [13]Diligently help Zenas the lawyer and Apollos get on their way with what they need. [14]Have our *people* learn to practice doing good to meet pressing needs so they'll be productive.

15The ones that are with me greet you. Greet those who love us in the faith.
Grace *be* with you all. **Tit 3:12-15**

PHILEMON

Salutation

1Paul, prisoner of Christ[Messiah] Jesus, and brother Timothy, to our dear fellow worker Philemon, **2**to sister Apphia, to fellow soldier Archippus, and to your[sg] house church. **3**Grace and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ. **Phil 1-3**

Paul's Prayer for Philemon

4I always thank God *for you*, mentioning you[sg] in my prayers, **5**because I hear about your love and faith toward the Lord Jesus and all the saints. **6**I pray that fellowshiping with your[sg] faith will lead to our experiencing everything good for Christ's sake. **7**Brother, I'm so happy and encouraged by your love, because you refresh the hearts of the saints. **Phil 4-7**

Requesting Freedom for Onesimus

8In light of that, I feel bold enough to tell *you* something that's appropriate. **9**But because I love you, I'd rather ask you to do it—being Paul the aged prisoner of Christ, and all.

10I'm appealing to you about my child Onesimus that I begot while I was in bonds. **11**At one time he was useless to you, but now he's useful to you <u>and</u> to me. **12**As my own heart, I've sent him back to you in person. **13**I wanted to keep him here to help me on your behalf while I'm in prison because of the good news. **14**But I didn't want to do anything without your consent. I wanted your goodness to be because you wanted to, not because you had to. **15-16**Maybe he left you for a while so you could have him forever physically and in the Lord, not as a servant, but as a dear brother—to me too. **Phil 8-16**

Additional Urgings About Onesimus

17So if you consider me a partner, accept him as me. **18**If he has wronged you or owes you anything, charge it to me. **19**I, Paul, write it with my own hand: I'll repay it. (I won't tell you that you also owe me your very self.) **20**Yes, brother, I want to have joy in the Lord; refresh my heart in Christ. **21**I'm writing, confident that you'll do more than I'm saying. **22**While you're at it, prepare[sg] a place for me to stay, because I'm hoping by your[pl] prayers to be released to you[pl]. **Phil 17-22**

Greetings

23Epaphras, my fellow prisoner in Christ Jesus, sends you[sg] greetings. **24**Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, Luke—my fellow workers—*greet you as well*.

25The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ *be* with your[pl] spirit. **Phil 23-25**

HEBREWS

Speaking Through the Son

1:1Long ago God spoke to our ancestors by prophets in many parts and different ways. 2In these last days he has spoken to us in a Son. He made the universe through him and made him heir of everything. 3He's the radiance of God's glory, the exact image of his nature, and upholds everything by his powerful word. When he'd made purification for sins, he sat down on the right side of the Majesty on high, 4and became as much better than angels as he inherited a better name than they have. **Heb 1:1-4**

The Son's Superiority over Angels

5To what angel did God ever say,

"You're my Son; I've begotten you today" **[Ps 2:7]**

or,

"I'll be a Father to him; he'll be a son to me" **[2 Sam 7:14; 1 Ch 17:13]**?

6When he brings the Firstborn into the world, he says,

"All God's angels are to worship him" **[Deut 32:43 LXX].**

7He says in regard to angels,

"Who makes his angels spirits
and his ministers flames of fire" **[Ps 104:4].** **Heb 1:5-7**

8But *he says* to the Son,

"Your throne, God, is forevermore;
the scepter of your kingdom is a righteous **scepter.**
9***You've loved goodness and hated lawlessness,***
so God has anointed you
with greater gladness than your companions" **[Ps 45:6-7];**

10and,

"In the beginning, LORD, you founded the earth
and made the skies.
11***They'll perish, but you'll remain;***
they'll get old like a robe;
12***you'll fold them up like a cloak***
and change them *like a robe.*
But you're the same;
your years won't end" **[Ps 102:25-27].**

13What angel did he ever tell,

"Sit on my right hand
till I make your enemies your footstool" **[Ps 110:1]**?

14Aren't they ministering spirits that he sends to help the heirs of salvation? **Heb 1:8-14**

Heeding the New Revelation

2:[1]So we need to pay close attention to what we've heard so we never drift away from it. [2]What God said through angels stood firm, and every sin received the punishment it deserved. [3]So how will we get off if we neglect such a great salvation? After the Lord spoke it, the ones that heard it confirmed it to us. [4]God testified alongside them with signs, wonders, and various miracles and gifts that the Holy Spirit dispensed as he saw fit. **Heb 2:1-4**

Mankind as Caretaker of Creation

[5]It wasn't to angels that God subjected the future world we're talking about. [6]In a certain place one has testified,

"What are people that you remember them or visit them?
[7]***You made them lower than angels for a little while,***
crowned them with glory and honor,
[8]***and put everything under their authority"*** **[Ps 8:5-7 LXX].**

"Putting everything under their authority" means God didn't leave anything that wasn't under them, but we don't see that yet. [9]We do see Jesus, however, *"made lower than angels for a little while,"* so by God's grace he could taste death for every*one*. Now we see him "crowned with glory and honor" because he suffered death. **Heb 2:5-9**

The Son's Incarnation

[10]Everything is through him and for him. It was appropriate, then, in bringing many children to glory, that he make perfect the Author of their salvation with suffering. [11]Both the sanctifier and the sanctified have the same *nature*. That means he's not ashamed to call them *"siblings."*

[12]***"I'll present you to my siblings***
and sing your praises in the congregation" **[Ps 22:22].**

[13]Again,

"I'll trust him" **[Is 8:17 LXX],**
". . . I and the children God gave me" **[Is 8:18].** **Heb 2:10-13**

[14]Since *"the children"* exist in flesh and blood, he took on flesh and blood so that by dying he could take the power of death away from the one that has it—the devil. [15]*That way* he could free people that the fear of death had enslaved as long as they were alive. [16]It's clear he's not *here* to help angels, but *to help* Abraham's descendants. [17]So he needed to be like people in every respect so he could become a merciful, faithful high priest in things that have to do with God and could atone for people's sins. [18]Since he faced temptation in what he suffered, he can help those who face temptation. **Heb 2:14-18**

The Son's Superiority over Moses

3:[1]So, holy *"children"* that take part in the heavenly calling, pay close attention to Jesus, the Author and Perfecter of what we profess. [2]He was faithful to the One that appointed him just like Moses *was* in his house. [3]*But Jesus* has been considered worthy of more honor than Moses—as much more as a house builder has *more honor* than the house. [4]Somebody builds every house; God has built everything. [5]Moses was faithful as a servant in his house to testify about things that would be spoken later; [6]Christ[Messiah] *was faithful* as a Son over his house. We are that house if we stay confident and take pride in our hope. **Heb 3:1-6**

Being Sensitive to Righteousness

[7]So, like the Holy Spirit says,

"Today, if you hear him speaking to you***,***
[8]***don't harden your hearts***
like they did when they rebelled
and tested me in the desert,
[9]***where your ancestors tested me at Meribah,***
and saw what I did [10]***for 40 years.***
That generation wasn't pleasing to me,
and I said,
'They always stray in their hearts;
they don't know my ways.'
[11]***As I swore in my anger,***
'They're not going to go into my rest!'" **[Ps 95:7-11]** **Heb 3:7-11**

[12]Be careful so there won't be an evil, disbelieving "heart" in any of you, and you fall away from the living God. [13]Encourage one another every day as long as it's *"Today"* so sin's deception doesn't *"harden"* you. [14]You've become partakers of Christ if you hold firm to the end the assurance you had at the first—[15]while he says,

"Today, if you hear him speaking *to you,*
don't harden your hearts
like they did when they rebelled **against me"** **[Ps 95:7-8]**.

[16]Who *"rebelled"* against him when they *"heard"*? Wasn't it everybody that Moses brought out of Egypt? [17]Who was he *"angry"* with for "40 years"? Wasn't it the ones who sinned and their corpses fell in the *"desert"*? [18]Who'd he *"swear"* wouldn't *"go into his rest"* but the ones that disbelieved? [19]We can see that they couldn't go in because they disbelieved. **Heb 3:12-19**

The Promise of Rest

4:[1]Let's be alert so none of us even looks like we're coming short of a promise he left behind about *"going into his rest."* [2]We've had good news presented to us just like they did. But what they heard didn't do them any good because they didn't combine hearing with believing. [3]We who believe do go into rest like he said,

"As I swore in my anger,
'They are not going into my rest!'" **[Ps 95:11]**

He finished his work when he founded the world. [4]In one text it says of the seventh day,

"On the seventh day God rested from his work" **[Gen 2:2]**;

[5]and in this place,

"They're not going to go into my rest!" **[Ps 95:11]** **Heb 4:1-5**

[6]Since there's still a rest for some to enter, and *since* the ones that received good news before didn't enter *it* because they disbelieved, [7]he established another day, *"Today."* He said at David's time much later like he'd said before,

"Today, if you hear him speaking to you***,***
don't harden your hearts" **[Ps 95:7-8]**.

[8]If Joshua had given them rest, *God* wouldn't be talking after that about another day. [9]So there's still a rest for God's people. [10]Whoever rests from his work has rested like God did. [11]Let's be diligent then about going into that rest so none of us fall after the same kind of disobedience.

God's Living Word

[12]God's word is living and active and sharper than any two-edged sword. It cuts through to the separation of soul and spirit, and bones and marrow; it judges a person's inner thoughts and intentions. [13]Nothing created is hidden from him; everything is naked and laid bare to the eyes of one we're dealing with. **Heb 4:6-13**

Our Great High Priest

[14]We have a great high priest that's passed through the sky, Jesus the Son of God. So let's hold onto what we're committed to. [15]He's a high priest that can sympathize with our weaknesses because he has faced every temptation we have, but without sinning. [16]So let's boldly draw near to the throne of grace to receive mercy and find grace when we need it.

Heb 4:14-16

5:[1]Every high priest is appointed for people from among people to deal with things that relate to God, and to offer gifts and sacrifices for sins. [2]He's somebody that can deal gently with the ignorant and erring because he has weaknesses too. [3]On that account he's obligated to offer *sacrifices* for his own sins as well as the people's. [4]And, nobody takes the honor to himself; he's called by God like Aaron was. **Heb 5:1-4**

[5]In the same way, Christ didn't exalt himself to become a high priest, but the One that said,

"You're my Son;
I've appointed you today" **[Ps 2:7]**,

[6]says in another *place*,

"You <u>are</u> a priest forever
<u>after the order of Melchizedek</u>" **[Ps 110:4]**.

[7]When he was in the flesh, he offered up prayers and pleas, with tears and audible crying to the One that could save him from death, and God heard him because of his godly fear. [8]As a Son, he learned obedience by what he suffered. [9]Once *he attained* perfect *righteousness*, he became the source of eternal salvation for everyone that obeys him. [10]God designated him *"a high priest after the order of Melchizedek."* **Heb 5:5-10**

Priest After the Order of Melchizedek

[11]We have a lot to say about Melchizedek that's difficult to explain because you're hard of hearing. [12]By now, you should be teachers, but you still need somebody to teach you the basics of God's message. You need "milk" instead of solid food. [13]People that keep drinking milk don't get accustomed to the message about goodness; they're infants. [14]"Solid food" is for grownups that have trained their faculties to discriminate between right and wrong. **Heb 5:11-14**

Getting Beyond the Basics

6:[1]So let's get past the basics about Christ and press on toward maturity. Let's not lay again a foundation about repentance from dead works, and *about* faith toward God, [2]teaching about cleansings, laying on hands, resurrection, eternal judgment. [3]We'll get past the basics, God willing. [4]You can't renew people to repentance that have once seen the light, tasted the heavenly gift, partaken of the Holy Spirit, [5]tasted God's good word and the powers of the age to come—[6]and then fall away. They crucify to themselves God's Son all over again and hold him up to public disgrace. [7]God blesses the ground that soaks up frequent rains and produces crops farmers can use. [8]If it grows thorns and briars, it's worthless and close to being accursed. It ends up getting burned off.

[9]But we're convinced that in matters of salvation you're better than that, despite what we're saying. [10]God is just and remembers your work and love in his name when you ministered to the saints—and still do. [11]We want each of you to keep showing that same diligence, which will endure in the end to a firm hope. [12]That way you won't get sluggish. By faith and endurance, you'll be following the example of people that obtain promises. **Heb 6:1-12**

God's Oath to Abraham

[13]When God made his promise to Abraham, he didn't have anything greater to swear by; so ***"he swore by himself*** **[Gen 22:16]**, [14]***I'll certainly bless you and multiply*** *you"* **[Gen 22:17]**. [15]After Abraham had waited a long time, he did receive the promise. [16]People swear by something greater and settle every dispute with an oath to confirm it. [17]That's what God did when he wanted to show more certainly to the heirs of the promise how unchangeable his plan was: he guaranteed *it* with an oath. [18]By two unchangeable things, then (God can't lie), we can have great confidence who have fled for refuge to take hold of the hope we headed for. [19]That hope anchors our soul; it's a hope that's certain and reliable. It leads inside the curtain, [20]where Jesus went as a forerunner for us when he became *"a high priest after the order of Melchizedek."* **Heb 6:13-20**

Christ's Melchizedekian Priesthood

7:[1]That ***Melchizedek—king of Salem, priest of God Most High—met Abraham when he came back from killing the kings*** *and* ***blessed him.*** [2]***Abraham*** separated off to him ***a tenth of everything*** **[Gen 14:17-20].** First, by translation, *"Melchizedek"* was *"king of righteousness,"* and then *"king of Salem,"* meaning *"king of peace."* [3]Without *record of* father, mother, genealogy, birth, or death—like God's Son—he remains a priest for all time. **Heb 7:1-3**

[4]Look how great the man was that Abraham the patriarch gave a "tenth" of the spoils *of war*. [5]In the Law the Levites that receive the priesthood have a commandment to receive a tithe from the people, that is, from their kin though they've descended from Abraham. [6]But the one whose genealogy *wasn't* from them received a tithe from Abraham and blessed the one that had the promises. [7]Without argument, the greater blesses the lesser. [8]Here men that die receive tithes, but there *one received it who is* pictured as alive. [9]So to speak, through Abraham even Levi, who receives tithes, has paid a tithe. [10]He was in his ancestor's loins when Melchizedek met him. [11]If perfection could come through the Levitical priesthood (by which the people received the Law), why *would there be* another priest *"after the order of Melchizedek"*? [12]Changing the priesthood requires changing the Law, [13]because the One these things speak about belonged to different tribe; nobody from that tribe ever served at the altar. [14]It's clear that our Lord descended from Judah; Moses never said anything about priests from that tribe. [15]It's even clearer if another priest arises like Melchizedek, [16]who has become *a priest*, not by law based on physical requirement, but by power based on indestructible life. [17]Scripture testifies,

"You're a priest <u>forever</u>
after the order of Melchizedek" **[Ps 110:4]**.

[18]*That statement* annuls the preceding commandment because it was weak and unprofitable—[19]the Law didn't make anything perfect—and brings in a better hope by which we can draw near to God. **Heb 7:4-19**

God's Oath About Christ's Priesthood

[20-21]Furthermore, Christ's priesthood *came in* with an oath. The Levites became priests without an oath, but he *became a priest* with an oath from the One that said to him,

"The LORD swore
and won't change his mind,
'You're a priest forever'" **[Ps 110:4].**

[22]By that much Jesus also guaranteed a better covenant. [23]There were lots of former *priests* because death prevented them from continuing. [24]He holds his priesthood without successors because he remains forever. [25]So he can save "forever" the ones that draw near to God through him. He's always alive to intercede for them. **Heb 7:20-25**

[26]That's the kind of high priest we need—holy, innocent, undefiled, separate from sinners, higher than the sky. [27]Unlike those high priests, he didn't need to make an offering every day first for his own sins and then for the people's. He made an offering once and for all when he offered himself. [28]The Law appoints men high priests that have weakness, but the oath that came after the Law *appointed* forever a perfected Son. **Heb 7:26-28**

Christ's Priesthood in Heaven

8:[1]Here's the point: we have the kind of high priest that sat down on the right hand of the majestic throne in heaven. [2]He ministers in the sanctuary, the real tabernacle the LORD pitched, not man. [3]Every high priest is appointed to offer gifts and sacrifices; so he needed to offer something too. [4]On earth, he wouldn't be a priest at all since there are those who offer gifts according to the Law and serve a copy and shadow of heavenly things. [5]God warned Moses when he was getting ready to put up the tabernacle, ***"Be sure you make everything like the design I showed you on the mountain"*** **[Ex 25:40].** [6]Christ received a ministry that's as much better as the covenant he's mediating is better, because God enacted it on better promises.

Heb 8:1-6

The Promise of a New Covenant

[7]If the first covenant hadn't had faults, God wouldn't have planned to put a second covenant in place. He's finding fault with *the first* [8]when he says,

"The time's coming
when I'll make a new covenant
with Israel and Judah.
[9]***It won't be like the covenant I*** **made** ***with their ancestors***
when I brought them out of Egypt.
They didn't continue on in my covenant,
and I wasn't pleased with them.
[10]***This is the*** **kind of** ***covenant I'll make with Israel later:***

I'll put my laws in their <u>minds</u>
and write them on their <u>hearts</u>.
I'll be their God,
and they'll be my people.
[11]***<u>Nobody will be teaching his fellow citizen</u> and friend,***
'<u>Know the *LORD*.</u>'
They'll all know me from smallest to greatest,
[12]***because I'll have mercy on their sins;***
I won't remember them anymore" **[Jer 31:31-34].**
[13]When he said *"new,"* he made the first old. What's getting old *is* about to pass away. **Heb 8:7-13**

Service in the First Sanctuary

9:[1]Now the first *covenant* had an earthly sanctuary and regulations for service. [2]The first tabernacle, *"the Holy Place,"* had a lampstand and a table with sacred bread on it. [3]Behind the second curtain stood another tabernacle, *"the Holy of Holies."* [4]It had a gold altar of incense and the Ark of the Covenant that was gold-plated all over. Inside the ark there was a gold pot with manna in it along with Aaron's rod that budded and the tablets that contained the covenant. [5]Above the ark the glorious cherubs hovered over the mercy seat. We can't speak in detail about these now. **Heb 9:1-5**

[6]With things arranged that way, the priests regularly go into the first tabernacle to perform rites of divine service. [7]But the high priest goes into the second tabernacle by himself once a year and takes blood to offer for himself and the sins people committed in ignorance. [8]The Holy Spirit signified by that design that the way into the Holy of Holies wasn't obvious while the original tabernacle was standing. [9]The tabernacle figuratively pictured its own time when gifts and sacrifices couldn't clear a worshiper's conscience. [10]Those gifts and sacrifices only dealt with foods, drinks, various washings—physical regulations in place till the new order would come in. **Heb 9:6-10**

Christ as Priest of What's Real

[11]Christ appeared as a high priest of good things that are here now. He went in by the greater and more perfect tabernacle not made with hands, that is, not of this creation. [12]He didn't go into the Holy of Holies on the basis of the blood of goats and calves, but on the basis of his own blood once and for all to obtain eternal salvation. [13]If the blood of bulls and goats and the ashes of a heifer sprinkling the defiled, sanctifies to cleanse the <u>flesh</u>, [14]how much more will the blood of Christ—who offered himself without blemish to God through the eternal Spirit—cleanse our <u>conscience</u> from dead works to serve the living God. **Heb 9:11-14**

Christ's Mediating the New Covenant

[15]So he's the mediator of a new covenant. His death redeemed sins that people committed under the first covenant so the heirs of the eternal covenant could receive the promise. [16]A testamentary covenant involves the death of the one that made it. [17]It's never in force while he's alive. [18]The first covenant was instituted with blood. [19]When Moses had spoken every commandment to the people, he took the blood of goats and young bulls—with water, scarlet wool, and hyssop—and sprinkled the scroll itself and the people, [20]saying, *"This is* ***the blood of the covenant God commanded you"*** **[Ex. 24:8]**. [21]He also sprinkled blood on the tabernacle and the vessels used in it. [22]*I can* almost *say*, according to the Law, blood cleanses everything; there's no forgiveness without shedding blood. **Heb 9:15-22**

[23]These things cleansed the copies of heavenly things, but something better needed to cleanse the heavenly things themselves. [24]Christ didn't go into a handmade copy of the real sanctuary; he went into heaven itself to appear for us now in God's presence. [25]And, he didn't need to offer himself many times like the high priest does in the Holy Place every year with blood that's not his own. [26]Otherwise, Christ would've had to suffer many times since the world began. But now, once and for all at the end of the ages, he has appeared to get rid of sin by sacrificing himself. [27]It's appointed to men to die once and after that *to face* judgment. [28]In the same way, Christ offered himself once to bear the sins of many. He'll appear a second time—apart from sin—to the ones who wait expectantly for him to save us. **Heb 9:23-28**

Replacing Shadows with Realities

10[:1]The Law has a shadow of good things to come, not the very things themselves; so, by the same sacrifices every year, it can never make the ones perfect that are drawing near. [2]Otherwise, wouldn't those sacrifices have ceased to be offered? The worshipers wouldn't feel like sinners anymore because they would've been cleansed once and for all. [3]But every year the sacrifices remind people that they're still sinners. [4]The blood of bulls and goats can't take away sins. **Heb 10:1-4**

[5]So when he comes into the world, he says,

"You didn't want sacrifice and offering;
you prepared a body for me.
[6]***You didn't delight in whole burnt offerings***
and sacrifices for sins.
[7]***Then I said,***
'God, I've come to do your will;
it's been written about me in the scroll'" **[Ps 40:6-8, cp. LXX]**.

[8]When he says above, "***You didn't want or delight in sacrifices and offerings and whole burnt offerings*** and ***sacrifices for sins,"*** which are offered according to the Law, [9]***then*** he says, ***"I've***

come to do your will." He takes away the first to establish the second. [10]By that will, the one-time offering of Christ's "body" has made us holy. **Heb 10:5-10**

[11]Every day, priests stand ministering and offering the same sacrifices over and over that can never take away sins. [12]But he offered one sacrifice for sins for all time, sat down on the right hand of God, [13]and is waiting till his enemies become his "footstool." [14]By one offering, he permanently perfected the ones he sanctified.

[15]The Holy Spirit also testifies. After he said,

[16]***"This is the covenant I'll make with them***
after those days:
I'll put my laws in their hearts
and write them on their minds'" **[Jer 31:33]**;

[17]*then he says,*

"'I won't remember their sins
and lawless deeds anymore'" **[Jer 31:34]**.

[18]Where there's forgiveness for sins, there's no more sacrificing for them. **Heb 10:11-18**

Obtaining a Clear Conscience

[19]So we have confidence about entering the Holy Place by the blood of Jesus. [20]*We go in* by the new and living way that he has opened for us through the curtain, that is, his flesh. [21]We have a great priest over God's house; [22]so let's draw near with a true heart in full assurance that comes from trust. *Let's draw near* with hearts sprinkled from a guilty conscience and bodies washed with pure water. [23]Let's hold onto *our* hope confidently without wavering; we can trust the One that promised. [24]Let's think carefully how we can encourage one another to love and good works. [25]Let's not quit going to church like some do; let's encourage one another, especially as we see "the time" coming close. [26]If we keep on sinning deliberately after we know the truth, there's no more sacrifice *to be offered*. [27]There's a fearful dread of judgment and the furious fire that will consume *God's* opponents. [28]Anybody that disregards the Law of Moses, dies without mercy at the testimony from two or three witnesses. [29]How much more severe punishment do you suppose people deserve who trample the Son of God under their feet, regard as unclean the blood of the covenant that sanctified them, and insult the Spirit of grace? [30]We know who said,

"Revenge is my business;
I'll take care of it" **[Deut. 32:35]**;

and,

"The LORD will judge his people" **[Deut 32:36; Ps 135:14]**.

[31]It's a terrifying thing to fall into the hands of the living God. **Heb 10:19-31**

Confidence in Hardships

[32]Remember the earlier days when you first saw the light and suffered such hardships. [33]You were publicly shamed with insults and difficulties and shared with other people that were abused that way. [34]You sympathized with people in prison and accepted it joyfully when authorities confiscated your possessions, because you knew you had a better possession that lasts. [35]So don't lose confidence; an important payment is coming. [36]You need to hang in there so, once you've done God's will, you'll obtain the promise,

[37]***"In a little while***
the ***One that's coming will come,***
[38]***and my righteous one will have life by faith.***
If he gives up,
I won't be pleased with him" **[Hab 2:3-4].**

[39]We aren't among those who "give up" and get destroyed; we have "faith" to the preserving of *our* "life." **Heb 10:32-39**

Roll Call of the Faithful

11:[1]Faith is confidence about what *we* hope for, certainty about what *we* can't see. [2]By faith people of old received testimony.

[3]By faith we understand that God spoke the universe into existence, so what we see didn't come from something previous.

[4]By faith Abel offered God a better sacrifice than Cain did. Through it he received testimony that he was good. (God testified in response to his gifts.) Through it he's still speaking though he's dead. **Heb 11:1-4**

[5]By faith Enoch didn't die. **"*God took him up, and he* simply *wasn't there"*** **[Gen 5:24]**. Before God took him up, *the ancient writings* say "*he pleased God"* [**Gen 5:22-24;** Sir 44:16; Enoch 70:1-4; Wis 4:10]. [6]Without faith a person can't please God. Whoever comes to him has to believe he exists and rewards people who look for him.

[7]By faith Noah built an ark that saved his family. God had warned him about things he couldn't see yet, and he paid attention to the warning. By faith he condemned *his* world and inherited the results of the goodness that comes from faith. **Heb 11:5-7**

[8]By faith Abraham obeyed when God called him, and went out to a place he'd inherit later. He went without knowing where he was going. [9]By faith he lived as a foreigner in a land God had promised him. He lived there as a nomad in tents with Isaac and Jacob, heirs of the same promise. [10]He did it because he was looking for a city that had foundations, whose architect and builder is God.

[11]By faith Sarah, too, though she couldn't have children, God enabled to conceive even after child-bearing years. She did so because she had faith in the One that promised. [12]So, from

one *man* that was as good as dead, there descended as many as the stars in the sky and the grains of sand on the seashore. **Heb 11:8-12**

[13]These all died in faith without receiving the promises. They saw them a long way off and greeted them from afar. They regarded themselves as foreigners and temporary residents on earth. [14]People that say things like that show they're looking for a homeland. [15]If they were looking to where they'd come from, they could've gone back. [16]But they longed for a better, heavenly homeland. So God's not ashamed of being their God, as he showed by preparing a city for them. **Heb 11:13-16**

[17]By faith Abraham, when God put him to the test, *went ahead and* offered up Isaac. *The man* that was so happy to receive the promises offered up the only *son* he had. [18]He was the one God told, ***"Your lineage will descend through Isaac"*** **[Gen 21:12]**. [19]He figured that God could even raise Isaac from the dead; in a way, that's what happened.

[20]By faith Isaac blessed Jacob and Esau even about future things.

[21]By faith Jacob, as he was dying, blessed each of Joseph's sons and "***worshiped, leaning on his staff"*** **[Gen 48:15-16; 47:31 LXX]**. **Heb 11:17-21**

[22]By faith Joseph, when he was about to die, remembered the *future* exodus of Israel's descendants and gave instructions about his bones.

[23]By faith Moses' parents hid him for three months. They saw he was a handsome little boy and weren't afraid of Pharaoh's decree.

[24]By faith Moses, when he grew up, refused to be considered the son of Pharaoh's daughter. [25]He chose to suffer mistreatment with God's people rather than enjoy the pleasures of sin for a while. [26]He considered the disgrace of Christ more valuable than the wealth of Egypt because he was looking on ahead to the later reward. [27]By faith he left Egypt, not afraid of Pharaoh's anger, and endured as if he saw the One that's invisible. [28]By faith he kept the Passover and the smearing of blood *on the doorposts* so the one that destroyed the firstborn wouldn't touch them. [29]By faith he crossed the Red Sea as on dry ground. When the Egyptians tried it, they drowned. **Heb 11:22-29**

[30]By faith the walls of Jericho fell down after the Israelites circled them for seven days.

[31]By faith Rahab the harlot didn't perish with the disobedient because she welcomed the spies in peace. **Heb 11:30-31**

Extreme Faithfulness

[32]What more can I say? There's not enough time to talk about Gideon, Barak, Samson, Jephthah, David and Samuel, and the prophets. [33]By faith they conquered kingdoms, did good things, received promises, shut the mouths of lions, [34]extinguished the power of fire, escaped the sword, were made strong out of weakness, became mighty in war, drove out armies of foreigners. [35]Women received back their dead by resurrection. Some[mas] were beaten to death,

rather than accept deliverance so they could gain a better resurrection. [36]Others received public torture and scourging, *were put in* chains and imprisoned. [37]They were stoned, sawn in two, murdered with swords. They went around in sheepskins and goatskins, destitute, oppressed, abused; [38]wandering in deserts and mountains, *hiding in* caves and holes in the ground. The world didn't deserve them. [39]They all received testimony through their faith, but they didn't receive the promise. [40]God provided something better for us so that *what they anticipated* wasn't completed till we received it. **Heb 11:32-40**

Renewed Zeal from Faithful Examples

12:[1]So, surrounded by such a crowd of witnesses to us, let's lay aside everything that weighs us down and the sin that so easily holds us back. Let's press on in the race that's in front of us, [2]as we look ahead to Jesus the forerunner and finisher of our faith. For the joy in front of him, he endured the cross, overlooked the disgrace, and sat down on the right side of God's throne. [3]Keep in mind the One that endured such verbal hostility from sinners so you don't get discouraged. **Heb 12:1-3**

[4]You haven't shed your blood yet in straining against sin. [5]You've forgotten the encouragement that reasons with you like children,

"My child, don't take lightly the LORD's discipline
or give up when he scolds you.
[6]***The LORD disciplines the ones he loves***
and punishes every child he receives" **[Pro 3:11-12].**

[7]Endure to gain discipline because God's treating you like children. What child doesn't a father discipline? [8]If you're not receiving discipline, you're not children; you're illegitimate offspring. [9]Besides, we respected our physical fathers who disciplined us; won't we respect our spiritual Father more and live? [10]They did what they thought was appropriate; he does it for our benefit so we'll be holy like him. [11]Discipline always seems harsh at the time; but later it pays back the peaceful results of right living. [12]So strengthen the limp hands and weak knees, [13]and make straight paths for your feet so what's lame won't veer off but get corrected. **Heb 12:4-13**

Getting Serious About Holy Living

[14]With everybody, strive for peace and the holiness you need to have to see the Lord. [15]Make sure none *of you* come short of God's grace. Don't let some root of bitterness sprout up and cause trouble and end up defiling other people. [16]Don't be immoral or irreligious like Esau, who sold his birthright for one meal. [17]As you know, afterward, when he wanted to inherit the blessing, he was refused. He didn't find any change of heart *in his father* though with tears he tried diligently to get it. **Heb 12:14-17**

[18]You haven't come to *a mountain* you can touch or one blazing with fire. You haven't come to darkness, gloom, and whirlwind, [19]to a trumpet blast or the sound of words *the Israelites* begged not to hear. [20]They couldn't deal with the severe demand,

"If even an animal touches the mountain, stone it" **[Ex 19:12-13].**

[21]The spectacle was so terrifying, Moses said, ***"I'm so afraid*** *I'm shaking"* **[Deut 9:19].** [22]But, you've come to Mount Zion,

to the city of the living God,
to the heavenly Jerusalem and countless thousands of angels,
to the assembly [23]and church of the firstborn who are enrolled in heaven;
to God, the judge of all;
to the spirits of good people made perfect;
[24]to Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant; and
to the sprinkling of blood that speaks better than Abel's. **Heb 12:18-24**

[25]Make sure you don't ignore who's talking to you. If <u>they</u> didn't escape who ignored the One that warned them on earth, <u>you</u> certainly won't escape if you turn away from the One *who has warned you* from heaven. [26]His voice shook the earth then, but now he has promised,

"One more time I won't just shake the earth
but ***the sky*** *too"* **[Hag 2:6].**

[27]*"One more time"* means taking away what can be shaken—this creation—so what can't be shaken will be all that's left. [28]Since you're receiving a kingdom that can't be shaken, be grateful. In gratitude serve God in an acceptable way with reverence and awe; [29]he's a consuming fire. **Heb 12:25-29**

Service to All People

13:[1]Love the believers. [2]Be hospitable to strangers. (Some have entertained angels without knowing it.) [3]Remember prisoners as if you're in prison with them, and those abused as if you're in *their* bodies. [4]With everybody, keep marriage honorable and the bed undefiled; God will judge fornicators and adulterers. [5]Be free from the love of money and be content with what you have. He said it himself,

"I'll never abandon you" **[Deut 31:6].**

[6]So we can confidently say,

"The LORD's my helper;
I won't be afraid.
What are people going to do to me?" **[Ps 118:6].**

[7]Remember your leaders, who spoke God's message to you. Look at the way their lives turned out and imitate their faith. [8]Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today, and forever. **Heb 13:1-8**

Resisting Distractions

9Don't get drawn off course by strange teachings. It's good to feel secure because of grace rather than food. Observing regulations about food doesn't benefit the ones that observe them. **10**We have an altar that the ones who serve the tabernacle don't have a right to eat from. **11**The high priest takes into the Holy Place the blood of animals *as a sacrifice* for sin; the bodies of those animals get burned outside the camp. **12**Jesus also suffered outside the gate to sanctify the people through his own blood. **13**Let's go out to him—outside the camp—and bear his disgrace. **14**We don't have an eternal city here, but we anticipate the one that's coming. **15**Through him let's offer up to God a sacrifice of continuous praise, that is, what we say in acknowledging him. **16**Don't neglect doing good and sharing; God delights in sacrifices like that.

Heb 13:9-16

Assisting the Leaders

17Obey your leaders; defer to them. They watch over your souls so they can enjoy giving account. (Doing so with sighing wouldn't benefit you.)

18Pray for us. We have a clear conscience; we want to conduct ourselves well in everything we do. **19**I urge *you* to do that all the more so I can get back to you sooner.

Doxology

20-21 May the God that brings peace, that resurrected the Great Shepherd of the sheep, equip you by the blood of the eternal covenant to do his will in everything that's good. Through Jesus Christ, may he accomplish in you what delights him. Glory to him forever[more][ms]! Amen.

Closing Exhortation and Greeting

22I encourage you to listen to *this* brief encouragement. **23**Be aware that our brother Timothy is free now. If he comes soon, I'll see you with him.

24Greet your leaders and all the saints. The ones from Italy greet you.

25Grace *be* with you all.

Heb 13:17-25

JAMES

Salutation

1:[1]James, servant of God and the Lord Jesus Christ[Messiah], to the twelve tribes in the Dispersion. Greetings.

Temptation, Wisdom, Humility

[2]Consider temptation something to be glad about. [3]It challenges your faith to produce stamina, [4]and stamina gives you the ability to finish what you're doing.

[5]If you need wisdom, ask God. He gives it generously to everybody without blaming *them for asking*. [6]Trust him when you ask. If you doubt, you're like an ocean wave blown around by the wind. [7]Don't suppose you'll get anything from God. [8]If you can't make up your mind, you're unsettled about everything you do. **James 1:1-8**

[9]Disciples in humble circumstances should take pride in their high position. [10]Rich disciples should take pride in their humble circumstances because their wealth will fade away like a flower in the grass. [11]The sun climbs high and joins the hot wind to dry up the grass and wilt the flowers, and their beauty fades away. That's how it is with rich people: they wither away in what they're trying to do. **James 1:9-11**

[12]When you hold up under temptation you're blessed. When approved, you'll receive life as a crown. That's what the Lord has promised people that care about him. [13]When you face temptation, don't say, *"God's tempting me."* Evil isn't tempting to God, and he doesn't tempt anybody. [14]Your own lusts are what tempt you, lure you away, entice you. [15]When lust conceives, it bears sin, and sin grows up to produce death. **James 1:12-15**

Listening, Doing, Controlling the Tongue

[16]Don't get misled. [17]Every good and perfect gift comes down from the Father that enlightens us. There's no wavering or hint of inconsistency with him. [18]He took the initiative in bringing us forth by the message about the truth so we've become a kind of firstfruits among people he created. **James 1:16-18**

[19]Know *this*: people must be willing to listen, be careful about what they say, and be slow to get mad. [20]People's anger doesn't produce God's goodness. [21]So get rid of filthy ways of living and the excesses that evil brings; humbly yield to the implanted message that can save you. **James 1:19-21**

[22]Do the word; don't just listen to it and kid yourselves. [23]If you hear *it* and don't do *it*, you're like a fellow that looks in a mirror [24]and forgets what he looked like. [25]When you stare into the perfect "law," the law of liberty, and continue as a doer, not just a hearer, you'll be blessed in what you do. **James 1:22-25**

[26]If you consider yourself religious but don't control your tongue, you're fooling yourself; your religion is useless. [27]Pure, undefiled religion with God the Father is this: looking after orphans and widows in their hardship and keeping yourselves from getting stained by the world. **James 1:26-27**

No Discrimination Against the Poor

2:[1]Fellow Christians, don't discriminate against people while claiming to have faith in our glorious Lord Jesus Christ. [2]If a man comes into your assembly dressed nice with a gold ring on his finger, and a poor man comes in wearing shabby clothes, [3]and you give preference to the one in fine clothes and say, *"Sit here in a nice place,"* and say to the poor man, *"Stand over there,"* or *"Sit by my footstool,"* [4]aren't you discriminating and making judgments from bad motives? **James 2:1-4**

[5]Listen, hasn't God chosen poor people to be rich in faith and inherit the kingdom he promised to people that care about him? [6]But you've looked down on poor people. Don't rich people bully you and take you to court? [7]Don't they slander the good name you wear? [8]But, you do well to fulfill the royal law according to the scripture, ***"Love your neighbor as yourself"*** **[Lev 19:18]**. [9]If you discriminate, you sin, and the Law convicts you of being a sinner. [10]Whoever keeps the whole Law but stumbles in one point, has become liable to the Law *as such*. [11]The One that said, ***"Do not commit adultery"*** **[Ex 20:14; Deut 5:18]** is the same One that said, ***"Do not murder"*** **[Ex 20:13; Deut 5:17]**. If you don't commit adultery but commit murder, you're still a law breaker. [12]Speak and do like people that are evaluated by a "law" of liberty. [13]Condemnation is without mercy to people that haven't shown mercy. Showing mercy is better than criticizing. **James 2:5-13**

Doing *vs.* Believing

[14]What good is it to say you believe but don't do? Believing can't save you, can it? [15] When a brother or sister needs clothes or daily food, what good is it [16]if somebody says, *"Have a good day; keep warm and eat well,"* but doesn't give them what they need? [17]It's the same way if belief doesn't do anything; it's dead by itself. **James 2:14-17**

[18]Somebody might say, *"<u>You</u> have belief; <u>I</u> have deeds."* Show me your belief without doing anything, and I'll show you my belief by what I do. [19]You believe there's one God; that's nice. Demons believe *that* too—and tremble. [20]Can't you see that believing without doing is useless? [21]Wasn't our ancestor Abraham justified by what he did when he sacrificed his son Isaac? [22]Belief combined with his deeds; his deeds completed his belief. [23]He fulfilled the scripture that said, ***"Abraham believed God, and God considered him righteous"*** **[Gen 15:6]**, and he was called "God's friend" **[2 Ch 20:7; Is 41:8]**. [24]That shows we're justified by what we do, not simply by what we believe. [25]The same with Rahab the prostitute; wasn't she justified by what

she did when she received the messengers and sent them out a different way? [26]As the body is dead if it doesn't breathe, believing is dead if it doesn't do anything. **James 2:18-26**

More about Controlling the Tongue

3:[1]Not many of you should try to be teachers; you'll get judged more strictly. [2]In lots of ways we all slip up; if we don't slip up in what we say, we're perfect; and we can bridle our whole body. [3]We put bits in horses' mouths so they'll obey us, and we guide their whole body. [4]The same thing with ships. Though they're so big and driven by strong winds, the helmsmen control them with a very small steering paddle wherever they want them to go. [5]The same thing with the tongue. It's a small part of the body, but it makes big claims. **James 3:1-5**

[6]A little spark can set a big forest on fire! [7]People tame all kinds of animals and birds, reptiles and sea creatures; [8]but nobody can tame the tongue; *it's* an uncontrollable evil full of deadly poison. [9]We bless the Lord and Father with it, and *then* curse people made like him. [10]Blessing and cursing from the same mouth! That shouldn't be. [11]Brackish and sweet water don't gush out of the same spring, do they? [12]A fig tree can't bear olives or a vine yield figs, can it? What's salty can't make something sweet. **James 3:6-12**

The Importance of Wisdom

[13]Who's wise and understanding among you? Show it in good, humble, wise living. [14]If you're jealous and selfish, don't act proud and lie *to cover it up*. [15]"Wisdom" like that doesn't come from above; it's earthly, unspiritual, demonic. [16]Where there's jealousy and selfishness, people are unstable and exhibit all kinds of bad behavior. [17]Wisdom from above is first pure, then peaceful, gentle, open to reason, merciful, and yielding good fruits. It doesn't waver or show hypocrisy. [18]Peacemakers use peace to plant righteous fruit. **James 3:13-18**

Effects of Self-Centeredness

4:[1]Where do conflicts and disagreements come from? Don't they come from pleasures at conflict inside you? [2]You want and don't have, you kill and covet and can't get, you quarrel and fight and don't obtain because you don't ask. [3]When you do ask, you don't receive because you ask with the wrong motive: *you ask* so you can spend it on your pleasures. [4]Adulterers, you know, don't you, that friendship with the world amounts to hostility toward God? So whoever wants to be friendly with the world makes himself hostile toward God. [5]Do you suppose the scripture says for no reason, *"The Spirit he put among us yearns to receive exclusive loyalty"?* [6]He gives more grace, ***"God resists the proud, but he gives grace to the humble"*** **[Pro 3:34 LXX]**. [7]So submit to God. Resist the devil, and he'll run from you. [8]Come close to God, and he'll come close to you. Clean *your* hands, you sinners; purify *your* hearts, you with divided loyalties. [9]Be

sad, mourn, and cry. Turn your laughing into mourning, and your lightheartedness into serious-mindedness. [10]Humble yourselves in front of the Lord, and he'll lift you up. **James 4:1-10**

Ban on Criticism

[11]Don't gossip about each other. When you criticize your brother or sister, you're acting like a judge. If you do that, you go from being a doer of the law to serving as a judge for the law. [12]There is one lawgiver and judge that can acquit or execute. Who are you to serve as a judge over your neighbor? **James 4:11-12**

Recognizing Your Dependent Place

[13]Come, come, now, you that say, *"Today or tomorrow we'll go to such and such a city, spend a year, carry on business, make money."* [14]You don't know what tomorrow holds. What's your life but a vapor that appears for a while and vanishes? [15]You should say, *"The Lord willing, we'll live and do this or that."* [16]But you take pride in your bragging; that's not right. [17]If you know to do good and don't do it, you're sinning. **James 4:13-17**

Futility of Wealth

5:[1]Come, come, rich people. Cry out loud over the miseries heading your way. [2]Your wealth has decayed; your clothes are moth-eaten; [3]your gold and silver have tarnished. Their tarnish will testify against you and consume you like fire. They're the 'wealth' you've laid up for your last days! [4]You haven't paid the workers that mowed your fields. Their complaints have gone up to the Lord of hosts. [5]You've lived in self-indulgence and luxury. You've fattened yourselves up at the expense of people you've ruined. [6]You've condemned, you've murdered the Righteous One; he doesn't resist you. **James 5:1-6**

Exhortation to Endurance

[7]So be patient till the Lord comes. A farmer patiently waits for his valuable crop till it gets *its* early and late rains. [8]You be patient too; strengthen your hearts because the Lord's coming soon. [9]Don't complain about each other or you'll be complained about; the judge is standing right outside your doors. [10]Take the *LORD*'s prophets as models of suffering and endurance. [11]We consider them blessed that endured. You've heard about Job's patience, and you know the Lord's compassionate and merciful in the end. **James 5:7-11**

Dispensing with Oaths

[12]Above all, don't swear by the sky, the earth, or anything else. Just say "yes" or "no"; otherwise, you fall under condemnation. **James 5:12**

Calling the Elders

[13]Is anybody suffering among you? He should pray. Is anybody happy? He should sing. [14]Is anybody sick? He should call the church elders. They should pray over him and anoint him with olive oil in the name of the Lord. [15]Prayer with faith will save the sick, and the Lord will raise them up. If they have sinned, God will forgive them. [16]Admit your sins to each other and pray for each other so you'll be healed. A good person's prayer can accomplish a lot. [17]Elijah was a man like us, and he prayed sincerely that it wouldn't rain, and it didn't for three and a half years. [18]He prayed again and it rained, and the ground grew its crops. **James 5:13-18**

Returning the Stray

[19]Fellow believers, if somebody wanders off from the truth and somebody gets him turned around, [20]he can be sure that returning a sinner from error will save him from death and cover a host of sins. **James 5:19-20**

FIRST PETER

Salutation

1:1 Peter, apostle of Jesus Christ[Messiah], to the Chosen who live as foreigners in the Dispersion throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia, **2**known by God the Father a long time ago, sanctified by *his* Spirit, sprinkled with Christ's blood, and obedient to him. Grace and peace many times over. **1 Pet 1:1-2**

Gratitude for Heaven Offered

3Blessed *be* the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ. In his great mercy, he gave us a living hope by resurrecting Jesus. **4**He has reserved for us in heaven an inheritance that doesn't deteriorate, that can't be defiled and won't fade away. **5**Trusting his power protects us so we can receive the salvation that's ready for him to reveal in the end.

6With that to look forward to, rejoice, even though for a little while now, various trials may be bringing you grief. **7**Your faith is worth more than gold that perishes. Testing that faith—as if by fire—leads to praising, exalting, and honoring Jesus Christ when he returns. **8**Though you haven't seen him, you love him. Because you believe in him, your joy is so great and glorious that you can't express it. **9**In the end, your faith will save your souls. **1 Pet 1:3-9**

The Prophets' Ministry to Us

10Prophets who prophesied about the grace that *would come* to you searched out this salvation carefully. **11**They wanted to find out what time or what kind of time the Spirit of Christ in them was indicating about his sufferings and subsequent glories. **12**They learned that they weren't ministering these things to themselves, but to you. The Holy Spirit, sent from heaven, has announced those things now through your evangelists—things angels long to look into.

13So think straight and be serious. Put your hope completely in the grace that will come to you when Jesus Christ appears. **14**Like obedient children, don't conform to the desires you lived by in your former ignorance; **15**conform yourselves to the Holy One that called you to become holy in everything you do. **16**Like scripture says, ***"Be holy because I'm holy"*** **[Lev 11:44-45; 19:2; 20:7].** **1 Pet 1:10-16**

Hope Based on Spiritual Things

17You call him Father who judges impartially each person's work; so, like foreigners, live out your time here in fear. **18**You weren't redeemed with corruptible things—silver or gold—from the empty life you inherited from your ancestors. **19**You were redeemed with the precious blood of the unblemished Lamb. **20**Christ was foreknown before the founding of the world but was revealed in the last times. **21**Through him you're faithful to God, who resurrected him and

glorified him. So, your faith and hope lie in God. [22]You've cleaned up your lives by obeying the truth in brotherly love; continue to love each other with a pure heart. [23]You've been born again from incorruptible seed through God's living, lasting message:

[24]***"Flesh is like grass;***
its beauty is like blossoms in the grass.
The grass dries up;
the blossoms fall off;
[25]***but what the LORD says lasts forever"*** **[Is 40:6-8]**.

That's the message we presented to you. **1 Pet 1:17-25**

The Cornerstone

2:[1]So, get rid of hate, deceit, hypocrisy, jealousy, insults. [2]Like newborn babies, be hungry for pure spiritual milk so you can grow up to salvation—[3]if you've tasted how good the Lord is. [4]Come to him as to a living stone, rejected by people, but chosen and precious to God. [5]Like living stones you're building yourselves up into a spiritual house for a holy priesthood that offers spiritual sacrifices to God through Christ. [6]So it stands in scripture,

"I'm laying a stone in Zion,
a precious cornerstone.
He won't disappoint the ones that trust in him" **[Is 28:16]**.

[7]To you believers *he's* precious, but to disbelievers *he's*

"a stone the builders rejected
that has become the cornerstone" **[Ps 118:22]**;

[8]and

"a stone they trip over,
a rock that makes them fall" **[Is 8:14]**.

They "trip" by disobeying the message—as they were allowed to do. **1 Pet 2:1-8**

Living in Light of Who You Are

[9]But you're **a chosen race [Is 43:20], a royal priesthood, a holy nation [Ex 19:6], a people that belongs to God. That's so you can present *to others* the excellence [Is 43:21]** of the One that called you out of darkness into his amazing light.

[10]*"You that weren't a people at one time*
are now God's people;
you that he hadn't shown mercy
have now received it" **[Hos 2:23].** **1 Pet 2:9-10**

[11]I urge you, like foreigners here temporarily, to stay away from physical drives that fight against the soul. [12]Keep your lifestyle good among the Gentiles so whatever they'd slander you for, when they observe the good things you do, they'll praise God in the end.

Societal Virtues

[13]Submit to human institutions for the Lord's sake—[14]to the king in authority or his governors sent to punish the bad and praise the good. [15]God wants you to silence the ignorance of bad people by doing good. [16]You're free, but freedom doesn't mean you can do as you please; you're God's servants. [17]Respect everybody, love Christ's family, respect God, honor the king.

1 Pet 2:11-17

[18]Servants, defer to your masters with respect, not just the good and considerate ones, but the harsh ones *too*. [19]This pleases God: suffering unjustly and bearing it for conscience sake toward him. [20]What's notable about suffering for sin and bearing it? But suffering for doing good and bearing it, pleases him. [21]That's what he's called you to. Even Christ suffered; he did it for you and left footprints for you to step in. [22]He ***"didn't sin or deceive"*** **[Is 53:9].** [23]When he was insulted, he didn't insult back. When he suffered, he didn't threaten. He turned himself over to the One who judges justly. [24]He humbly bore your sins in his body on the cross so you would live right; his wounds healed you. [25]You were wandering off like sheep, but you've returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls. **1 Pet 2:18-25**

Family Virtues

3:[1]Wives, defer to your husbands so even if they don't believe the message, your conduct will win them over aside from it [2]as they watch your innocent, respectful behavior. [3]For beauty, don't rely on external things like elaborately braided hair or the gold or clothes you wear. [4]Root your beauty in the inner self as in a gentle, quiet spirit; that's especially precious to God. [5]That's the way holy women who hoped in God used to adorn themselves in respect for their husbands. [6]Sarah respected Abraham and called him Sir [lord]. You're her daughters. if you do good and feel secure in your situation. **1 Pet 3:1-6**

[7]Husbands, live with your wives with the understanding that they are weaker vessels. Honor them as fellow heirs of the grace of life so you don't hinder your prayers.

Interpersonal Virtues

[8]In conclusion, you need to be like-minded, sympathetic, tenderhearted, humble, with brotherly love. [9]Don't return evil for evil or insult for insult; bless instead. You were called for that so you could inherit good fortune:

[10]***"Who wants to live***
a long time and prosper?
Keep your tongue from evil
and your lips from lying.
[11]***Quit doing bad and do good;***
look for peace and pursue it.

[12]*The LORD watches over good people*
and hears their prayers.
He turns against
people that practice sin" **[Ps 34:12-16].** **1 Pet 3:7-12**

[13]Who's going to hurt you if you're eager to do what's good? [14]Even if you suffer for it, you're well off. Don't be afraid of people's evil, or let it get you down. [15-16]Set Christ apart as Lord in your hearts. With gentleness and respect, be ready to answer anybody that asks you about the hope you have. Keep your conscience clear so whatever people slander you about, your good behavior in Christ will discredit them. **1 Pet 3:13-16**

Suffering for Doing Good

[17]If God wills, it's better to suffer for being good than for being bad. [18]To bring you to God, Christ also suffered for sin once and for all, the righteous for the unrighteous. He was put to death in the flesh but made alive in the spirit. [19]He went in the spirit and preached to the spirits in prison [20]that disobeyed while God patiently waited for Noah to build the ark. In it, water saved a few people—eight. [21]That's like baptism saving you. It doesn't wash off dirt, but appeals to God for a clear conscience because of Christ's resurrection. [22]He's ascended to God's right hand in heaven with angels, authorities, and powers subject to him. **1 Pet 3:17-22**

Good News Presented to the Dead

4:[1]Christ suffered; so arm yourselves with the attitude he took, because suffering purifies from sin. [2]You won't be living the rest of your life by human desires, but by God's will. [3]You spent enough time following the pattern of life the Gentiles carry on: a lifestyle of sensuality, lust, drunkenness, revelry, drunken parties, disgusting idolatry. [4]They're surprised that you don't run with them in that excessive, reckless living; and they slander you for it. [5]They'll give account to the One who's set to judge the living and the dead. [6]In that connection, the good news was presented even to the dead so they'd be judged like the living who live according to God in the spirit. **1 Pet 4:1-6**

Living with Christ's Return in Mind

[7]The end is close. Be sensible and serious in prayer. [8]Especially, have ongoing love toward each other because love covers lots of sins. [9]Be hospitable toward each other without grudges. [10]Each of you needs to minister your gift to the others as good stewards of the grace God has shown in *these* different ways. If it's speaking, speak as if God himself is speaking. [11]If it's serving, do it wholeheartedly. That way you'll praise God through Christ. Glory and dominion belong to him forevermore. Amen. **1 Pet 4:7-11**

Nothing Surprising About Suffering

[12]Don't be surprised at the fiery trial that's testing you, as if something strange is happening. [13]Instead, to the extent that you're sharing Christ's sufferings, be happy so you can be really happy when he appears in his glory. [14]If people dishonor you because of him, *you're* blessed; God's Spirit and honor rest on you. [15]Don't suffer as a murderer, thief, evildoer, intruder in other people's business. [16]If you suffer as a Christian, don't be ashamed; praise God in that name. [17]It's time to judge God's family. If judgment begins with us, what's going to happen to people that disbelieve God's good news?

[18]***"If good people are barely saved,***
where will godless people come in?" **[Pro 11:31 LXX]**

[19]So you that suffer according to God's will, entrust yourselves to the faithful creator by continuing to do what's right. **1 Pet 4:12-19**

Urging Elders

5:[1]Elders, I'm a fellow elder, a witness of Christ's sufferings. I share in the glory that's going to be revealed. [2]Shepherd God's flock that's among you. Provide oversight, not because you have to, but because you want to; not to make money (which is shameful), but out of internal initiative. [3]Don't lord it over your charges; set an example for the flock. [4]When the Chief Shepherd appears, you'll receive a glorious crown that won't fade away. **1 Pet 5:1-4**

Urging Younger People

[5]Young men, defer to the elders and dress in humility toward each other because

"God resists the proud
and gives grace to the humble" **[Pro 3:34 LXX].**

[6]So "humble" yourselves under God's strong hand, and he'll exalt you in due time. [7]Place your cares on him because he cares about you. [8]Be serious-minded and alert. Your adversary the devil is prowling around looking for somebody to devour. [9]Resist him firmly with faith; you know your fellow believers in the world are experiencing the same sufferings. [10]After you've suffered a little while, the all-gracious God that has called you into his eternal glory will confirm you, strengthen you, and establish you. [11]Dominion to him forever! Amen. **1 Pet 5:5-11**

Closing Comments

[12]I've written you a few words by Silvanus *my* faithful brother, as I consider him. I wanted to encourage you and confirm to you that what you've received is in fact God's grace; stand firm in it. [13]The elect brotherhood in 'Babylon' greets you as does my son Mark. [14]Greet each other with a loving kiss. Peace to all of you in Christ. **1 Pet 5:12-14**

SECOND PETER

Salutation

1:1 Simon Peter, servant and apostle of Jesus Christ[Messiah], to those who've received a faith that's equally precious to us—*faith* in the goodness of our God and Savior Jesus Christ. **2**Grace and peace many times over because you know God and Jesus our Lord. **2 Pet 1:1-2**

God's Sufficient Provisions

3His divine power has given us everything related to life and godliness. He has provided it all by our knowing the One who called us by his own honor and goodness. **4**Through *that honor and goodness* he has provided us great, precious promises so we can partake of the divine character and escape the corruption that's in the world from living by lust. **5**So do your best to add to your faith virtue, to your virtue knowledge, **6**to knowledge self-control, endurance, **7**godliness, brotherly kindness, love. **8**If these keep developing in you, they'll make you useful and fruitful as a result of personally knowing our Lord Jesus Christ. **9**Those who lack them are nearsighted and blind. They've forgotten that they were cleansed from *their* old sins. **10**So be all the more diligent in confirming your calling and being chosen. As long as you live that way, you won't stumble. **11**You'll be making abundant provision for entering the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. **2 Pet 1:3-11**

12So I'll keep reminding you even though you know all this and are standing firm in the truth already. **13**As long as I'm in this body, I think it's good to keep you alert by reminding you. **14**I know I'll be laying aside my tabernacle soon, as our Lord Jesus Christ has shown me. **15**I'll be diligent so after I'm gone, you can remember what I've said. **2 Pet 1:12-15**

Events, not Myths

16We didn't follow clever, made-up myths when we told you about the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ. We saw his majesty with our own eyes. **17**He received from God the Father honor and glory when the Majestic Glory declared, *"This is my dearly loved Son that I delight in."* **18**We heard that voice from heaven ourselves when we were with him on the holy mountain. **19***And so* we have verified the prophetic word. You do well *then* to pay attention to it as to a lamp shining in a dark place till the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts. **20**First of all, get this: no prophecy in scripture comes from somebody's own insight *into things*. **21**No prophet ever *just* decided to make a prophecy. Instead, the Holy Spirit moved them to speak from God. **2 Pet 1:16-21**

Watch Out for False Teachers

2:1 As false prophets arose among the people before, false teachers will arise among <u>you</u>. Under false pretenses they'll bring in destructive heresies. They'll even deny the Master who

bought them and bring swift destruction on themselves. [2]Many will follow their sensual practices, and people will slander the true Way because of them. [3]In their greed they'll exploit you with *their* made-up ideas. Their sentence from of old won't delay; their destruction won't sleep. **2 Pet 2:1-3**

God's Judgment on Evil

[4]God didn't spare angels that sinned; he imprisoned them with chains in the dark underworld [Tartarus] to hold them for judgment. [5]God didn't spare the ancient world; he preserved Noah, one of eight, a man who preached righteousness when *God* brought a flood on the ungodly world. [6]God destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah and reduced them to ashes. He made an example out of them for ungodly people later on. [7]But he rescued righteous Lot; their corrupt conduct weighed on that good man. [8]While he lived among them, the immoral deeds he saw and heard about day after day tormented him. [9]*So*, the Lord knows how to rescue godly people from temptation and keep ungodly ones under punishment till judgment day—[10]especially those who chase after physical lusts and despise authority. **2 Pet 2:4-10a**

Evil People Described

Daring and arrogant, they rail at angels without qualms. [11]But angels, though more powerful, don't rail out condemnations at <u>them</u> in front of the Lord. [12]*People like that* are like wild animals that can't reason, creatures that live by instinct from birth who need to be trapped and exterminated. They rail out about things they don't know. In their destroying, they'll get destroyed. [13]They'll suffer wrong as payback for doing wrong. They think it's fun to carouse in broad daylight. They are stains and blemishes who enjoy deceiving you while they eat with you. [14]They're always looking around for someone to commit adultery with. They sin without ceasing, they lure unsteady souls, they have hearts well-practiced in greed. They're accursed offspring [15]that forsake the right way to follow Balaam son of Beor that loved to make money from his sin. [16]But a donkey, talking like a person, reprimanded him for it and stopped him from carrying out his madness. **2 Pet 2:10b-16**

[17]They're springs without water, fog swirled by the wind. It's pitch dark where they're going. [18]They say arrogant, meaningless things, and lure with lust the ones just escaping from error. [19]They promise freedom while themselves being slaves to corruption. What overcomes people puts them in servitude. [20]If they've escaped the defilements of worldly living by knowing the Lord and Savior Jesus Christ and then get tangled up in them again, they're worse off than before. [21]They'd been better off not to know how to live God's way, than to know *it* and turn away from the holy commandment they'd received. [22]They illustrate the proverb,

> ***"The dog returned to its vomit"*** **[Pro 26:11]**,
> and,

"the washed sow went back to wallowing in the mud." **2 Pet 2:17-22**

Reminders About the Future

3:[1]This is the second letter I've sent you. In both *of them*, I'm trying to keep your sincere minds alert [2]by reminding you about the message from the holy prophets and about your apostles' commandments from the Lord Savior. [3]Get this, first of all: later, mockers will follow their lusts and say, [4]*"Where's the promise about his coming? From the time our ancestors died, everything's like it's been since creation."* [5]They choose to forget that by God's word the skies came into existence long ago and the earth consisted of water and emerged from water. [6]By God's word, the flood destroyed that world. [7]By that same word, the earth and sky that exist now are destined for fire; *they're being* kept for the judgment day and the destruction of ungodly people. **2 Pet 3:1-7**

Assurance About the Future

[8]Friends, don't miss this one point: to the Lord, a day *is* like 1,000 years, and 1,000 years *is* like a day. [9]He's not slow about *keeping* his promise the way people might think. He's not being slow; he's being patient. He doesn't want anybody to perish; he wants everyone to repent. [10]The day of the Lord <u>will come</u>—like a thief: the sky will pass away with a loud noise; the elements will burn up; earth and its works will disappear. [11]Since they're destined for destruction, how should you live [12]as you anticipate the time when God destroys the sky with fire and melts the elements with heat? [13]According to his promise, we look forward to a new earth and sky where goodness prevails. **2 Pet 3:8-13**

Living Meantime

[14]So, as you look forward to that, try hard to be at peace, spotless and blameless, when he finds you. [15]Consider our Lord's patience *a chance* to be saved, as our dear brother Paul wrote to you with the wisdom he's received. [16]In all *his* letters, he talks about those things. Some of them are hard to understand, and unlearned and unsteady people twist them—like *they do* the other scriptures—to their own destruction. [17]So, since you know *all that* ahead of time, make sure not to get deceived by unprincipled people and fall from your steadfastness. [18]Keep growing in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.

Glory to him now and forever. **2 Pet 3:14-18**

FIRST JOHN

Life and Light

1:[1]What was from the beginning, what we've heard and seen, what we've observed and touched about the living message—[2]the eternal life that was with the Father and he revealed to us—that's what [3]we're passing along to you so we can have it in common with you as well as with the Father and his Son Jesus Christ[Messiah]. [4]We're writing these things *to you* to fully share our joy. **1 Jn 1:1-4**

[5]The message is that God is light; there's no darkness in him at all. [6]If we claim to be in fellowship with him and live in the dark, we're lying and not practicing the truth. [7]If we live in the light with him, we have fellowship with each other, and the blood of his Son continues to cleanse us from sin. [8-10]If we claim we don't have any sin, we deceive ourselves and make God a liar. If we admit we've sinned, we can trust him to be just and forgive us of everything. **1 Jn 1:5-10**

Christ Our Advocate

2:[1]My little children, I'm writing so you'll continue not to sin. If any of us <u>do</u> sin, we have an Advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the Just. [2]He's the basis for forgiving <u>our</u> sins as well as the sins of the whole world. [3]We can tell we know him by whether we're keeping his commandments. [4]If we claim to know him but don't obey him, we're not telling the truth and don't have it. [5]If we keep God's word, we really have loved God completely. That's how we can tell we're in him. [6]If we claim to be in him, we should be like him. **1 Jn 2:1-6**

Love, the New Commandment

[7]Friends, I'm not telling you anything new; it's what you've heard all along. [8]Then again, I <u>am</u> saying something new, something that's true in him and us: darkness is disappearing, and true light is already shining. [9]People that claim to be enlightened and hate fellow believers are still in the dark. [11]They don't know where they're going because they can't see in the dark. [10]Whoever loves a fellow believer is in the light and doesn't make people stumble.

[12]I'm writing to you little children
because he's forgiven your sins.
[13]I'm writing to you fathers
because you've known the One that's from the beginning.
I'm writing to you young men
because you've overcome the evil one.
[14]<u>I've written</u> to you children
because you've known the Father.
<u>I've written</u> to you fathers

because you've known the One that's from the beginning.
I've written to you young men
because you're strong;
God's message remains in you, and
you've overcome the evil one. **1 Jn 2:7-14**

[15]Don't love the world or what's in it. Loving the world means not loving the Father. [16]Nothing worldly comes from the Father; the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life come from the world. [17]The world will pass away along with its lust, but whoever does God's will lasts forever. **1 Jn 2:15-17**

The Antichrist

[18]Little children, we're in the last hour. You've heard that antichrist is coming, and lots of antichrists have already come; so we know we're in the last hour. [19]Some people have left us, but they weren't part of us, or they would've stayed; leaving us shows they weren't part of us. [20]You have an anointing from the Holy One, and you all know *what you need to know*. [21]I'm not writing to tell you something you don't know, but because you do know it and because there's a difference between false and true. [22]Who's telling what's false if it's not someone that denies Jesus is the Christ[Messiah]? It's the antichrist that denies the Father and the Son. [23]Nobody that denies the Son has the Father either; anybody that acknowledges the Son has both. [24]Let what you've heard from the beginning stick with you. If you do, you'll continue to be in the Son and the Father, [25]and you'll have the eternal life he promised.

[26]I'm writing about the ones that are trying to mislead you. [27]The anointing you received from him is still in you; you don't need anybody to teach you *anything more*. His anointing is correct and complete. Stick with what he taught you [28]so when he returns, you'll feel confident, not ashamed. [29]If you know he's good, you know he's begotten everyone that's good. **1 Jn 2:18-29**

Children of God

3:[1]Look at what special love the Father has extended to us in calling us his children. The world doesn't know us because it didn't know him. [2]We're God's children now. It's not clear what we will be, but we do know that when *Christ* returns, we'll be like him and see him as he is. [3]Everybody that has that hope keeps himself pure like he is.

[4]Everybody that practices sin is practicing lawlessness; sin is lawlessness. [5]You know he came to take away sins; there's no sin in him. [6]Nobody that's in him practices sin. If they do, they haven't known him or seen him. [7]Little children, don't let anybody mislead you. Whoever does good is good—like he is. [8]Whoever does evil is like the devil because he's been sinning since the beginning. The Son of God came to destroy what the devil does. [9]None of the ones God begets practices sin because *God's* seed stays in them. They can't be sinning because God's

begotten them. [10]That's how you can tell God's children from the devil's. Anybody that doesn't practice goodness or care about fellow believers, doesn't belong to God. **1 Jn 3:1-10**

Love One Another

[11]You've heard all along that we should love each other [12]and not be like Cain. The evil one influenced him, and he murdered his brother. Why'd he do it? Because what his brother did was good, and what he did was bad. [13]Don't be surprised if the world hates you. [14]We've come from death to life because we love fellow Christians. People that hate fellow Christians are still dead. [15]They *amount to* being murderers *like Cain*, and murderers don't have eternal life. [16]We've known what love is because he showed us by laying his life down for us, and we should lay our lives down for our fellow Christians. [17]How can God's love be in anyone that has this world's possessions, sees what a brother or sister needs, and turns off sympathy for them? [18]Little children, let's not talk about love; let's do it. **1 Jn 3:11-18**

[19]We can have confidence in his presence [20]even if we feel guilty. God's greater than our feelings and knows everything. [21]If our conscience doesn't make us feel guilty, we're confident in front of him, [22]and he gives us what we ask for because we do what pleases him. [23]He has told us to believe in his Son Jesus Christ and love each other. [24]When we do that, he lives in us and we in him. We know he's in us by the spirit he's given us. **1 Jn 3:19-24**

Testing the spirits

4:[1]Friends, don't believe every *prophet that claims to speak by the* spirit. Test whether *his* spirit is from God; a lot of false prophets have gone out. [2]You can recognize that a spirit is from God by whether it agrees that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh. [3]Any spirit that doesn't, isn't from God; it's the antichristian *spirit* that you've heard is coming and is already here. [4]You belong to God. You've triumphed over the world, because the One that's in you is greater than the one that's in it. [5]False leaders belong to the world, so they speak of it, and it listens to them. [6]We belong to God; people that know him listen to us. People that don't belong to him, don't listen to us. That's how you can tell if *a prophet has the* true spirit or a deceiving one. **1 Jn 4:1-6**

God is Love

[7]Let's love each other because love comes from God, and everybody that loves has been begotten by him and knows him. [8]People that don't love don't know God because he is *characterized by* love. [9]God showed that love by sending his only Son into the world so we could have life through him. [10]Love is not so much that we love God as that he's loved us and sent his Son as a basis for forgiving our sins. [11]If God loved us that much, we should love each other. [12]Nobody has ever seen God; *but* if we love each other, he's in us and his love has accomplished its purpose in us. **1 Jn 4:7-12**

[13]We know he's in us and we're in him by the spirit he's given us. [14]We've seen and speak to the fact that the Father has sent the Son to save the world. [15]If anybody agrees that Jesus is God's Son, God's in him and he's in God. [16]We've known and believed that God has put his love in us. God is *characterized by* love and whoever keeps loving keeps being in God and God keeps being in him. [17]Love ends up giving us confidence at judgment time because we're like he was in the world. [18]There's no fear in love; perfect love eliminates fear because fear corresponds with punishment; whoever is afraid has not become perfect at loving. [19]Let's love because he loved us first. [20]If people say they love God and hate fellow Christians, they're not telling the truth. If they don't love Christians they've seen, they can't be loving God they've not seen. [21]We have this commandment from him: whoever loves God must love God's children too.

1 Jn 4:13-21

Victory by Faith

5:[1]Everybody that believes Jesus is the Christ[Messiah] has been begotten by God, and everybody that loves the begetter loves the begotten. [2]We can tell we love God's children by whether we love God and do what he says. [3]Loving God means keeping his commandments without feeling like they're burdensome. [4]The ones God begets triumph over the world, and faith makes that triumph possible. [5]Who triumphs over the world except the one that believes Jesus is God's Son?

1 Jn 5:1-5

Witnesses for Christ

[6]Jesus Christ came by water (*at his baptism*) and blood (*on his cross*), not just by water. The Spirit is the One that bears witness, because the Spirit is *characterized by* truth. [7]There are three witnesses: [8]the Spirit, the water, and the blood; and they agree. [9]We accept what people tell us; what God tells us is more important. God has told us about his Son. [10]Whoever believes in his Son accepts what *God* has told us; whoever doesn't, makes God a liar. [11]God has told us that eternal life lies in the Son. [12]Whoever has the Son has *that* life; whoever doesn't have him, doesn't have it. **1 Jn 5:6-12**

Confidence in Christ

[13]I've written these things to you that believe in God's Son in order to make you confident that you have eternal life. [14]This is the confidence we have with him: whatever we ask for according to his will he listens to. [15]If we know he <u>listens to</u> what we ask for, we know he <u>answers</u> what we ask for. **1 Jn 5:13-15**

[16]If you see a fellow believer doing some sin that doesn't lead to death, ask God and he'll give him life. There <u>is</u> a kind of sin that does lead to death; I'm not saying you should ask about that. [17]All unrighteousness is sin, but there are sins that don't lead to death. **1 Jn 5:16-17**

18People that God begets don't practice sinning; they keep themselves *from sinning*, and the evil one doesn't touch them. **19**We belong to God, and the world belongs to the evil one. **20**God's Son came so we could understand what's true. We're in the true One, *God's* Son Jesus Christ. He's true deity and eternal life. **21**Little children, stay away from idols. **1 Jn 5:18-21**

SECOND JOHN

Salutation

1The Elder to the elect lady and her children that[pl] I really love—as does everybody that knows the truth—**2**because of the truth that's in us and with us forever. **3**We'll have grace, mercy, and peace from God the Father and Jesus Christ[Messiah], the Son of the Father in truth and love. **2 Jn 1-3**

Remaining in Truth and Love

4I was so happy to find your[sg] children living in the truth the Father commanded us. **5**Now I urge you, lady—not as some new commandment but what we've had all along: love one another **6**and so be living his way. **7**Many deceivers have gone out who don't agree that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh. They're deceivers and antichrist. **8**Watch that you not lose what you've gained, but receive a full reward. **9**Anybody that goes out on his own and doesn't stay in Christ's teaching doesn't have God. The one that stays in *his* teaching has both the Father and the Son. **10**If a person doesn't bring that teaching, don't invite him into your house or greet him. **11**Whoever greets him shares in his evil work. **2 Jn 4-11**

Farewell

12I have lots to tell you[pl] but not in writing. I hope to speak to you in person to make your joy complete.

13The children of your elect sister say hello. **2 Jn 12-13**

THIRD JOHN

Salutation

[1]The Elder to Gaius, that I truly love.

[2]I pray that you'll be as prosperous and healthy in every way as you are in your soul. [3]I was so happy when the brothers reported that you really live by the truth. [4]Nothing makes me happier than hearing that my children are doing that. **3 Jn 1-4**

Cooperation and Opposition

[5]Friend[sg], you're acting faithfully in what you do for your fellow believers in Christ[Messiah], especially for the ones you don't know. [6]In front of the church, they've testified to your love. You do well to send them forward in a way worthy of God. [7]They went out for The Name, not taking anything from Gentiles. [8]We should support servants like them and so become their true fellow workers. **3 Jn 5-8**

[9]I wrote to the church, but Diotrephes, who loves to take charge among them, wouldn't receive us. [10]So if I come, I'll remind people how he slanders us, and—more than that—doesn't receive disciples, stops the ones that want to, and excommunicates them from the church. **3 Jn 9-10**

[11]Imitate good, not evil. Whoever does what's good belongs to God; whoever does what's evil hasn't seen him. [12]Demetrius receives good testimony from everybody, from the truth itself, and from us. You know you can rely on what we say. **3 Jn 11-12**

Farewell

[13]I've had so much I want to tell you[sg] but not in writing. [14]I hope to see you soon and speak to you in person. Peace to you. Your friends send their greetings. Greet your friends by name. **3 Jn 13-14**

JUDE

Salutation

[1]Jude, servant of Jesus Christ[Messiah] and brother of James, to the ones called by God the Father, loves and keeps you in Jesus Christ. [2]Mercy, peace, and love many times over.

Condemnation of False Teachers

[3]Friends, I'm anxious to write to you about the salvation we share. I need to encourage you to keep contending earnestly for the faith once and for all delivered to the saints. [4]Ungodly people have sneaked in under false pretenses; long ago they were assigned to that condemnation. They deny Jesus Christ as our only Master and Lord and try to pervert God's grace into lustful living.

[5]You know that once and for all, but I want to remind you that after the LORD saved a people out of Egypt, he destroyed the ones that didn't trust *him*. [6]Angels that didn't keep their place he has held under darkness in permanent bonds till the great judgment day. [7]Likewise, Sodom and Gomorrah and the cities around them lived immorally, going after other flesh. They serve as examples of being subjected to eternal punishment by fire. **Jude 1-7**

Describing Some False Teachers

[8]Yet in like manner such people even fantasize about defiling the flesh, rejecting authority, and railing at angels. [9]But when Michael the archangel was arguing with the devil about the body of Moses, he didn't bring railing condemnation; he said, *"The LORD reprimand you."* [10]People like them rail out about what they don't understand, about what they know by instinct like animals that can't reason—and therefore destroy themselves. [11]What consequences await them! They've followed Cain's way; they've plunged into Balaam's deception for money; they've perished in Korah's rebellion. [12]They're hidden pieces of gravel in your love-feast *food*; without qualms they carouse among *you*, shepherding themselves. They're clouds with no moisture, driven around by the wind. *They're* late autumn trees with no fruit, uprooted, and doubly dead. [13]*They're* wild waves of the sea, foaming up shameful acts. *They're* stars out of orbit that the gloom of darkness is reserved for. **Jude 8-13**

[14]Enoch, the seventh from Adam, prophesied about them, *"The LORD will come with 10,000 holy ones* [15]*to convict sinners of their ungodly deeds and terrible blasphemies against him."* [16]They grumble, complain, pursue lusts, talk arrogantly, flatter people for gain. **Jude 14-16**

Maintaining Faithfulness Despite Competition

[17]But dear friends, remember what the apostles of our Lord Jesus Christ [18]used to tell you, *"In the end mockers will come, chasing after ungodly lusts.* [19]*They'll be divisive, materialistic, unspiritual."* [20]But <u>you</u>, build yourselves up with your most holy faith and with

prayer in the Holy Spirit. [21]Keep yourselves in God's love and wait for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ, who brings eternal life. [22]Have mercy on some that doubt; [23]save some by snatching them out of the fire; have mercy on others cautiously, hating even their clothes stained by the flesh.

Jude 17-23

Benediction

[24]Now to him who can keep you from stumbling and stand you blameless in front of his glory with great joy, [25]to the only God our Savior through Jesus Christ our Lord *be* glory and majesty, dominion and authority before all time, now, and forever. Amen. **Jude 24-25**

THE REVELATION OF JOHN

Introduction

1:**1**The relevation God gave to Jesus Cjhrist[Messiah] to show his servants about what must happen soon. He sent *it* through his angel to his servant John, **2**who has passed on everything he saw about God's message and Jesus Christ's revelation. **3**Blessed *is* the one who reads and the ones that hear the prophecy[fem] and keep what's written in it[fem]. It's coming soon. **Rev 1:1-3**

Salutation

4John, to the seven churches in Asia. Grace and peace from him who is and was and is to come, from the seven spirits in front of his throne, **5-6**and from Jesus Christ, the faithful witness, firstborn from the dead, ruler over the kings of the world. Glory and dominion forevermore to him who loved us, released us from our sins with his blood, and made us into a kingdom of priests to his God and Father. Amen. **Rev 1:4-6**

7He'll come with the clouds;
everyone will see him,
including those who pierced him.
Every tribe on earth will mourn because of him.
Yes. Amen

8 *"I'm Alpha and Omega,"* the Lord God Almighty says, who is and was and is to come.
Rev 1:7-8

Vision of Christ

9I'm John, your[pl] brother, who shares your hardships, kingdom, and endurance in Jesus. I was exiled on the island Patmos for preaching God's message and for my testimony about Jesus. **10**I was in the spirit on the Lord's Day when I heard a loud voice behind me that sounded like a trumpet, **11** *"Write on a scroll what you see and send it to the seven churches in Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia, and Laodicea."*

12I turned around to see who was talking to me, and I saw seven gold lampstands. **13**Among them was One that looked like a man in a long robe with a wide gold sash across his chest. **14**His hair was white like wool, and his eyes flamed like fire. **15**His feet looked like refined, polished brass; and his voice sounded like crashing waves. **16**He held seven stars in his right hand and had a sharp double-edged sword coming out of his mouth. His face shined like the sun at its brightest. **Rev 1:9-16**

17When I saw him, I fell down like a dead man. He put his right hand on me,
"Don't be afraid. I'm the First and Last, **18***the Living One that died and came back to life forevermore. I have the keys to death and the grave.* **19***Write down what you've seen, what is and will be.* **20***The seven stars in my right hand are the evangelists for the seven churches; the lampstands are the churches."* **Rev 1:17-20**

The Letter to Ephesus

2:1 *"Write this to the evangelist for the church in Ephesus:*

'This is what he says who holds the seven stars in his right hand and walks among the seven gold lampstands: 2 *"I know what you're doing—your labor and endurance. I know you can't put up with sinful people. You've tested those who called themselves apostles and weren't, and found them false.* 3 *You've endured for me without wearing out.*

4 *But you've slacked off from the level of love you had at first.*

5 *So remember where you've come down from, repent, and do what you were doing at first. Otherwise, I'll come and take your lampstand away.* 6 *To your credit, like me, you hate what the Nicolaitans do.*

7 *Whoever has an ear, listen to what the Spirit's telling the churches. Those who are victorious I'll let eat from the tree of life in Paradise."'"* **Rev 2:1-7**

The Letter to Smyrna

8 *"Write this to the evangelist for the church in Smyrna:*

'This is what the First and Last says, who died and came back to life: 9 *"I know your hardship and poverty (but you're rich) and the slander of those who call themselves Jews but belong to Satan's synagogue.* 10 *Don't be afraid of what you're going to suffer. The devil will throw some of you in jail to test you. You'll have hardship for ten days.*

Be faithful till death, and I'll give you life as a crown.

11 *Whoever has an ear, listen to what the Spirit's telling the churches. Those who are victorious won't suffer the second death."'"* **Rev 2:8-11**

The Letter to Pergamum

12 *"Write this to the evangelist for the church in Pergamum:*

'This is what he says who has the sharp two-edged sword: 13 *"I know you live where Satan's throne is. You've held fast to me and haven't denied faith in me, even when Antipas my faithful witness was executed among you, where Satan lives.*

14 *But I do have some things against you. You have people that are following the teaching of Balaam, who showed Balak how to make the Israelites stumble—by eating things sacrificed to idols and doing immoral things.* 15 *You also have people that hold to what the Nicolaitans teach.*

16 *So repent; otherwise, I'll come quickly and fight them with the sword that's in my mouth.*

[17]*Whoever has an ear, listen to what the Spirit's telling the churches. Those who are victorious I'll supply with hidden manna and give them a white stone inscribed with a new name that nobody knows but him.""*" **Rev 2:12-17**

The Letter to Thyatira

[18]*"Write this to the evangelist for the church in Thyatira:*

'This is what the Son of God says, who has eyes like flames and feet like refined, polished brass: [19]*"I know what you're doing—your love, faith, service, and endurance, and that your last works are greater than the first.*

[20]*But, I have against you that you've allowed Jezebel, who calls herself a prophetess, to teach my servants to do immoral things and eat things offered to idols.* [21]*I gave her time to repent, but she didn't want to.* [22-23]*Unless they repent of her deeds, I'll throw them and her into a bed with a terminal plague. I'll certainly kill her offspring, and all the churches will know that I examine minds and hearts. I'll give to each according to what they've done.* [24]*The rest of you in Thyatira—who don't have that teaching, who don't know 'the deep things of Satan,' as they call them—I won't burden with anything else.* [25]*Just hold on to what you have till I come.*

[26]*Those who are victorious and keep my deeds to the end, I'll give authority over the nations.* [27]*He'll shepherd them with an iron rod and shatter them like clay pots.* [28]*As I received from my Father, I'll give them the morning star.*

[29]*Whoever has an ear, listen to what the Spirit's telling the churches.""*"

Rev 2:18-29

The Letter to Sardis

3[:1]*"Write this to the evangelist for the church in Sardis:*

'This is what he says who has the seven spirits of God and the seven stars: "I know what you're doing, that you're alive in name only. [2]*Wake up and strengthen what's left that's about to die. I haven't found your deeds perfect in front of my God.* [3]*So remember what you've received, keep it, and repent. If you don't wake up, I'll come like a thief at night when you don't expect it.* [4]*You have a few in Sardis that haven't gotten their clothes dirty. They'll live with me in white because they're worthy.*

[5]*Those who are victorious I'll dress in white clothes, I won't remove from the Book of Life, and I'll acknowledge in front of my Father and his angels.*

[6]*Whoever has an ear, listen to what the Spirit's telling the churches.""*"

Rev 3:1-6

The Letter to Philadelphia

[7] *"Write this to the evangelist for the church in Philadelphia:*
'These things the Holy and True says,
who has the key of David,
who opens and nobody shuts,
who shuts and nobody opens,
[8] *"I know what you're doing. I've opened a door for you that nobody can shut. Because you have a little strength, you've kept my word and haven't denied me.* [9] *The ones that claim to be Jews but belong to Satan's synagogue, I'll make bow down to you and recognize that I love you.* [10] *Because you've kept my word and persevered, I'll protect you from the testing that's coming on the world.* [11] *I'm coming soon; hold onto what you have so nobody takes your crown.*
[12] *Those who are victorious I'll make pillars in the Temple of my God, and they'll never leave it. I'll write my new name on them, the name of my God, and the name of his city, the New Jerusalem that's coming down out of heaven from him.*
[13] *Whoever has an ear, listen to what the Spirit's telling the churches.'"*

Rev 3:7-13

The Letter to Laodicea

[14] *"Write this to the evangelist for the church in Laodicea:*
'This is what the faithful and true witness says, the ruler of God's creation: [15] *"I know what you're doing—that you're not hot or cold. I'd rather you were one or the other.* [16] *Since you're lukewarm, I'll spew you out of my mouth.* [17] *You say, 'I'm rich; I've made money and don't need anything.' You don't realize that you're miserable, pitiful, poor, blind, and naked.* [18] *I advise you to buy gold from me refined by fire so you'll be rich, white clothes to cover your nakedness, and eye salve so you can see.* [19] *I reprove and discipline the ones I care about; so be earnest and repent.* [20] *I'm knocking at the door. If anybody hears me and opens it, I'll come in and we'll eat together.*
[21] *"Those who are victorious will sit with me on my throne like I overcame and sat with my Father on his throne.*
[22] *"Whoever has an ear, listen to what the Spirit's telling the churches."'"*

Rev 3:14-22

The Throne Room in Heaven

4:[1]After that, I saw a door standing open in heaven. The first voice I heard sounded like a trumpet, *"Come up here, and I'll show you what needs to happen."* [2]Right away I was in the spirit and saw a throne in heaven and One sitting on it [3]that looked like jasper and cardelian with an emerald rainbow arching over the throne. [4]Around the throne, 24 elders were sitting on 24 thrones, dressed in white and wearing gold crowns. [5]Lightning flashes and loud peals of thunder

came out of the throne. In front of the throne, seven braziers were burning that were the seven spirits of God. [6]What looked like a clear crystal sea lay in front of the throne.

Close around the throne were four living beings with eyes all over them. [7]The first looked like a lion, the second like a calf; the third had a man's face, and the fourth looked like a flying eagle. [8]The four living beings, each with six wings and eyes all over, kept saying day and night,

"Holy, holy, holy,
LORD God Almighty,
who was and is and is to come."

[9]When the four living beings gave glory, honor, and thanks to the One on the throne, who lives forevermore, [10]the 24 elders knelt to worship him and cast their crowns in front of the throne, saying,

[11] *"Our LORD and God, you deserve*
glory, honor, and power
because you created everything;
by your will they came into being." **Rev 4:1-11**

The Scroll with the 7 Seals

5:[1]I saw a scroll in the right hand of the One on the throne. It had writing inside and out, and seven seals on it. [2]A strong angel shouted, *"Who's worthy to break the seven seals and unroll the scroll?"* [3]Nobody in heaven, on earth, or under the earth could unroll it—or *even* look at it. [4]I started to cry because nobody could unroll it. [5]One of the elders said, *"Don't cry. The Lion from the tribe of Judah, David's descendant, has overcome* death. He *can break the seven seals and unroll it."* **Rev 5:1-5**

Worshipping the Lamb

[6]Among the throne, elders, and four living beings, I saw a Lamb standing as if it had been slain. It had seven horns and seven eyes, which are the seven spirits God sent into the whole world. [7]He came and took the scroll from the One on the throne. [8]Then the four living beings and 24 elders knelt in front of the Lamb. Each one had a harp and a gold bowl of incense, which is the saints' prayers. [9]They sang a new song,

"You're worthy to take the scroll and break its seals
because you were killed.
With your blood you purchased for God
people out of every tribe, language, people group, and nation.
[10]*You made them into a kingdom of priests for our God,*
and they'll rule on earth." **Rev 5:6-10**

[11]I saw countless thousands of angels around the throne, created beings, and elders, shouting,

[12] *"The Lamb that was killed deserves*
to receive authority, wealth, wisdom,
strength, honor, glory, and blessing!"
[13]Everyone created in heaven, on earth, under the earth, and on the sea said,
"To the One on the throne and to the Lamb,
blessing, honor, glory, and power forevermore."
[14]The four living beings said, *"Amen,"* and the elders knelt down in worship. **Rev 5:11-14**

Breaking the First 6 Seals

6:[1]When I saw the Lamb break the first seal, I heard one living being say like thunder, *"Come."* [2]A white horse *came out*; its rider had a bow. He received a crown and went out to conquer.

[3]When *the Lamb* broke the second seal, the second living being said, *"Come."* [4]A fiery red horse came out. Its rider was allowed to take peace away from the earth so people would kill each other. He received a large sword. **Rev 6:1-4**

[5]When *the Lamb* broke the third seal, the third living being said, *"Come."* A black horse *came out*. Its rider was holding a balance scales. [6]I heard a voice from among the four living beings, *"A quart of wheat for a day's pay; three quarts of barley for a day's pay. Use oil and wine sparingly."*

[7]When *the Lamb* broke the fourth seal, the fourth living being said, *"Come."* [8]A pale green horse *came out*. Its rider was named Death; Grave followed him. They received control over a fourth of the earth to kill by sword, famine, death, and wild animals. **Rev 6:5-8**

[9]When *the Lamb* broke the fifth seal, under the altar I saw the souls of people that had been martyred for the message of God that they had. [10]They cried out, *"How long, Master, holy and true, before you avenge our blood on the people living on earth?"* [11]He gave each one a white robe and told them to rest a little longer till their fellow martyrs fulfill their course.
Rev 6:9-11

[12]When I saw *the Lamb* break the sixth seal, there was a major earthquake. The sun got as dark as burlap made of hair, and the whole moon looked like blood. [13]Stars fell to earth like unripe figs in a strong wind. [14]The sky separated like a scroll being unrolled, and every mountain and island quaked. [15]The kings on earth, the elite, the commanders of 1,000 *[chiliarchs]*, the rich, the powerful, servants and freemen hid in caves and mountain rocks. [16]They said to the mountains and rocks, *"Bring an avalanche over us and hide us from the One on the throne and from the anger of the Lamb.* [17]*The time for their great fury has come. Who can survive it?"*
Rev 6:12-17

Sealing the 144,000

7:[1]After that, I saw four angels standing at the four corners of the world. They were keeping the four winds from blowing on the land, sea, and trees. [2]I watched another angel come

down from the east with the seal of the living God. He shouted to the four angels that could harm the land and sea, [3] *"Don't harm the land, sea, or trees till we seal our God's servants on their foreheads!"* [4]I heard the number that were sealed: 144,000—from every tribe of Israel; 12,000 each [5]from Judah, Reuben, Gad, [6]Asher, Naphtali, Manasseh, [7]Simeon, Levi, Issachar, [8]Zebulun, Joseph, and Benjamin. **Rev 7:1-8**

The Great Host in White Robes

[9]After that, I saw a tremendous host nobody could count, from every nation, tribe, people group, and language, standing in front of the throne and the Lamb. They were wearing white robes and holding palm branches. [10]They shouted,

"Salvation to our God who sits on the throne,
and to the Lamb!"

[11]All the angels around the throne, the elders, and the living beings fell on their faces in front of the throne and worshiped God,

[12] *"Amen. Blessing, glory, wisdom,*
thanks, honor, power, and strength
to our God forevermore. Amen." **Rev 7:9-12**

[13]One of the elders asked me, *"Who are the ones in white robes? Where'd they come from?"*

[14]I said, *"Sir, you know."*

He said, *"They came through the great ordeal and washed their robes to make them white in the blood of the Lamb.*

[15] *"That's why they're in front of God's throne,*
and worship him day and night in his sanctuary.
The One on the throne will spread his tabernacle over them.
[16] *"They won't get hungry or thirsty anymore;*
the sun won't beat down on them with scorching heat anymore.
[17] *"The Lamb at the throne will shepherd them*
and guide them to springs of running water.
God will wipe every tear out of their eyes." **Rev 7:13-17**

Breaking the Seventh Seal

8:[1]When *the Lamb* broke the seventh seal, heaven was silent for about a half hour. [2]I saw seven angels standing in front of God, receiving seven trumpets.

[3]Another angel came and stood by the altar, holding a gold censer. He received a large amount incense to add to the prayers of the saints on the gold altar in front of the throne. [4]The smoke from the incense rose up from the angel's hand with the saints' prayers. [5]The angel filled

the censer with fire from the altar and threw it onto the earth. There came peals of thunder, lightning flashes, and an earthquake. **Rev 8:1-5**

Blowing the 7 Trumpets

[6]The seven angels with the seven trumpets raised them to blow.

[7]The first blew his trumpet. Hail and fire mixed with blood were thrown onto the earth. A third of the earth, a third of the trees, and all the green grass burned up.

[8]The second angel blew his trumpet. Something like a burning mountain was thrown into the ocean and turned a third of it to blood, [9]killed a third of marine life, and destroyed a third of the ships *that were on it*. **Rev 8:6-9**

[10]The third angel blew his trumpet. A big star, burning like a torch, fell on a third of the springs and rivers. [11]It's name was Wormwood. A third of the water turned bitter, and many people died from the brackish water. **Rev 8:10-11**

[12]The fourth angel blew his trumpet. A third of the sun, moon, and stars was struck. A third of the stars went out; the sun didn't shine for a third of the day, and the moon didn't shine for a third of the night.

[13]I saw and heard an eagle flying in the sky, shouting, *"Woe, woe, woe to people on earth because of the last three trumpet blasts!"* **Rev 8:12-13**

The Fifth Trumpet/The First Woe

9:[1]The fifth angel blew his trumpet. I saw a star that had just fallen* to earth. He received a key to the deep abyss. [2]He opened it, and a cloud of smoke came out of *it* as from a huge furnace, and the sun and air grew dark from it. [3]Locusts swarmed out of the cloud onto the earth with ability like scorpions have. [4]They were told not to harm the grass, anything green, any tree—just people that didn't have God's seal on their foreheads. [5]They weren't to kill them, but to torment them for five months as with scorpion stings. [6]The people would want to die but couldn't; they'd long for death, but it would elude them. **Rev 9:1-6**

[7]The locusts looked like horses outfitted for war. They wore what looked like gold helmets* *[chanfrons + crinets?]* on their heads. They had faces like people, [8]manes like women's hair, teeth like lions' teeth, [9]and iron chest plates* *[peytrals]*. Their wings sounded like hordes of horses with chariots charging into battle. [10]Their tails had stingers like scorpions that they could torment people with for five months. [11]Their king, the angel of the abyss, had the Hebrew name Abaddon—*Apollyon* [Destroyer]* in Greek.

[12]The first woe is over; two more are coming. **Rev 9:7-12**

The Sixth Trumpet/The Second Woe

[13]The sixth angel blew his trumpet. I heard a voice from the four horns of the gold altar in front of God, [14]telling the sixth angel to release the four angels on hold at the great River Euphrates. [15]He released the four angels—readied for an hour, day, month, and year—to massacre a third of all people. [16]The army of horsemen numbered 200,000,000 (I heard the number). [17]The horses and their riders in the vision looked like this: the riders wore breastplates the color of fire, hyacinth, and sulfur; the horses had heads like lions with fire, smoke, and sulfur coming out of their mouths. [18]The fire, smoke, and sulfur killed a third of all people. [19]The horses' power was in their mouths and tails; their tails were like snakes with heads that could injure people.

[20]People that didn't die from these plagues refused to stop worshiping demons and turn away from the idols their hands had made out of gold, silver, brass, stone, and wood—that can't see, hear, or walk. [21]They didn't repent of their murders, witchcraft, sexual immorality, or thefts.

Rev 9:13-21

The Little Open Scroll

10[:1]I watched another powerful angel come down from the sky, dressed in a cloud with a rainbow above his head. His face shined like the sun, and his legs were like pillars of fire. [2]He was holding a little, open scroll in his right hand. With his right foot on the sea and his left one on land, [3]he shouted like a roaring lion. When he shouted, seven thunders pealed. [4]When they did, I was about to write, but a voice from the sky said, *"Seal up what the seven thunders said; don't write it down."* [5]The angel that was standing on land and sea, lifted his right hand toward the sky [6]and swore by the One who lives forevermore—who created earth, sky, sea, and everything in them—that there wouldn't be any more delay. [7]When it's time for the seventh angel to blow his trumpet, God's unrevealed plan will come to completion like he'd told his servants the prophets. **Rev 10:1-7**

[8]The voice from the sky spoke to me again, *"Go take the little, open scroll that's in the hand of the angel that's standing on land and sea."* [9]I went and asked him for it. He said, *"Eat it; it'll make your stomach sour, but it'll leave a sweet taste in your mouth."* [10]I took it and ate it. It tasted sweet like honey; but when I swallowed it, it made my stomach sour. [11]They told me, *"You have to prophesy some more to many people groups, nations, languages, and kings."*

Rev 10:8-11

The Two Witnesses

11[:1]I received a measuring rod like a staff. *"Measure God's sanctuary, the altar, and the worshipers.* [2]*Don't measure the court outside the sanctuary because the Gentiles have received it, and they'll trample the Holy City underfoot for 42 months.* [3]*I'll authorize my two witnesses to prophecy for* those *1260 days in burlap and ashes."* [4]They're two olive trees, two lampstands in front of the Lord of the earth. [5]If anybody tries to injure them, fire will come out of their mouths and burn them up. [6]During the time they prophesy, they'll have authority to keep it from raining,

to turn water into blood, to strike the earth with any plague as often as they like. [7]When they've finished speaking *for God*, the beast from the abyss will attack them, conquer, and kill them. [8]Their corpses will lie in the street of the great city spiritually called Sodom and Egypt, where their Lord also was crucified. [9]People from tribes, languages, and nations will look at their corpses for 3½ days and won't let them be buried. [10]They'll celebrate and send gifts to each other because those two prophets had tormented them. [11]After 3½ days, breath from God will return, and they'll stand up and terrify everyone that sees them. [12]I heard a loud voice from heaven tell them, *"Come up here"*; and they went up in a cloud while their enemies watched. [13]Then a severe earthquake made a tenth of the city fall; 7,000 people died in the earthquake. Fear overwhelmed the rest, and they praised the God of heaven.

[14]The second woe is over. The third's coming soon. **Rev 11:1-14**

The Seventh Trumpet/The Third Woe

[15]The seventh angel blew his trumpet, and loud voices from heaven said,

"*The kingdom of this world has become*
the kingdom *of our LORD and his Christ*[Messiah],
and he'll reign forevermore."

[16]The 24 elders on their thrones in front of God fell on their faces and worshiped him,

[17] *"Thank you, LORD God Almighty, who is and was,*
because you've assumed power and begun to reign.
[18]*The nations raged, and your anger came.*
The time came for judging the dead,
the time for rewarding your servants the prophets and saints—
those who respect you from least to greatest;
the time for destroying those who destroy the world."

[19]God's sanctuary in heaven opened, and the Ark of the Covenant became visible there. There came lightning flashes, peals of thunder, an earthquake, and a severe hailstorm. **Rev 11:14-19**

The Woman and the Red Dragon

12:[1]An important sign appeared in the sky, a woman dressed in the sun with the moon under her feet and twelve crowns on her head. [2]She was pregnant and cried out in labor, straining to give birth. [3]Another sign appeared in the sky, a big red dragon with seven heads, ten horns, and seven diadems on its heads. [4]Its tail dragged down a third of the stars and threw them onto earth. It stood in front of the woman, *ready* to devour her child. [5]She had a Son that would rule the nations with an iron rod. He was snatched up to God and his throne, and [6]the woman ran into the desert. God had prepared a place there for people to sustain her 1260 days. **Rev 12:1-6**

[7]War broke out in heaven, Michael and his angels battling the dragon and his angels. [8]The dragon wasn't powerful enough, and he and his angels no longer had a place in heaven. [9]The great dragon was thrown out, the old serpent, the devil, Satan, the deceiver of the whole world. He and his angels were thrown down to earth. [10]I heard a loud voice in heaven,

"Now salvation and power has come,
the kingdom of our God,
the authority of his Christ[Messiah]*,*
because our brothers' accuser has been thrown out
who accused them in front of our God day and night.
[11]*They triumphed over* their accuser
by the blood of the Lamb and by his message;
they didn't love their life so much that they shrank from death.
[12]*So celebrate, heaven, and you that tabernacle there.*
Woe to land and sea
because the devil has come down to you furious;
he knows he doesn't have much time left." **Rev 12:7-12**

[13]When the dragon saw he'd been thrown down to earth, he persecuted the woman that had given birth to the male *child*. [14]She received the two wings of a giant eagle so she could fly into the wilderness away from the dragon and be sustained for 3½ times. [15]The dragon spewed a river out of its mouth to sweep the woman away in a flood, [16]but the earth helped her and opened its mouth and drank up the river. [17]The dragon raged over the woman and went away to fight her other offspring that keep God's commands and have the message about Jesus. **Rev 12:13-17**

The Beast from the Sea

13:[1]The dragon stood on the sand on the seashore. I watched as a beast came up out of the sea. It had ten horns, seven heads, ten diadems, and blasphemous names on its heads. [2]It looked like a leopard with bear's feet and a lion's mouth. The dragon gave it power, dominion, and great authority. [3]One of its heads looked like it had been mortally wounded and its mortal wound had healed. The whole earth marveled at the beast [4]and worshiped the dragon that gave it authority. They also worshiped the beast, *"Who's like it? Who can wage war with it?"* **Rev 13:1-4**

[5]The beast was allowed to speak great blasphemous things and have authority *to do it* for 42 months. [6]It blasphemed God, his tabernacle, and those who live in heaven. [7]It was allowed to fight the saints and defeat them, and to control every tribe, people group, language, and nation. [8]People worshiped it whose names weren't in the Lamb's Book of Life, *the Lamb* that was slain from the founding of the world.

[9]Whoever has an ear, listen:

[10]snyone that's *destined* for captivity

will go into captivity;
anyone that murders with a sword
will be killed with a sword.
That's why the saints stay confident. **Rev 13:5-10**

The Beast from the Land

11 I watched another beast come up out of the land. It had two horns like a lamb and
talked like a dragon. 12 It exercised all the authority the first beast had, and made people worship
the first beast, whose fatal wound had healed. 13 It performed great signs, even making fire come
down from the sky. 14 It deceived people with the signs it was allowed to do in front of the *first*
beast. It told them to make an image to the beast that had the sword wound and came back to life.
15 It was allowed to make the image of the *first* beast breathe so it could even speak, and it was
allowed to execute people that refused to worship the image. 16 It made everybody—great or
small, rich or poor, servant or free—receive a stamp on the forehead or right hand. 17 They
couldn't buy or sell without the stamp of the beast or the number of its name. 18 Here's a hint for
a discerning person to calculate its number. It's the number in use among people: 666.

Rev 13:11-18

The Lamb on Mt. Zion

14:1 I saw the Lamb standing on Mt. Zion with the 144,000 that had his and his Father's
name written on their foreheads. 2 I heard a noise from heaven like crashing waves and loud
thunder—like harpists playing harps. 3 They sang a new song in front of the throne, the four
living beings, and the elders. Nobody could learn the song except the 144,000 that had been
purchased out of the earth. 4 They hadn't defiled themselves with women; they were virgins, who
followed the Lamb wherever he went. They'd been purchased from among people as firstfruits to
God and the Lamb. 5 They'd never lied; they were blameless. **Rev 14:1-5**

The Messages from Three Angels

6 I saw another angel flying in the sky who had the everlasting good news to present to
every nation, tribe, language, and people group. 7 He shouted, *"Fear God and honor him! His
time for judging has come. Worship the One that made sky, earth, sea, and springs."*

8 A second angel followed, *"Fallen, fallen, 'Babylon' the Great that made the nations
drink the wine of her immoral passion."*

9 A third angel followed them, shouting, *"Those who have worshiped the beast and its
image and received a stamp on their forehead or right hand,* 10 *will drink the wine of God's
displeasure full strength. They'll be tormented with fire and sulfur in front of the holy angels and
the Lamb. The smoke from their torment will go up forevermore.* 11 *There'll be no rest day or
night for those who've worshiped the beast and its image and received the stamp of its name.*
12 *That's why the saints stay confident in Christ."*

[13]I heard a voice from the sky, *"Write* this*, 'People that die in the Lord from now on are fortunate.' 'Yes,'* the Spirit says, *'so they can rest from their labors, because* the account of *their deeds stays on their record.'"* **Rev 14:6-13**

Harvesting the Earth

[14]I saw what looked like a man sitting on a white cloud. He had a gold crown on his head and a sharp scythe in his hand. [15]Another angel came out of the sanctuary in heaven and called out to him, *"Use your scythe to reap; it's time to harvest; earth's harvest is ready."* [16]The one on the cloud swung his scythe over the earth and harvested it.

[17]Another angel came out of the sanctuary, holding a sharp hook-blade. [18]Another angel came out of the altar with authority over fire and shouted to the one with the hook-blade, *"Use your blade to gather the clusters from the vine (the world); the grapes are ripe."* [19]The angel used it to harvest the vine, and he put the grapes in the large winepress of God's anger. [20]The wine was pressed out outside the city, and the blood from the winepress came up to the horses' bridles for some 180 miles. **Rev 14:14-20**

The 7 Last Plagues

15:[1]I saw another great, amazing sign: seven angels that had the seven last plagues. With them God will finish his anger.

[2]I saw what looked like a glass sea mixed with fire. Those who were victorious over the beast, its image, and the number of its name, stood on the glass sea, holding harps God gave them [3]and singing the Song of Moses, God's servant, and the Song of the Lamb:

"Your works are great and amazing,
LORD God Almighty.
Your ways are just and true,
King of the nations.
[4]*Who won't respect you*
and praise you?
Only you are holy;
all nations will come and worship before you
because your judgments have been revealed." **Rev 15:1-4**

[5]After that, I saw in heaven the open sanctuary in the tabernacle of testimony. [6]Seven angels with the seven last plagues came out of the sanctuary dressed in clean, bright linen with gold sashes across their chests. [7]One of the four living beings gave the seven angels gold bowls full of the eternal God's anger. [8]Smoke from God's glory and power filled the sanctuary. Nobody could go into it till the seven plagues were over. **Rev 15:5-8**

Pouring Out the 7 Angels' Bowls

16:[1]I heard a loud voice from the sanctuary, telling the seven angels, *"Pour out the seven bowls of God's anger on the earth."*

[2]The first poured out his bowl on the land. A foul, painful boil festered up on the ones that had the stamp of the beast and worshiped its image.

[3]The second poured out his bowl on the ocean. It became like dead men's blood. Everything in the ocean died. **Rev 16:1-3**

[4]The third poured out his bowl on rivers and springs. They became blood. [5]I heard that angel say,

"You're just, Holy One, who are and were,
for decreeing those judgments.
[6]*Because they poured out the blood of saints and prophets,*
you've given them blood to drink.
That's what they deserve!"

[7]I heard the altar say,

"Yes, LORD God Almighty;
your judgments are true and just." **Rev 16:4-7**

[8]The fourth angel poured out his bowl on the sun, and it scorched people [9]with searing heat. They blasphemed God, who authorized those plagues; and they didn't repent or praise him.

[10]The fifth angel poured out his bowl on the throne of the beast. Its kingdom grew dark, and people gnawed their tongues in agony. [11]They blasphemed God in their agony and sores, but they didn't repent. **Rev 16:8-11**

[12]The sixth angel poured out his bowl on the big Euphrates River. It dried up so the kings in the East could cross it. [13]I saw three unclean spirits *leap* like frogs out of the mouths of the dragon, beast, and false prophet. [14]They were demons that performed signs, and they went to gather the kings of the world for war at the great day of God Almighty. [15]*"I'm coming like a thief at night. Blessed are those who stay awake and dressed so they won't be walking around naked, and people see their shame."* [16]He gathered them to a place called in Hebrew The Mound of Megiddo *[Harmagedon]**. **Rev 16:12-16**

[17]The seventh *angel* poured out his bowl on the air. A voice shouted out of the sanctuary from the throne, *"It's finished!"* [18]There came lightning flashes, peals of thunder, and the most severe earthquake in history. [19]The great city *'Babylon'* split into three parts, and the cities in the nations crumbled. God remembered to give 'Babylon' the Great his wine cup of fierce fury. [20]The islands sank, and the mountains collapsed. [21]Enormous hailstones, weighing over 90 pounds, fell on people. They blasphemed God because the hailstone plague was so severe.

Rev 16:17-21

17:[1]One of the seven angels with the seven bowls came over to me,

"Come here; I'll show you the condemnation of the great prostitute that sits on a vast expanse of water. [2]*Kings committed immoral acts with her, and people got drunk on the wine of her immorality."*

[3]He took me in spirit to a desert place, and I saw a woman on a red beast covered with blasphemous names and having seven heads and ten horns. [4]She wore purple and scarlet with precious stones and pearls, and held a gold cup full of detestable, unclean things related to her immorality. [5]On her headband was the mysterious name, *"'Babylon' the Great, Mother of Prostitutes and Detestable Things."* **Rev 17:1-5**

[6]She was drunk from the blood of saints, martyrs for Jesus. I was amazed. [7]The angel said,

"Why be amazed? I'll explain to you the meaning of the woman and the beast she's riding. [8]*The beast was, is not, and will come up from the abyss to* its *eternal destruction. People will marvel when they see it—people whose names haven't been in the Book of Life from the founding of the world.* [9]*Here's the explanation. The seven heads represent seven hills the woman sits on. There are seven kings:* [10]*five fallen, one existing, and the other yet to come. When he comes, he has to stay a little while.* [11]*The beast that was and is not, is an eighth, is like the seven, and is destined for destruction.* [12]*The ten horns are ten kings that haven't received a kingdom yet, but they'll receive authority like kings for a short time with the beast.* [13]*They have a joint purpose and give their power and authority to the beast.* [14]*They'll battle the Lamb, and the Lamb will conquer them because he's Lord of lords and King of kings. The ones on his side are called, chosen, and faithful.* **Rev 17:6-14**

[15]*"The water where the woman is sitting represents masses of people, nations, and languages.* [16]*The ten horns and the beast will hate the harlot, strip her bare, eat her flesh, and burn her up.* [17]*That's because God has put it in their minds to accomplish his purpose by making common cause and giving their kingdom to the beast till God's words come to fulfillment.* [18]*The woman is the great city that rules the kings on earth."* **Rev 17:15-18**

18:[1]After that, I watched a different angel come down from the sky with great authority, and his glory lit up the world. [2]He shouted,

"Fallen, fallen, 'Babylon' the Great!
She's become a place where demons live,
a haunt for unclean spirits and filthy birds.
[3]*All the nations have gotten drunk on the wine of her immoral fury.*

Kings have committed immoral acts with her;
merchants have gotten rich from her sensual luxuries." **Rev 18:1-3**

4I heard another voice from the sky,
"Get out of her, my people;
don't take part in her sins
so you can avoid her plagues.
5*Her sins have piled up to the sky;*
God has remembered her unjust acts.
6*Pay her back like she paid;*
give her full payback for what she's done;
mix double to her the cup she mixed.
7*As much as she glorified herself and lived sensuously,*
give her torment and mourning.
Because she said to herself,
'I sit like a queen;
I'll never mourn,'
8*her plagues will all come at the same time:*
mourning, famine, and death.
She'll be burned up
because the LORD God that condemns her has the power." **Rev 18:4-8**

9The kings that committed immoral acts and lived sensuously with her will cry and mourn when they see the smoke from her burning. **10**They'll stand a long way off in fear of her torment,
"Woe, woe, the great city;
'Babylon' the powerful city,
all at once its condemnation has come." **Rev 18:9-10**

11The merchants will cry and mourn over it because nobody's buying their merchandise anymore: **12**gold, silver, precious stones, pearls; fine linen, purple, silk, red; different kinds of scented wood, articles made out of ivory and expensive wood, bronze, iron, marble; **13**cinnamon, spice, incense, perfume, frankincense; wine, olive oil, fine wheat flour, wheat; cattle, sheep, horses, four-wheeled chariots, slaves (human lives).
14 *"The fruit you craved has left you;*
everything luxurious and splendid
has perished from you;
people won't find them anymore." **Rev 18:11-14**

15Merchants who got rich from those things will stand a long way off, crying and mourning, in fear of her torment.
16 *"Woe, woe, the great city,*

clothed in fine linen, purple, and red;
adorned with gold, precious stones, and pearls!
17*In a moment such wealth has disappeared!"*

Shipmasters and sailors, who make their living on the sea, will stand a long way off **18**and cry as they watch the smoke from her burning. *"What other city is like this great city?"*

Rev 18:15-18

19They'll throw dust on their heads, shout, cry, and weep,
"Woe, woe, to the great city
where those with ships got rich from its wealth,
because all at once it's been laid waste!"
20*Rejoice over it, heaven, saints, apostles, and prophets;*
because God has decreed against it
the condemnation it decreed against you." **Rev 18:19-20**

21A strong angel picked up a stone the size of a large millstone and threw it into the sea,
"That's how 'Babylon,' the great city,
will be violently overthrown,
and won't be there anymore.
22*The sound of harpists, musicians, flutists, and trumpeters*
won't be heard in it anymore;
no craftsman of any craft will be found in it anymore;
the sound of a mill won't be heard in it anymore;
23*the light of a lamp won't shine in it anymore;*
the voice of the bride and groom won't be heard in it anymore,
because its merchants were the greatest on earth,
because it deceived the nations with its sorceries,
24*and because the blood of prophets and saints was found in it*
and all those murdered on earth." **Rev 18:21-24**

19:1 After that, I heard what sounded like a great crowd in heaven,
"Hallelujah!
Salvation, glory, and power to our God
2*because his judgments are true and just;*
he's judged the great prostitute
that corrupted the earth with her immorality;
he's avenged the murder of his servants at her hand." **Rev 19:1-2**

3A second time they shouted,
"Hallelujah!"
and her smoke rose up forevermore. **4**The 24 elders and the 4 living beings knelt down and worshiped God Almighty, who sits on the throne,

"Amen! Hallelujah!"

5A voice came from the throne,

"Praise our God, all his servants,

everybody that fears him from least to greatest."

6I heard a great crowd like crashing waves and loud thunder,

"Hallelujah!

the LORD God Almighty has taken up his reign.

7*Let's rejoice, be happy, and give him glory,*

because the marriage of the Lamb has come,

and his bride has gotten herself ready."

8She was allowed to dress in bright clean linen, the righteous acts of the saints. **Rev 19:3-8**

9The angel said to me, *"Write* this down*: 'People are fortunate who are invited to the marriage feast of the Lamb. That is God's true message.'"* 10I fell down in front of him in worship him, but he said, *"Don't do that. I'm a fellow servant with you and your brothers that have the message about Jesus. Worship God. The message about Jesus is the purpose of prophecy."*

11I watched heaven open up. There was a white horse with a Rider called Faithful and True. He judged rightly and waged war justly. 12His eyes were like flames; he wore several diadems and had a name that nobody understood but him. 13He wore a robe soaked in blood; his name was The Word of God. 14The armies in heaven, wearing clean white linen, followed him on white horses. 15From his mouth came a sharp sword for striking the nations. He shepherded them with an iron rod and trod the winepress of the fierce anger of God Almighty. 16On the thigh of his robe, it said *King of kings, Lord of lords.* **Rev 19:9-16**

17I saw an angel standing in the sun. He shouted to the vultures in the sky, *"Flock to God's great feast!* 18*Eat the flesh of kings, commanders [chiliarchs]*, powerful men, horses, and riders!"* 19I watched the beast, the kings of the earth, and their armies gather to battle the Rider on the horse and his armies. 20He and his forces captured the beast and the false prophet that performed signs in front of it, *signs* it used to deceive people that had the stamp of the beast and worshiped its image. They threw them both alive into the burning sulfur lake. 21The Rider on the horse killed the rest with the sword from his mouth, and the vultures gorged on their flesh. **Rev 19:17-21**

The Millennium

20:1I watched an angel come down from heaven with the key to the abyss and a big chain in his hand. 2He seized the dragon—the old serpent, the devil, Satan—bound him for 1,000 years, 3and threw him into the abyss. He locked it and sealed it over him so he couldn't deceive the nations till the 1,000 years were over. Afterward he'll need to be released for a little while. **Rev 20:1-3**

[4]I saw thrones, and the people that sat on them received the authority to judge. I saw the souls of the people beheaded for *bearing* the message about Jesus and the word of God, *people* that hadn't worshiped the beast or its image and hadn't received the stamp on their forehead or hand. They'll live and reign with Christ 1,000 years. [5]The rest of the dead didn't live again till the 1,000 years ended. That's the first resurrection. [6]People that take part in the first resurrection are blessed and holy; the second death won't have any power over them. They'll be priests for God and Christ, and reign with him 1,000 years. **Rev 20:4-6**

Satan Unleashed and Conquered

[7]When the 1,000 years end, Satan will be released from his prison. [8]He'll go out to deceive the nations, Gog and Magog, to gather them for battle. Their number will be like the sand on the seashore. [9]They'll come up on the plain of the earth and surround the camp of the saints and the dearly loved city; fire will come from the sky and consume them. [10]The devil will be thrown into the burning lake of sulfur, where the beast and false prophet have been. They'll be tormented day and night forevermore. **Rev 20:7-10**

The Great White-Throne Judgment

[11]I saw a large white throne and the One that was sitting on it. Earth and sky fled from him; they were no longer there. [12]I saw the dead, from least to greatest, standing in front of the throne, and the books were opened. Another book was opened, *the Book* of Life; and the dead were judged by their deeds written in the books. [13]The sea, death, and the grave gave up their dead. [14]Death and the grave were thrown into the burning lake, which is the second death. [15]Anybody that wasn't in the Book of Life was thrown into the burning lake. **Rev 20:11-15**

The New Earth and Sky

21:[1]I saw a new earth and sky. The first earth and sky had passed away, and there wasn't any ocean anymore. [2]I watched the Holy City, the New Jerusalem, come down out of heaven from God, ready like a bride adorned for her husband. [3]A loud voice came from the throne,

> *"God's tabernacle is with his people; he'll live with them, and they'll belong to him. [4]He'll wipe away every tear, and there won't be any pain, weeping, crying, or death anymore. Former things will pass away."* **Rev 21:1-4**

[5]The One on the throne said,

> *"I'm making everything new. [6]Write this down because it's true and reliable. It's done. I'm Alpha and Omega, the beginning and end. I'll let whoever's thirsty drink from the spring of living water free of charge. [7]Those who overcome will inherit these things. I'll be their God, and they'll be my children. [8]But the unfaithful and corrupt, the cowards, murderers, sorcerers, idolaters,*

liars, and immoral will burn in the lake of sulfur, which is the second death."
Rev 21:5-8

The New Jerusalem

[9]One of the angels with the seven bowls of final plagues came to me, *"Come with me; I'll show you the Lamb's bride."* [10]He took me in spirit to a big, tall mountain and showed me the Holy City, Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, [11]shining with God's glory. Its brilliance was like a very valuable stone, like crystal-clear jasper.

[12]It had a broad, high wall and twelve gates, with an angel at each gate and the names of Israel's twelve tribes inscribed on them. [13]There were three gates each on the east, north, south, and west. [14]The wall consisted of twelve foundations with the names of the Lamb's twelve apostles on them. **Rev 21:9-14**

[15]The *angel* that was talking to me had a gold rod for measuring the city, its gates, and wall. [16]The city was shaped like a cube 1380 miles long, wide, and high; [17]its wall measured 216 feet high, [18]made out of jasper; the city was pure gold like clear glass. [19]The foundation stones were beautiful precious stones. In order, they were jasper, sapphire, agate, emerald, [20]sardonyx, carnelian*, chrysolite* *[yellow topaz]*, beryl, topaz, chrysoprase* *[green quartz]*, hyacinth, and amethyst. [21]Each gate was a single pearl, and the streets were pure gold like transparent glass.

[22]I didn't see a sanctuary in it because God Almighty and the Lamb were its sanctuary. [23]The city didn't need the sun or moon because God's glory gave it light, and the Lamb was its lamp. [24, 26]The nations lived by its light, and kings brought their glory and the honor of their nations into it. [25]Its gates never shut because there wasn't any night there. [27]Nothing profane or anyone detestable or false could go in, only the ones written in the Lamb's Book of Life.
Rev 21:15-27

The River of Life, The Tree of Life

22:[1]The angel showed me a crystal-clear river of life flowing from the throne of God and the Lamb. [2]Between the city street and the river stood the tree of life, bearing twelve kinds of fruit and growing leaves that heal the nations. [3]There won't be any more curse. The throne of God and the Lamb will be in *that city*, and his servants will worship him. [4]They'll see his face and have his name on their foreheads. [5]There won't be any night; they won't need a lamp or the sun because God will give them light, and they'll reign forevermore. **Rev 22:1-5**

The Return of Christ

[6]The angel said,

"What you've seen and heard is true and trustworthy. The LORD God of the spirits of the prophets sent his angel to show his servants what needs to happen soon. [7] *'I'm coming soon. Blessed are those who keep the prophecy that's in this book.'"*

Rev 22:6-7

8I, John, heard and saw those things. When I heard and saw them, I fell down to worship the angel that was showing them to me. **9**But he said,

"Don't do that. I'm a fellow servant with your brothers the prophets and the people that keep the message in this book. Worship God.

10 *"Don't seal up the prophecy in this book because the time is soon.*

11*Let the unrighteous stay unrighteous;*
let the filthy stay filthy;
let the holy stay holy.

12 *"I'm coming soon. I'll bring with me the reward for each person according to what they've done.* **13***I'm Alpha and Omega, the First and Last, the beginning and end."* **Rev 22:8-13**

Keeping the Message of This Book

14Blessed are those who wash their robes so they'll have a right to the tree of life and a right to go into the city through its gates. **15**Outside are dogs, sorcerers, immoral people, murderers, idolaters, and everybody that enjoys telling and doing something false.

16 *"I, Jesus, sent my angel to tell you*[pl] *these things for the churches. I'm the root and offspring of David, the bright morning star."*

17The Spirit and the bride say, *"Come."* Let the one that hears it say, *"Come."* Let the thirsty come and drink the water of life free of charge. **Rev 22:14-17**

No Tampering with the Message

18I say to everybody that hears the prophecy in this book: if you add to it, God will add to you the plagues in this book. **19**If you take anything away from it, he will take away your part from the tree of life and the Holy City in this book.

20The One that's telling *you* these things says, *"Yes, I'm coming soon."*

Come, Lord Jesus.

21The grace of the Lord Jesus *be* with *you* all. **Rev. 22:18-21**

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